

CORSAIR

A TABLETOP ROLEPLAYING GAME

PREAMBLE: A NOTE FROM THE AUTHOR

Funnily enough, my first tabletop roleplaying game wasn't Dungeons & Dragons. It was some obscure hungarian game called M.A.G.U.S., which if anything, helped me get a feel what I don't want from a roleplaying game. My second, and the first one I learned to run as a GM was Shadowrun. You might be able to spot a few influences here and there. I thoroughly fell in love with the setting but the rules were a bit too crunchy for my taste. That's when I started to experiment with rulesets. I probably tried to hack Shadowrun to be more friendly at least three separate times if not more.

Along the lines I discovered other games, systems, and game designers, each bringing something new to the table, but my other big muse was Blades in the Dark. John Harper's brilliant work was exactly on the opposite end of the spectrum when it came to complexity. You could create a character in less than fifteen minutes if you wanted to, and both you and your group had a clear identity and goal you were working toward. I still hope one day I get to be a player and not a game master in a Forged in the Dark game. That said...

I still found myself tinkering with the rules, trying to make them more complex this time around. I realised what I really wanted was somewhere in the middle. Something that could elegantly handle all the curveballs that players could throw at it with relatively simple mechanics. And somewhere along the line I ended up thinking, "what if I tried my hand at making my own system from scratch?" This is the result of that thought.

But this is the furthest I can go on without admitting how I'm standing on the shoulders of giants. I've already mentioned Shadowrun, and Blades in the Dark, but Dungeons and Dragons, Daggerheart, the Star Wars TTRPGs by Fantasy Flight Games were all crucial inputs to the final mechanics.

As far as the setting goes, where to even begin? I loved Destiny, Horizon Zero Dawn, Mass Effect, Guardians of the Galaxy, The Expanse and many more. I knew there were many other sci-fi settings out there, but I was really hoping that this specific idea of blending space fantasy with hard sci-fi would be original enough to stand out.

That said, it would have amounted to nothing if I didn't have help. From Large Language models too, putting so much words to, well, not paper but disk, but also, those people that listened to my pitches, rants, and ramblings, and gave me feedback along the way. Who were kind enough to sit down and play this with me when it was even bigger of a mess than it is now. I know most of you never expected yourself to appear in any sort of credits, but I hope this brings you some joy, or at least a good chuckle.

Special thanks to: Fábián János, Bangó Dávid

And an even bigger thanks to my wife and love of my life, **Farkas Ágnes**. I borrowed your ear more times than I can count, and you played a bigger role in making this a reality than anyone else.

Author & Lead Designer: Péter Csiszár
Version: 0.0.1

License: *Corsair* is published under the Creative Commons Attribution-NonCommercial 4.0 International License (CC BY-NC 4.0). © Péter Csiszár. You are free to share and adapt this material for non-commercial purposes with appropriate attribution.

TABLE OF CONTENTS

ACT 0: SYSTEM INTRODUCTION PAGE 1

Chapter 00: Front Matter & Overview 1

Who Are the Corsairs? 1

What is a Roleplaying Game? 2

What You'll Need to Play 2

Reader's Guide: How to Use This Book 3

ACT I: CORE RULES & ENGINE PAGE 7

Chapter 01: Core Mechanics & Resolution 7

Attributes & Attribute Pairs 8

Simple, Success & Complex Tests 10

Upgrades, Downgrades & Gambits 13

Scenes, Pacing & Action Points 15

Effects & Tactical Triggers 17

Interlude: 27th Hour 23

ACT II: CHARACTERS & CHASSIS PAGE 25

Chapter 02: Character Creation 25

Traits & Lineages Catalog 31

Advancement & Career Milestones 35

Chapter 03: Classes & The MANTLE System 39

The Five Chassis: Conduit, Hazard, Pilot, Vanguard, Weaver 41

Interlude: Post-War Headaches 79

ACT III: OPERATIONS & HARDWARE PAGE 81

Tactical Combat & Dynamic Cover 81

Chapter 04: The Armory & Equipment 87

Firearms, Melee, Armor & Exotic Hardware 91

Chapter 05: Starships & Naval Operations 101

The 24-Hour Downtime Cycle & Gigs 115

Interlude: Great Tithe 121

ACT IV: WORLDS OF THE SPHERE PAGE 125

Chapter 07: Worlds of the Sphere 125

Planetary Gazetteer & Clusters 127

Sovereign Powers, Corps & The Flotilla 135

Timeline of Arrival (0 to 518 AA) 149

Interlude: Space Tourism 155

ACT V: RUNNING THE GAME & LORE PAGE 161

Chapter 06A: Operational Systems 161

Chapter 06B: Bestiary & Threat Cards 171

The Procedural Mission Generator 185

Chapter 08: The Forbidden Archives 193

Chapter 10: Reference & Index 201

SYSTEM INTRODUCTION

THE ELEVATOR PITCH

Corsair is a tabletop roleplaying game of high-stakes frontier adventure, tactical problem-solving, and found-family camaraderie, set against the vast backdrop of a macro-engineered cosmos.

You and your crew portray a **Corsair Cell**: licensed, independent operatives flying a versatile starship with a cross-jurisdictional charter. When local planetary law ends at the clouds and the naval peacekeepers of the Flotilla are light-hours away, your sponsors call on you. Whether you are investigating corporate sabotage in a spinning orbital arcology, braving derelict Precursor ruins for lost technology, negotiating tense standoffs across a fraying border, or scraping together enough fuel credits to keep your reaction thrusters burning, your crew stands as the thin line holding a young civilization together.

WHO ARE THE CORSAIRS?

THE SPHERE AT A GLANCE

The game takes place within the **Sphere**, a breathtaking engineered solar system featuring over a hundred terrestrial, habitable worlds and moons locked in tight binary orbits around colossal gas giants, all circling a quiet Orange Dwarf star.

Circa five hundred years ago, automated seed arks brought the survivors of four dying worlds into this seemingly abandoned system. Arriving as the **Newcomers**, humanity and three alien lineages—the cold-blooded, crested **Naga**, the dense-skinned **Craggen**, and the chlorophyllic **Sylvan**—made their first historic landfall on a fertile moon appropriately named **Landfall**. Over five centuries of shared survival, exploration, and cultural blending across the moons, six natural hybrid lineages took root alongside them: **Drakelings**, **Elves**, **Gnomes**, **Dwarves**, **Kobolds**, and **Trolls**.

Today, civilization spans dozens of bustling worlds, gleaming orbital transfer stations, and remote mining habitats. Yet the laws of nature remain stubbornly grounded. There is no faster-than-light warp drive; ships burn continuous fusion engines along calculated orbital curves. There is no artificial gravity plating; you stay grounded either through the axial acceleration of your ship's thrusters, the gentle centrifugal spin of a habitat drum, or the solid click of magnetic boots against steel decks. And in the vacuum of space, waste heat is as dangerous as an enemy round.

YOUR ROLE: THE CORSAIR CELL

Civilization across the moons is divided by a historic treaty: planetary governments hold total jurisdiction within their atmospheric gravity wells, while the peacekeeping fleet known as the **Flotilla** polices the open void and interstellar shipping lanes. This separation creates a glaring legal seam. Smugglers, corporate raiders, rogue mercenaries, and political conspirators routinely commit crimes under planetary clouds and burn into orbit, daring local authorities to chase them past their legal boundaries.

To bridge this seam, authorities grant independent charters to **Corsairs**—small, autonomous crews given cross-jurisdictional warrants to cross from planetary mud to the cold vacuum of orbit without getting bogged down in red tape.

As players, you form a **Corsair Cell**—a tight-knit crew of 3 to 5 specialists sharing an agile starship. Every cell is distinct:

- **Conflicting Sponsors:** Legitimate Corsairs are typically backed by multiple, competing sponsors—such as a Flotilla naval commander, a planetary governor, a commercial trading guild, or an independent labor union. By balancing competing patrons, your crew maintains its operational independence.
- **The Omni-Role Ethos:** You are practical survivors, not rigid archetypes. While every operative has specialized training or hardware rigs, no Corsair is locked into a single duty. Every member of the crew knows how to draw a sidearm in a corridor firefight, monitor a sensor array, pilot a shuttle, patch a ruptured environmental suit, and haggle for spare parts at an orbital bazaar.
- **Freedom of Approach:** Whether your crew acts as principled investigators, gritty salvage hounds, diplomatic fixers, or razor-sharp troubleshooters, how you tackle your contracts is entirely up to you.

WHAT IS A ROLEPLAYING GAME?

A roleplaying game (RPG) is a collaborative storytelling experience. You and your friends create characters to portray, and together you navigate a living world full of adventure, intrigue, and danger.

One player takes on the role of the **Game Master (GM)**. The GM is the primary storyteller, the referee of the rules, and the voice of the non-player characters (NPCs) that inhabit the void. The other players portray the **Player Characters (PCs)**, the specialist operatives who make up the Corsair crew and drive the story forward.

The game unfolds through a natural conversation:

1. **The GM describes the situation:** The environment, the sensory details of the scene, and any imminent hazards or NPCs present.
2. **The players declare their intent:** You state what your characters do, say, or attempt—whether moving into cover, overriding an airlock seal, or negotiating terms with a tense frontier marshal.
3. **The mechanics determine uncertain outcomes:** When an action is routine, it simply succeeds. But when an outcome is uncertain, dangerous, or contested, the dice hit the table using the rules outlined in this book.
4. **The GM describes the consequences:** The fiction moves forward, the scene shifts, and the conversation continues.

There are no winners or losers in a roleplaying game. The goal is to collaborate, face tactical challenges, and tell a memorable, cinematic story together.

WHAT YOU'LL NEED TO PLAY

To play Corsair, you will need a few essentials:

TABLETOP ESSENTIALS	
Dice	The game uses three standard polyhedral die types: eight-sided (**d8**), ten-sided (**d10**), and twelve-sided (**d12**) dice. A handful of each die type (especially d10s, which form the primary resolution dice pool) is ideal for the table.
Sheets	Printable sheets for recording your operative's attributes, skills, equipment, and your starship's modules (Character Sheet & Crew Sheet).
Pencils	Pencils and scratch paper for tracking notes, tactical sketches, and fluctuating game states (Action Points, Light Wounds, Aggravated Wounds, and ammunition).
Tokens	Simple counters (coins, poker chips, or glass beads) are useful for tracking Action Points and tactical positions during moment-to-moment encounters.
Group	Corsair is designed for **3 to 5 players**, including the Game Master.

> **THE PRINCIPLE OF NARRATION**
>
> Dice never roll in a vacuum. A roll represents physical friction: boots catching against grated decking, capacitors whining under peak load, or thruster gimbal bearings fighting reaction torque. Describe what your character physically does before picking up the dice.

READER'S GUIDE: HOW TO USE THIS BOOK

This rulebook is organized into five functional sections designed to take you from foundational mechanics to active campaign play, interleaved with narrative fiction capturing the lived reality of the void:

PART I: CORE RULES & ENGINE

The fundamental mechanics that power every test, decision, and scene in the game.

- **Core Mechanics:** The foundational rules of Attributes, Attribute Pairs, Simple Tests (binary success), Success Tests (degree of achievement), Complex Tests (action + quality), Upgrades & Downgrades, Contests, Gambits, and Teamwork.
- **Scenes, Pacing & Action Points:** Zooming between Day-to-Day shifts and high-stakes Moment-to-Moment rounds, the 3 Action Point economy, turn swaps, teamwork actions, and delayed actions.
- **Effects:** Activating dynamic tactical opportunities by sacrificing Hits on Action Rolls (Chain, Upgrade/Downgrade, Blocker) and Success Rolls (Crit, Push).
- **Interlude:** *A Point of Order on the Twenty-Seventh Hour*

PART II: CHARACTER CREATION & CLASSES

Everything you need to conceive, build, and advance your Corsair operative.

- **Player Characters:** Core Attributes, Derived Attributes, Skills, and Condition (wounds and stress).
- **Character Creation:** Step-by-step procedures for assigning attributes, training skills, and choosing starting equipment.
- **Traits & Lineages:** Origin traits, cultural adaptations, and operational quirks that distinguish your operative's physiology and background.
- **Classes & MANTLE Rigs:** The five operational chassis: the energy-channeling **Conduit**, the biochemical **Hazard**, the drone-linking **Pilot**, the frontline bulwark **Vanguard**, and the nanite-weaving **Weaver**.
- **Advancement:** How operatives earn experience, refine skills, upgrade attributes, and achieve career milestones during downtime.
- **Interlude:** *Post War Head- and Heartaches*

PART III: ADVANCED OPERATIONS

The tactical systems, armaments, voidcraft, and operational downtime that keep Corsairs alive and solvent.

- **Tactical Combat:** Movement, grid and abstract occupancy, close-quarters combat (CQC), dynamic cover, and damage resolution.
- **Personal Armory & Hardware:** Catalogs of Firearms, Melee Weapons, Armor, Field Gear, and rare Precursor Exotic Hardware.
- **Starships & Space Combat:** Comprehensive rules for Starship Operations, Brachistochrone burns, Ship Weapons, Internal Modules, and The Hangar Bay.
- **Downtime & Operations:** The 24-hour downtime cycle, shifts, long rests, medical recovery, starship maintenance, commercial bazaars, and the master d100 freelance odd jobs table.
- **Interlude:** *The Mathematics of the Great Tithe*

PART IV: WORLDS OF THE SPHERE

The celestial gazetteer, faction dossiers, history, and fiction of the setting.

- **Planetary Gazetteer:** Macro-engineering of the Sphere, the Newcomer heartland in the Fume Cluster, the cradle of Landfall, and the X'ara Cluster.
- **Factions & Powers:** Dossiers on the Sovereign Colonies, Megacorporations, the Flotilla, and the Underworld.
- **The Corsairs & Timeline:** The legal mandate of Corsairs, the 500-year history since arrival, and master anthology Stories of the Sphere.
- **Interlude:** *Space Tourism*

PART V: RUNNING THE GAME

Procedures, campaign structures, threat rosters, and mission generators for running the game.

- **Running the Game:** Core guidelines for Time Management, Social Interactions, Stealth & Infiltration, Investigation, Chases & Pursuits, and Tracks.
- **Threats of the Sphere:** Tactical profiles and statblocks for corporate security, pirates, drone swarms, void horrors, and NPC Guidelines.
- **Missions & Contracts:** Procedural Mission Generator and Open Play Contracts.

> **FLIGHT CLEARANCE APPROVED**
> Proceed to the foundational resolution mechanics: **Chapter 01: Core Mechanics →**

CORE MECHANICS & RESOLUTION

In Corsair, the story unfolds through a conversation between the players and the Game Master (GM). The players narrate the actions of their characters, describing what they want to do, where they want to go, and what they say. The GM, in turn, narrates the world around the characters. The GM describes the environment, controls the non-player characters, and explains how the world reacts to the players' actions.

Most of the time, this back-and-forth is all that's needed. If a player says, *"I walk across the room and open the door,"* and there's no reason they couldn't, the GM simply says, *"Okay, you open the door and see..."*

However, sometimes a character attempts an action where the outcome is uncertain. Can the character leap across a chasm? Can they persuade a fugitive with a gun to stand down? Can they land a hit with their sidearm if they don't? In these moments, when the drama and tension of the story hang in the balance, we turn to the dice to see what happens. This is the heart of the game's mechanics, and it's where the rules of Corsair come into play.

ATTRIBUTES

In Corsair, any significant feature of a person, creature, or object can be represented by an **Attribute**. Attributes are a way to assign a numerical value to a characteristic, making it a concrete element of the game world. Anything and everything can have Attributes.

While characters have core Attributes representing their physical and mental capabilities—**Strength**, **Agility**, **Finesse**, **Instinct**, **Knowledge**, and **Presence**—the concept extends to all corners of the game:

- **Strength:** Raw physical power, muscular force, and bodily mass. Used for lifting heavy cargo, forcing jammed airlocks, overpowering opponents in hand-to-hand combat, and carrying heavy equipment.
- **Agility:** Whole-body speed, balance, and athletic coordination. Used for sprinting between cover, dodging incoming hazards, vaulting obstacles, and maneuvering in zero-gravity.
- **Finesse:** Manual dexterity, surgical precision, and fine motor control. Used for aiming firearms, picking mechanical locks, performing delicate surgery, and manipulating intricate instruments.
- **Knowledge:** Formal education, technical literacy, and deductive reasoning. Used for slicing computer security, analyzing sensor telemetry, operating starship consoles, and understanding alien relics.
- **Presence:** Force of personality, charisma, and commanding social authority. Used for negotiating deals, intimidating rivals, inspiring companions, and maintaining composure under intense pressure.
- **Instinct:** Intuition, acute situational alertness, and gut-level reflexes. Used for sensing impending ambushes, detecting hidden hazards, reading an adversary's unspoken intent, and reacting in the chaos of battle.

Beyond living characters, the concept of Attributes extends to all corners of the game. A weapon might have **Rate of Fire** and **Accuracy** as Attributes. A jetpack could have a **Thrust** Attribute, while a cybernetic arm might have a **Power** rating. A starship is defined by a whole range of Attributes, such as its **Thrusters**, **Hull**, and **Scanners**. These ratings are the primary factor in determining the outcome of an action. A higher Attribute value signifies greater capability, directly impacting the dice rolls you'll make during the game.

ATTRIBUTE PAIRS

When a situation calls for a die roll, the GM will determine the two most relevant Attributes to form an **Attribute Pair**. This pair becomes the foundation of the test. The choice of Attributes is always dependent on the context of the action being performed.

It's important to note that the same Attribute can be selected twice if the action calls for a focused application of that single quality. For example, lifting a heavy crate might call for a **Strength + Strength** test, representing a pure application of raw power. Additionally, when a test specifies only a single Attribute, it should be understood as a test where both Attributes in the Attribute Pair are that specified Attribute.

Here are a few examples of how these might be combined into Attribute Pairs:

- **Accuracy (of the gun) + Finesse:** To fire a ranged weapon.
- **Manouverability (of the spaceship) + Instinct:** To carefully pilot a shuttle through a dense asteroid field.
- **Strength + Presence:** To intimidate a guard with a show of force.
- **Knowledge + Instinct:** To investigate a crime scene, look for clues and deduce what happened.

TESTS

When the outcome of an action is uncertain, the GM will call for a test. There are three types of tests in Corsair: **Simple**, **Success**, and **Complex**.

SIMPLE TESTS

A Simple Test is used when the outcome of an action is binary: you either succeed or you fail. There is no middle ground. To make a Simple Test, you form a dice pool by taking a number of ten-sided dice (d10s) equal to the higher of the two Attributes in the pair. In order to succeed, you need at least one of the dice to roll an 8 or higher (also called a *Hit*). If it does, you succeed; if it doesn't, you fail.

Examples of Simple Tests include:

- Leaping across a chasm.
- Sneaking through a patrolled corridor.
- Disarming a trap.

SUCCESS TESTS

A Success Test is used for actions that are certain to succeed, but the degree of success is variable. The question isn't *if* you can do it, but *how well* you do it in the time available. For a Success Test, you form a dice pool using a number of d10s equal to the *higher* of the two Attributes in the pair. The highest single die roll from the pool becomes your **success points**, which measures how effectively you performed the action.

Examples of Success Tests include:

- Applying first aid to a wounded crewmate to see how many wounds you can patch up.
- Spending a day in the workshop repairing your ship to see how much progress you make.
- Moving around the battlefield and seeing how much distance you cover.

COMPLEX TESTS

Complex Tests are for situations where you need to know both *if* an action is successful and *how* successful it is. This is most common in combat, where you need to know if an attack hits and, if it does, how much damage it deals. A Complex Test is a two-step process:

1. **The Action Roll:** First, you make a roll to see if you succeed at all. This is identical to a Simple Test: you roll a number of d10s equal to the **higher** of the two Attributes in the pair. If your highest die is a 7 or lower, your action fails.
2. **The Success Roll:** If your Action Roll is a success (at least one die shows 8 or higher), you then determine the *quality* of your success. You take a number of dice from the successful roll equal to the **lower** of the two Attributes. The highest value on these dice becomes your "success points."

Essentially, a Complex Test combines a Simple Test to see if you hit, and a Success Test to see how well you hit.

THE IMPORTANCE OF NARRATION

It is crucial to understand that the GM determines the type of test and the Attribute Pair based on *how you describe your character's actions*. Your narration matters. The choices you make in describing an action can change the Attributes used, and therefore the dice you roll.

For example, let's say your character is trying to persuade an NPC:

- If you say, *"I try to reason with him, surely he will see my point in all this,"* the GM will call for a **Presence + Knowledge** test, splashing in Knowledge for the reasoning part.
- If you instead say, *"I put on all the charm my character has and try to appeal to him that way,"* the GM will call for a **Presence + Presence** test.
- If you narrate, *"I get all up in his face and make it very clear to him in no uncertain terms that he will do as I say,"* the GM will call for a **Strength + Presence** test.
- And if you instead say, *"I hold my gun to his head and start counting,"* the GM could still ask for the **Damage** or the **Load** (size) of the gun and say roll that plus your **Presence**.

UPGRADES AND DOWNGRADES

Situational factors can influence the outcome of a test. A character might have a significant advantage, like using a high-quality tool, or a disadvantage, like working in a hazardous environment. These are represented by **Upgrades** and **Downgrades**:

- **Upgrade:** For each net **Upgrade**, you change one of the d10s in your dice pool to a twelve-sided die (d12). If all the dice in your pool are already d12s, each further **Upgrade** adds a new d10 to the pool.
- **Downgrade:** For each net **Downgrade**, you change one of the d10s in your dice pool to an eight-sided die (d8). If all the dice in your pool are already d8s, each further **Downgrade** forces you to remove a d8 from the pool.

Before any roll, the GM assesses the situation and assigns Upgrades for advantages and Downgrades for disadvantages. These cancel each other out on a 1-to-1 basis (e.g., 3 Upgrades and 2 Downgrades yields a net of 1 Upgrade).

The net number of Upgrades or Downgrades has a **maximum limit of 6**. If you have 8 Upgrades and 1 Downgrade, you have a net of 7 Upgrades, but you apply only 6 to the roll. In the rare case that you run out of all dice to downgrade, the test is extremely difficult: you roll two d8s and must take the lower result.

THE GAMBIT SYSTEM

Gambit is a special resource that allows players to snatch victory from the jaws of defeat. It's a pool of dice that you can use to turn a failed roll into a success.

EARNING GAMBIT

You earn **Gambit** by taking risks. After you roll your dice pool for a test, if any die shows its maximum possible value (e.g., a 10 on a d10, or a 12 on a d12), you have a choice. You can either use that die as part of your test as normal, or you can "bank" it for later. If you choose to bank it, you remove the die from your current roll and add it to your personal **Gambit** pool. This die can then be spent on a future roll.

SPENDING GAMBIT

You can spend a **Gambit** die from your pool on any test your character makes. You can declare you are spending **Gambit** at any point during the test—before you roll, after you see the results, anytime. When you spend a **Gambit** die, you simply add it to your current dice pool and roll it. Its result is added to the other dice, potentially changing the outcome of the test.

When a player spends a **Gambit** die, and the dice pool has already been modified by **Upgrades** or **Downgrades**, the newly added **Gambit** die retains its original die type.

THE GOLDEN RULE OF GAMBIT

There is one crucial restriction on using **Gambit**: **a player can either spend or gain Gambit during a test, but not both.** This means that if you spend any **Gambit** from your pool on a test, you cannot choose to bank any dice from that test to earn new **Gambit**. Conversely, if you bank a die from a roll to earn a **Gambit**, you cannot spend any **Gambit** on that same test.

PUTTING IT ALL TOGETHER: AN EXAMPLE TEST

Let's see how all these elements come together in play:

- **The Scenario:** Serving an apprehension warrant against an armed syndicate cell in an unpoliced orbital warehouse, Jax, a nimble gunslinger, is pinned down behind a cargo container. An outlaw skirmisher is advancing on his position, laying down suppressing fire. Jax decides to pop up and take a quick shot at the suspect with his sidearm. The GM decides this is a **Complex Test**, as they need to know if the shot hits and how much damage it deals. Jax's player describes the action as a quick, precise shot, so the GM chooses the Attribute Pair: **Finesse + Accuracy**. Jax has **Finesse 4**, his sidearm has **Accuracy 3**, and he holds two d10s in his Gambit pool.
- **1. The Action Roll (Did the shot hit?):** For the first part of a Complex Test, Jax uses the higher of the two Attributes (**Finesse 4**), assembling a dice pool of **4d10**. He rolls `[2, 4, 5, 7]`. The highest result is 7 (a miss). Jax spends a Gambit die: *"I'm spending a Gambit."* He rolls the banked d10 and gets an `[8]`. His pool is now `[2, 4, 5, 7, 8]`. With an 8, the shot hits!
- **2. The Success Roll (How much damage was dealt?):** For the second part of a Complex Test, Jax uses the lower Attribute (**Accuracy 3**), taking the 3 highest dice from his pool: `[5, 7, 8]`. The highest die is an 8 (8 points of damage). Jax decides to maximize the damage: *"I'm spending my second Gambit die."* He rolls his second banked d10 and rolls a `[9]`. His Success pool is now `[5, 7, 8, 9]`. The highest result is a 9.
- **Resolution:** Jax deals 9 points of damage to the outlaw, taking them down before they can breach his cover. Spending his banked Gambit turned a clean miss into a devastating shot.

CONTESTING A TEST

Often, a test isn't just against a static obstacle; it's against an active opponent who is trying to interfere. When a character is the target of another character's test (like being shot at, deceived, or tackled), they have the opportunity to contest.

In order to contest an action taken by another creature, you must be in close physical proximity to its target—typically sharing the immediate space with them. For example, you can contest an attack coming at you or an ally right beside you, and you can contest an enemy's movement crossing your space. On the other hand, you cannot contest a hostile creature reviving an ally 40 meters away by shooting at them.

To perform a **Contest**, the defending creature rolls a **Simple Test** determined by the GM (called a **Contest Roll**). Each die landing **8 or higher (a Hit)** eliminates the highest die from the roll you contested.

You **resist** a test if your Contest Roll eliminates every 8+ die from the contested roll.

You can contest **Success Tests** as well. If, after contesting, no 8+ dice remain in the contested character's pool, the Success Test generates **0 Success Points**, even if there are dice that are yet to be eliminated.

You can also contest actions that would normally not require a test (such as shushing someone before they can speak, or preventing an enemy you knocked prone from standing up). When this happens, you declare your intent to contest, and the contested creature must decide if they are willing to perform a **Simple Test** to complete their action—which you can then contest—or forego it altogether.

CONTEST EXAMPLE

Returning to our gunslinger Jax: suppose Jax fires at a fleeing syndicate smuggler trying to reach an airlock, rolling `[2, 4, 5, 7, 8]`. The suspect has an **Evasion** of 3 and dives behind reinforced deck piping. The GM calls for an Evasion Contest Roll (**3d10**). The smuggler rolls `[3, 8, 9]`—scoring two Hits (8 and 9). These two Hits eliminate Jax's two highest dice (the 8 and the 7). Jax's remaining pool is `[2, 4, 5]`. With no die of 8 or higher remaining, the attack becomes a **Failure**; the round ricochets harmlessly off the reinforced piping as the suspect scrambles out of the line of fire.

TEAMWORK

Sometimes, a single character isn't enough for the job. When multiple characters cooperate on the same task at the same time—forcing open a hydraulic blast door, infiltrating past a vigilant patrol, or executing a coordinated breach—they can use **Teamwork**.

JOINING A TEAMWORK ACTION

Any character's action can be turned into a **Teamwork Test** by additional eligible characters declaring their intent to join. A character can join a Teamwork action if:

- **Proximity:** The participants are in close physical proximity to each other and their shared objective.
- **Appropriate Contribution:** Each participant rolls the Attribute Pair appropriate to their weapon, gear, or method of action. Participants do not need to roll the same Attribute Pair! For example, two characters forcing a heavy blast door might both roll **Strength + Strength**, but in a coordinated combat assault, one character might swing a warhammer (**Strength + Finesse**, Striking) while an ally thrusts with a combat knife (**Agility + Finesse**, Piercing). Because all tests evaluate Hits on an 8 or higher, dice can be swapped freely between pools regardless of which attributes generated them.
- **Shared Target or Objective:** If the action has a target or destination, it must be identical for all participants (firing on the same enemy, treating the same wounded ally, forcing the same bulkhead).
- **Logical Feasibility:** The task must be something that multiple people can realistically cooperate on simultaneously.

THE DICE SWAP

After all participants declare their intent to cooperate, everyone rolls their respective test pools simultaneously. Once the dice hit the table, **any two participants can swap any amount of dice between their pools**. The strategic purpose of this exchange is mutual support: characters with surplus high-value dice (8+) pass extra results to allies who rolled low, ensuring the entire team achieves its goal or shaves away vulnerabilities.

CONTESTING TEAMWORK: DEFENDER'S ADVANTAGE

When an adversary is targeted by a Teamwork action, the defender gains the **Defender's Advantage**:

1. **Team Rolls:** All attacking participants roll their dice pools simultaneously.
2. **Team Swaps:** Attackers coordinate and commit their dice distribution.
3. **Defender Rolls:** The defender rolls their Contest pool *after* the attackers commit their dice swap.
4. **Targeted Elimination:** Each Hit (8+) on the Contest Roll allows the defender to eliminate the highest die from **whichever participating attacker's pool the defender chooses**. The defender can focus all Hits onto a single attacker to knock them out of the test, or split Hits across multiple foes.
5. **Knocking Attackers Out:** In a Complex Test, if the defender eliminates all 8+ dice from an attacker's pool, that attacker fails their Action Roll completely and **cannot advance to the Success Roll**. Only attackers who retain an 8+ move forward to roll damage!

COMPLEX TESTS & CONTESTS IN TEAMWORK

Teamwork can be employed across both stages of a Complex Test. Surviving attackers roll their Success pools and may **swap dice between their Success pools as well**, funneling high dice onto an operative with high-damage weapons or critical effects.

Defenders can also use Teamwork to resist incoming actions: when multiple defenders coordinate to resist an action, they roll their contest pools simultaneously, swap dice to maximize total Hits (8+), and allocate their combined eliminations against the attackers.

SCENES, PACING, AND ACTION

Corsair's gameplay is structured to keep the action moving and give every character a chance to shine. The story unfolds in Scenes, which are the fundamental building blocks of your adventure. However, not all scenes are paced the same. The GM can control the narrative flow by "zooming in" or "zooming out" on the action, changing the scope of a scene from a single, heart-pounding moment to the events of an entire day.

The game distinguishes between three types of scenes based on their scope: **Moment to Moment**, **Place to Place**, and **Day to Day**.

SCENE TYPES AND PACING

Think of the scene type as a camera lens. The GM can zoom in for a close-up on a dramatic confrontation or zoom out to quickly cover a long journey:

- **Day to Day:** This is the most "zoomed-out" level of play. It's used to cover long periods of time in which the characters are engaged in ongoing activities, but nothing requires immediate, second-by-second attention. This could be a day spent repairing the ship, a week of interstellar travel, or a month of downtime in a bustling city.
- **Place to Place:** This is the mid-level scope, focusing on a specific location and the events that unfold there. It's used for exploring a space station, navigating a dangerous asteroid field, or investigating a crime scene. Time is more fluid here than in Moment to Moment play, but the focus is on a single, contiguous area.
- **Moment to Moment:** This is the most "zoomed-in" level of play, where every second counts. This is for high-stakes situations like combat, a frantic chase, or a tense negotiation.

ACTION POINTS

Action Points are the currency you spend to perform significant actions, especially those requiring a Test. Every player has a maximum of **3 Action Points**.

Every test you take, whether it be Simple, Success, or Complex, requires **1 Action Point**. In some cases the GM might also call on you to spend an Action Point without taking a test, for example, to transit from one major location to the next.

ROUNDS

Within any scene, the action is broken down into **Rounds**. A round is a period of in-game time appropriate to the scene's pacing, where every character present has an opportunity to act. This ensures that the chaos of a situation is manageable and that the spotlight is shared.

A round in moment-to-moment pacing is only a dozen or so seconds long. In place-to-place pacing, a round might last from minutes to a few hours, while in day-to-day pacing, it's a full day.

At the start of every Round, every creature refills their Action Points to the maximum.

When the round ends, the GM gets an opportunity to introduce new characters into the scene, based on the broader scope of the scene that's playing out and the amount of time that passed during the round. This can be new reinforcements arriving in a moment-to-moment gunfight, or an inspection from the local authorities while you are going place-to-place. This also lets the GM advance the plot via NPCs that are acting outside the ongoing scene.

TURNS

Each round is divided into multiple turns of two different types: The **Player Turn** and the **GM Turn**.

- **Player Turn:** During the Player Turn, the players decide and declare what their characters are doing. A crucial aspect of the Player Turn is its free-form nature. **Players can act in any order they wish.** You can coordinate your actions, set up combos, and react to each other's decisions dynamically. One player might act, then another, then the first player might act again.
- **GM Turn:** During the GM Turn, the Game Master narrates the actions of the non-player characters (NPCs) in the scene. This is when every NPC makes their moves. If there are no NPCs in the scene other than the players, the GM turn is skipped, and it's the Player's Turn again.

The turn swaps from the players to the GM (or vice versa) after the active side has spent a total of **2 or more Action Points** and resolved their last action. The round concludes when both sides choose to "pass," meaning they have no further actions to take. Every round starts with the Player Turn first.

Most rounds will fly by due to the players being grounded with no NPCs, or NPCs that generally don't wish to affect the player characters. Therefore, most rounds will be rather one-sided, but that is a good thing as the GM already has a lot of work just arbitrating the player characters' narrations.

When a player action causes an NPC to go from a passive to an active participant in the scene, they become active and receive their Action Points next round, meaning each player character has a chance to act before the GM gets to react with NPCs.

GOING FIRST

Every round begins with the Player Turn. The players always act first, coordinating their moves and executing their strategies before the GM responds with the actions of non-player characters.

TEAMWORK ACTIONS

Teamwork allows multiple characters to contribute to a single goal. When characters use Teamwork, they can spend their Action Points to contribute to the collective effort. While players spending Action Points to participate in a Teamwork Test counts towards the 2AP per Turn limit, reaching the limit doesn't stop additional characters from participating. The turn will only end once the Teamwork Test has resolved.

TEAMWORK EXAMPLE: CHECKPOINT INFILTRATION

The crew is working an undercover assignment tracking a fugitive into an outlaw-run freeport. To reach the lower docks without tipping off the local syndicate, they must pass through an enforcer-controlled checkpoint. The GM rules this will be a Teamwork action, requiring each character to make a Success Test to see how well they blend into the underworld foot traffic:

- Silas, a master of disguise, creates a subtle diversion at a cargo terminal and scores 2 hits.
- Griz, a large and imposing figure, tries to look inconspicuous by pretending to be an off-shift maintenance hauler, but fails miserably, scoring no hits.
- Jax, ever the opportunist, strikes up a casual conversation with one of the gang lookouts to draw their attention, scoring just one hit.

The players have now collectively spent 3 Action Points. Silas swaps one of his hits for one of Griz's dice, representing the operatives covering for each other's slip-ups and successfully slipping past the checkpoint as a cohesive unit.

The flexibility of the turn structure and Action Point system is designed to encourage creative problem-solving and dynamic, cinematic action. Don't be afraid to combine actions, work together, and push your characters to their limits.

DELAYED ACTIONS

During high-stakes encounters, characters do not always act immediately; often, a disciplined Corsair holds their fire until an enemy leaves cover, waits for an incoming threat to breach a threshold, or readies a shot to interrupt a hostile move. You can prepare for such moments by declaring a **Delayed Action**:

- **Setting Up (1 AP):** On your turn, you spend **1 Action Point** to prepare a delayed action. When declaring a delayed action, you must specify two things:
  1. **The Trigger:** The observable event or condition you are reacting to (e.g., *"when an enemy steps out of cover," "if Brant draws a sidearm,"* or *"when the blast door starts to open"*).
  2. **The Planned Action:** The specific action you intend to take when the trigger occurs. The planned action must be manageable within **1 AP** (such as taking a shot with a firearm, swinging a melee weapon, making a Simple Test, or moving up to your base movement distance).
- **Declaring Timing (Before vs. After):** You have tactical freedom over when your action resolves relative to the trigger, but you must declare your timing beforehand when setting it up:
  - **Reacting Before (Interrupt):** You act *before* the triggering event resolves. For instance, declaring that you will shoot at a target the moment they attempt to fire at you allows you to shoot first, potentially eliminating or disrupting them before their attack can land.
  - **Reacting After (Response):** You act *after* the triggering event has completed. For instance, waiting until an enemy has moved completely out from behind heavy cover into open ground before firing ensures they cannot claim cover bonuses against your attack.
- **Action Point & Turn Accounting:** The 1 AP cost is paid **on the turn you set up the delayed action**, counting against the 2 AP limit of that turn. When the trigger condition occurs and you take your action, it requires **0 additional AP** in that moment, and it does not count against the AP limit of the turn in which it triggers.
- **Resolution and Expiration:** When the trigger condition is met, you immediately execute the declared test or action. If the triggering condition does not occur before the end of the round, the prepared action expires without effect—the spent Action Point represents the time, readiness, and vigilance invested in holding your position.
- **Delayed Teamwork Actions:** Multiple characters can coordinate to set up a shared delayed action (such as establishing a crossfire overwatch or setting a synchronized ambush):
  - **Setup:** All participants must share the same space, spend **1 AP** each, and agree upon the exact same **Trigger**, **Target**, and **Timing** (Before or After). Each participant prepares the action and Attribute Pair appropriate to their weapon or tool. An ally can spend 1 AP on a subsequent turn to join an existing ally's delayed action if they enter their space.
  - **Triggering & Swapping:** When the trigger condition occurs, all linked participants roll simultaneously for **0 additional AP** and can swap dice between their pools under standard Teamwork rules. If the target contests, Defender's Advantage applies normally.
  - **Disruption:** If an individual participant is incapacitated, knocked out of the space, or forced to defend before the trigger occurs, their readied action is broken, but remaining allies can still execute their delayed action when the condition is met.

ZOOMING IN AND OUT

The GM can transition between scene types as the story demands:

- **Zooming In:** When a broader scene suddenly becomes more dangerous or dramatic, the GM can "zoom in." For example, while the crew is executing a recovery warrant aboard an abandoned freighter (Place to Place), they might be ambushed by barricaded pirate scavengers, instantly shifting the scene to Moment to Moment. When zooming in, all characters present in the scene synchronize their broader Action Points down to the lowest remaining AP among them (reflecting time elapsed together). They then refill their Action Points in the new, narrower pacing to their maximum (3 AP) and begin a fresh round. Any ongoing effects created in the broader pacing are retained.
- **Zooming Out:** When a high-stakes scene concludes, the GM "zooms out" back to the broader pacing. Players set aside their tactical Action Points and resume the broader pacing with their remaining broader Action Points. If characters still have Action Points remaining in that broader round, they continue their shift or day; if all broader AP have been spent, the broader round concludes at the End of the Round. Characters operating in parallel in other locations retain their unspent broader AP and can take actions during that same timeframe.

EFFECTS

While succeeding at a test achieves your immediate objective, game mechanics in Corsair invite you to shape the battleground, create tactical openings, and alter the narrative flow of a scene. This is accomplished through Effects. Rather than relying solely on standard outcomes, Effects allow you to convert exceptional rolls into dynamic opportunities—turning a single strike into a sweeping attack, driving an opponent backward, or setting up a defensive barrier for an ally.

ACTIVATING EFFECTS

To activate an Effect, you sacrifice **Hits**—dice displaying a result of 8 or higher—rolled during an Action Roll or a Success Roll, depending on the specific Effect's requirements.

Activating an Effect is an exercise in collaborative storytelling between you and the Game Master. The Effect you declare must align logically with your character's action, declared narration, and chosen Attribute Pair. For instance, you cannot use an attack roll with a rifle to push a heavy blast door shut across the room, but you could easily describe forcing an enemy backward into cover or shooting out a control panel. The GM retains final discretion on whether an Effect fits naturally into the unfolding fiction.

ACTION EFFECTS

Action Effects are activated during your **Action Roll**. By setting aside Hits before moving on to resolve your Success Roll, you can manipulate the immediate environment or extend the reach of your action:

- **Chain Effect:** When performing an action directed at a single target out of several eligible choices—most commonly during combat—you may spend Hits on a **Chain Effect**. For each Hit you sacrifice from your Action Roll, you select one additional eligible target to include in the action. When chaining a Complex Test, perform a single Success Roll using the lower Attribute; the highest die applies individually to every target caught in the chain. You cannot chain actions that naturally affect multiple targets by default. Furthermore, if the base action requires expending a specific resource (such as ammunition, power cells, or consumable gear), you must pay that resource cost separately for each chained target. When making a ranged attack, you can only chain targets in the same range band, and the combined use of Chain and Crit effects cannot exceed your weapon's Rate of Fire (RoF).
- **Upgrade and Downgrade Effect:** When your action creates a clear situational advantage for yourself or an impending disadvantage for an enemy, you can activate an **Upgrade or Downgrade Effect**. Each Hit spent from your Action Roll allows you to step up or step down a die on subsequent tests related to that altered circumstance. Crucially, if you are resolving a Complex Test, you may apply this effect immediately to step up dice on your own upcoming Success Roll without needing to specify the situational advantage.
- **Blocker Effect:** If your narration aims to hinder, interrupt, or prevent an enemy from carrying out a specific future action, you can establish a **Blocker Effect**. For every **2 Hits** you sacrifice from your Action Roll, you set aside 1 Hit to create a pool of defensive dice. When an opponent attempts the blocked action, each set-aside Hit negates the single highest die from their test pool before resolving. Once a set-aside Hit negates an opponent's die, that set-aside Hit is expended. The Blocker Effect persists until all set-aside Hits are exhausted. If an opponent attempts to perform an action that normally does not require a test (such as opening a latch or standing up), the Blocker forces them to execute a **Simple Test** first; failing to eliminate all set-aside Hits prevents them from completing the action.

SUSTAINED EFFECTS

Certain Effects can be sustained over time rather than depleting after a single use. An Effect can become a **Sustained Effect** whenever there is an active physical object (such as magnetic restraints, deployed gear, a smoke screen, or specialized equipment) or an ongoing continuous action sustaining it.

When an Effect is sustained, any set-aside Hits or mechanical benefits do not deplete when triggered. Instead, the full pool of set-aside Hits or advantages resets after each affected action or attempt. Sustained Effects can be applied to any Effect type where continuous operation makes logical narrative sense—most commonly Blocker Effects or ongoing Upgrade/Downgrade Effects. A Sustained Effect remains active until an opponent succeeds despite the penalty or until the physical object or continuous action sustaining it is removed, destroyed, or neutralized.

SUCCESS EFFECTS

Success Effects are activated during your **Success Roll**, allowing you to amplify the effectiveness or intensity of an action that has already proven successful:

- **Crit Effect:** The primary Success Effect across all Success Rolls. For every Hit (8+) sacrificed from your Success Roll pool, you add **+2 Success Points** directly to your highest remaining die value.
- **Push Effect:** Leverage raw momentum or physical force to reposition a target. For each Hit sacrificed from your Success Roll, you knock or force the target backward by up to 4 meters. If you wish to maintain pressure or stay in close proximity, you may move along with the target as they are displaced without spending additional movement. Push Effects can only be activated if **Strength** (or a similar physical power attribute) is included in the test's Attribute Pair; they cannot be activated with tests relying solely on finesse, mental, or social attributes.

REMOVING EFFECTS

Ongoing environmental hazards, physical restraints, and persistent blockers do not have to remain forever. If a character is in a position to eliminate or neutralize an active ongoing effect, they may spend **1 Action Point** on their turn to make a **Simple Test** determined by the GM. Each Hit scored on this Simple Test removes 1 set-aside Hit from the targeted effect, gradually breaking down the obstacle until it is completely eliminated.

COMBINED MECHANICS IN ACTION

COMBINED MECHANICS IN ACTION: SYNDICATE CACHE BREACH

Acting under a Flotilla interdiction warrant, Jax and his team are raiding a fortified syndicate contraband cache defended by illegal combat drones. Engaging in close-quarters combat at the breached bulkhead, Jax declares, "I step in and swing my axe in a sweeping melee strike across the lead combat drone to tear open its plating while driving it back into its squadmate to clear the entryway."

The GM assesses the melee action and calls for a **Strength (5) + Strength (5)** Complex Test. Jax rolls 5d10 for his Action Roll based on his higher Attribute (**Strength 5**), producing `[3, 5, 8, 8, 9]`.

With three Hits (8, 8, and 9), Jax spends one Hit (8) to activate an Action Effect—an **Upgrade Effect**—stepping up one die on his upcoming Success Roll from a d10 to a **d12**. He leaves his remaining Hits (8 and 9) to ensure his Action Roll succeeds.

Moving to his Success Roll for his lower Attribute (**Strength 5**), Jax rolls 4d10 and 1d12 (modified by his Upgrade Effect). His roll yields `[5, 6, 7, 8]` on the d10s and 8 on the d12.

Jax scores two Hits (both 8s) on his Success Roll. He decides to activate two Success Effects:

- He spends his first 8 to activate a **Push Effect** (valid since his test relies on Strength), shoving the lead combat drone back 4 meters directly into its squadmate.
- He spends his second 8 to activate a **Crit Effect**, granting **+2 Success Points** to his highest remaining die.

The highest remaining die on his Success Roll is 7. By sacrificing his second 8 for Crit instead of keeping it as his base die, Jax increases his total from 8 to **9 Success Points** (7 + 2 = 9), neutralizing the lead drone while driving it clear of the doorway.

A POINT OF ORDER ON THE TWENTY-SEVENTH HOUR

A CORSAIR STORY • FICTION INTERLUDE

Jesse Haddon was fifty-eight years old, which was old enough to know that the universe was enormously large, profoundly strange, and mostly interested in generating paperwork.

As Speaker of the Crossroads Council, Jesse sat behind a heavy cedar table that he had planed and varnished with his own two hands thirty years ago. Outside the high arched windows, the twin world of Nimbus—a swirling sphere of purple and gold sixty thousand miles across—was casually drifting across the afternoon sky toward the sun. In about twenty minutes, it would block the light entirely. The thirty-hour day would pause, the valley would plunge into a sudden, freezing twilight, and the gas lamps out in the square would click on for *The Pause*.

To a poet, it was an awe-inspiring celestial dance. To Jesse, it meant he had exactly twenty minutes to get five very stubborn people to agree on a ditch before the room went dark and his tea went cold.

"It is not merely a question of the ditch," Councilwoman Vaelith was saying, leaning forward until her leafy green hair brushed the ceiling beams. She was an eight-foot-tall Sylvan elder with magnificent wooden tusks, peering down her nose through a pair of tiny brass spectacles. "It is a question of common decency. The new rocket shuttles taking off from the south field are blowing black soot all over the valley. My people hang their bedsheets out to dry in the morning, and by noon they look like chimney sweeps. My cousin's boy had to get married in a grey tunic, Jesse. A *grey* tunic."

On the other side of the table, Brom of the Stone-Carvers Guild gave a long, gravelly sigh that sounded like a wheelbarrow of river rocks being tipped into a creek. Brom was a Craggen, which meant his skin was solid grey granite, his eyes were cut gemstones, and his patience was measured in centuries.

"The shuttles carry iron sewer pipes," Brom rumbled, tapping a thick stone finger on his ledger. "Caldera Foundry makes the pipes on the other side of the mountain. The shuttles bring them here. If we tax the shuttles, the foundry raises the price of the pipes. If the price goes up, we don't finish the sewer. And with all respect to your cousin's wedding, Vaelith, if we don't finish the sewer before the rainy season, clean bedsheets will be the very least of our problems."

"Call the vote, Jesse," hissed Magistrate Ssisera. She was a slender Naga judge, currently coiled in a tight, shivering knot on top of the room's single cast-iron steam radiator, her scaly crest flushed an irritable yellow. "It is the twenty-seventh hour. I am cold, my crest is peeling, and if Nimbus covers the sun before I get a hot bowl of broth, I am going to bite the next person who mentions laundry."

From the open terrace behind the council table, a deep, resonant voice chimed in:

"I rather like the smell of the rockets," the voice rumbled. It was a magnificent sound, like a cathedral pipe organ being played through three feet of warm honey. "It smells like hot iron and ambition. But Vaelith is right about the sheets, Jesse. Grey linens are dreadfully dreary."

Jesse didn't turn around. He didn't need to. Resting his massive chin comfortably on the marble balustrade of the terrace was **Goldheart**.

He was a void dragon. Out in the deep, freezing silence between the stars, he was a creature of myth and terror, a living furnace of bio-fusion capable of outrunning warships and trading blows with alien dreadnoughts. Here in Crossroads Valley, however, where he had lived since the first colony ship opened its hatches five hundred years ago, he was essentially the town's overgrown grandfather. He liked roasted apples, he liked watching the village children play in the square, and above all, he dearly loved municipal meetings. To an immortal being that fed on cosmic energy, there was something endlessly soothing about mortal politics. It was like watching someone fold origami from a legal document so that in the end you could read a haiku from the back of a paper swan. That was the ideal anyway, but the dragon appreciated the effort too.

"Thank you, Goldheart," Jesse said mildly, tapping his wooden gavel. "Your thoughts on bedsheets are, as always, deeply valued. The chair recognizes the dragon's remark. Now, all those in favor of the shuttle drainage fee—"

A horrible, high-pitched whistling shriek tore through the clouds.

It wasn't the polite, muffled hum of a licensed cargo hauler. It was the frantic, screeching howl of a small, stolen hopper engine that was on fire, missing half its thruster nozzles, and falling out of the sky far too fast.

Jesse looked up. Through the hall's stained-glass skylight—an antique window commemorating the First Landing—he saw a streak of greasy black smoke, followed immediately by two pairs of boots. An instant later, the skylight gave way with a sound like a greenhouse being dropped from an orbital crane, showering shards of antique leaded glass and splintered roof tiles across the chamber.

A body struck the center of Jesse's beloved cedar table with the dull, violent impact of a side of beef dropped from a cargo gantry, snapping the center plank clean in half and sending water pitchers, ink pots, and tax ledgers flying in all directions.

Jesse closed his eyes, took a deep breath, and counted slowly to three. When he opened them, a twitchy kid in a grease-stained leather flight jacket was scrambling backward across the ruined table, clutching a humming, glowing hunk of alien metal wrapped in a dirty burlap sack. The object was pulsing with a strange, dull rhythm that made Jesse's front teeth ache. In his other hand, the kid was waving a dented, ugly little machine pistol.

"Stay back!" the kid shrieked, his eyes wild and bloodshot. "Don't touch me! I pulled this core straight out of the old war wreck in the crater! You take one step and I crack the casing! I'll level the whole street!"

Councilwoman Vaelith stared at the wreckage of the table, her wooden spectacles askew on her nose. "Young man," she said in a tone of voice that could freeze boiling water, "you have just ruined a thirty-year-old finish."

"I don't give a damn about your furniture!" the boy screamed, waving the gun at her. "Tell those Corsairs to back off! I'm not going to the penal mines! Tell them to back off!"

Above the hole in the roof, two thick steel cables snapped taut against the iron rafters with the sharp, mechanical bite of industrial winches. Two figures dropped through the opening, hitting the stone floor with the heavy, hydraulic crunch of powered armor. They were covered in soot, their grey metal plates were scraped to bare alloy, and they looked thoroughly, profoundly exhausted.

The lead Corsair brought a heavy, snub-nosed shotgun up to their shoulder in one smooth, practiced motion. Beside them, an elven partner leveled a taser rifle.

"Iron on the floor, kid," the one holding the shotgun rasped through her helmet grille. "Don't do anything stupid. Stupid is what got you into this mess. Put down the gun and live long enough to enjoy some variety in life."

The fugitive backed frantically toward the open terrace, his knuckles white against the grip of his machine pistol. "Stay back! I mean it! One step and I crack the casing! I'll take half the block with me!"

Jesse sighed. He picked up his bent glasses, rubbed the glass dust off them, and set them on his nose.

"Young man," Jesse said politely, "you are already facing three counts of grand larceny, an unlicensed atmospheric descent, and the destruction of a thirty-year-old cedar table. Do not make this afternoon any more expensive than it already is."

The kid's face twisted into desperation. He swiveled the gun straight toward Jesse's chest. "Shut up, old man, or I—"

He didn't finish.

From the sunlit terrace outside, a massive golden foreleg—roughly the thickness of an ancient cedar trunk—reached smoothly through the broken archway. With the gentle, practiced care of someone scooping up a wayward kitten, Goldheart curled his enormous paw around the boy, lifting him six inches clean off the floorboards.

The boy's arms were pinned neatly to his ribs inside a cage of golden, mirror-polished talons. He squirmed. He kicked his heels against empty air. He might as well have been trying to wrestle a mountain range.

Goldheart lowered his enormous horned head into the room. His golden eyes, each the size of a tavern tabletop, blinked down at the suspended thief with mild, grandfatherly reproach. When he exhaled, a warm, fragrant gust of air smelling of cinnamon, summer ozone, and woodsmoke gently ruffled the boy's greasy hair and blew his cap off.

"I wouldn't shoot Jesse if I were you," the dragon rumbled pleasantly, the sound vibrating through the boy's jawbone. "He made that table himself, you know. And when Jesse gets upset, he forgets to put sugar in my tea."

The boy stared into an eye the size of a wagon wheel. His fingers went limp. The machine pistol slipped from his hand and clattered harmlessly against the floorboards. He wondered how a dragon of Goldheart's size could drink a cup of tea.

"Thank you, honoured dragon," the lead Corsair murmured, exhaling in immense relief. Stepping in swiftly, she kicked the pistol into the corner and snapped heavy magnetic cuffs over the kid's wrists as Goldheart gently set him back onto his feet. The elven scout stepped forward with a lead-lined lockbox, popped the humming alien relic inside, and slammed the latches. The thrumming in Jesse's teeth vanished instantly.

The room fell dead silent, save for the tick of the wall clock and the cold wind blowing through the shattered skylight.

Only now, with the fugitive secured, did the two Corsairs seem to fully realize where their chase had ended. They looked around at the vaulted cedar rafters, the stone-faced Craggen, the imposing Sylvan elder, the magistrate shivering on her radiator, and finally up at the colossal golden dragon resting his chin on the balcony.

The lead Corsair hurriedly unlatched her helmet with a sharp hiss of pressurized seals, pulling it off to reveal a soot-streaked face and eyes wide with sudden, flustered mortification. Her posture snapped straight, instantly shifting from hardened void commando to an apologetic schoolchild who had just kicked a ball through the cathedral's finest stained glass.

"Speaker Haddon… Council elders… Honoured Goldheart," she said, her voice dropping into a hasty, respectful bow. "We are… profoundly sorry. For the roof, for the noise, and—most especially—for him. We had him boxed in over the reservoir, but his lateral thruster blew."

Beside her, her partner tilted his head back, stared up through the gaping crater in the ceiling, and muttered under his breath: "Fuck me, is that coming out of our paycheck?"

"Shut up," she hissed out the side of her mouth, bowing even lower toward Jesse. "The Corsair Oversight Committee will cover all structural damages, of course. Full restitution to the municipal treasury within two weeks."

Jesse looked at the broken glass. Then he looked up through the hole in the ceiling.

Outside, the enormous dark curve of Nimbus was sliding cleanly across the face of the sun. The amber sunlight faded into a soft, bruised violet. Down in the square, the gas streetlamps lit with a series of muffled *pops*, their yellow flames flickering in the chilly mountain breeze. *The Pause* had begun.

Jesse picked up the handle of his broken gavel and tapped it against the cedar stump.

"Take him down to the cellar lockup," Jesse said wearily. "Council is adjourned for the eclipse. We'll vote on the sewage pipes once the sun comes back."

Goldheart purred, tucked his great golden snout under his wing on the terrace, and went to sleep in the dark.

CHARACTER CREATION & ADVANCEMENT

Your character is your avatar in the world of Corsair. They are the protagonist of the stories you forge across the Sovereign Moons, and their attributes, learned skills, neural rig chassis, and tactical traits determine their survival on the high frontier.

In Corsair, characters are licensed peacekeepers, warrant-holders, or independent contractors operating under high-stakes institutional oversight. Before distributing attributes, the group decides on the campaign's **Mode of Play**, establishing your crew's legal authority, starship access, and relationship with sponsors.

THE 7-STEP CREATION SEQUENCE

Building an operative follows seven structured operational steps:

1. **1. Mode of Play & Sponsor:** Establish your legal standing (*Freelancers*, *Corsairs*, or *Rogue Corsairs*) and patron.
2. **2. Lineage (Race):** Choose your biological background among the ten lineages of the Sphere.
3. **3. Class MANTLE Chassis:** Choose your cybernetic rig (*Conduit*, *Hazard*, *Pilot*, *Vanguard*, *Weaver*), distribute 7 Class Creation Points, and select an Ability Package.
4. **4. Core Attributes & Derived Stats:** Spend 10 Creation Points across the six Core Attributes (rated 1 to 5), then derive **Endurance** and **Willpower**.
5. **5. Starter Kit & Load Capacity:** Select armor, weapons, and utility rigs within your Max Load: $12 + (\text{STR} \times 2)$.
6. **6. Starting Credits:** Bank your initial allowance of **5,000 Credits**.
7. **7. Starting XP (Skills & Traits):** Spend your Experience Points (6 XP base; 10 XP Humans; 8 XP Hybrids) on Skills (Levels 1–2) and tactical Traits.

MODES OF PLAY

1. FREELANCERS (ASPIRANTS)

- **Status & Resources:** Independent contractors with **no Sponsor** and **no starship**.
- **Campaign Premise:** Operating at ground level. Taking dirt-side security gigs, habitat contracts, bounties, or salvage jobs, operatives rely on passenger liners, cargo transports, and shuttles to travel between moons.
- **Crew Objective:** Building reputation, amassing credits for their own hull, or catching the attention of a major power for a formal charter. Skip the Sponsor step.

2. CORSAIRS (CHARTERED CELL)

- **Status & Resources:** Commissioned peacekeepers with an official cross-jurisdictional legal mandate, **individual Sponsors**, and a shared **Corsair Starship** (such as an RF "Kestrel").
- **Campaign Premise:** The standard Corsair experience. Autonomous cells dispatched to investigate incidents, enforce inter-jurisdictional law, conduct tactical strikes, and resolve geopolitical crises.
- **Sponsor Selection:** Each player chooses an active **Sponsor**. To maintain impartiality, it is recommended that **each player selects a different sponsor**.

3. ROGUE CORSAIRS (OUTLAWS)

- **Status & Resources:** Outlaws with **ex-sponsors** and an unregistered, jury-rigged **ship** (such as a GVI "Rusty Hook").
- **Campaign Premise:** Former Corsairs whose mandates were revoked. The crew takes on questionable contracts—black-market salvage, smuggling, shadow ops, and privateering—while dodging patrol cutters.

SPONSORS & JURISDICTIONS

Depending on your Mode of Play, select a **Sponsor** (for *Corsairs*) or an **Ex-Sponsor** (for *Rogue Corsairs*). Each player should ideally represent a distinct faction:

- **Flotilla:** The independent interstellar defense force. Focuses on fleet defense, orbital integrity, anti-piracy, and peacekeeping.
- **Colonial:** Planetary administrations across the Sovereign Moons. Focuses on territorial law, colonial defense, and resource stability.
- **Corporate:** Multi-system megacorporations. Focuses on corporate intelligence, trade protection, asset recovery, and security.
- **Civilian:** Labor unions, scientific consortiums, and NGOs. Focuses on worker rights, research ethics, and refugee relief.
- **Private:** Wealthy oligarchs or dynasties. Focuses on private collections, high-stakes personal vendettas, and shadow influence.

LINEAGES OF THE SPHERE

Over five centuries of isolation under varied radiation, centrifugal spin, and atmospheres, Newcomer civilization diversified into distinct biological lineages. Your lineage grants attribute adjustments or bonus starting XP:

HUMAN

Adaptable, ambitious, and widespread across every habitat. Possess cognitive versatility. Gain **+4 XP** at creation (total starting pool of **10 XP**).

CRAGGEN

Stout, small-sized humanoids with mineral-dense skin and gemstone eyes. Hardened in dense mine-vaults. Gain **+2 points** distributed between **Finesse** and **Knowledge** (+2/+0, +1/+1, or +0/+2).

NAGA

Cold-blooded, bipedal reptilians with vibrant cranial crests. Exceptional reaction speeds and thermal awareness. Gain **+2 points** distributed between **Agility** and **Instinct** (+2/+0, +1/+1, or +0/+2).

SYLVAN

Imposing, powerful humanoids marked by manes, tusks, and chlorophyllic skin. Biochemically robust. Gain **+2 points** distributed between **Strength** and **Presence** (+2/+0, +1/+1, or +0/+2).

DRAKELING

Nimble, scaly humanoids with swept horns and serpentine tails. Reptilian reflex with human drive. Gain **+2 XP** (8 XP total), plus **+1 Agility** or **+1 Instinct**.

ELF

Graceful, slender humanoids with pointed ears and chlorophyllic pigmentation. Sylvan resilience with human social drive. Gain **+2 XP** (8 XP total), plus **+1 Strength** or **+1 Presence**.

GNOME

Inquisitive, slender humanoids with iridescent eye/hair pigmentation. Natural curiosity and technical dexterity. Gain **+2 XP** (8 XP total), plus **+1 Finesse** or **+1 Knowledge**.

DWARF

Dense, subterranean humanoids combining crystalline deposits with reinforced frames. Sylvan bulk with Craggen endurance. Gain **+1 Strength** or **+1 Presence**, plus **+1 Finesse** or **+1 Knowledge**.

KOBOLD

Cunning reptilians crowned with natural bone masks. Naga reflexes with Craggen precision. Gain **+1 Agility** or **+1 Instinct**, plus **+1 Finesse** or **+1 Knowledge**.

TROLL

Towering, horned humanoids with thick hides and tusks. Sylvan mass with Naga predatory instincts. Gain **+1 Strength** or **+1 Presence**, plus **+1 Agility** or **+1 Instinct**.

> **RACIAL BONUS TIMING**
>
> Racial attribute adjustments are applied prior to Creation Point distribution. Stepping an Attribute from 4 to 5 always costs 2 Creation Points regardless of racial bonuses.

CORE ATTRIBUTES

Every operative is defined by six Core Attributes representing baseline physical conditioning and cognitive capacity on a scale from 1 to 10 (with 1 being standard untrained ability and 10 representing peak potential).

PHYSICAL ATTRIBUTES

- **Strength:** Muscular force, skeletal leverage, and athletic power. Used for forcing jammed bulkhead seals, grappling opponents, wielding heavy ordnance, and carrying combat loads.
- **Agility:** Whole-body speed, balance, kinesthetic coordination, and physical reflexes. Crucial for dodging fire, vaulting obstacles, and zero-gravity maneuvering.
- **Finesse:** Manual dexterity, fine motor skills, and surgical hand-eye coordination. Used for precision marksmanship, field surgery, lockpicking, and delicate electronics work.

MENTAL ATTRIBUTES

- **Knowledge:** Technical education, data analysis, and memory recall. Used for slicing computer nodes, repairing starship reactors, and deciphering Precursor archives.
- **Presence:** Force of personality, commanding bearing, and social resolve. Vital for interrogations, diplomatic de-escalation, and tactical command.
- **Instinct:** Gut intuition, situational awareness, and split-second subconscious perception. Used for spotting concealed ambushes, reading body language, and reacting to surprise hazards.

DERIVED ATTRIBUTES

From your Core Attributes, calculate two vital derived ratings:

- **Endurance:** Physical resilience and pain tolerance. Equal to your **second-highest Physical Attribute** (Strength, Agility, or Finesse).
- **Willpower:** Mental fortitude, stress management, and emotional resistance. Equal to your **second-highest Mental Attribute** (Knowledge, Presence, or Instinct).

DISTRIBUTING CREATION POINTS

All six Core Attributes start at a baseline rating of **1** (`1 / 1 / 1 / 1 / 1 / 1`). You have **10 Creation Points** to distribute:

- Increasing an Attribute from **1 to 4** costs **1 point** per increase.
- Increasing an Attribute from **4 to 5** costs **2 points**.
- **Starting Cap:** The maximum rating for any Core Attribute at creation is **5**.

CLASS CHASSIS (MANTLE RIG)

Your Class is a proprietary **MANTLE** (*Modular Adaptive Neural Transmission Linked Equipment*)—an aerospace-grade cybernetic or technological chassis interfacing directly with your nervous system via a permanent **Neural Control Chip (NCC)** and spinal shunt.

Due to neural bandwidth limits, an operative can have only **one active MANTLE chassis equipped at a time**.

THE FIVE STARTING CHASSIS

- **Conduit:** Elemental shock trooper channeling electrical and thermal volatility. *Class Attributes:* Flame, Frost, Lightning.
- **Hazard:** Combat alchemist armed with a pressurized Catalyst Chamber. *Class Attributes:* Venom, Hazard, Serum.
- **Pilot:** Neuro-synced exoskeleton and autonomous exodrone operator. *Class Attributes:* Power, Speed, Precision.
- **Vanguard:** High-mobility frontline breaker with a morphing kinetic board. *Class Attributes:* Shield, Glider, Cannon.
- **Weaver:** Nanite artisan manipulating a living fluid swarm. *Class Attributes:* Create, Control, Modify.

CLASS ATTRIBUTES BUDGET

All three Class Attributes start at **1** (`1 / 1 / 1`). Spend **7 Class Creation Points** to increase them (1 to 4 costs 1 point; 4 to 5 costs 2 points; starting cap is 5). Select **one starting Class Ability Package** from your class chapter.

STARTER KIT & OUTFITTING

Every operative receives standard survival gear for life on the fringe, including tactical communications, protective armor, weapons, and a specialized utility rig.

THE LOAD CAPACITY SYSTEM

All gear is governed by the **Load** system, representing mass, bulk, and holstering awkwardness. An operative's carrying limit is determined directly by their physical power:

> **Maximum Load Capacity = 12 + (Strength × 2)**

This capacity is an absolute operational limit; an operative cannot carry gear exceeding this value under any circumstances. Reserve spare Load for field salvage, power cells, and munitions.

1. UNIVERSAL COMMUNICATIONS

- **1 Commlink** (Load 0 | Long-Range Tactical Comms).

2. PERSONAL ARMOR (CHOOSE 1)

- **Padded Flightsuit** (Protection 2 | Load 1) — *Lightweight, pressurized jumpsuit with minimal bulk.*
- **Armored Jacket** (Protection 3 | Load 2) — *Durable ballistic coat lined with reinforced composite inserts.*

3. MELEE WEAPON (CHOOSE 1)

Select one melee tier your **Strength** satisfies (1H weapons require two hands if below Min STR). Pick the damage type matching your favored attribute pair:

- **Piercing (Agility + Finesse):** Adds lower of Agility or Finesse to damage.
- **Slashing (Agility + Strength):** Adds lower of Agility or Strength to damage.
- **Striking (Strength + Finesse):** Adds lower of Strength or Finesse to damage.

Light Melee (Min STR 1 | Load 1/2 | Dmg +0):

- Shiv / Stiletto (Piercing)
- Combat Knife (Slashing)
- Knuckleduster (Striking)

Tactical Melee (Min STR 2 | Load 1 | Dmg +1):

- Dagger (Piercing)
- Hatchet / Machete (Slashing)
- Baton / Club (Striking)

Heavy Melee (Min STR 3 | Load 2 | Dmg +2):

- Shortsword (Piercing)
- Boarding Axe (Slashing)
- Mace / Crowbar (Striking)

4. FIREARM (CHOOSE 1)

Select one firearm based on desired engagement range. Ranged tests always pair weapon **Accuracy** at the target's range band with **Finesse**:

Close-Quarters (Short Range: 0–5 spaces / ~0–20m):

- **Service Pistol:** 1H | Load 1 | Dmg +1 | RoF 1 | Acc: 3 / 2 / 1 / -
- **Compact SMG:** 2H | Load 2 | Dmg +1 | RoF 2 | Acc: 4 / 3 / 1 / -
- **Combat Shotgun:** 2H | Load 3 | Dmg +3 | RoF 1 | Acc: 4 / 3 / 0 / -

Mid-Range & General (Medium Range: 6–12 spaces / ~20–40m):

- **Heavy Revolver:** 1H | Load 1 | Dmg +2 | RoF 0 | Acc: 3 / 2 / 1 / -
- **Assault Carbine:** 2H | Load 3 | Dmg +2 | RoF 2 | Acc: 3 / 3 / 2 / 1
- **Assault Rifle:** 2H | Load 3 | Dmg +2 | RoF 2 | Acc: 2 / 4 / 3 / 1

Long-Range & Standoff (Long/Extreme: 13–20+ spaces / ~40–80+m):

- **Battle Rifle:** 2H | Load 3 | Dmg +4 | RoF 0 | Acc: 2 / 3 / 4 / 2
- **Marksman Rifle (DMR):** 2H | Load 4 | Dmg +4 | RoF 1 | Acc: 1 / 3 / 5 / 3
- **Sniper Rifle:** 2H | Load 4 | Dmg +5 | RoF 0 | Acc: 0 / 2 / 5 / 4

5. SPECIALIZED UTILITY KIT (CHOOSE 1)

- **Medic Kit:** 1 Field Medi-Kit (Medicine 3 | Cap 3 | Lesser Physical) & 1 Neuro-Stabilizer Inhaler (Medicine 3 | Cap 3 | Lesser Mental).
- **Grenadier Kit:** 1 Tactical Grenade Rig (Cap 3) & 1 Grenade Launcher Rig (Medium Range | Load 2).
- **Techie Kit:** 1 "Spider" Cyberdeck (Interfacing 3, Hacking 2 | Load 2) & 1 Proximity Sensor (Scouting 4m | Load 1/2).
- **Mobility Kit:** 1 Standard Grapple Launcher (Mobility 3 | Range 8m | Cap 3) & 1 Gecko Climbing Kit (Surface Adhesion | Load 1).
- **Trench Kit:** 1 Deployable Cover (Medium Cover +2 | 24 HP | Load 3) & 1 Mechanic's Kit (Tinkering 2, Locksmith 2 | Load 2).

STARTING CREDITS

Every operative begins with **5,000 Credits** to purchase additional specialized ordnance, reserve ammunition, or bank for operational expenses.

SKILLS & STARTING EXPERIENCE

While Attributes represent raw physical and mental power, Skills represent trained operational expertise in specific fields, providing reliable Upgrades when the pressure mounts.

SKILL RATINGS & UPGRADES

Skills are rated from 1 to 3. When you make a test using the Attribute Pair associated with your skill, you automatically receive a number of **Upgrades** equal to your skill rating:

- **Skill Level 1:** Trained operative. You receive **+1 Upgrade** on relevant tests.
- **Skill Level 2:** Seasoned specialist. You receive **+2 Upgrades** on relevant tests.
- **Skill Level 3:** Sector-renowned authority. You receive **+3 Upgrades** on relevant tests.

FLEXIBLE SKILL NAMING

A core feature of the Corsair engine is narrative flexibility. You are encouraged to invent descriptive, character-defining names for your skills. The only mechanical rule is that the skill must logically connect to its assigned Attribute Pair:

- **Accuracy + Finesse:** *Gunslinging, Precision Marksmanship, Standoff Sniping.*
- **Finesse + Agility:** *Zero-G Acrobatics, Sleight of Hand, Blade Dancer.*
- **Knowledge + Presence:** *Corporate Law, Crisis De-escalation, Xeno-Linguistics, Tactical Analysis.*
- **Strength + Agility:** *Boarding Breacher, Free-Running, Kinetic Wrestling.*
- **Knowledge + Finesse:** *Cyber-Infiltration, Field Surgery, Explosive Ordnance Disposal.*
- **Instinct + Presence:** *Hostage Negotiation, Streetwise Grift, Interrogation.*

While the skill name injects distinct flavor into your character, the mechanical Upgrades apply to **any test** rolled with that Attribute Pair.

STARTING XP BUDGET

Rather than tracking separate pools of skill points and talent slots, characters receive flat **Experience Points (XP)** at creation.

You may spend this starting XP freely to purchase Skills, acquire Traits, or combine both:

- **Baseline Starting Pool: 6 XP**.
- **Human Operatives:** Gain +4 XP for **10 XP total**.
- **Hybrid Lineages (Drakeling, Elf, Gnome):** Gain +2 XP for **8 XP total**.

SKILL COSTS

- **Level 1 Skill:** Costs **2 XP** (+1 Upgrade).
- **Level 2 Skill:** Costs **4 XP** (6 XP cumulative; +2 Upgrades).
- **Level 3 Skill:** Costs **6 XP** (12 XP cumulative; +3 Upgrades).
- **Creation Skill Cap:** The maximum rating for any Skill at character creation is **Level 2** (preserving Level 3 as an elite distinction earned in active play).

PURCHASING TRAITS

Operatives can spend starting XP directly to acquire standalone **Traits** from the catalog. Each Trait has a flat cost between **2 XP and 8 XP** with zero prerequisite tree gatekeeping.

SAMPLE STARTING BUILDS

With a baseline pool of 6 XP, operatives enjoy complete freedom to define their starting tactical profile:

- **The Generalist:** Purchase three separate Level 1 Skills (3 × 2 XP = 6 XP) for broad coverage.
- **The Dedicated Specialist:** Invest all 6 XP into a single signature Level 2 Skill (2 XP + 4 XP = 6 XP).
- **The Pure Tactician:** Purchase standalone Traits, such as *Tough as Nails* (6 XP) or *Brawler* (2 XP) + *Counter Striker* (4 XP).
- **The Balanced Operative:** Combine one Level 1 Skill (2 XP) and one 4 XP Trait (such as *Marksman*, *Iron Will*, or *Healer*).
- **Human Versatility:** A Human with 10 XP can acquire a Level 2 Skill (6 XP) plus two Level 1 Skills (4 XP), or pair a top-tier Trait like *Controlled Blast* (8 XP) with a Level 1 Skill (2 XP).

TRACKING SHEETS

Record your stats, load, and chassis abilities on the official printable **Corsair Character Sheet**. For crews operating a shared vessel, use the **Corsair Crew Sheet** to manage bridge stations, vessel damage, and collective cargo.

CREATION IN ACTION: JAX

To illustrate how the creation sequence operates in practice, here is the complete build walkthrough for **Jax**, a licensed Corsair peacekeeper operating under a Flotilla interdiction warrant:

STEP 1: MODE OF PLAY & SPONSOR

Jax's cell plays a standard **Corsair (Chartered Cell)** campaign aboard an RF "Kestrel" light cutter. Jax selects the **Flotilla** as his sponsor, granting him a lawful cross-jurisdictional warrant to apprehend system fugitives, investigate orbital breaches, and intercept pirate raiders.

STEP 2: LINEAGE (RACE)

Jax is a **Human**. Rather than innate attribute adjustments, Jax receives **+4 bonus starting XP** (for a starting budget of **10 XP**).

STEP 3: CLASS MANTLE CHASSIS

Jax equips the **Vanguard** chassis—a high-mobility frontline rig featuring a morphing kinetic board. His three Class Attributes start at `1 / 1 / 1`. With **7 Class Creation Points**, he allocates:

- **Shield 4** (3 pts from 1 to 4)
- **Cannon 4** (3 pts from 1 to 4)
- **Glider 2** (1 pt from 1 to 2)

Starting Package: He selects the **Vanguard Defense Package** (unlocking *Bulwark Anchor*, *Aegis Intercept*, and *Kinetic Deflection*).

STEP 4: CORE ATTRIBUTES & DERIVED STATS

Jax starts at `1 / 1 / 1 / 1 / 1 / 1` and allocates his **10 Creation Points**:

- **Strength 4** (3 pts) & **Finesse 4** (3 pts)
- **Agility 3** (2 pts)
- **Knowledge 2** (1 pt) & **Instinct 2** (1 pt)
- **Presence 1** (0 pts)

Derived Stats: Second-highest Physical is **Endurance 4**. Second-highest Mental is **Willpower 2**. Physical Condition tracks have **8 segments each** (4 + 4); Mental tracks have **6 segments each** (4 + 2).

STEP 5: STARTER KIT & LOAD BUDGETING

Carrying limit: $\text{Max Load} = 12 + (\text{STR } 4 \times 2) = 20 \text{ Load}$.

- **Commlink:** Load 0 (Tactical communications).
- **Armored Jacket:** Protection 3 | Load 2.
- **Boarding Axe:** Heavy Melee Slashing | Load 2 | Dmg +2 | Pairs *Agility + Strength*.
- **Heavy Revolver:** Handgun, 1H | Load 1 | Dmg +2 | RoF 0 | Acc: 3 / 2 / 1 / - | Pairs *Accuracy + Finesse*.
- **Trench Kit:** Deployable Cover (Load 3) & Mechanic's Kit (Load 2) = Load 5.

Total Load: 10 / 20 Load (leaving **10 spare Load** for ammo, field salvage, and contraband evidence).

STEP 6: STARTING CREDITS

Jax banks his baseline reserve of **5,000 Credits**.

STEP 7: SKILLS & TRAITS (STARTING XP)

With **10 XP** as a Human, Jax purchases:

- **Skill — Gunslinging 1 (Accuracy + Finesse):** Costs 2 XP (+1 Upgrade on ranged marksmanship tests).
- **Trait — Gunslinger:** Costs 4 XP. Ignores the 3 Downgrades for firing ranged weapons while in Close Quarters Combat (CQC).
- **Trait — Marksman:** Costs 4 XP. Treats targets as 1 Range Band closer or further for weapon Accuracy.

JAX — CHARACTER SUMMARY

Human Corsair | Flotilla Sponsor | Vanguard Chassis Lvl 1
Attributes: STR 4, FIN 4, AGI 3, KNO 2, INS 2, PRE 1
Derived: Endurance 4, Willpower 2 | **Load:** 10 / 20
Class Attributes: Shield 4, Cannon 4, Glider 2
Skills: Gunslinging 1 (Accuracy + Finesse; +1 Upgrade)
Traits: Gunslinger (4 XP), Marksman (4 XP)
Armory: Armored Jacket (Prot 3), Heavy Revolver (Dmg +2), Boarding Axe (Dmg +2), Trench Kit, Commlink | **Credits:** 5,000

CONDITION & TRAUMA

Condition represents an operative's capacity to endure trauma. Instead of tracking an abstract pool of hit points, resilience is divided into two distinct categories: **Physical Condition** and **Mental Condition**.

Physical Condition measures structural bodily integrity against kinetic trauma, thermal burns, and toxins, governed by **Endurance**. **Mental Condition** measures cognitive resilience, emotional fortitude, and sanity under sensory shock and psychological terror, governed by **Willpower**.

THE THREE SEQUENTIAL TRACKS

Both Physical and Mental Condition are divided into three sequential **Tracks** (Track I, Track II, and Track III). Whenever your character suffers damage or mental stress, mark off segments starting on Track I. Once a Track becomes completely full, any subsequent damage naturally overflows into the next Track:

> **Track Capacity = 4 + Derived Attribute**

(4 + Endurance for Physical Tracks; 4 + Willpower for Mental Tracks)

DAMAGE TYPES: LIGHT VS. AGGRAVATED

Damage is tracked as either **Light Wounds** (standard combat fatigue and surface trauma) or **Aggravated Wounds** (severe tissue destruction or psychic fracture):

- **Light Wounds:** Standard damage instances that fill open segments. Readily restored through basic medical supplies and short rests.
- **Aggravated Wounds:** When an incoming source of damage overflows the remaining capacity of a Track, the excess points convert filled Light Wounds on that filled Track into **Aggravated Wounds**. Aggravated Wounds represent deep structural trauma that cannot be healed through basic Lesser Healing.

ATTRIBUTE PENALTIES: IMPAIRED & CRIPPLED

Filling a Condition Track inflicts severe strain on an operative's capabilities:

- **Impaired (Light Wounds):** When a Track is completely filled with Light Wounds, select and mark one corresponding Attribute on your sheet (a Physical Attribute for Physical Tracks, or a Mental Attribute for Mental Tracks). That Attribute becomes **Impaired**. From that moment forward, any test involving that Impaired Attribute suffers **1 Downgrade**.
- **Crippled (Aggravated Wounds):** If an individual Track becomes completely filled with Aggravated Wounds, the marked Attribute becomes **Crippled**. Any test involving a Crippled Attribute suffers **2 Downgrades** instead.

CONSEQUENCES OF FULL CONDITION

Filling all three sequential Tracks brings critical consequences:

- **Physical Collapse:** When all three Physical Tracks are filled with any combination of Light or Aggravated Wounds, your character falls **Unconscious** and cannot act until at least one segment is cleared. If every single segment across all three Physical Tracks becomes filled with **Aggravated Wounds**, your character **Dies**.
- **Mental Breakdown:** When all three Mental Tracks become filled, your character is mentally overwhelmed and **cannot earn or spend Gambit Dice** (though existing Gambit dice remain banked) until at least one segment is cleared. If all three Mental Tracks are filled entirely with **Aggravated Wounds**, your psyche collapses, leaving your character **susceptible to suggestions, commands, and intimidation** in the exact same manner as non-player characters.

HEALING ACROSS SCOPES

Recovery is divided into two distinct medical methodologies based on trauma severity: **Lesser Healing** restores standard Light Wounds, while **Greater Healing** represents intensive medical intervention capable of repairing Aggravated Wounds.

Opportunities for recovery depend directly on the scene's pacing:

- **Moment-to-Moment Pacing:** Under active fire, healing is restricted to rapid tactical items (such as Field Medi-Kits, Neuro-Stabilizers, or class chems), functioning according to their specific item capacity.
- **Place-to-Place Pacing (Short Rest):** When the cell catches its breath during exploration, operatives access Lesser Healing through a Short Rest. Roll a **Success Test** using **Endurance + Willpower**. For every **2 Success Points** generated (rounded down), heal 1 Light Wound segment on Physical or Mental Condition.
- **Day-to-Day Pacing (Long Rest):** During extended downtime, operatives gain access to Greater Healing. Roll a **Success Test** using **Endurance + Willpower**. Generated Success Points can be allocated freely:
  - **1 Success Point:** Heals 1 Light Wound segment.
  - **2 Success Points:** Clears 1 Aggravated Wound segment.

  Dedicated ship medbays and planetary clinics provide additional diagnostic bonuses.

CONDITION & RECOVERY IN ACTION

During a fierce orbital warehouse raid, Jax takes **8 physical damage** from a close-range shotgun blast. Jax has an **Endurance of 3**, giving his Physical Condition three sequential Tracks of **7 segments each** (4 + 3).

The first 7 points of damage fill **Track I** completely with Light Wounds. Jax marks his **Strength** Attribute as **Impaired**, meaning any future test involving Strength suffers **1 Downgrade**.

The 1 point of overflow damage turns 1 Light Wound on Track I into an **Aggravated Wound** (leaving Track I with 6 Light Wounds and 1 Aggravated Wound). Any subsequent damage will now overflow into Track II.

Later, back aboard their cutter during a **Long Rest**, Jax makes an **Endurance (3) + Willpower (2)** Success Test rolled with his lower Attribute (**Willpower 2**), rolling `[4, 9]`. The `9` yields **9 base Success Points**.

Jax spends **2 Success Points** to clear the 1 Aggravated Wound on Track I (costing 2 SP per segment), and spends **6 Success Points** to heal the remaining 6 Light Wounds on Track I (costing 1 SP per segment).

Because Track I is completely cleared and no longer full, Jax removes the **Impaired** condition from his Strength Attribute, restoring his rolls to full baseline capability.

TRAITS CATALOG

Beyond raw Attributes and learned Skills, operatives are defined by unique Traits—specialized operational doctrines, combat reflexes, and tactical habits forged on the fringe.

Traits grant distinctive mechanical exceptions, alter action economies, enhance team coordination, or unlock decisive reactions.

ACQUIRING TRAITS

Operatives acquire Traits by spending **Experience Points (XP)**. Each Trait is an independent asset with a flat XP cost between 2 XP and 8 XP. There are no prerequisite trees or artificial gatekeeping:

- **Character Creation:** Spend your starting XP pool (6 XP base; 8 XP hybrids; 10 XP humans) on any Traits.
- **Campaign Advancement:** Spend earned mission XP during day-to-day downtime training to unlock new Traits permanently.

TRAITS IN ACTION: CATWALK INTERDICTION

Jax breaches an orbital cargo bay holding the **Duelist** (3 XP) and **Counter Striker** (4 XP) Traits.

Rushing onto an isolated gantry to intercept an outlaw enforcer, Jax and the target are the only occupants on that space, immediately activating **Duelist** for **+2 Upgrades** on his melee strike.

When the outlaw counter-attacks with a combat knife rolling a single Hit (an 8), Jax spends 1 AP to react with a **Contest Roll**, rolling `[4, 7, 9]`. Scoring a `9`, Jax eliminates the outlaw's Hit. Thanks to **Counter Striker**, Jax doesn't just parry—he redirects the blade's momentum to deal **9 damage** (his highest contest die) directly to the attacker.

MELEE COMBAT TRAITS

Optimized for hand-to-hand engagements, boarding operations, and close-quarters scuffles:

BRAWLER

Cost: 2 XP

You cannot be outnumbered in melee; hostile creatures gain no Upgrades from Outnumbering when attacking you.

COMBO MASTER

Cost: 5 XP

You can spend one **Gambit** die to perform an additional melee attack (paying 1 AP as normal), even if the Player Turn would normally end.

COUNTER STRIKER

Cost: 4 XP

If you fully eliminate all Hits when contesting a melee attack, you can deal damage to one attacking creature equal to the highest value you rolled on the **Contest Roll**.

DUELIST

Cost: 3 XP

You gain +2 **Upgrades** on all melee attacks and contests against a creature in your space if you two are the only ones occupying that space.

INTERCEPTOR

Cost: 2 XP

When you successfully contest a creature's movement, you can deal damage to that creature equal to the highest value you rolled on the **Contest Roll**.

STRIKER

Cost: 3 XP

Your unarmed attacks deal bonus damage equal to your **Endurance**.

RANGED COMBAT & ORDNANCE

These traits refine firearms handling, tactical marksmanship, and the lethal deployment of heavy explosives under suppressive fire.

MARKSMAN

Cost: 4 XP

You can treat your target as being one **Range Band** closer or further for the purpose of determining weapon **Accuracy**.

RAPID FIRE

Cost: 6 XP

You can spend one **Gambit** die to perform an additional ranged attack (paying 1 AP as normal), even if the Player Turn would normally end.

GUNSLINGER

Cost: 4 XP

You ignore the 3 Downgrades for firing a ranged weapon while engaged in Close Quarters Combat (CQC).

SHARPSHOOTER

Cost: 7 XP

You ignore Protection bonuses granted by cover and the 2 Downgrades from firing into Close Quarters Combat (CQC).

BOMBARDIER

Cost: 3 XP

When you activate a **Crit Effect** on a test made with Ordnance, each spent Hit increases Success Points (damage) by +3 instead of +2.

CONTROLLED BLAST

Cost: 8 XP

When you use an item or ability that deals damage to all creatures in one or more spaces, you can choose any number of creatures in the area of effect to be completely unaffected by the blast.

DEFENSE & RESILIENCE

Bolstering physical endurance, mental grit, and bodyguard interception when under heavy hostile barrage.

BODYGUARD

Cost: 5 XP

When you contest an attack targeting an ally in your space, you gain +2 **Upgrades** on your **Contest Roll**.

IRON WILL

Cost: 4 XP

You gain +2 **Willpower**. This does not increase any other Attributes.

STOIC

Cost: 5 XP

You gain Mental Protection equal to your **Willpower**.

LIGHTNING REFLEXES

Cost: 8 XP

Once per round, you can contest one incoming attack targeting you without spending an Action Point (0 AP).

TOUGH AS NAILS

Cost: 6 XP

You gain +2 **Endurance**. This does not increase any other Attributes.

THICK SKIN

Cost: 7 XP

You gain Physical Protection equal to your **Endurance** while not wearing armor.

STEALTH & INFILTRATION

Specialized doctrines for operatives moving through enemy sensor sweeps and ventilation shafts.

SEASONED STALKER

Cost: 5 XP

If the turn ends with you hidden from all non-ally creatures, you can pay one **Gambit** die to take one more action, paying its Action Point cost (1 AP) as normal.

SNEAK ATTACK

Cost: 3 XP

When you make an attack against a creature that has not detected you yet, the attack deals +3 bonus damage.

MEDICAL & FIELD SUPPORT

HEALER

Cost: 4 XP

Once per round, when you heal your own or another creature's Physical or Mental Condition, you can heal one additional segment.

TEAMWORK & LEADERSHIP

Synchronizing fireteams, executing delayed actions, and pooling tactical momentum.

COORDINATOR

Cost: 3 XP

When you take part in a **Teamwork** Action, every other participant receives 1 **Upgrade**.

LEADER

Cost: 5 XP

Once per round, when you take part in a **Teamwork** Action, a chosen ally can join the action without spending an Action Point (0 AP).

PLANNER

Cost: 3 XP

When two or more Delayed Actions are triggered in the same turn, you gain a d10 **Gambit** die.

HEART OF THE TEAM

Cost: 4 XP

Allies can freely transfer any Gambit dice they earn to your **Gambit** pool, and you can transfer **Gambit** dice from your pool to allies whenever they are eligible to spend Gambit.

SOCIAL & NEGOTIATION

CLOSER

Cost: 5 XP

You can spend one **Gambit** die to perform a test that involves communication (paying 1 AP as normal), even if the Player Turn would normally end.

IMPRESSIVE

Cost: 2 XP

Your first social interaction test with a creature you have never met before gains +1 **Upgrade**.

GAMBIT & MOMENTUM

CALLED SHOT

Cost: 4 XP

When you add a **Gambit** die to a dice pool before rolling, you can re-roll that **Gambit** die once after the roll.

DOUBLE DOWN

Cost: 5 XP

When you spend two or more **Gambit** dice on a single test, those **Gambit** dice step up to d12s.

DRAW TWO

Cost: 4 XP

When you earn a **Gambit** die, if your **Gambit** pool was previously empty, you gain an additional d8 **Gambit** die.

CHARACTER ADVANCEMENT

As operatives execute warrants, survive firefights, and navigate corporate intrigues, they accumulate Experience Points (XP) to advance their innate capabilities.

EARNING EXPERIENCE POINTS

XP is earned through two primary engines: **operational missions** and **downtime training**.

MISSIONS & CONTRACT TIERS

When a cell successfully completes an operational warrant, each participating operative receives a flat XP award based on threat tier:

CONTRACT THREAT TIERS & REWARDS

TIER	SCOPE & THREAT LEVEL	XP AWARD	REPUTATION
Tier 1	Local interdictions, precinct patrol, minor asset recovery	**+4 XP**	+1 to +2 Rep
Tier 2	Cross-jurisdictional strikes, black-ops, hostile boardings	**+8 XP**	+3 to +5 Rep
Tier 3	Systemic crises, Precursor incursions, fleet actions	**+12 XP**	+7 to +10 Rep

DOWNTIME TRAINING DRILLS

Between contracts, operatives can spend downtime studying tactical theory or practicing combat drills. Spending **1 Day-to-Day Action Point (AP)** on training awards **1 XP**.

- **Strict Daily Limit:** To reflect biological conditioning limits, an operative can earn a **maximum of 1 XP from Training per 24-hour round** (spending at most 1 Day-to-Day AP on training). The remaining 2 AP must be allocated to other activities (medical rest, starship maintenance, odd jobs, personal research).
- **Closing the Gap:** Downtime training serves primarily to top off the final 1 or 2 XP needed for a new Trait, Skill rank, or Attribute increase before deployment.

IMPROVING ATTRIBUTES

To improve an Attribute, pay XP equal to **three times the new target level**. You can only advance one level at a time:

ATTRIBUTE ADVANCEMENT COSTS

TARGET LEVEL	XP REQUIRED	NARRATIVE CAPABILITY SCALE
Level 2	6 XP	Basic operational competency.
Level 3	9 XP	Standard field agent proficiency.
Level 4	12 XP	Highly trained veteran specialist.
Level 5	15 XP	Elite sector-level capability.
Level 6	18 XP	Master-class human conditioning.
Level 7	21 XP	Peak biological performance.
Level 8	24 XP	The absolute physical/cybernetic limit.

LEARNING & UPGRADING SKILLS

To learn or improve a Skill, pay XP equal to **two times the new target level**. Advance one level at a time:

SKILL ADVANCEMENT COSTS

TARGET LEVEL	XP REQUIRED	FIELD COMPETENCY SCALE
Level 1	2 XP	Basic field familiarity (+1 Upgrade).
Level 2	4 XP	Advanced specialist standard (+2 Upgrades).
Level 3	6 XP	Elite master-class authority (+3 Upgrades).

CHASSIS HARDWARE UPGRADES

In Corsair, your Class is manufactured hardware interfacing with your neural port—not biological experience. Consequently, chassis do not advance via XP.

Operatives upgrade their MANTLE chassis by financing precision biomedical retrofits, micro-machined parts, and firmware overclocks with **Credits** during day-to-day downtime.

STANDARDIZED CHASSIS PROGRESSION

All five MANTLE chassis follow an identical five-tier upgrade path:

CHASSIS LEVEL PROGRESSION

LEVEL	BENEFITS UNLOCKED	COST	MILESTONE
Level 1	Base Chassis, 7 Attribute Points (1/1/1 base), Starting Package, Engine	**Free***	Commissioning as an operative.
Level 2	+1 Class Attribute Point, +1 Ability Package (3 Abilities)	**20,000 Cr**	Field-tested optimization.
Level 3	+1 Class Attribute Point, +1 Mod Slot (Slot 1), +1 Ability Package	**40,000 Cr**	Unlocks first signature overclock.
Level 4	+1 Class Attribute Point, +1 Ability Package (All Packages Unlocked)	**75,000 Cr**	Complete omnirole flexibility.
Level 5	+1 Class Attribute Point, +1 Mod Slot (Slot 2)	**150,000 Cr**	Dual-overclock peak capability.

*The Level 1 chassis chosen at character creation is free. Purchasing an additional chassis during downtime costs 100,000 Credits.

CLASS MODS (HARDWARE OVERCLOCKS)

Class Mods represent high-end firmware alterations and mechanical customizations that bend the chassis's core operating rules:

- **Fixed Cost:** Each Class Mod costs **25,000 Credits**.
- **Mod Sockets:** Operatives unlock **Mod Slot 1 at Level 3** and **Mod Slot 2 at Level 5**, supporting up to two active mods simultaneously per chassis.
- **Swapping Mods:** Operatives can freely swap between owned mods during day-to-day downtime at zero cost.

CHASSIS OWNERSHIP & SWAPPING

Due to metabolic strain and neural bandwidth limits, an operative can have **only one active chassis equipped at a time**.

During downtime, an operative can purchase additional chassis frames for **100,000 Credits** each and calibrate them to their neural port. Upgraded levels, attribute ratings, and installed mods are tied to each physical chassis frame and are permanently preserved whenever an operative swaps suits in the hangar.

> **THE CREDIT ECONOMY BALANCE**
>
> Because gear, starship components, and chassis levels all compete for earned contract Credits, players face meaningful strategic decisions between buying heavy ordnance, upgrading their personal MANTLE frame, or investing in the cell's shared starship.

CELL ADVANCEMENT & STANDING

While individual operatives advance their personal conditioning and gear, the Corsair Cell also possesses its own collective advancement system.

The Cell is both an asset and an investment in the eyes of its Sponsors. Cells hold a letter-grade clearance rank from **Grade D to Grade S**, advancing based on accumulated **Reputation**.

THE REPUTATION LADDER

Crossing reputation thresholds triggers a formal **Rank Evaluation** with your Sponsors:

RANK PROMOTION REWARDS & CLEARANCES

RANK	REP	DISCRETIONARY BONUS	SHIP FUNDS	MARKET CLEARANCE
Grade D	0–14	—	—	Greenhorn charter; local contracts.
Grade C	15 Rep	$20,000 Cr / op	$5,000,000 Cr	Regional trade networks, commercial hull mods.
Grade B	40 Rep	$45,000 Cr / op	$10,000,000 Cr	Restricted EW packages, medium frigate hulls.
Grade A	75 Rep	$75,000 Cr / op	$25,000,000 Cr	Military spinal mounts, heavy destroyers.
Grade S	120 Rep	$100,000 Cr / op	$50,000,000 Cr	Sponsor black-tech, flagship-tier hulls.

Discretionary Bonuses are distributed directly to each operative. **Ship Funds** are restricted strictly to purchasing, repairing, and refitting the cell's starship.

POST-GRADE S PRESTIGE: THE LEGEND CYCLE

Achieving Grade S represents the summit of the Sphere's operational hierarchy. To reward continued legendary service:

- **The Legend Cycle:** Every time a Grade S Cell accumulates an additional **+30 Reputation** beyond the 120 baseline (e.g., hitting 150, 180, 210 Rep), they trigger a **Prestige Evaluation**.
- **The Recurring Payday:** Clearing this evaluation grants each operative a fresh **$100,000 Credit Discretionary Bonus**, and injects **$20,000,000 Credits** into the ship fund.
- **High Stakes:** Reputation losses are doubled for an active Grade S Cell.

REPUTATION FLUX & DEMOTIONS

Reputation is volatile and reflects institutional trust:

- **Mission Rewards:** Tier 1 (+1 Rep), Tier 2 (+3 Rep), Tier 3 (+7 Rep), with sponsor bonus consensus adding up to +1 to +3 Rep.
- **Objective Failure:** -2 to -5 Rep (asset destroyed, target escapes).
- **Illegal Activity:** -3 to -8 Rep (caught operating outside mandate).
- **Sponsor Slight:** -1 to -3 Rep (defying sponsor directives).
- **Idle Penalties:** If a full **5-Day Upkeep Cycle** passes without completing a contract, standing decays.
- **Rank Demotions:** If Reputation drops below a rank threshold, the cell enters a 1-cycle grace period to restore standing. Failing to recover strips the rank. A cell falling below Grade D is expelled from the Corsair program.

THE MATHEMATICS OF THE GREAT TITHE

A CORSAIR STORY • FICTION INTERLUDE

The primary difficulty with possessing four arms, Skrix had long concluded, was that it gave the universe four distinct opportunities to make you drop something valuable.

Floating in the zero-gravity cargo hold of the *Rust-Weevil*, Skrix used his two upper hands to cling stubbornly to an overhead structural pipe while his two lower hands wrestled with a rusty iron pry-bar. His multifaceted compound eyes, each made of three thousand iridescent hexagonal lenses, twitched with focused irritation as he attempted to unjam the lid of a dented steel crate. Around him, the air smelled of scorched insulation, old sweat, and the sharp, sour tang of cheap hydrazine thruster exhaust—the universal scent of Scavenger domesticity.

"Mind the seal, Skrix," muttered Krikk, who was suspended upside-down three feet away, his magnetic boot-clamps locked onto the ribbed steel deck-plate. Krikk was young, had an unbroken glossy sheen to his dark-brown chitin, and still possessed that tragic, starry-eyed optimism common to third-tier raiders who had not yet been shot in the thorax. "The Raiding Captain said if we dent the casing, he's deducting two marks of ration chits from our tally."

"The Raiding Captain," Skrix rasped, his lower mandibles clicking together in a dry, rhythmic clatter that sounded like two dry sticks being snapped in an empty tin, "can take his *krskva* ration chits and shove them straight up his *skvskrsk*. Sideways, if he prefers. Without grease, if he insists on this being finished before the third shift."

With a screech of protesting iron, the crate lid popped free, drifting lazily into the center of the hold.

Inside, cushioned in layers of scorched thermal insulation, lay the true prize of their lightning raid on a frontier research dig along the Wanabo border: an intact Precursor catalytic core. To the ivory-tower physicists at the Sphere Research Center, it was a priceless impossibility—a brick-sized slab of seamless black glass whose non-baryonic lattice resonated with the diffuse dark matter halo of the Sphere, silently transmuting invisible cosmic mass into a steady, boundless flow of direct electrical current. To Skrix and Krikk, it was something far simpler and infinitely more sacred: a battery that never ran dry. You could clamp copper leads to either pole of the cold glass, bolt it into the belly of an asteroid scow, and run life-support scrubbers, target radars, and railgun capacitor banks for two centuries without burning a single droplet of precious helium-3 fuel. Right now, it pulsed with a slow, dull violet rhythm that made the magnetic clamps on Skrix's boots tingle—pulled straight from a freshly unearthed Vault trench before the Sphere Research Center could slap their quarantine beacons on it.

And stuffed around the edges—crammed into the empty corners by two greedy grunts while the perimeter sirens were still wailing—lay the common salvage they had snatched for personal keeping: seven copper water-pipe elbows, a cracked diagnostic slate, a spool of braided wire, and four dented cans of preserved Landfall peaches in heavy syrup.

Krikk's antennae stood straight up in predatory excitement. His upper claws reached reverently toward the black glass, but his lower claws drifted immediately toward the food.

"Look at that catalytic core, Skrix! Pure Vault stock! The Collector himself will sing through the comms when the Chief slides that down the chute! And real fruit! Skrix, by the holy chitin of the Maker, between the relic bounty and the scrap, we're going to buy ourselves onto the second deck! I'm taking one of the peach tins. I've never tasted fruit that didn't come out of a nutrient paste injector."

Skrix sighed—a wet, rattling hiss that escaped through six thoracic spiracles along his ribcage. He reached down with his lower-left claw, plucked the boy's reaching hand out of the air, and shoved him back toward his tether.

"You are not taking the peaches, Krikk. You are not taking the wire. The core belongs to the Chief the second we clear the airlock, and if you are exceptionally lucky with the rest, you might be allowed to keep three shavings of copper dust to scrape between your molars for flavor."

"That's against the rules!" Krikk protested, his four hands waving in symmetrical indignation. "We were the breach-runners! We bled for this salvage! The rules say raiders get fifty percent of whatever personal pickings they haul out!"

"The rules," Skrix said patiently, wrapping a frayed webbing strap around the copper pipes so they wouldn't float into the ventilation grille, "were written by someone who had four arms, six eyes, and an immense ledger, and who was standing behind a reinforced blast bulkhead twelve decks above your head. Allow me to explain the holy mathematics of the Great Tithe, as revealed to our ancestors by the Collector himself."

Skrix held up the four cans of peaches, two in each upper hand, like a priest demonstrating the mysteries of the cosmos to an especially dim-witted acolyte.

"There are four cans," Skrix began. "A clean, harmonious number. You and I bled for them. Therefore, we present them to Raiding Captain Vorash alongside the Vault relic. Captain Vorash looks at the four cans and immediately discovers that the holy cause requires two of them. One for ship's maintenance—because hydrazine doesn't grow on space rocks—and one as the Captain's Discretionary Tithe, which he will eat while watching us scrub the bilge on the bridge camera. That leaves two cans."

Krikk's mandibles clicked rapidly. "One for you, one for me."

"Do not gallop ahead of the theology," Skrix snapped, tapping Krikk on the head with the flat of the pry-bar. "Captain Vorash does not own this bucket of rust. The *Rust-Weevil* belongs to Clan Vrag-Kresh. When we dock at the Outward Spire of the Hoard, Clan Chief Gresh-Mor will board the vessel with eight enforcers wearing powered carapaces. The Chief will take the Precursor core—naturally—and then he will inspect our remaining two cans. He will explain that Clan Vrag-Kresh is currently in an expensive trade dispute with the Iron Fang cartel over salvage rights to a derelict ore barge, and therefore the Clan requires a mandatory fifty percent sovereignty tax on all personal scrap. There goes the third can."

Krikk's antennae drooped, folding flat against the crown of his carapace. "Leaving... one can."

"Leaving one can," Skrix agreed somberly. "And then, young Krikk, comes the majesty of creation itself. Our great, sprawling, glorious junk-world: the Hoard. A moon made entirely of four centuries of stolen titanium, twisted bulkheads, dormant Precursor coils, and crushed dreams, all orbiting the outer dark like a massive, metallic tumor. At the center of the Hoard sits the Collector."

Skrix paused, bowing his head slightly and making the ceremonial four-fingered sign of the Clasped Fist over his primary heart.

"Our father. A veritable God of Greed. An immortal cosmic intelligence capable of calculating the trajectory of every photon in the cluster, who uses that unfathomable intellect to catalog every bent nail and canned peaches we bring them. When Clan Chief Gresh-Mor approaches the Golden Chute to present the Clan's monthly tribute, the Collector's automated collection maw will descend from the vaulted ceiling. The Collector will receive the catalytic core with divine satisfaction, look down upon the final can of peaches, register its barcode, determine that canned sugar is a rare and unique cultural complexity not currently cataloged in the Archives, and suck it into the celestial vaults forever. In return, he will radiate a warm, benevolent wave of cosmic static that bestows a five-percent reduction on our Clan's annual reproductive licensing fee."

Krikk stared at the empty space between Skrix's hands, his multifaceted eyes dimming in profound, bureaucratic despair. "So... what do we get?"

"We get the lid," Skrix said brightly, handing him the jagged circle of stamped tin. "If you lick the rim very carefully, you can sometimes detect the phantom molecular ghost of high-fructose corn syrup without severing your tongue. It builds character. It makes you lean and hungry for the next raid."

Krikk drifted backward into his safety webbing, curling all four limbs inward until he looked like an oversized, disgruntled walnut. "The Sphere is a miserable place, Skrix. Everything out there wants to kill us, and everything in here wants to charge us for the privilege."

"Of course it is," Skrix said, securing the cargo straps with brisk, practiced yanks. "Survival is purely an exercise in knowing which particular horror is currently attempting to turn your thorax inside out, and running in the opposite direction with your loot tucked securely under your second pair of arms."

"What's the worst one?" Krikk asked quietly, peering out through the small, thick quartz viewport at the cold, star-dusted blackness of the frontier void. "The Orks?"

"The Orks are loud, but they are honest," Skrix muttered, pulling a greasy rag from his utility pouch to polish the grit from his leg joints. "An Ork doesn't bother with subtlety. Their entire design philosophy is taking a heavy naval hull, strapping four times as much reactor thrust to the back as the frame was built to handle, and bolting the biggest, ugliest cannons they can forge to the front. You run into an Orkish gunboat in the Wanabo buffer, and what happens? They don't hail you. They don't threaten to board. They just roll out heavy broadside macro-cannons the size of factory smokestacks and fire eight-hundred-millimeter high-explosive shells until the space around you is mostly shrapnel and expanding fire. If an Ork hits you, you don't need a medical kit, Krikk; you need an envelope so your clan can mail your ashes home. But an Orkish ship is the size of an apartment block and burns hot enough to light up the passive sensors three sectors away. You see his drive flare coming from half an astronomical unit out, and you run."

"And the Flotilla?"

Skrix shuddered, his carapace plates shivering against one another with a dry, papery rustle. "The Flotilla isn't scary until you look at the sensor board. With an Ork, you can hear him screaming through the bulkhead. With the Flotilla, you're drifting through an orbital lane three light-seconds out, thinking you're completely alone, and suddenly your console pings with a prerecorded, agonizingly polite radio chime. A calm, bored voice informs you that under Section 123, Sub-clause XYZ of the whatever mumbo jumbo, your unregistered transponder has violated sovereign orbital clearance. And while the voice is still reading the second paragraph of the legal citation, an eight-hundred-meter capital frigate three thousand kilometers away fires a two-ton solid tungsten dart from an electromagnetic spinal railgun. You don't even see the ship. You just see a flash of relativistic light, and suddenly your engine block is a cloud of hot copper vapor. They don't even raise their voices, Krikk. It's just clerks with three-mile kinetic lances."

"What about the tall ones on X'ara?" Krikk asked, his voice hushed. "The Ancestrals?"

"Worse," Skrix hissed. "They don't even have the decency to use radios. You land on an Ancestral moon by mistake to pick through an ancient spire, and they don't shout, they don't shoot slug-throwers, they don't even breathe. They just step out of the shadows in those shimmering, bone-white silks, gliding across the floor without touching the dust. You point your rifle at them, you pull the trigger, and the slug just stops in mid-air, drops to the floorboards, and then a singing spear made of hard light slides through your primary breastplate before you can finish blinking all your eye-facets. And they look at you while you die—not with hatred, mind you. Hatred would be flattering. They look at you the way a fastidious housekeeper looks at an oily smudge on an antique crystal goblet."

"And the dragons?"

"The dragons?" Skrix shuddered violently, all four of his claws locking tight around his pry-bar. "Do not even speak of the dragons, Krikk. Those are not beasts. They are giant, hungry nightmares living out in the black. You see a shadow in the dark that blots out the stars, and then two eyes open that burn like suns. They chew through ten inches of hull plating like dried kelp just to drink the fuel from your engines. When a dragon finds you, there is no fight, no boarding, and no escape—just a flash of fire, your ship crushed like an eggshell, and you're gone. But even a dragon is huge. You see the heat on your screens from millions of miles off. You keep your lights off, you drift cold, and you pray to the Collector it finds someone else to eat."

Krikk uncurled slightly, scratching at his mandible. "So what is it, then? If you can run from an Ork gunboat, avoid a Flotilla frigate, and drift cold past a dragon... what is the worst thing in the Sphere?"

Skrix lowered his tools. His four hands settled flat against his chitinous knees. When he spoke, his voice was barely a dry scrape of wind through his spiracles.

"Corsairs."

Krikk blinked his upper four eyes, then his lower two. "Corsairs? The Chief said they're just small-time scavengers. A few people in a little boat."

"The Chief," Skrix said with venomous precision, "is an old fat tick who hasn't left his cushioned couch in twenty years, and the only exercise he gets is chewing synthetic kelp and counting his share of our misery. Listen to me, boy. The Orks, the Flotilla, the dragons—what do they all have in common? They are big. They are loud. You can see them coming. An Ork gunboat spits fire across half the sky. A Flotilla warship lights up the void like a lantern. Even a wild dragon burns hot enough to blind your sensors. If you keep your eyes open, you can see them from millions of miles away. You cut your engines, tuck behind an asteroid, hold your breath, and let them pass."

Skrix leaned in close, his antennae twitching against Krikk's forehead.

"You don't see a Corsair coming, Krikk. That's what makes them terrifying."

"Why? Are their ships fast?"

"Their ships look like *nothing*," Skrix whispered. "They don't fly battleships. They fly a tiny little boat no bigger than a cargo hopper. No giant guns. No big glowing engines. They run cold and quiet through the dark. You glance at your sensor screen, you think it's a drifting rock or an empty piece of scrap. You don't run, because you don't even know you're being hunted. And then—their clamps hit your hull."

Krikk's mandibles clicked rapidly. "And then?"

"And then three people climb through your hatch. Maybe four. Not an army. Just three or four small creatures in plain, scuffed suits."

"Just three?" Krikk asked, his antennae tilting with skepticism. "Against a whole raiding crew?"

"That's the trap, boy. You look at them and think, *'There's only three of them. We have claws, we have guns, we can kill them.'* And before you even raise your weapon, you're already on the deck."

"How?"

"Because they don't yell. They don't posture. They just move. Fast. Faster than you can think. One of them grabs your barrel, snaps your wrist like a dry twig, and pins you to the wall with one hand. Another one slips right past you, clears the whole corridor in four seconds, and puts a dart into the Captain before he even gets out of his chair. They don't look like monsters, Krikk. They look like tired people doing a chore. And by the time your brain figures out that you're under attack, your arms are zip-tied behind your back, your loot is in their bag, and they're walking back to their ship complaining about the draft."

Krikk swallowed hard, his throat clicking. "Have you... seen that happen?"

"Three years ago," Skrix whispered, shivering until his carapace plates rattled against his ribcage. "On an abandoned fuel station. Our raiding team was stripping copper conduits when their cutter docked. No warning sirens, no drive flare. Just a quiet hiss, and suddenly three of them were in the corridor."

"What did you do?" Krikk asked wide-eyed. "Did you fight them?"

"Fight them?" Skrix looked at the boy like he had suggested chewing on a live plasma torch. "I fell face-first into a puddle of cold machine oil, curled all four of my arms tight against my belly, tucked my antennae under my collar, and played dead. I played so dead I stopped my secondary heart from beating."

"Did it work?"

"One of them walked right past me," Skrix said, his voice dropping to a trembling rasp. "Tapped my shell with the toe of a scuffed boot. Said to the other one: *'Don't bother with that one, it's already popped.'* I lay in that puddle of freezing oil for four hours without blinking an eye-facet, Krikk. Four hours. I didn't dare breathe until their thruster wake was two light-minutes out."

Krikk looked around the dimly lit cargo hold, suddenly finding the cold shadows between the storage lockers far more threatening than he had two minutes ago. "Well... at least we're four days out from the Wanabo frontier line. Nothing can track a dead-burn ballistic vector through the outer asteroid belt without active radar, and if anyone lit up active radar, our passive sensors would—"

A sharp, shrill electronic ping chimed across the sensor console.

Skrix froze. All four of his hands remained locked in place, suspended in mid-air.

Then came the urgent, double-pulsed chime of an emergency proximity alarm.

From the cockpit three compartments forward, a muffled, panicked scream tore through the intercom, followed immediately by the frantic clicking of Raiding Captain Vorash's terrified mandibles:

"All hands! All hands to breach stations! We've got an un-identified contact on our dorsal blind spot! No drive plume! No transponder! They were riding our exhaust shadow!"

Before Krikk could even reach for his slug-thrower, the entire five-hundred-ton hull of the *Rust-Weevil* groaned with a sickening shudder, like an iron anvil dropped onto an empty steel drum.

It wasn't the violent, tearing collision of an Orkish cannon shell. It was the heavy, precision bite of pneumatic magnetic harpoons—four heavy steel tethers punching through the outer micrometeorite shielding and locking onto the structural keel with hydraulic finality.

Directly above their heads, on the exterior surface of the cargo bay's primary airlock hatch, came the heavy, rhythmic vibration of magnetic boots pacing across the hull.

Then, through the heavy steel hatch, came a sound that made Skrix's compound eyes dilate in absolute, paralyzing horror.

It was the high-frequency, pressurized hiss of a thermal cutting torch, tracing a neat, rectangular line through the exterior blast seal.

Skrix looked at Krikk. "So, the trick to playing dead is this..."

CLASSES & THE MANTLE SYSTEM

In *Corsair*, your Class is not an abstract RPG profession, cultural caste, or permanent biological destiny. Instead, it represents an advanced, proprietary MANTLE (*Modular Adaptive Neural Transmission Linked Equipment*)—a specialized, aerospace-grade cybernetic and technological chassis engineered for high-intensity tactical operations across planetary gravity wells and the void.

While civilian spacers and commercial security guards rely on standard vac-suits and off-the-shelf ballistic armor, Corsair operatives and fleet specialists wear MANTLEs. These fully integrated tactical rigs synchronize directly with the wearer's central nervous system, translating split-second subconscious impulses into overwhelming kinetic, thermal, chemical, or molecular force.

1. THE NEURAL CONTROL CHIP (NCC)

At the heart of every MANTLE rig lies the **Neural Control Chip (NCC)**. Permanently fused into the base of the operative's skull and cervical spine, the NCC interfaces directly with major motor nerve clusters and sensory pathways through an array of sub-dermal optical conduits and cranial shunt ports.

Operating a MANTLE is not like picking up a rifle or donning a set of body armor; it requires extensive neuro-physical conditioning, biometric calibration, and mental discipline. When an operative jacks into their chassis, the NCC establishes a closed-loop telemetry bridge:

- **Reflex Synchronization:** Actuator servos, capacitor banks, and manifold solenoids respond to motor intentions at the speed of neuro-chemical impulse—bypassing the mechanical latency of physical triggers or levers.
- **Sensory Telemetry:** The operative feels the condition of their chassis as a natural extension of their physical anatomy. A Conduit feels electrostatic charge prickling along their peripheral nerves; a Hazard perceives fluid pressure within their Catalyst Chamber as visceral chest tension; a Pilot senses external drone hull-stress as direct proprioceptive pressure.
- **Air-Gapped Isolation:** Because early neural experiments in human history proved vulnerable to electronic intrusion, all NCC architectures utilize strict, air-gapped optical buses. A MANTLE never communicates with external wireless networks without hardware-isolated firewalls, protecting the operative's brain from cyber-warfare intrusion or rogue signal resonance.

Once surgically installed and bonded to the operative's spinal column, the Neural Control Chip remains a permanent part of the character's body, ready to interface with any authorized MANTLE chassis they acquire.

2. ORIGINS & DISCOVERY

The technology underpinning modern MANTLE rigs was born out of survival and desperation across two centuries of Newcomer history.

THE VAULT DISCOVERIES & EARLY COVENANT (14-60 AA)

Following the founding of Crossroads and the historic alliance with Stormdrinker on Nimbus, early Newcomer researchers venturing into dormant Precursor Vaults discovered fragments of ancient, air-gapped optical-neural bus architecture. While the cosmic purpose of these relics was kept contained under the Covenant's charter to prevent cosmic beacons from firing, cyberneticists studied their inert conductive pathways, laying the theoretical groundwork for bio-compatible neural interfaces.

THE SCAVENGER INCURSIONS & ABE-REDMANE SKUNKWORKS (315-320 AA)

In 315 AA, the peaceful expansion of the Fume cluster was shattered by the **Scavenger Incursions**—brutal raider armadas composed of biologically modified Scav clans. When Scav boarding parties sacked Cloudspire and ambushed civilian transports, Newcomer defense militias were outmatched in close-quarters void combat by the raiders' terrifying biological reaction speeds.

Facing fleet extinction, Commander **Velen Redmane** rallied an independent coalition of spacers and engineers at the **Port Zenith Orbital Engineering Yards**, suspended in the upper atmosphere of Landfall. Redmane commissioned Chief Fleet-Engineer **Kira Abe** to weaponize vault-derived neural bus conduits into an emergency combat harness.

Working around the clock in Port Zenith's zero-gravity skunkworks, Abe's team created the first generation of closed-loop **MANTLE** prototypes. By linking heavy tactical systems directly into the wearer's motor reflexes, strike teams could match and exceed Scav agility in zero-g boarding actions. Equipped with these experimental rigs, Redmane's coalition routed the raiders at the decisive **Battle of Fume Rings (320 AA)**, leading directly to the birth of the Flotilla and the signing of the Skyline Accords (335 AA).

In the two centuries following the Battle of Fume Rings, MANTLE technology evolved through continuous refinement across dozens of production blocks. Early military engineers incorporated dragon biology research—studying the efficient bio-electric resonance of dragon scales and nerve tissue—alongside new discoveries extracted from deep Precursor vaults and hard-won industrial telemetry from the Drift Wars. By the time of the Frontier War (485-508 AA), the MANTLE had matured into the defining tactical platform of modern void combat.

3. THE 518 AA REALITY

In the present day of **518 AA**—ten years after the Fall of the *Evergaol* and the signing of the Great Truce—the production, possession, and maintenance of MANTLE rigs are shaped by post-war realities.

MANTLE ACQUISITION PIPELINES (518 AA)

- **1. Sponsor Candidate Pipelines:** Official patron underwrites NCC surgery and issues a certified fleet rig during elite training, pending Oversight Committee charter.
- **2. The Freelancer Network:** Grassroots fraternity of Corsair veterans and dockside armorers passing down repaired, surplused, or salvaged frames to promising aspirants.
- **3. Post-War Salvage & Black Markets:** Decommissioned war stock or battlefield salvage from the Frontier War repaired in orbital chop-shops and retrofitted with jailbroken firmware.

FLOTILLA CONTROL & LEGAL STATUS

Under the Law of the Void, the Flotilla High Council classifies combat-grade MANTLEs as **Tier-1 Restricted Military Hardware**. Licensed production is tightly restricted to major orbital naval foundries (such as the Bastion Yards at Port Zenith), and unauthorized possession in orbital transit lanes carries severe criminal penalties. However, under the **Skyline Accords (335 AA)**, planetary governments hold sovereign authority within their atmospheric gravity wells, allowing surface colonies, private corporations, and frontier syndicates to license and deploy their own proprietary variants.

For commissioned **Corsairs**, possessing a top-tier MANTLE is an official entitlement of their charter. When an operative joins a chartered cell, their individual Sponsor (Flotilla, Colonial administration, Megacorporation, Union, or Private patron) legally registers and underwrites their chassis, granting them cross-jurisdictional authorization to carry lethal tactical hardware across both orbital space and planetary soil.

Uncommissioned **Freelancers (Aspirants)** acquire starting frames through sponsor candidate pipelines, the informal **Freelancer Network** of veterans and dockside armorers, or restored Frontier War battlefield salvage calibrated in dockside cyber-clinics.

4. THE FIVE BESPOKE CHASSIS

While every MANTLE interfaces through the standardized Neural Control Chip, physical chassis are **not** interchangeable modular shells. Each class represents an entirely bespoke, dedicated full-body frame engineered from aerospace alloys, micro-servos, and specialized tactical hardware:

- **The Conduit:** Engineered as a living capacitor suit, featuring spine-mounted graphene-dielectric plates, subcutaneous energy conduits, and shoulder Peltier thermoelectric heat sinks that vent excess thermal and cryogenic bleed during high-voltage Amp and Burst cycles.
- **The Hazard:** An armored chemical warfare harness housing a pressurized thoracic Catalyst Chamber, micro-solenoid mixing valves, hermetically sealed reagent reservoirs, and chemical-resistant fluoropolymer conduits routed to transdermal dermojets.
- **The Pilot:** A motorized bio-mechanical exoskeleton frame equipped with cranial high-frequency telemetry uplinks, heavy solid-state battery banks, reinforced skeletal shock-absorbers, and dorsal magnetic docking clamps that host an autonomous, articulated Exodrone.
- **The Vanguard:** A high-mobility kinetic assault platform featuring articulated dorsal locking collars, calf-to-spine inertial balance nodes, and micro-servo shock mounts built to catch, wield, and redirect the tremendous torque of a morphing multi-segment kinetic Board.
- **The Weaver:** An advanced molecular fabrication chassis centered around thoracic titanium-ceramic reservoirs housing millions of microscopic alloy nanites, governed by high-frequency magnetic confinement conduits and fluid-fabric kinetic shrouds.

5. NEURO-PHYSICAL INVARIANTS

SINGLE ACTIVE CHASSIS LIMIT (SYNAPTIC SATURATION)

Because the Neural Control Chip establishes a comprehensive bidirectional map between the operative's motor cortex, autonomic nervous system, and suit telemetry, the biological brain can only sustain **one active chassis mapping at a time**.

Attempting to cross-link or equip multiple MANTLE frames simultaneously causes immediate sensory confusion and neurological overload—a life-threatening condition known as **Synaptic Burnout** that results in violent motor seizures, cardiovascular shock, and permanent neural scarring. Consequently, an operative can have **only one MANTLE chassis equipped and active at any time**.

CLASS ATTRIBUTES & STARTING CREATION

Every MANTLE chassis is governed by **three specialized Class Attributes** (e.g., *Flame, Frost, Lightning* for the Conduit; *Venom, Hazard, Serum* for the Hazard; *Power, Speed, Precision* for the Pilot).

- **Starting Values:** All three Class Attributes begin at a baseline of **1** (`1 / 1 / 1`).
- **Creation Budget:** At character creation, spend **7 Class Creation Points** across your three Class Attributes.
- **Point Costs:** Increasing an Attribute from 1 to 4 costs **1 point** per step; raising an Attribute from 4 to 5 costs **2 points**. Maximum starting rating is **5**.

DOWNTIME ACQUISITION & SWAPPING (100,000 CR)

Operatives are not locked into a single chassis for their entire career. During campaign downtime, an operative can purchase an additional bespoke MANTLE chassis for **100,000 Credits**.

This substantial investment reflects the true cost of acquiring an aerospace-grade military frame on the open or grey market, purchasing proprietary firmware licenses or black-market decryption keys, and spending an extended shift in an orbital cyber-clinic to undergo neuro-pod recalibration. During recalibration, the operative's NCC is flushed and flashed with the telemetry profiles of the new frame, preventing synaptic rejection.

Preserved Investment: Attribute ratings, unlocked ability packages, and purchased class mods belong permanently to each specific chassis. When an operative spends downtime swapping from their Conduit MANTLE to their Vanguard MANTLE in the ship's armory, their Vanguard attributes and unlocked combos remain exactly as they left them.

CLASS: THE CONDUIT

The Conduit is the cell's living capacitor and high-intensity shock trooper, defined by total neuro-synaptic integration with a specialized Conduit-pattern MANTLE (*Modular Adaptive Neural Transmission Linked Equipment*). Controlled directly through the operative's permanent Neural Control Chip (NCC) and cranial shunt, the rig synchronizes layered graphene-dielectric capacitor plates and a dense network of subdermal energy conduits mounted along the operative's spine and major limb axes. Translucent fluoropolymer conduits trace along the limbs and torso, glowing with sharp chromatic pulses—radiant amber, sub-zero cerulean, or electric violet—that correspond to their current electromagnetic and thermal saturation. Thermoelectric Peltier arrays and micro-vent heat sinks embedded across the shoulders continuously dissipate ambient thermal bleed, surrounding the Conduit in a shimmering haze of superheated air, drifting ice vapor, or crackling static discharge.

In active combat, the Conduit operates under hard-science principles of rapid energy accumulation, capacitive storage, and directed discharge. Rather than relying on external power cells, the operative's internal plates draw kinetic recoil, thermal friction, and metabolic potential, converting them into a high-density internal charge. As these capacitor banks saturate through tactical Amp maneuvers, the Conduit channels this power into devastating physical and technical feats—accelerating muscle contraction for near-instant bounds, flash-freezing deckplates, or discharging high-voltage arcs across enemy formations. Yet this stored power creates immense systemic tension: holding peak voltage strains internal insulation and elevates core temperatures, demanding that the operative periodically vent their fully saturated plates in catastrophic, encounter-shifting Burst releases.

The modular versatility of the Conduit MANTLE chassis makes them an invaluable asset across every operational theater. An operative can tune their capacitor discharge to deliver high-yield explosive breaching charges and searing thermal barrages to crack armored strongpoints, flash-freeze corridors into impenetrable crystalline barricades to secure a defensive retreat, or defibrillate flatlined cell members with calibrated neuro-electric pulses during frantic firefights. When technical systems fail, the Conduit can overcharge friendly electronics, fabricate temporary tactical gear from polarized plate residue, or surge bodily across the battlefield to dismantle enemy squads. Whatever the mission requires, the Conduit controls the flow of battlefield energy.

ATTRIBUTES

A Conduit's capabilities are governed by three specialized Class Attributes:

- **Flame:** The generation and vectoring of high-thermal incendiary blasts, concussive pressure waves, and kinetic combustion.
- **Frost:** The rapid endothermic extraction of heat, cryogenic crystallization, and molecular structural stabilization.
- **Lightning:** The accumulation and discharge of high-voltage galvanic arcs, electromagnetic pulses, and synaptic acceleration.

At character creation, distribute **7 Class Creation Points** across your Flame, Frost, and Lightning Attributes (baseline 1 / 1 / 1). Raising an Attribute from 1 to 4 costs 1 point per increase; raising an Attribute from 4 to 5 costs 2 points. The maximum starting rating for any Class Attribute is **5**.

BASIC MECHANICS

MINOR TOUCH EFFECTS

Even without a test, you can channel low-voltage currents, focused heat, or endothermic siphons through your bare hands to produce minor narrative effects:

- **Flame:** Warm an object, ignite a pilot light or fuse, dry wet fabric, thaw thin frost, or cauterize a minor surface abrasion.
- **Frost:** Chill a beverage, flash-freeze standing water, solidify a viscous chemical puddle, or soothe a localized burn.
- **Lightning:** Deliver a mild static shock, illuminate a low-voltage LED indicator, ground static interference on a console, or clear visual distortion from a monitor.

MELEE COMBAT

You can channel raw elemental energy through your fists, limbs, and close-quarters weapons, making melee attacks using your Conduit Attributes paired with their corresponding physical Core Attributes:

- **Flame (Thermal / Incendiary):** Favored pair **Flame + Strength**. Unleash concussive kinetic blasts and searing thermal strikes, directing explosive force with muscular might.
- **Frost (Cryogenic Piercing):** Favored pair **Frost + Finesse**. Wield and drive crystalline ice daggers into structural seams and joint seals with pinpoint precision.
- **Lightning (Galvanic Arc):** Favored pair **Lightning + Agility**. Blitz opponents with high-voltage arcing strikes and rapid-fire blows, using electrical potential to augment raw speed.
- **Favored Pair Damage Bonus:** When you make a melee attack using the weapon's favored Attribute Pair, you gain a damage bonus equal to the **lower attribute** in that pair.

EFFECT SYNERGIES

Channeling specific elemental frequencies through your Conduit Attributes enhances the potency of standard tactical Effects:

- **Flame:** When taking a test that uses your Flame attribute, your **Crit Effects** grant **3 Success Points** instead of the standard 2 per Hit sacrificed.
- **Frost:** When taking a test that uses your Frost attribute, any **Blocker Effects** or **Downgrade Effects** you establish become **Sustained Effects** until the end of the round, resetting after each affected attempt until overcome or cleared.
- **Lightning:** When taking a test that uses your Lightning attribute, your **Chain Effects** also increase your total **Success Points by +1**, and you can spend any dice that rolled **7 or higher** to activate them instead of the normal 8 or higher.

THE CHARGE ENGINE

Conduit abilities revolve around the dynamic accumulation and venting of **Charges** held within your subcutaneous capacitor plates:

- **Capacity & Starting State:** Your capacitor plates can hold a maximum of **3 Charges**. You begin every combat encounter at **0 Charges**.
- **Amp Abilities (Charge Generators):**
  - Amp abilities channel raw energy into your plates, building up elemental Charge while delivering immediate tactical advantages.
  - Activating an Amp ability with 0 Charges grants you **1 Charge** of that ability's element type.
  - Activating an Amp ability of the *same* element as your current Charges increases your stored **Charges by 1** (up to the maximum of 3 Charges).
  - Activating an Amp ability of a *different* element than your current Charges immediately resets your stored Charges to 0 before granting 1 Charge of the new element (unless modified by Class Mods).
  - You cannot activate an Amp ability if you already hold the maximum of 3 Charges for that element (unless modified by *Infinity*).
  - You can only activate a single Amp ability per action.
- **Burst Abilities (Charge Venters):**
  - Burst abilities vent your fully saturated capacitor plates in devastating, encounter-defining releases.
  - Burst abilities can only be activated when you hold **exactly 3 Charges** (unless modified by *Finality*).
  - You can only activate the Burst variant corresponding to your currently stored elemental Charge.
  - Activating a Burst ability consumes and vents **all 3 Charges**, resetting your stored Charges to 0.

CLASS ABILITIES

Conduit abilities are organized into **7 thematic packages**, each featuring a paired **Amp Ability** and **Burst Ability** with distinct Flame, Frost, and Lightning branches. Operatives select **1 starting package** at character creation, and unlock **1 additional package** at Levels 2, 3, and 4.

Every ability explicitly declares its **Action Economy Tag**:

- **[Rider]:** Costs **0 additional AP**; enhances or triggers during an existing action (such as a firearm attack, melee strike, or movement action).
- **[Reaction]:** Costs **0 AP**; triggered in response to an external event (such as being targeted by an incoming attack). Limited to once per turn unless noted.
- **[Action]:** Costs **1 AP**; requires rolling a test or deploying an immediate tactical effect.

1. RANGED PACKAGE

The Ranged Package integrates subcutaneous capacitor lines directly with chambered ammunition and ballistic rails, infusing firearm projectiles with elemental payload before venting residual energy in devastating area bombardments.

Amped Shot [Rider]

- **Cost:** 0 AP
- **Trigger:** When declaring a ranged attack with a Firearm.
- **Effect:** *Capacitor shunts bleed raw energy directly into the chambered round as the firing pin strikes.* You gain **+1 Charge** of the chosen element and apply the matching effect to the attack:
  - **Flame:** Ranged attacks deal a flat **+1 Damage Bonus per active Charge** (including the Charge just gained) as superheated thermal jackets detonate on impact.
  - **Frost:** You may reroll a number of dice across all rolls in the test equal to your **active Charges** (including the Charge just gained), freezing your targeting reticle onto structural weak points.
  - **Lightning:** When activating your first **Chain Effect** during the attack test, you can target a number of additional creatures equal to your **active Charges** (including the Charge just gained) without expending additional ammunition.

Blast Burst [Action]

- **Resource Cost:** Requires and consumes 3 Charges
- **Cost:** 1 AP
- **Effect:** *Capacitor plates vent their entire reserve through external projector nozzles in a catastrophic ranged detonation.* Target a space within **Short range (0–5 spaces)** and make a **Conduit Success Test** using the attribute matching your consumed Charges:
  - **Flame:** Searing incendiary blast waves scour the impact zone. You inflict thermal damage equal to your **Success Points + your Flame Attribute** to every creature occupying an **8-meter radius** centered on the target space.
  - **Frost:** A pressurized cryogenic shockwave flash-freezes the atmosphere. You inflict cryogenic damage equal to your **Success Points + your Frost Attribute** to every creature caught in a **90-degree cone, 12 meters long**, originating from your space. In addition, every space caught within the cone becomes **Difficult Terrain** until the end of the round.
  - **Lightning:** A piercing bolt of stepped-leader plasma lances forward. You inflict galvanic damage equal to your **Success Points + your Lightning Attribute** to up to **three chosen creatures** in your space, the target space, or any space intersecting the straight line of fire between them. You can activate **Chain Effects** on this roll to increase the number of targets.

2. MELEE PACKAGE

The Melee Package routes high-density capacitor currents directly through forearm plates and knuckles, supercharging physical strikes with kinetic backblast before venting in an earth-shattering point-blank impact.

Amped Strike [Rider]

- **Cost:** 0 AP
- **Trigger:** When declaring a melee attack or elemental melee strike.
- **Effect:** *Subdermal conduits flash with kinetic energy, amplifying close-quarters impact.* You gain **+1 Charge** of the chosen element and apply the matching effect to the strike:
  - **Flame:** Thermal backblast detonates on contact. The attack deals a flat **+1 Damage Bonus per active Charge** (including the Charge just gained), or you may spend your strike's momentum to **Push** the target 1 space (2 meters) per active Charge.
  - **Frost:** Sub-zero frost coats the target's limbs and servos. For each **active Charge** you hold (including the Charge just gained), apply **1 standard Downgrade** to the target's physical tests until the end of the round.
  - **Lightning:** High-voltage static leaps between targets. If the attack hits, you can chain the strike to **1 additional adjacent enemy per active Charge** (including the Charge just gained) without sacrificing Hits.

Impact Burst [Action]

- **Resource Cost:** Requires and consumes 3 Charges
- **Cost:** 1 AP
- **Effect:** *All capacitor banks vent simultaneously through your striking limb, detonating a point-blank kinetic catastrophe.* Target a creature or reinforced structure in your space or an adjacent space and make a **Conduit Success Test** using the attribute matching your consumed Charges:
  - **Flame (Inferno Impact):** You deliver an explosive punch that inflicts massive thermal damage equal to your **Success Points + your Flame Attribute + 4 bonus damage** to the primary target. In addition, an outward shockwave inflicts damage equal to your **Flame Attribute** to all other hostile creatures in your space and adjacent spaces.
  - **Frost (Glacial Impact):** You drive a flash-freezing spike of solid ice into the target, inflicting damage equal to your **Success Points + your Frost Attribute** and encasing them in dense crystalline frost. This establishes a **Blocker Effect of 3 dice** against all physical and movement actions attempted by the target until the ice is shattered or cleared.
  - **Lightning (Thunder Impact):** A devastating galvanic arc vaporizes air between you and the target, inflicting damage equal to your **Success Points + your Lightning Attribute**. You instantly arc-discharge through the target, reappearing in any unoccupied space up to **8 meters away**; all hostile creatures caught in the line between your starting space and destination take damage equal to your **Lightning Attribute**.

3. MOBILITY PACKAGE

The Mobility Package siphons stored energy into myofibril micro-servos and personal propulsion vents, converting raw electrical and thermal voltage into blinding battlefield traversal.

Amped Sprint [Rider]

- **Cost:** 0 AP
- **Trigger:** When declaring a Movement Action.
- **Effect:** *Internal capacitor loops flood motor pathways and directional thrusters with accelerated voltage.* You gain **+1 Charge** of the chosen element and execute your movement with enhanced parameters scaling with your **active Charges** (including the Charge just gained):
  - **Flame:** Vector thrusters ignite with thermal fury. You gain **+2 meters of movement per active Charge**, and you may **Fly** for the duration of this movement action.
  - **Frost:** Frictionless cryogenic frost glazes the deck beneath your boots. You gain **+2 meters of movement per active Charge**, ignore Difficult Terrain, and leave a trail of **Difficult Terrain** behind you through every space traversed (persisting until the end of the round).
  - **Lightning:** Hyper-accelerated neuro-muscular reflexes twitch at microsecond speeds. You gain **+2 meters of movement per active Charge**, and your movement is **completely uncontested** (it cannot trigger reactions, intercept fire, or blocker effects).

Motion Burst [Action]

- **Resource Cost:** Requires and consumes 3 Charges
- **Cost:** 1 AP
- **Effect:** *You dump all three capacitor banks into full-body acceleration, executing a supersonic blitz across the battlefield.* You move a number of meters equal to your **active Conduit Attribute × 4**, followed immediately by an elemental impact or tactical release:
  - **Flame:** You fly at extreme velocity directly into a hostile target's space. All creatures occupying your destination space suffer thermal collision damage equal to your **Flame Attribute + your Strength Attribute**.
  - **Frost:** You skate across the engagement zone, turning every space traversed into **Difficult Terrain** for enemies. In your final destination space, you instantly manifest a jagged wall of reinforced ice that acts as **Medium Cover (Cover Rating 2, 24 HP, Innate Protection 8)**.
  - **Lightning:** You blitz across the battlefield with blinding speed, making an elemental melee attack against a creature along your path (inflicting standard melee damage + your Lightning Attribute). You may use any remaining movement after the attack to disengage freely. Furthermore, you can activate **Chain Effects** on this attack against **any creature in any space you traversed** during this movement.

4. DEFENSE PACKAGE

The Defense Package channels stored capacitive reserves into reactive dispersion meshes, endothermic kinetic barriers, and high-frequency deflector fields to nullify incoming assaults.

Amped Defense [Reaction]

- **Cost:** 0 AP
- **Trigger:** Once per turn, when you are targeted by an incoming attack.
- **Effect:** *Reactive capacitor circuits discharge defensively before the incoming strike lands.* You gain **+1 Charge** of the chosen element and apply the matching defensive protection scaling with your **active Charges** (including the Charge just gained):
  - **Flame:** Thermal flare vents outward. If the attacker occupies your space or an adjacent space, they immediately take thermal counter-damage equal to your **Flame Attribute + your active Charges**.
  - **Frost:** Endothermic plates flash-freeze ambient moisture across your torso. You gain **+1 Physical Protection per active Charge** against this incoming attack.
  - **Lightning:** An electrostatic distortion field crackles around your chassis. If you contest the incoming attack, you gain a number of **Upgrades to the Contest Roll equal to your active Charges** (including the Charge just gained).

Shield Burst [Reaction]

- **Resource Cost:** Requires and consumes 3 Charges
- **Cost:** 0 AP
- **Trigger:** When you or an ally in your space are targeted by an incoming attack.
- **Effect:** *You dump your entire capacitor reserve in an emergency defensive surge, contesting the incoming attack for free (0 AP) using your active Conduit Attribute:*
  - **Flame:** A concussive thermal explosion engulfs your perimeter. All creatures other than you in your space take damage equal to **Flame Attribute + Your Conduit Level**.
  - **Frost:** A reinforced crystalline ice cocoon locks across your position. You may create **Medium Cover** in your current space.
  - **Lightning:** You dodge the attack with immense speed. You can move a number of meters equal to your highest die plus your **Lightning Attribute**.

5. RESTORATION PACKAGE

The Restoration Package routes delicate micro-currents and regulated thermal gradients through cardiovascular pathways, stimulating cellular mitosis, stabilizing shock, and defibrillating flatlined allies.

Amped Regen [Action]

- **Cost:** 1 AP (0 AP if activated as a Reaction via Lightning)
- **Trigger:** Once per Player Turn, as long as you have Light Wounds (or Light Stress in the case of Frost), or immediately after taking damage if using Lightning.
- **Effect:** *Precision bio-electric currents stimulate rapid cellular granulation and synaptic stabilization.* You gain **+1 Charge** of the chosen element and heal **Light Wounds equal to your active Charges** (including the Charge just gained). In addition:
  - **Flame:** Searing thermal cauterization closes hemorrhaging instantly; heal **+1 additional Light Wound** (healing total Light Wounds equal to your **active Charges + 1**).
  - **Frost:** Endothermic biogel soothes trauma; you may choose to heal either **Light Wounds** or **Light Stress**.
  - **Lightning:** Galvanic defibrillation triggers on instinct; this ability can be activated as a **Reaction (0 AP) immediately after taking damage**, but if activated in this way, you cannot activate Amped Regen on your next Player Turn.

Healing Burst [Free Action]

- **Resource Cost:** Requires and consumes 3 Charges
- **Cost:** 0 AP
- **Target:** You or a single ally occupying your current space.
- **Effect:** *Your plates release a massive metabolic and neuro-electrical surge to reconstruct damaged tissue, supercharge adrenaline, and restart stopped hearts.* The chosen target heals **Light Wounds or Light Stress** (recipient's choice) equal to your **chosen elemental Attribute + your Willpower or Toughness** (your choice). In addition, based on the element consumed:
  - **Flame:** Searing thermal stimulation and metabolic overdrive stoke fiery vigor; the target gains **+1 Upgrade** on all **Strength** and **Presence** tests for the rest of the round.
  - **Frost:** Endothermic crystalline biogel flash-freezes across vitals; the target gains **+1 Upgrade** on all **Finesse** tests for the rest of the round, and gains **+4 Protection** against the next attack targeting the recipient that would hit.
  - **Lightning:** Galvanic cardiac-synaptic resuscitation surges through reflexes; the target gains **+1 Upgrade** on all **Agility** tests for the rest of the round, and this ability can resurrect the target if they died during the current round, immediately reviving them to consciousness with their healed Light Wounds.

6. PROWESS PACKAGE

The Prowess Package bridges internal capacitor storage with everyday physical, mental, and sensory operations, channeling elemental reserves into non-combat challenges, investigations, and technical feats.

Amped Prowess [Action]

- **Cost:** 1 AP
- **Restriction:** Strictly for non-combat, narrative, and downtime challenges (cannot be used during combat rounds).
- **Effect:** *Internal energy reservoirs focus body, mind, or senses into effortless mastery.* You gain **+1 Charge** of the chosen element and make a non-combat test using an attribute matching your element, gaining **Upgrades equal to your active Charges** (including the Charge just gained):
  - **Flame:** Channel thermal combustion into athletic feats, heavy labor, physical intimidation, or commanding social presence (tests using **Strength** or **Presence**).
  - **Frost:** Channel endothermic calm into micro-manipulation, technical repair, hacking, forensic investigation, or surgery (tests using **Finesse** or **Knowledge**).
  - **Lightning:** Channel galvanic reflexes into navigation, stealth, environmental awareness, or rapid zero-g traversal (tests using **Agility** or **Instinct**).

Overdrive Burst [Action]

- **Resource Cost:** Requires and consumes 3 Charges
- **Cost:** 1 AP
- **Effect:** *You dump all three capacitor banks into an overwhelming surge of biological, analytical, or sensory hyper-performance.* When taking any test that includes an attribute matching your consumed Charges (Flame: **Strength / Presence**; Frost: **Finesse / Knowledge**; Lightning: **Agility / Instinct**) that is **not an attack action** (usable in or outside of combat):
  - You set up to **3 dice in your Success Roll to their maximum possible face value** (10 on a d10, 12 on a d12).
  - These maximum-value dice can be banked for **Gambit Points**, sacrificed for **Hits** and **Crit Effects**, or kept to guarantee extraordinary Success Points.

7. GEAR SYNTHESIS PACKAGE

The Gear Synthesis Package links capacitor output directly with field equipment, boosting active hardware with elemental frequencies or condensing energy into short-lived physical munitions, barriers, and electronic rigs.

Amp Gear [Rider / Action]

- **Cost:** 0 AP as a Rider when utilizing eligible gear, or 1 AP as an Action to calibrate gear.
- **Effect:** *Capacitor shunts couple directly into handheld tools, weapons, and devices.* You gain **+1 Charge** of the chosen element and select one of two calibration options corresponding to your element:
  - **Flame (Strength-Linked Gear):** *Thermal Striker:* Equipped melee weapon gains a flat **+1 Damage Bonus per active Charge** until end of round. *Pyrotechnic Fuse:* On Ordnance tests, dice equal to your active Charges score **Crit Effects on 7+** instead of 8+.
  - **Frost (Finesse-Linked Gear):** *Cryo Calibrator:* When performing tests requiring Finesse gear, reroll dice equal to your active Charges. *Endothermic Coagulant:* Medical items gain bonus **Success Points equal to active Charges**.
  - **Lightning (Agility-Linked Gear):** *Vector Supercharger:* Mobility equipment gains **Upgrades equal to active Charges**. *Conductive ICE-Breaker:* Hacking or Interfacing tests gain **Upgrades equal to active Charges**.

Synthesis Burst [Action]

- **Resource Cost:** Requires and consumes 3 Charges
- **Cost:** 1 AP
- **Effect:** *Condense high-density energy into single-use hardware (Load 0, lasts one activation or until encounter ends):*
  - **Flame:** *Thermal Grenade:* Frag or HE grenade with **Ordnance equal to Flame**. *Vectored Jump-Rig:* Jetpack with **Mobility equal to Flame** (grants 1 flight move).
  - **Frost:** *Cryo Trauma Kit:* Field Medi-Kit with **Medicine equal to Frost**. *Glacial Barricade:* Medium Deployable Cover (**+2 Cover, 24 HP, Protection 8**) in your space.
  - **Lightning:** *Arc Flashbang:* Flashbang with **Ordnance equal to Lightning** (Stun, 4m radius). *Virtual Cyberdeck:* Cyberdeck with **Hacking/Interfacing equal to Lightning**.

CLASS MODS

Class Mods represent advanced dielectric overclocks and firmware overrides installed directly into the Conduit's chassis. The Conduit has access to **5 distinct Class Mods** (25,000 Credits each, socketed at Levels 3 and 5, max 2 active):

- **1. Duality:** You can store Charges of **two different elements simultaneously** (maximum 3 Charges shared). Burst consumes all stored charges, venting the majority element (your choice if split).
- **2. Infinity:** Continue activating Amp abilities even when holding **maximum 3 Charges**. Resolves active mechanical effects while stored Charges remain capped at 3 without resetting.
- **3. Intensity:** Whenever scoring a **Hit (8+)** on any test using Conduit Attributes, sacrifice that Hit to **generate 1 Charge** of that element type (up to max capacity).
- **4. Finality:** Activate Burst abilities with **fewer than 3 Charges** (even at 0 Charges). Consumes all charges; you **cannot gain Charges of any element until end of round**.
- **5. Ingenuity:** Activating an Amp of a different element does not reset charges; choose to **convert all existing Charges into the new element type** and increase by +1.

PROGRESSION

The Conduit chassis can be upgraded at specialized cybernetic armories and neuro-clinics by spending Credits during downtime. Each upgrade level expands attribute capacity, unlocks advanced ability packages, and opens hardware Mod slots. At character creation, distribute **7 Class Creation Points** among Flame, Frost, and Lightning (base 1 / 1 / 1, starting cap 5). You begin with **1 Ability Package** of your choice.

CONDUIT CHASSIS PROGRESSION (LEVELS 1-5)

LEVEL	BENEFITS UNLOCKED	CREDIT COST
Level 1	Base Chassis, 7 Attribute Points (base 1/1/1), Starting Package (Amp & Burst), Charge Engine (Max 3)	**100,000 Credits***
Level 2	+1 Attribute Point, +1 Ability Package	**20,000 Credits**
Level 3	+1 Attribute Point, +1 Class Mod Slot (Slot 1), +1 Ability Package	**40,000 Credits**
Level 4	+1 Attribute Point, +1 Ability Package	**75,000 Credits**
Level 5	+1 Attribute Point, +1 Class Mod Slot (Slot 2)	**150,000 Credits**

**The 100,000 Credit cost for Level 1 applies only when purchasing an additional class chassis after character creation; an operative's starting class chassis is free.*

TACTICAL CONDUIT ARCHETYPES

- **The Pyromancer Breacher:** Maximizes *Flame* paired with Strength and Melee/Ranged. Uses Amped strikes to shatter barricades, venting Inferno Impacts to wipe enemy assault squads.
- **The Cryo Sentinel:** Prioritizes *Frost* paired with Finesse and Defense/Mobility. Freezes hostile corridors, locks down heavy threats in crystalline ice, and protects allies with reactive armor.
- **The Galvanic Blitz:** Combines high *Lightning* with Agility and Mobility. Chains high-voltage arcs through multiple enemies at once, blitzing across the battlefield without provoking intercept fire.
- **The Field Resuscitator:** Invests in Restoration, balancing Frost biogels with Lightning defibrillation to heal wounds, soothe stress, and revive fallen allies mid-firefight.

CLASS: THE HAZARD

The Hazard is the cell's combat alchemist and chemical warfare specialist, defined by their neural synchronization with a specialized Hazard-pattern MANTLE (*Modular Adaptive Neural Transmission Linked Equipment*) and its pressurized ChemPack manifold. Controlled directly through the operative's permanent Neural Control Chip (NCC) and cervical shunt, the rig coordinates an intricate network of reinforced subcutaneous fluid lines and an armored dorsal harness. Mounted between the operative's shoulder blades, the Catalyst Chamber houses high-pressure reaction vessels, micro-solenoid valves, and high-frequency acoustic mixers that synthesize complex biochemical compounds in fractions of a second. Translucent fluoropolymer conduits trace along the operative's arms and torso, pulsing rhythmically with luminous reagents as transdermal dermojets and wrist-mounted atomizers prepare volatile mixtures for instant deployment. Often seen wearing a low-profile negative-pressure respirator to withstand their own toxic microclimates, the Hazard operates in an unmistakable aura of ozone, sharp ether, and metallic vapor.

In active combat, the ChemPack functions under principles of rapid binary synthesis and extreme hydraulic pressure. Rather than hauling bulk quantities of unstable compounds, the Hazard stores stabilized base reagents in three hermetic reservoirs, combining them within the central Catalyst Chamber only at the moment of discharge. This internal pressure dictates the potency of every brew: as the operative redlines the chamber, internal atomizers produce hyper-reactive mists, searing incendiaries, and accelerated stimulant cocktails. Yet this power demands disciplined regulation. Pushing the Catalyst Chamber beyond its mechanical tolerance risks catastrophic blowout, violently rupturing safety gaskets and spewing caustic backwash across the operative's own chassis.

The modular versatility of the Hazard MANTLE chassis makes them an indispensable tactical pivot across all combat scenarios. In heavy firefights, the operative can lay down blinding aerosol screens and adhesive polymer barriers to disrupt enemy advances, dissolve armored bulkheads with hyper-reactive acids, or detonate thermal blasts that scour entrenched firing nests. When cell members fall under heavy fire, the Hazard shifts immediately from biohazard offensive to frontline triage, injecting neuro-metabolic stimulants to restore spent action potential, dosing wounded allies with coagulant biogels, or shocking flatlined comrades back to consciousness. Whatever the operational theater demands, the Hazard controls the biochemical battlefield.

ATTRIBUTES

A Hazard's capabilities are governed by three specialized Class Attributes:

- **Venom:** The synthesis and delivery of debilitating neurotoxins, systemic bio-agents, and corrosive acids that degrade enemy resilience from within.
- **Hazard:** The compounding and detonation of volatile, hypergolic, and thermal reagents engineered to deliver catastrophic concussive force on impact.
- **Serum:** The precision compounding and rapid administration of restorative bio-gels, clotting coagulants, and cellular metabolic stimulants.

At character creation, distribute **7 Class Creation Points** across your Venom, Hazard, and Serum Attributes (baseline 1 / 1 / 1). Raising an Attribute from 1 to 4 costs 1 point per increase; raising an Attribute from 4 to 5 costs 2 points. The maximum starting rating for any Class Attribute is **5**.

BASIC MECHANICS

THE CATALYST CHAMBER & PRESSURE ENGINE

The Hazard's abilities are powered by the internal pressure of their ChemPack's Catalyst Chamber. Internal pressure dictates chemical atomization velocity, mixture density, and overall potency:

- **Pressure Range:** Chamber Pressure is measured on a scale from **0 to 3**. Operatives begin every combat encounter at **Pressure 0**.
- **The Volatile Die:** As chamber pressure climbs, internal agitation supercharges your tests with an additional **Volatile Die**. The size of the Volatile Die corresponds directly to your current Pressure:
  - **Pressure 0:** No Volatile Die.
  - **Pressure 1: d8** Volatile Die.
  - **Pressure 2: d10** Volatile Die.
  - **Pressure 3: d12** Volatile Die.
- **Inherent Volatility:** Whenever Pressure is **1 or higher**, rolling your active Volatile Die is **mandatory** on all tests using Hazard Attributes. The Volatile Die cannot be stepped up, stepped down, or modified by standard Upgrades or Downgrades.
- **Test Pool Integration:** In Simple and Success Tests, roll the Volatile Die alongside your standard test pool. In Complex Tests, the Volatile Die is added to your Action Roll pool; if selected as one of your kept dice during the Success Roll, its face value determines your Success Points as normal.

RUPTURE RESOLUTION (CHAMBER BLOWOUT)

Pushing the Catalyst Chamber to high pressure offers immense tactical reward, but risks catastrophic mechanical failure:

- **Triggering a Rupture:** Whenever the Volatile Die rolls a **Hit (8 or higher)** on any test, a **Rupture** occurs immediately.
- **The Hit Counts:** The Hit rolled on the Volatile Die is valid and contributes to the success of your action, Success Points, or Hit-spending effects as normal.
- **Blowout Consequence:** The chamber's emergency pressure seals blow out under the stress. You immediately suffer **2 Light Wounds** (bypassing Physical Protection) and your Chamber Pressure **instantly vents to 0**.

REGULATE CHAMBER [ACTION]

To ensure you never become tactically deadlocked when your active abilities require specific pressure conditions, you can manually modulate the Catalyst Chamber's valves:

- **Action Cost:** 1 AP
- **Effect:** You manually cycle the ChemPack's pneumatic purge valves or stroke the primer pump. Choose one of the following:
  - **Pump:** Increase Chamber Pressure by **+1** (to a maximum of Pressure 3).
  - **Vent:** Decrease Chamber Pressure by **-1** (to a minimum of Pressure 0).

BASELINE ATTRIBUTE ACTIONS

Every Hazard Attribute provides a baseline combat application that can be executed without unlocking specific ability kits. Each baseline action costs **1 AP** and standardizes around spending rolled **Hits**:

- **Venom — Debilitating Dose [Action]:** Administer a debilitating dose against a creature in your space or an adjacent space (which can be delivered as a melee strike or applied **covertly**, such as a subtle touch or concealed contact), rolling a **Venom Success Test**. For each **Hit** you sacrifice from the roll, apply **1 Downgrade** to that creature. This Downgrade is permanent until treated or removed. A creature can be affected by only one of your Venom Downgrades at a time, and you can maintain a maximum number of active Venom Downgrades equal to your **Venom** Attribute rating.
- **Hazard — Explosive Strike [Action]:** Make a melee attack using your **Hazard** Attribute to detonate a pressurized binary charge against a target in your space or an adjacent space. This attack deals your standard melee striking damage plus **bonus damage equal to your Hazard Attribute rating** (and you can spend Hits on effects as normal).
- **Serum — Performance Dose [Action]:** Administer a fast-acting metabolic cocktail to yourself or a willing creature in your space or an adjacent space, rolling a **Serum Success Test**. When administered, bind the dose to a specific **Core Attribute** (Strength, Agility, Finesse, Knowledge, Presence, or Instinct). For each **Hit** you sacrifice from the roll, apply **1 Upgrade** that triggers specifically on tests using that chosen Attribute. This Upgrade is permanent until removed or expended. A creature can benefit from only one of your Serum Upgrades at a time, and you can maintain a maximum number of active Serum Upgrades equal to your **Serum** Attribute rating.

CLASS ABILITIES

Hazard abilities are grouped into specialized **Kits**, each containing three synergized chemical techniques. Operatives select **1 starting Kit** at character creation, and unlock **1 additional Kit** at Levels 2, 3, and 4.

Every ability explicitly specifies its **Pressure Cost/Change** and **Action Economy Tag**:

- If an ability's Pressure change would cause your Pressure to exceed **3** or drop below **0**, that ability **cannot be used** (unless modified by hardware such as the *Redline Engine*).

MEDIC KIT

The Medic Kit packages rapid-clotting bio-foams, transdermal tissue reconstructors, and defibrillating micro-currents for frontline surgical stabilization.

First Aid [Action]

- **Attribute:** Serum | **Pressure:** `-1 Pressure` | **Cost:** 1 AP
- **Effect:** *Pressurized bio-gel seals lacerations and stabilizes hemorrhaging flesh.* Target yourself or a creature in your space or an adjacent space and make a **Serum Success Test**. For every 2 Success Points, heal **1 Light Wound** on the target. In addition, heal a flat number of extra Light Wounds equal to your current **Pressure** level.

Regenerator [Action]

- **Attribute:** Serum | **Pressure:** `-1 Pressure` | **Cost:** 1 AP
- **Effect:** *Neuro-calming biogels soothe frayed synapses and alleviate cognitive overload.* Target yourself or a creature in your space or an adjacent space and make a **Serum Success Test**. For every 2 Success Points, heal **1 Light Stress** (Mental Wound) on the target. In addition, heal a flat number of extra Light Stress equal to your current **Pressure** level.

Defibrillator [Action]

- **Attribute:** Serum / Hazard | **Pressure:** `+2 Pressure` | **Cost:** 1 AP
- **Effect:** *A high-voltage chemical electrode discharges either restorative stimulus or lethal concussive shock.* Target a creature in your space or an adjacent space:
  - **Unconscious Target (Serum):** Make a **Serum Success Test**. For every 2 Success Points, heal **1 Light Wound**. In addition, if your Pressure is at least 1, heal **1 Aggravated Wound**.
  - **Conscious Enemy (Hazard):** Make a melee attack using **Hazard**. The attack deals standard melee damage plus bonus damage equal to your current **Pressure** level.

BOOSTER KIT

The Booster Kit delivers aggressive neuro-stimulants, respiratory dilators, and muscular overclocks to shatter biological limits under fire.

Micro-Booster [Rider]

- **Pressure:** `+1 Pressure` | **Cost:** 0 AP
- **Trigger:** When you or an ally in your space or an adjacent space declare an action.
- **Effect:** *A pressurized transdermal jet releases a micro-dose of hyper-stimulant into the bloodstream.* Add your active **Volatile Die** to all rolls involved in the declared action's test. If the Volatile Die rolls a Hit (8+), it triggers a Rupture on your ChemPack as normal.

Maximum Effort [Action]

- **Attribute:** Serum | **Pressure:** `-2 Pressure` | **Cost:** 1 AP
- **Effect:** *Adrenal superchargers flood motor neurons, amplifying raw physical output.* Roll a **Serum Simple Test**. For each **Hit** you sacrifice, grant **+1 Upgrade** to all physical tests made by a creature in your space or an adjacent space until the end of the round.

Adrenaline Rush [Free Action]

- **Attribute:** Serum | **Pressure:** `-3 Pressure` | **Cost:** 0 AP
- **Effect:** *An emergency surge of neuro-stimulants accelerates synaptic transmission to hyper-reflexive speeds.* Target yourself or an ally in your space or an adjacent space. The next action taken by the target does not count against the Player Turn limit.

POISON KIT

The Poison Kit synthesizes necrotic toxins, respiratory agents, and systemic catalysts that break down biological structures over sustained engagements.

Envenom [Rider]

- **Attribute:** Venom | **Pressure:** `+1 Pressure` | **Cost:** 0 AP
- **Trigger:** When you declare a melee strike (against a target in your space or an adjacent space) or fire a weapon at Short range.
- **Effect:** *Pneumatic conduits coat your weapon edge or ammunition jacket in virulent neurotoxin.* The attack gains **+1 bonus damage per Pressure level**. Additionally, you may sacrifice **Hits** rolled on the attack to apply **1 Venom Downgrade per Hit** to the target (subject to your active Venom limit).

Decay [Action]

- **Attribute:** Venom | **Pressure:** `-3 Pressure` | **Cost:** 1 AP
- **Effect:** *A resonant acoustic pulse or catalytic compound triggers violent cellular breakdown in previously dosed targets.* Make a **Venom Success Test**. All creatures within Medium range currently suffering from your Venom Downgrades take damage equal to your **Success Points + your Venom Attribute rating**. This action immediately consumes and clears those active Downgrades.

Cloudkill [Action]

- **Attribute:** Venom | **Pressure:** `+3 Pressure` | **Cost:** 1 AP
- **Effect:** *A pressurized aerosol grenade shatters on impact, releasing a swirling fog of dense, corrosive vapor.* Target a space within **Short range (0–5 spaces)** and make a **Venom Success Test**. For each **Hit** you sacrifice, apply **1 level of a Venom Downgrade** to every creature occupying the target space. The cloud heavily obscures vision into, out of, and through that space until the end of the round.

PYRO KIT

The Pyro Kit arms the Hazard with hypergolic liquid mixtures and acoustic atomizers that ignite violently upon atmospheric contact.

Firebolt [Action]

- **Attribute:** Hazard | **Pressure:** `+1 Pressure` | **Cost:** 1 AP
- **Effect:** *A focused pneumatic nozzle hurls a pressurized stream of self-igniting chemical gel.* Make a ranged attack using **Hazard** against a target within **Short range (0–5 spaces)**. The attack inflicts thermal damage equal to your test result plus **+1 bonus damage per Pressure level**.

Flamestrike [Action]

- **Attribute:** Hazard | **Pressure:** `+2 Pressure` | **Cost:** 1 AP
- **Effect:** *An explosive aerosol canister detonates overhead, bathing the target zone in clinging liquid fire.* Target a space within **Short range (0–5 spaces)** and make a **Hazard Success Test**. All creatures and flammable structures within the chosen space suffer thermal damage equal to your **Success Points + your current Pressure level**.

Flame Ward [Reaction]

- **Attribute:** Hazard | **Pressure:** `-3 Pressure` | **Cost:** 0 AP
- **Trigger:** When you are targeted by an incoming attack.
- **Effect:** *Emergency purge valves vent a concussive thermal flash outward, deflecting the blow and scorching attackers.* Contest the incoming attack for **0 AP**, rolling your contest pool using your **Hazard** Attribute. If the attacker occupies your space or an adjacent space, they immediately take damage equal to the highest die remaining in your contest pool.

CAUSTIC KIT

The Caustic Kit utilizes hyper-concentrated fluorosulfuric acids and molecular solvents to dissolve inorganic armor plating, vehicle chassis, and structural cover.

Acid Strike [Action]

- **Attribute:** Venom
- **Pressure Change:** `+2 Pressure`
- **Cost:** 1 AP
- **Effect:** *A pressurized burst of fuming acid coats the target, eating away structural seals and composite armor.* Make a melee attack against a creature or object in your space or an adjacent space using **Venom**. For each **Hit** you sacrifice from your roll, you set aside that Hit as an armor-melting effect on the target. You or an ally can expend a set-aside Hit when dealing damage to the target to completely ignore the target's Physical Protection for that instance of damage.

Caustic Bullets [Rider]

- **Pressure Change:** `+1 Pressure`
- **Cost:** 0 AP
- **Trigger:** When you declare a ranged attack with a Firearm.
- **Effect:** *Chambered ammunition is coated in high-potency molecular acid jackets prior to firing.* The attack **ignores the target's Physical Protection entirely**. However, the weapon loses any standard flat Damage Bonus it would normally provide for this shot.

Metal Transfer [Reaction]

- **Attribute:** Venom
- **Pressure Change:** `-2 Pressure`
- **Cost:** 0 AP
- **Trigger:** When you or an ally in Short range are targeted by an attack or suffer damage.
- **Effect:** *Catalytic bio-conduits siphon dissolved metallic residue from active corrosive agents, instantly flashing a protective metallic film across allied hulls and armor.* Every friendly creature in **Short range (0–5 spaces)** gains **+1 Physical Protection** against the next instance of damage equal to the number of **Hits** you currently have spent and active across your ongoing Venom abilities and Downgrades.

OOZE KIT

The Ooze Kit synthesizes rapid-curing visco-elastic polymers and non-Newtonian fluids to tether adversaries, restrict limbs, and reshape tactical terrain.

Rubberband [Action]

- **Attribute:** Serum
- **Pressure Change:** `+1 Pressure`
- **Cost:** 1 AP
- **Effect:** *A high-tensile polymer filament launches from your wrist harness at an anchor point or creature within Short range (0–5 spaces / 16 meters):*
  - **Inanimate Anchor & Terrain:** You are immediately winched in a straight line directly to the anchor point.
  - **Hostile Creature:** Roll a **Serum Simple Test**. If you score at least one Hit, the tether latches on; you can spend any **Hits** from the roll to activate **Push Effects** that pull the target creature 1 space (4 meters) directly towards you per Hit spent (spending a single Hit on this Push Effect still counts the action as a success). Following the pull, you may advance along the tether line any number of spaces towards the target (up to entering its space). If you and the target make contact (ending in the same space), you deal collision damage to the target equal to the highest die rolled.

Slimeball [Action]

- **Attribute:** Venom
- **Pressure Change:** `-2 Pressure`
- **Cost:** 1 AP
- **Effect:** *A pressurized globule of heavy, quick-curing resin engulfs the target's extremities.* Make a ranged attack against a target within **Short range (0–5 spaces)** using **Venom**. Instead of dealing damage, sacrifice **Hits** from the roll to establish a **Blocker Effect**:
  - **Locomotion Blocker (Legs/Thrusters):** Negates the target's highest die on movement tests.
  - **Manipulation Blocker (Hands/Weapons):** Negates the target's highest die on weapon attack or manipulation tests.

Slip and Slide [Action]

- **Attribute:** Serum
- **Pressure Change:** `-1 Pressure`
- **Cost:** 1 AP
- **Effect:** *Pressurized nozzles coat deck plates in an ultra-slick surfactant polymer.* Choose a number of adjacent spaces up to your current **Pressure** level (minimum 1 space). Until the start of your next turn, these spaces become **Difficult Terrain** for hostile creatures, and you and your allies gain **+1 Upgrade** on any movement tests made through them.

SMOKE KIT

The Smoke Kit deploys dense chemical aerosols, thermal-scattering smokescreens, and dual-agent particulate clouds to control visual sightlines and tactical positioning.

Smoke Screen [Action]

- **Attribute:** Hazard | **Pressure:** `+2 Pressure` | **Cost:** 1 AP
- **Effect:** *Dense micro-particulate smoke scatters visual and IR spectrums.* Roll a **Hazard Simple Test**. For each Hit spent, deploy smoke in one chosen space within Short range. Creatures inside cannot see out, and creatures outside cannot see in/through (2 Downgrades to tests requiring vision). Persists until end of round.

Gas Canister [Action]

- **Attribute:** Venom / Serum | **Pressure:** `+2 Pressure` | **Cost:** 1 AP
- **Effect:** *Dual-stage aerosol disperses tailored compounds.* Target space within Short range, rolling Venom (applies Venom Downgrade to all enemies) or Serum (applies Serum Upgrade to all allies). Sacrifice 1 Hit to isolate to a single target.

Gas Turbine [Action]

- **Attribute:** Hazard | **Pressure:** `-2 Pressure` | **Cost:** 1 AP
- **Effect:** *Pneumatic exhaust turbines cycle high-pressure gas into vectored thrust.* Next movement test rolls using Hazard. You ignore Difficult Terrain, can fly, gain +4 SP per Hit on Crit Effects, and ignore all falling damage until end of round.

CLASS MODS

Class Mods cost 25,000 Credits each (socketed at Levels 3 and 5, max 2 active):

- **Dart Launcher:** Execute baseline actions (Debilitating Dose, Explosive Strike, Performance Dose) at **Short range (0–5 spaces)** instead of melee reach.
- **Pressure Controls:** Alter an ability's Pressure cost/change by **+1 or -1** (cannot shift positive to negative or vice versa).
- **Critical Rupture:** When Volatile Die rolls a Hit (8+), score the Hit and reroll the Volatile Die (chaining bonus Hits), suffering a Rupture (2 Light Wounds, Pressure vents to 0) for each Hit scored in the chain.
- **Catalyst Controls:** At the start of each combat round, freely set your Catalyst Chamber Pressure to **any value of your choice (0, 1, 2, or 3)**.
- **Redline Engine:** Activate abilities even if positive cost exceeds Pressure 3 (resolves at max Pressure 3, then triggers an automatic Rupture: 2 Light Wounds, vents to 0).

PROGRESSION

At character creation, distribute **7 Points** among Venom, Hazard, and Serum (base `1 / 1 / 1`, max 5). You begin with **1 Kit**.

HAZARD CHASSIS PROGRESSION (LEVELS 1-5)

LEVEL	BENEFITS UNLOCKED	CREDIT COST
Level 1	Base Chassis, 7 Attribute Points (base 1/1/1), Starting Kit, Pressure Engine (Max 3)	**100,000 Credits***
Level 2	+1 Attribute Point, +1 Kit	**20,000 Credits**
Level 3	+1 Attribute Point, +1 Class Mod Slot (Slot 1), +1 Kit	**40,000 Credits**
Level 4	+1 Attribute Point, +1 Kit	**75,000 Credits**
Level 5	+1 Attribute Point, +1 Class Mod Slot (Slot 2)	**150,000 Credits**

**The 100,000 Credit cost for Level 1 applies only when purchasing an additional class chassis after character creation; an operative's starting class chassis is free.*

TACTICAL HAZARD ARCHETYPES

- **The Toxic Saboteur:** Focuses on Venom, Envenom, and Cloudkill. Scours cover with acidic gas, sets up crippling neurotoxin Downgrades, and collapses enemy formations with Decay.
- **The Combat Alchemist:** Balances Hazard with Pyro and Smoke. Dominates corridors with high-pressure Flamestrikes and thermal smoke screens, controlling lines of sight.
- **The Field Surgeon:** Maximizes Serum with Medic and Booster kits. Delivers combat-critical heals, clears mental stress, and overclocks allied initiative with emergency stimulants.

CLASS: THE PILOT

The Pilot is defined by direct neuro-synaptic synchronization with a specialized **Pilot-pattern MANTLE** (*Modular Adaptive Neural Transmission Linked Equipment*)—a motorized bio-mechanical frame that serves as both a wearable exoskeleton and an autonomous tele-operated Exodrone. Controlled directly through the operative's permanent **Neural Control Chip (NCC)** and cranial shunt ports along the neck and temples, the rig allows the Pilot to operate the external frame as a natural extension of their own nervous system. Visually, a Pilot presents an imposing, industrial silhouette. Lightweight ceramic-composite plating and subdermal shock-absorbing harnesses fit beneath the Exodrone's shifting mechanical carapace. In its dormant, docked configuration, the chassis folds tightly along the Pilot's spine like a segmented pair of metallic wings, its hydraulic solenoids hissing softly in rhythm with the user's pulse and cooling fans humming against the operative's back.

In active combat, the Exodrone acts as an instrument of overwhelming mechanical force, driven by high-density solid-state battery banks and pneumatic actuators. When locked to the operative's spinal harness in Attached Mode, the Exodrone reinforces the Pilot's skeletal structure, allowing them to sprint through heavy automatic fire, shatter reinforced security bulkheads with hydraulic strikes, or stabilize heavy squad weapons without recoil fatigue. The true tactical genius of the chassis emerges when the locking pins disengage, allowing the Exodrone to detach and operate as an independent avatar. Governed by high-frequency telemetry feeds, the detached drone can advance into hazardous breaches, lay down suppressive fire from elevated vantages, provide physical barricades for pinned allies, or administer emergency trauma triage in hot landing zones while the Pilot directs operations from secure cover.

The operational versatility of the Pilot MANTLE chassis is defined by its modular firmware architecture. Rather than locking the operative into a singular battlefield duty, the Exodrone can be reconfigured with specialized hardware packages between engagements. A Pilot can optimize their frame for close-quarters breach and clear with high-frequency vibro-blades, calibrate its hardpoints into a heavy shoulder-mounted ballistic and laser artillery platform, mount pneumatic vector thrusters for frictionless three-dimensional boarding actions, or equip surgical micro-manipulators for life-saving combat stabilization. In any theater of operations, the Pilot ensures the cell possesses both a fortified anchor and a versatile remote presence capable of shifting the tactical balance at a moment's notice.

ATTRIBUTES

The Exodrone possesses its own signature set of physical Attributes that reflect its mechanical capabilities:

- **Power:** The raw mechanical torque, hydraulic lifting capacity, and kinetic impact force generated by the Exodrone's articulated frame (corresponds to **Strength**).
- **Speed:** The rapid servo response, thruster acceleration, and swift evasive articulation of the Exodrone (corresponds to **Agility**).
- **Precision:** The micrometric fine-motor dexterity, targeting telemetry, and sensor alignment of the Exodrone (corresponds to **Finesse**).

MECHANICS

EXODRONE MODES

The Exodrone operates in two distinct operational states: Attached Mode and Detached Mode.

- **Attached Mode:** While docked to your spinal interface, the Exodrone reinforces your natural anatomy. Whenever you make a test involving **Strength**, **Agility**, or **Finesse**, you may choose to substitute your own Core Attribute with the Exodrone's corresponding Attribute (**Power**, **Speed**, or **Precision**).
- **Detached Mode:** When decoupled from your harness, the Exodrone acts as an autonomous tele-operated proxy. The Exodrone can navigate and take actions independently on the battlefield. When the Exodrone makes a test, it forms test pools using its own physical Attributes (for example, a test requiring Strength and Agility resolves using **Power + Speed**, while a pure Strength test resolves using **Power + Power**). If a test requires an Attribute the Exodrone does not possess (such as mental Attributes like **Knowledge**, **Presence**, or **Instinct**), the Exodrone cannot perform that action independently.

CORE CHASSIS OPERATIONS

Every Pilot understands the foundational operation of their Exodrone chassis:

- **Detach [Free Action]:** You decouple the Exodrone from your spinal harness for **0 AP** and **0 Batteries**. The Exodrone deploys into your current space and enters Detached Mode. You may perform this action once per turn.
- **Attach [Free Action]:** You magnetically dock the Exodrone onto your spinal interface for **0 AP** and **0 Batteries** while occupying the same space as the Exodrone. The Exodrone enters Attached Mode. You may perform this action once per turn.
- **Drone Commands:** While the Exodrone is in Detached Mode, you command it over your neural link. Directing the Exodrone to move, make an attack, or perform a test costs **1 AP** from your standard 3 Action Point pool.
- **Overdrive Command [Free Action]:** You transmit an overclocked neural surge to the detached Exodrone, expending **4 Batteries**. The Exodrone immediately gains **1 Action Point** to take an action for **0 of your own AP**.

BATTERY POWER CELLS

The Exodrone's high-torque actuators, energy carbines, and specialized modules are powered by a central bank of high-density solid-state batteries:

- **Capacity:** The Exodrone can store a maximum of **10 Batteries**.
- **Expenditure:** Activating specialized Pilot abilities expends a designated number of Batteries from this reserve.
- **Recharging:** At the beginning of each Round, the Exodrone automatically recharges **2 Batteries** if it is in Attached Mode. While in Detached Mode, it recharges 0 Batteries. During place-to-place or day-to-day pacing, the Battery pool automatically refills to maximum (10).
- **Damage & Shutdown:** When the Exodrone suffers damage while in Detached Mode, its physical casing and capacitors absorb the shock: it loses **1 Battery for every 4 points of damage suffered**, rounded down. If the Exodrone's Battery pool drops to **0 Batteries**, it enters an emergency shutdown state, collapsing and ceasing all functions until it recharges at least 1 Battery.

PILOT ABILITIES

The Pilot customizes their Exodrone through specialized hardware and software **Modules**. Each Module is a cohesive package of three coordinated abilities designed for a distinct tactical focus. Operatives learn one complete Module (3 abilities) at Level 1, and unlock an additional Module at Levels 2, 3, and 4.

WINGMAN MODULE

The Wingman Module emphasizes tactical synergy and coordinated maneuvers between the operative and their detached Exodrone.

Boost [Free Action]

- **Cost:** 1 Battery
- **Limit:** Max 3 per turn
- **Effect:** You route auxiliary current to the Exodrone's primary servos. The Exodrone gains **+1 Upgrade** to any one chosen Exodrone Attribute until the beginning of the next Player Turn.

Double Move [Rider]

- **Cost:** 1 Battery
- **Trigger:** When you take a Movement Action during the Player Turn.
- **Effect:** Fluid coordination allows the Exodrone to reposition alongside you. The Exodrone immediately executes a full Movement Action for **0 additional AP**.

Tag Team [Rider]

- **Cost:** 3 Batteries
- **Requirement:** Detached Mode, occupying the same space as the Pilot.
- **Trigger:** When you declare an action or attack.
- **Effect:** The Exodrone coordinates seamlessly with your strike. The Exodrone participates in your action using **Teamwork** for **0 additional AP**.

WARDEN MODULE

The Warden Module configures the Exodrone into a hardened defensive bastion, absorbing ballistic trauma and providing mobile cover for the cell.

Armadillo [Free Action]

- **Cost:** 1 Battery
- **Limit:** Once per round
- **Requirement:** Attached Mode
- **Effect:** The Exodrone shifts its interlocking ceramic plates across your vitals. Your Physical Protection increases by **+2** until the end of the Round.

Guardian [Reaction]

- **Cost:** 2 Batteries
- **Trigger:** When the Exodrone is targeted by an attack.
- **Effect:** Automated counter-deflection routines engage. The Exodrone can contest the incoming attack for **0 AP**.

Barricade [Action]

- **Cost:** 1 Battery, 1 AP
- **Requirement:** Detached Mode
- **Effect:** The Exodrone drops into a low-profile posture and drives hydraulic anchoring spikes into the deck, converting itself into deployable mobile cover until the end of the round. The Cover Rating of the Exodrone's current space increases by **+1**. While configured as a barricade, the only action the Exodrone can take is to disengage its anchors and revert to standard mode for **0 AP**.

DUELIST MODULE

The Duelist Module transforms the Exodrone into a lethal close-quarters combatant, mounting high-frequency cutting edges for silent breaches and melee skirmishes.

Shadow Strike [Rider]

- **Cost:** 1 Battery
- **Requirement:** Attached Mode, or occupying the same space as the target in Detached Mode.
- **Trigger:** After successfully landing a melee attack.
- **Effect:** The Exodrone executes an immediate hydraulic follow-up blow. Add bonus damage to your attack equal to the Exodrone Attribute corresponding to the Physical Attribute used in your attack.

Power Weapons [Free Action]

- **Cost:** 1 Battery
- **Effect:** The Exodrone extends twin wrist-mounted powered weapons of your choice between vibro-blades, shock-batons, or pneumatic spikes, remaining active until the end of the round. They function as dual-wielded 1H melee weapons with a **Damage Bonus of 1 plus your Pilot Level**, allowing you to choose between **Slashing** (favored pair **Agility + Strength**), **Striking** (favored pair **Strength + Finesse**) or **Piercing** (favored pair **Agility + Finesse**) damage for your melee attacks.

Plasma Lance [Action]

- **Cost:** 2 Batteries, 1 AP
- **Effect:** The Exodrone locks its articulated frame and unleashes a superheated thermal cutting lance in a devastating thrust against a target or structural barrier. Make a single melee attack using any melee attribute pair. On a hit, this attack deals damage with a **Damage Bonus equal to 2 plus your Pilot Level**. This damage completely ignores the target's Physical Protection (including armor, shields, and cover).

ARSENAL MODULE

The Arsenal Module outfits the Exodrone with heavy ranged weaponry, transforming it into a versatile mobile weapons platform.

Laser Carbine [Free Action]

- **Cost:** 1 Battery
- **Effect:** The Exodrone deploys a wrist-mounted pulsed laser carbine, remaining active until the end of the round. It features the following firearm profile: `Acc: [3/2/1/-], Dmg: +1 + Pilot Class Level, RoF: 2`.

Shoulder Cannon [Action]

- **Cost:** 2 Batteries, 1 AP
- **Effect:** The Exodrone locks its chassis and discharges a concentrated high-output optical blast from its shoulder-mounted heavy laser: `Acc: [1/4/3/2], Dmg: +4 + Pilot Class Level, RoF: 0`.

Plasma Grenade [Action]

- **Cost:** 2 Batteries, 1 AP
- **Effect:** The Exodrone produces a small blob of superheated plasma and lobs it at any target space within Short range (0–5 spaces). The blob acts as a grenade with the following profile: `Ordnance: 3 + Pilot Class Level, 2m Radius`.

ASSAULT MODULE

The Assault Module enhances dynamic movement, enabling the Exodrone to scale vertical obstacles, drop from high altitudes, and close combat distances rapidly.

Full Throttle [Action]

- **Cost:** 1 Battery, 1 AP
- **Effect:** Overcharging hydraulic leg actuators, you or your Exodrone sprint up to 12 meters in a straight line directly into a hostile creature's space and execute a melee attack as part of the same action.

Spider Climb [Free Action]

- **Cost:** 1 Battery
- **Effect:** Micro-fiber magnetic clamps engage across the Exodrone's extremities. Until the end of the round, the Exodrone gains **Surface Adhesion**, allowing it to move across vertical bulkheads and sheer ceilings as regular terrain.

Jump Pack [Free Action]

- **Cost:** 2 Batteries
- **Effect:** The Exodrone fires integrated vector thrusters, gaining the **Mobility** virtual item attribute equal to 3 + Pilot Class Level. Until the end of round, the Exodrone's and the wearer's base movement speed becomes 12, it may sacrifice Hits on movement tests to gain +4 meters of movement per Hit spent and it and its wearer ignores difficult terrain and all damage from falling until end of turn. If in mid-air, it falls at the end of the Player Turn, taking no damage.

RECON MODULE

The Recon Module equips the Exodrone with adaptive optical cloaking, remote neural telepresence, and electronic infiltration tools.

Active Camouflage [Free Action]

- **Cost:** 2 Batteries
- **Effect:** The Exodrone activates adaptive light-refracting micro-panels, establishing a Persistent Blocker Effect against hostile detection from outside your space until the end of the round. Any tests that benefit from remaining unseen gain **+1 Upgrade**.

Neural Relay [Passive]

- **Effect:** The direct duplex telemetry feed between your NCC and the Exodrone streams full sensory perception. While the Exodrone is in Detached Mode, it can utilize your own mental Attributes (**Knowledge**, **Presence**, and **Instinct**) to perform tests, allowing it to scout hostile spaces, slice electronic terminals, or perform technical analysis remotely.

Omni Tool [Action]

- **Cost:** 1 Battery, 1 AP
- **Requirement:** Detached Mode
- **Effect:** The Exodrone interfaces directly with an electronic terminal, locked hatch, or sensor console in its space, forcing the device to perform any standard function without requiring an external tool. When executing the hack, roll the Exodrone's highest physical Attribute in place of Finesse.

SERAPH MODULE

The Seraph Module equips the Exodrone with emergency trauma medicine and vital-sign resuscitation hardware, allowing it to stabilize wounded operatives under fire.

First Aid [Action]

- **Cost:** 2 Batteries (increasing by +1 Battery for each additional use within the same Round)
- **Effect:** In Attached Mode, the Exodrone administers rapid trauma coagulants and painkillers to you, immediately healing **2 Light Wounds**. In Detached Mode, the Exodrone injects a target friendly creature occupying its current space, healing **2 Light Wounds**.

Healer Darts [Free Action]

- **Cost:** 2 Batteries
- **Effect:** The Exodrone deploys a pneumatic dart projector, active until the end of the round. It features the following profile: `Acc: [2/-/-/-], Dmg: 0, RoF: 0`. On a successful hit against an ally, rather than dealing damage, the dart injects stimulant biomaterials that heal **1 Light Wound for every 2 Success Points** scored on the attack roll.

Trauma Protocol [Action]

- **Cost:** 4 Batteries, 1 AP
- **Requirement:** Detached Mode
- **Effect:** The Exodrone moves into the space of an incapacitated or dying ally, locking its armored chassis around the patient. Make an emergency medicine test using the Exodrone's Precision + your Instinct: each 2 SP heals 1 Light Wound, or each 4 SP clears 1 Aggravated Wound. If the target was killed during the current Round, scoring at least 2 SP revives the target with 1 Light Wound. While clamped onto an ally, all incoming damage targeting that ally is redirected to the Exodrone until it detaches.

CLASS MODS & PROGRESSION

Pilot Class Mods cost **25,000 Credits** each and can be installed into open chassis mod slots (unlocked at Levels 3 and 5; maximum 2 active mods):

- **Solid-State Expansion Bank:** Auxiliary battery capacitors expand the Exodrone's total storage capacity from 10 to **12 Batteries**.
- **Tethered Inductive Field:** Hardened induction coils reinforce the Exodrone's damage dissipation. While in Detached Mode, the Exodrone loses 1 Battery per **6 points of damage suffered** (instead of 4). In addition, the Exodrone recharges 1 Battery at the start of each round even while in Detached Mode.
- **Biomechanical Dynamo:** Micro-generators capture the kinetic energy of your physical movements. While in Attached Mode, whenever you score Hits on a physical test, you may convert 1 Hit into **1 Battery** recharged (up to your maximum capacity).
- **Kinetic Overclock:** Activating any Pilot ability routes surplus current to all secondary actuators, granting **+1 Upgrade** to the Exodrone's next test before the end of your turn. This effect stacks up to twice per turn.
- **Standby Capacitor Loop:** If no Battery abilities were activated during a Round, the Exodrone's idle induction cycle automatically stores **2 additional Batteries** at the end of the Round.

PILOT CHASSIS PROGRESSION (LEVELS 1-5)

LEVEL	BENEFITS UNLOCKED	CREDIT COST
Level 1	Base Chassis, 7 Attribute Points (base 1/1/1), Starting Module, Battery Engine	**100,000 Credits***
Level 2	+1 Attribute Point, +1 Module (3 Abilities)	**20,000 Credits**
Level 3	+1 Attribute Point, +1 Class Mod Slot (Slot 1), +1 Module (3 Abilities)	**40,000 Credits**
Level 4	+1 Attribute Point, +1 Module (3 Abilities)	**75,000 Credits**
Level 5	+1 Attribute Point, +1 Class Mod Slot (Slot 2)	**150,000 Credits**

**The 100,000 Credit cost for Level 1 applies only when purchasing an additional class chassis after character creation; an operative's starting class chassis is free.*

CLASS: THE VANGUARD

The Vanguard is the cell's frontline breaker and kinetic specialist, defined by their neural synchronization with a specialized Vanguard-pattern MANTLE (*Modular Adaptive Neural Transmission Linked Equipment*) and its adaptable multi-segment Board. Controlled directly through the operative's permanent Neural Control Chip (NCC) and cervical shunt, the rig interfaces with subdermal balance nodes embedded along the user's calves, spine, and forearms. Mounted along the operative's spine via a high-torque magnetic docking latch, this articulated piece of aerospace-grade hardware consists of interlocking ceramic-composite plates, micro-servos, and pneumatic locking pins that read minute shifts in center of mass, transmitting physical balance feedback at the speed of reflex. In its dormant state, the folded chassis rests as a compact, streamlined dorsal carapace across the operative's back, often scarred by shrapnel deflection or thermal wash from high-speed descents.

In active combat, the Board functions as an instrument of relentless momentum, transforming between three distinct operational geometries at a moment's notice. When facing suppressive fire, the chassis snaps forward into the Vanguard's off-hand, locking into a broad, reinforced **Shield** engineered to disperse heavy ballistic impacts and batter through enemy barricades in close-quarters breaches. When rapid repositioning or flanking becomes necessary, the mechanism deploys beneath the user's boots as a hoverboard **Glider**, engaging vectored thrusters to skim over hazardous terrain, traverse zero-gravity gaps, and launch the operative into aerial drop attacks. When distant threats demand decisive force, the Board hinges outward into a heavy shoulder-slung or hip-braced **Cannon**, cycling heavy penetrator rounds capable of punching clean through bulkhead plating and mechanized armor.

The true tactical depth of the Vanguard MANTLE chassis lies in the fluid, stance-dancing rhythm of its kinetic engine. Rather than committing to a single combat posture, an experienced Vanguard continuously reconfigures the Board mid-assault, converting the mechanical torque of each form swap into banked **Boost** dice that fuel explosive combo techniques. Whether shattering enemy defensive lines with a boosted shield charge, surfing over crossfire to extract a pinned ally, or laying down devastating artillery blasts from elevated vantage points, the Vanguard commands the pace of engagement. Their presence ensures the cell possesses an immovable defensive anchor, an agile vanguard scout, and a heavy fire-support platform unified in a single operative.

ATTRIBUTES

The Vanguard's three primary Attributes correspond to the different forms their Board can take:

- **Shield:** The toughness, structural mass, and kinetic impact absorption of its shield form.
- **Glider:** The speed, vector acceleration, and frictionless maneuverability of its hoverboard form.
- **Cannon:** The penetrative power, optical range, and ballistic precision of its ranged weapon form.

MECHANICS

VANGUARD FORMS

The Vanguard's Board has three different forms, corresponding to the three Attributes in its kit. Each form provides distinct tactical benefits:

- **Shield:** While in Shield Form, your Physical Protection increases by half your Shield Attribute, rounded down. You can also use the Shield as a Striking melee weapon (rolling **Strength + Shield**), dealing bonus damage equal to the lower Attribute in the pair (Strength or Shield). You can also use your Shield Attribute to contest most forms of incoming harm. You have one hand occupied while in Shield Form. You typically rely on **Strength** in Shield Form.
- **Glider:** While in Glider Form, you can use your Glider Attribute in any movement action you take. You also ignore Difficult Terrain and fall damage. While in the air, you can move horizontally or downward, but not upward, and only using your Glider Attribute. You have both hands free while in Glider Form. You typically rely on **Agility** in Glider Form.
- **Cannon:** While in Cannon Form, you can make a ranged attack using your Board. Its Accuracy is equal to your Cannon Attribute at short range and one less at every subsequent range band. If you would get negative Accuracy, you cannot shoot at that range. You have both hands occupied in Cannon Form. You typically rely on **Finesse** in Cannon Form.

SWITCHING & SWAPPING FORMS

The Board is an adaptable kinetic weapon chassis capable of rapid mechanical reconfiguration. Its operational state is governed by two core concepts:

- **Current Form & Shifting Forms:** Whenever you roll a test that uses one of your Vanguard Attributes (such as a melee attack with **Shield**, a Movement Action with **Glider**, or a ranged attack with **Cannon**) or activate a Vanguard ability, your Board automatically shifts into that Form immediately prior to resolving the action. You remain in that form until your Board transforms again. Taking a test with a Vanguard Attribute or executing an ability inherently counts as a **Form Move** for that Form during the current turn.
- **Specific Form & Setup Requirements:** While most abilities automatically shift your Board into their associated Form upon activation, certain abilities have specific prerequisites:
  - **Required Starting Form:** Reactions and defensive stances (such as *Repulse* and *Brick Wall*) require you to *already* be in that specific Form when triggered.
  - **Form Moves:** Kinetic combo follow-ups (such as *Turbo Slam*) require a preceding Form Move to build the necessary momentum.
  - **Situational Requirements:** Aerial maneuvers (such as *Meteor Crash*) require specific environmental positioning (e.g. being at least 4 meters above your target space).

BOOSTS & FORM MOMENTUM

To channel kinetic momentum into explosive combos, the Vanguard banks kinetic energy as **Boost** dice. A **Boost** is a single banked **d10** die. You can hold only **one** Boost die at a time in your reserve (unless increased by Class Mods like *Twin Turbo*). Banked Boost dice power signature Vanguard combo finishers and riders, or bolster regular actions.

Gaining a Boost: There are two ways to generate and bank a Boost die:

1. **Active Form Swap (1 AP):** Spend **1 AP** to swap into any of your three forms (Shield, Glider, or Cannon). Swapping immediately places you in that form, counts as a **Form Move**, and grants a banked **d10 Boost die** (replacing any previously held Boost).
2. **Banking a Hit:** When rolling a test using a Vanguard Attribute while holding no Boost die, you may bank one **Hit (8+)** from the roll into your reserve as a **d10 Boost die** (that die does not contribute to successes or effects).

Spending a Boost: Spend your Boost die by rolling it and adding it to any Vanguard test pool (before or after the roll). Many abilities also consume your active Boost die to unleash devastating kinetic strikes, high-altitude maneuvers, or heavy artillery blasts.

The Golden Rule of Boosts: You can either spend or gain a Boost during a test or action, but never both. You cannot gain a Boost on an action where you spent a Boost, and a newly gained Boost is banked to fuel future actions.

VANGUARD ABILITIES

The Vanguard reconfigures their Board into coordinated combat routines called **Combos**. Each Combo contains three synergized abilities: an opening setup, a devastating finisher, and a responsive tactical rider or passive.

Operatives learn one complete Combo (3 abilities) at Level 1, and unlock an additional Combo at Levels 2, 3, and 4. Activating an ability automatically shifts your Board into that ability's **Form**, unless noted.

SENTINEL COMBO

The Sentinel Combo emphasizes frontline defense, utilizing shield throws to scatter enemy formations and reactive bracing to protect against incoming fire.

Shield Throw [Action]

- **Form:** Shield
- **Effect:** You hurl your Board in Shield Form up to 20 meters as a ranged melee attack (rolling **Strength + Shield**). The Shield ricochets off the target and snaps immediately back to your magnetic gauntlet. It deals your standard Shield melee damage at range.

Ricochet [Rider]

- **Form:** Shield
- **Trigger:** When your **Shield Throw** successfully hits a target.
- **Effect:** You may expend your active **Boost** die. If you do, kinetic resonance arcs through the target's space: every other hostile creature in that space suffers damage equal to the damage dealt to the primary target.

Repulse [Reaction]

- **Form:** Shield
- **Requirement:** Shield Form (must already be in Shield Form)
- **Trigger:** When you are targeted by an attack while in Shield Form.
- **Effect:** You can contest the incoming attack using your Shield Attribute for **0 AP** by expending your active **Boost** die. Add the **Boost** die directly to your contest roll.

FALLINGSTAR COMBO

The Fallingstar Combo harnesses explosive vertical lift and high-altitude drops, crushing enemy clusters beneath devastating shockwaves.

Rocket Jump [Action]

- **Form:** Cannon
- **Effect:** You angle your Cannon directly into the ground beneath you and fire a high-pressure kinetic blast, rolling a **Cannon Success Test** (you may expend and add your active **Boost** die to this test). The blast deals damage to all creatures in your space equal to your Cannon Attribute; if you expended a **Boost** die on the test, it instead deals damage to all creatures in your space equal to the highest die rolled. The explosion immediately lifts you 4 meters straight up into the air, and you can spend any **Hits** from the test to activate **Push Effects** on yourself. This action also counts as a **Glider Move**.

Meteor Crash [Action]

- **Form:** Shield
- **Requirement:** Elevated position (must fall or dive from at least 4 meters above your target space).
- **Effect:** You slam directly into the space beneath you, ignoring all fall damage. You deal damage equal to your Shield Attribute to all creatures in the target space. If you expend an active **Boost** die, roll the Boost die and add the rolled result to the total damage dealt.

Air Trick [Rider]

- **Form:** Glider
- **Trigger:** When taking a Movement Action using your Glider (Glider Move) starting from solid ground.
- **Effect:** You can convert horizontal thrust into vertical flight for up to 4 meters of your movement, easily leaping 4 meters into the air to set up a devastating **Meteor Crash**. You fall at the end of the Player Turn unless sustained by another ability.

FALCON COMBO

The Falcon Combo is engineered for rapid skirmishing, frictionless traversal, and high-altitude momentum, allowing the Vanguard to reposition across the battlefield and strike without becoming pinned.

Rocketeer [Action]

- **Form:** Glider
- **Effect:** You make a Glider Movement Action and fly for the entire duration of the movement. If you expend an active **Boost** die, add the Boost die to your movement test roll; you double the rolled movement distance and fly at extreme velocity without altitude loss until the end of the Player Turn.

Hit and Run [Rider]

- **Form:** Glider
- **Requirement:** Glider Move (must have completed a Glider Move this turn).
- **Trigger:** As part of declaring any melee attack.
- **Effect:** You can move a number of meters equal to your **Glider Attribute × 4 meters** either immediately before or immediately after making the attack. This movement is completely fluid and cannot be contested by enemies.

Windsurfer [Passive]

- **Form:** Glider
- **Effect:** While in Glider Form, you do not fall at the end of the Player Turn. Instead, you remain suspended at your current altitude. You can maneuver horizontally across the airspace as long as you use your Glider to move. If you swap out of Glider Form, you fall at the end of that Player Turn.

SCORPION COMBO

The Scorpion Combo converts the Vanguard's Board into a heavy ballistic platform, laying down sustained automatic suppressive fire and punishing openings with devastating follow-up cannonades.

Assault Cannon [Passive]

- **Form:** Cannon
- **Effect:** Your Board reconfigures into an Assault Cannon. While in Cannon Form, your weapon gains a **Damage Bonus of +2** and a **Rate of Fire of 2**, but suffers **-1 Accuracy** across all range bands. This configuration cannot be combined with *Long Cannon* (if you possess both abilities, you choose which configuration your Cannon Form takes during downtime).

Charged Shot [Action]

- **Form:** Cannon
- **Effect:** Make a ranged attack using your Cannon, expending your active **Boost** die. Add the **Boost** die to your attack roll. On a hit, you puncture the target's armor, dealing bonus damage equal to your Cannon Attribute.

Follow Up [Rider]

- **Form:** Any Form
- **Trigger:** After successfully landing any attack in any form (Shield, Glider, or Cannon).
- **Effect:** You can immediately pay **1 AP** to deliver a point-blank snap shot with your Cannon against the target, dealing bonus damage equal to your Cannon Attribute. If you expend an active **Boost** die, roll the Boost die and add damage equal to the result you rolled. This attack immediately swaps your Board into Cannon Form. You can execute this follow-up even if the Player Turn would otherwise end.

RHINO COMBO

The Rhino Combo focuses on battlefield displacement and immovable close-quarters enforcement, harpooning priority targets, smashing them into structural barriers, and locking down all movement.

Hook Shot [Action]

- **Form:** Cannon
- **Effect:** You fire a high-tensile magnetic kinetic tether from your Cannon at an anchor point or creature up to Short range (16 meters):
  - **Inanimate Anchor:** You are immediately winched in a straight line directly to the anchor point.
  - **Hostile Creature:** Roll a **Cannon + Finesse Simple Test**. If no Hits are scored, the shot misses and the tether snaps back. If you score at least one Hit, the tether latches on; you can spend any **Hits** from the roll to activate **Push Effects** that pull the target creature 1 space (4 meters) directly towards you per Hit spent (even if you only roll a single Hit, spending it on this Push Effect still counts the Hook Shot as a success). Following the pull, you may advance along the tether line any number of spaces towards the target (up to entering its space). If you and the target make contact (ending in the same space), you deal collision damage to the target equal to the highest die rolled. This action also counts as a **Glider Move**.

Turbo Slam [Action]

- **Form:** Shield
- **Requirement:** Glider Move (must have completed a Glider Move this turn, such as advancing via *Hook Shot* or Glider movement, to convert kinetic momentum into impact force).
- **Effect:** Make a melee strike with your Shield, dealing bonus damage equal to your Shield Attribute. If the target is large or smaller, you may push it a number of meters equal to the damage dealt. If the pushed creature collides with solid cover, a bulkhead, or another combatant, it suffers bonus damage equal to your Shield Attribute again.

Brick Wall [Reaction]

- **Form:** Shield
- **Requirement:** Shield Form (must already be in Shield Form)
- **Trigger:** When a creature attempts to move across or out of your space while you are in Shield Form.
- **Effect:** Contest the creature's movement using your Shield Attribute. If you succeed, their movement is halted, and they take damage equal to the highest die you eliminated from their roll. You can also trigger this reaction to contest forced movement triggered by your allies during the Player Turn, even if the Player Turn would normally end.

ROOK COMBO

The Rook Combo transforms the Vanguard into an immovable battlefield bastion, deploying reinforced fortifications to shelter squad members, ferrying allies rapidly across hostile firing lanes, and returning heavy ranged fire from behind hardened ballistic plating.

Gun Shield [Passive]

- **Form:** Shield
- **Effect:** Your Board's Shield Form incorporates an articulated weapon brace and magnetic clamp. You can wield and fire a two-handed firearm while in Shield Form, retaining your Shield Form's Physical Protection bonus (+SHD/2).

Hitchhiker [Rider]

- **Form:** Glider
- **Requirement:** Glider Move
- **Trigger:** When declaring a Movement Action using your Glider.
- **Effect:** One willing ally in your space or an adjacent space can latch onto your harness or board. They are carried with you for the full duration of your movement for **0 AP**, ending their movement in your destination space. If you end your movement by swapping into Shield Form or deploying your **Tactical Barricade**, the hitched ally immediately shares the fortified space and its cover. You can expend an active **Boost** die to add the Boost die to your movement test roll and carry up to two allies simultaneously.

Tactical Barricade [Action]

- **Form:** Shield
- **Cost:** 1 AP
- **Effect:** You spend 1 AP to drive your Board into the ground, deploying an immovable kinetic barricade that provides **Medium Cover (+2 Protection)** to you and any allies within your space against attacks originating from outside the space. If you expend an active **Boost** die when deploying the barricade, it reinforces into **Heavy Cover (+3 Protection)**. Occupants sheltering behind the barricade are anchored and immune to forced movement (such as push or pull effects). Enemies cannot enter or cross the barricade's space without succeeding on an opposed contest against your **Shield**. You can reclaim the Board back into standard Shield Form for **0 AP** whenever you declare a Movement Action or swap forms.

HAWK COMBO

The Hawk Combo configures the Board into an extreme-range precision marksman rifle, utilizing gyroscopic stabilization and telemetry tracking across vast engagement distances.

Long Cannon [Passive]

- **Form:** Cannon
- **Effect:** Your Board reconfigures into a Long Cannon sniper platform. While in Cannon Form, your Board suffers **-1 Accuracy** at Short range, gains **+1 Accuracy** at Long and Extreme range, and gains a **Damage Bonus of +2** when firing at Medium range or farther. This configuration cannot be combined with *Assault Cannon* (if you possess both abilities, you choose which configuration your Cannon Form takes during downtime).

Tracking Shot [Action]

- **Form:** Cannon
- **Cost:** 1 AP
- **Effect:** Make a ranged attack using your Long Cannon against a visible target. For each Hit you choose to set aside from the attack roll, you paint the target with a persistent telemetry tag, granting an automatic Hit on your next ranged attack made against that target during the current Round.

Overwatch [Reaction]

- **Form:** Cannon
- **Cost:** 1 AP
- **Trigger:** When a target affected by your Tracking Shot tag declares an action or attempts a Movement Action.
- **Effect:** You consume 1 automatic Hit granted by Tracking Shot to fire an intercepting snap shot at the target before its declared action resolves. Roll a **Cannon Success Test** to determine the damage dealt by the shot.

CLASS MODS

Vanguard Class Mods cost **25,000 Credits** each and can be socketed into open chassis mod slots (unlocked at Levels 3 and 5; maximum 2 active mods):

- **Twin Turbo:** Advanced dual-capacitor banks allow you to hold up to two **Boost** dice at the same time. When spending Boost, you may choose to expend one or both banked dice on the same action.
- **Cheat Move:** Once per round, you can change your Board's form without spending AP (**0 AP**), and this transition still counts as a legitimate **Form Move** for combo prerequisites.
- **Head Start:** At the start of each Round during combat pacing, you can swap to any desired Form for free (**0 AP**). If you do not currently hold a Boost die, you immediately gain one **d10 Boost die**.
- **Hesitation Moves:** Inertial stabilizers preserve kinetic charge. You qualify for Form Move requirements if you performed the corresponding Form Move at any point during the current **Round**, rather than strictly during your current turn.
- **Boost Buildup:** At the end of the Player Turn, if you have remained in the same Form and have not swapped Forms during that turn, kinetic pressure builds up and grants you one **d10 Boost die**.

PROGRESSION

At character creation, distribute **7 Class Creation Points** among Shield, Glider, and Cannon (base 1 / 1 / 1; maximum starting rating of 5). You begin with **1 complete Combo** of your choice.

VANGUARD CHASSIS PROGRESSION (LEVELS 1-5)

LEVEL	BENEFITS UNLOCKED	CREDIT COST
Level 1	Base Chassis, 7 Attribute Points (base 1/1/1), Starting Combo, Boost Engine	**100,000 Credits***
Level 2	+1 Attribute Point, +1 Combo (3 Abilities)	**20,000 Credits**
Level 3	+1 Attribute Point, +1 Class Mod Slot (Slot 1), +1 Combo (3 Abilities)	**40,000 Credits**
Level 4	+1 Attribute Point, +1 Combo (3 Abilities)	**75,000 Credits**
Level 5	+1 Attribute Point, +1 Class Mod Slot (Slot 2)	**150,000 Credits**

**The 100,000 Credit cost for Level 1 applies only when purchasing an additional class chassis after character creation; an operative's starting class chassis is free.*

CLASS: THE WEAVER

The Weaver is the cell's master of molecular manipulation and on-the-fly fabrication, defined by total neural command over a specialized Weaver-pattern MANTLE (*Modular Adaptive Neural Transmission Linked Equipment*) housing millions of microscopic Nanites. Controlled directly through the operative's permanent Neural Control Chip (NCC) and cranial shunt, the rig centers around pressurized titanium-ceramic reservoirs anchored to the thoracic spine and routed across the body through subdermal micro-manifolds. Visually, a Weaver cuts an unmistakable, iridescent silhouette. Dormant nanite fluid constantly cycles across their person, pooling into shifting metallic scarves, flowing cloaks, or reinforced layers of kinetic weave that shimmer with subtle chromatic pulses. With a single neuro-synaptic impulse, these fluid fabrics can instantly solidify into razor-sharp monomolecular blades, lock into rigid ballistic plating, or atomize into an airborne cloud of micro-mechanical dust.

In active combat, the Weaver's reservoir operates under hard-science principles of programmable matter and high-frequency magnetic confinement fields. Billions of microscopic, multi-jointed alloy nodes rapidly interlock at the molecular level, allowing the Weaver to fabricate tools, forge weapons, or reinforce structural bulkheads in mere seconds. The experience of commanding the swarm is intensely tactile; operatives describe a distinct hum along their nerve endings as high-density telemetry streams back through their shunt port, conveying the structural integrity, surface tension, and molecular density of their creations in real time. Rather than carrying cumbersome bags of situational gear, the Weaver carries raw structural potential, reshaping their metallic fluid to solve logistical hurdles or tactical crises as they unfold.

The modular versatility of the Weaver MANTLE chassis makes it the ultimate force multiplier across all operational theaters. An operative can tune their nanite suspension into solid-state ballistic shields and physical armor to anchor a defensive perimeter, forge high-leverage melee blades or precision-calibrated long guns, weave aerodynamic aerofoils for effortless 3D flight, or flood allied tissue with cellular micro-sutures and clotting agents for emergency field triage. In technical environments, the nanite swarm can infiltrate sealed data ports and electronic consoles, short-circuiting security networks from the inside out. Whatever the mission demands, the Weaver ensures the cell is never without the right tool for the job.

ATTRIBUTES

A Weaver's capabilities are governed by three Class Attributes:

- **Create:** Molecular structural synthesis, solidifying dormant nanite fluid into functional physical tools, shields, and armaments.
- **Control:** Telemetric dynamic manipulation, guiding active swarms and directing forged constructs across spatial vectors.
- **Modify:** Precision lattice bonding, infusing existing equipment, physical structures, and organic tissue with adaptive nanite layers.

BASIC MECHANICS

When utilizing nanite capabilities, you roll tests using your Weaver Attributes. By default, your raw nanites can only create, modify, or manipulate simple objects that do not possess combat statistics or specialized properties—such as basic prybars, ropes, lockpicks, simple furniture, or utilitarian covers. Forging functional weapons, ballistic armor, medical consumables, or electronic viruses requires unlocking the corresponding **Nanite Weaves**.

To execute a nanite test, you declare your narrative action and pair your chosen Weaver Attribute with an appropriate Core Attribute (`Class + Core`), or with another Weaver Attribute (`Class + Class`). For example, combine **Create + Strength** to forge a heavy prybar and wrench open a jammed hatch, pair **Create + Finesse** to fabricate a micro-lockpick and align security tumblers, roll **Control + Instinct** to thread a nanite sensory cable beneath a blast door, or use **Modify + Presence** to subtly alter the identification text and seal on an executive credential.

THE NANITE RESERVOIR

Every Weaver maintains a physical reserve of programmable matter, measured in **Reserve**:

- **Baseline Capacity:** Operatives start with a capacity of **4 Reserve**.
- **Physical Volume:** A single point of Reserve corresponds to roughly 1 liter of concentrated nanite fluid held within the operative's pressurized dorsal canisters and subcutaneous manifold lines.
- **Material Scale & Density:** Stretched to its structural limits, 1 Reserve can produce a 24-meter cable, a 1-square-meter rigid surface, or handheld items equivalent to Load 1–2:
  - **1 Reserve:** Handheld tools, cables, grappling hooks, 1H weapons, simple containers (Load 1–2).
  - **2 Reserve:** Ladders, chairs, full hazard suits, 2H firearms, deployable barriers (Load 3–4).
  - **3 Reserve:** Reinforced benches, heavy 1m × 1m blast walls, pressurized airlocks (Load 5–6).
- **Workspace Limitation:** You deploy nanites in the **space you currently occupy**, unless an ability extends range.
- **Load Invariant:** All items forged purely from nanites have an effective **Load of 0**. Modifications applied to existing equipment preserve that equipment's original Load.
- **Instant Disassembly [Free Action]:** Decouple, liquefy, and siphon creations back into your reservoir at any time for **0 AP**, instantly recovering spent **Reserve**.
- **Reserve Cycles:** When spent Reserve recharges at the start of next round or end of turn, it is actively circulating and cannot be allocated until the duration elapses.

CLASS ABILITIES

Weaver abilities are grouped into thematic packages called **Nanite Weaves**. Each Weave is a tripartite suite containing three specialized applications—one for **Create**, one for **Modify**, and one for **Control**. Operatives select one starting Weave at character creation, and unlock an additional Weave at Levels 2, 3, and 4.

HARDWEAVE

HardWeave configures your nanite swarm into high-density interlocking crystalline lattices engineered to absorb catastrophic kinetic shock and deflect incoming fire.

HardWeave Shield [Action]

- **Attribute:** Create
- **Cost:** 1 Reserve, 1 AP
- **Effect:** *Micro-crystallized plates interlock across your forearm to form a rigid ballistic barrier.* You forge a physical shield in your space for yourself or an ally. It functions as a **1H shield** (Min STR 0, Load 0) granting a base **+1 Physical Protection Bonus**. Roll an Action Roll using **Create**. Each **Hit** spent increases the shield's Protection Bonus by **+1**.

HardWeave Armor [Action]

- **Attribute:** Modify
- **Cost:** 1 Reserve, 1 AP
- **Effect:** *Adaptive fluid seeps into seams and weave layers, hardening upon impact to distribute concussive force.* You reinforce worn armor on yourself or an ally in your space. Roll an Action Roll using **Modify**. Each **Hit** spent increases the armor's **Physical Protection by +1** until the end of the round.

HardWeave Block [Reaction]

- **Attribute:** Control
- **Cost:** 1 Reserve (recharges at the start of the next round)
- **Trigger:** When you or an ally in your space are targeted by an attack.
- **Effect:** *A reactive burst of pressurized nanites flashes outward to deflect an incoming projectile or blade.* You can contest the incoming attack for **0 AP**, rolling your **Contest Roll** using your **Control** Attribute instead of your standard physical Attributes.

SLICEWEAVE

SliceWeave aligns your nanite swarm into high-density cutting geometries, honing edges to monomolecular sharpness capable of parting composite armor and bone with equal ease.

SliceWeave Blade [Action]

- **Attribute:** Create
- **Cost:** 1 Reserve, 1 AP
- **Effect:** *Metallic fluid coalesces into an ergonomic hilt and extends a razor-honed blade of solid carbide alloy.* You forge a melee weapon in your space for yourself or an ally. It functions as a **1H melee weapon** (Min STR 0, Load 0, base **Damage Bonus +1**). When forged, declare its damage property: **Piercing** (favored pair **Agility + Finesse**), **Slashing** (favored pair **Agility + Strength**), or **Striking** (favored pair **Strength + Finesse**). Roll an Action Roll using **Create**. Each **Hit** spent increases the weapon's flat **Damage Bonus by +1**.

SliceWeave Edge [Action]

- **Attribute:** Modify
- **Cost:** 1 Reserve, 1 AP
- **Effect:** *A vibrating monomolecular ribbon bonds along the striking edge of an existing weapon.* You reinforce a melee weapon in your space. Roll an Action Roll using **Modify**. Each **Hit** spent increases the weapon's flat **Damage Bonus by +1** until the end of the round.

SliceWeave Slash [Action]

- **Attribute:** Control
- **Cost:** 1 Reserve (recharges at the start of the next round), 1 AP
- **Effect:** *A scything ribbon of high-velocity nanites lashes across the air in a lethal, sweeping arc.* Select your current space or one adjacent space and roll a **Control Success Test**. You inflict **Slashing** damage equal to your **Success Points + your Control Attribute** to all designated targets in the chosen space. You may spend additional available Reserve (which recharges at the start of the next round) to include one additional space per Reserve spent.

BOLTWEAVE

BoltWeave structures nanites into high-tolerance magnetic accelerator barrels, tailored propellant chambers, and aerodynamically perfected kinetic sabots.

BoltWeave Weapon [Action]

- **Attribute:** Create
- **Cost:** 1 Reserve, 1 AP
- **Effect:** *Fluid alloy solidifies into a shoulder-fired long gun with calibrated magnetic rails and an optical rail.* You forge a firearm in your space for yourself or an ally. It functions as a **2H firearm** (Min STR 0, Load 0) with a base weapon profile: `Acc: [3 / 2 / 1 / 0], RoF: 1, Dmg: +1`. Roll an Action Roll using **Create**. Each **Hit** spent allows you to calibrate the firearm by selecting one of the following options (you cannot choose the same option twice; different Accuracy band pairs count as separate options):
  - Increase flat **Damage Bonus by +2**.
  - Increase **Rate of Fire (RoF) by +2**.
  - Increase two adjacent **Accuracy bands by +1** each (cannot increase a single band by +2).

BoltWeave Ammo [Action]

- **Attribute:** Modify
- **Cost:** 1 Reserve (recharges at the start of the next round), 1 AP
- **Effect:** *Chambered ammunition is coated in high-mass sabot jackets and terminal guidance fins.* You infuse and calibrate the ammunition of an ally occupying your space. Roll an Action Roll using **Modify**. Each **Hit** spent grants that ally's firearm attacks your choice of the following benefits until the end of the round:
  - **+1 Damage Bonus**.
  - **+1 Rate of Fire (RoF)**.
  - **+1 Accuracy in a single range band** (this cannot grant the ability to fire at a range band the weapon cannot naturally engage, marked `-`).

  The spent Reserve recharges at the start of the next round.

BoltWeave Bullet [Action]

- **Attribute:** Control
- **Cost:** 1 Reserve (recharges at the start of the next round), 1 AP
- **Effect:** *Pressurized reservoir coils launch a dense, hyper-velocity slug directly from your harness.* Make a ranged attack against a creature or object within **Short range (0–5 spaces)**, rolling a **Control Success Test**. You inflict kinetic damage equal to your **Success Points + your Control Attribute**.

FLOATWEAVE

FloatWeave integrates aerostatic micro-turbines, magnetic repulsion baffles, and aerodynamic surface foils into your constructs to conquer vertical terrain and master 3D movement.

FloatWeave Infusion [Passive]

- **Attribute:** Create
- **Effect:** *Internal counter-grav nodes and micro-thrusters allow forged items to hover weightlessly.* Any item or weapon you create with your nanites gains integrated levitation. These creations hover freely within your space, move alongside you without requiring hands to carry, and can be wielded or operated **hands-free** using your **Control or Create** Attribute in place of the normal required Core Attribute (such as firing a hovering BoltWeave rifle or striking with a floating SliceWeave blade).

FloatWeave Wings [Action]

- **Attribute:** Modify
- **Cost:** 1 Reserve, 1 AP
- **Effect:** *Articulated aerofoil wings of layered composite feather-plates unfold from the recipient's shoulders.* You attach wings to yourself or an ally in your space. The recipient gains **Flight** (base speed 4 meters, ascending costs double, ignores Difficult Terrain, and hovers in place). The recipient is immune to falling damage while the wings remain attached. When the recipient takes a movement action, they may execute their movement by rolling a Success Test using your **Modify** or **Control** Attribute.

FloatWeave Wind [Action]

- **Attribute:** Control
- **Cost:** 1 Reserve (recharges at the end of the turn), 1 AP
- **Effect:** *A howling micro-vortex of directed air and swirling nanites lifts you bodily into the air.* Until the end of your turn, you gain **Flight** and can use your **Control** Attribute on all Movement Actions.

LIFEWEAVE

LifeWeave programs microscopic bio-medical assembler nodes capable of cellular reconstruction, accelerated tissue granulation, and synthetic neural bridging.

LifeWeave Elixir [Action]

- **Attribute:** Create
- **Cost:** 1 Reserve, 1 AP
- **Effect:** *Nanites suspend themselves in a concentrated metabolic nutrient fluid inside a sealed autoinjector.* You synthesize a consumable injector (Load 0). When a creature consumes the elixir as an Action, the user rolls a **Create Success Test** using your Create rating. For every **2 Success Points**, the user heals **1 Light Wound or 1 Light Stress**.

LifeWeave Heal [Action]

- **Attribute:** Modify
- **Cost:** 1 Reserve (recharges at the start of the next round), 1 AP
- **Effect:** *Active medical micro-swarms flood an open wound to cauterize vessels and knit torn flesh.* You inject medical nanites directly into an injured creature occupying your space. Roll a **Modify Success Test**. For every **3 Success Points**, you heal **2 Light Wounds** on the target.

LifeWeave Enhancement [Passive]

- **Attribute:** Control
- **Effect:** *Subdermal nanite filaments weave through muscle fibers and neural pathways to augment physical and mental performance.* Any creature affected by your other LifeWeave abilities can substitute your **Control** Attribute in place of any Core Attribute on their tests until the end of the round.

MIRAGEWEAVE

MirageWeave commands nanites to align their surfaces into microscopic refractive lenses, sound-absorbing baffles, and adaptive pigments that bend light, alter physical appearances, and deaden acoustic signatures.

MirageWeave Infusion [Passive]

- **Attribute:** Create
- **Effect:** *Adaptive photonic metamaterials and micro-pigments reshape the surface of your fabrications.* You can alter the visual texture, markings, and finish of any item you create to make it appear authentic, legitimate, or disguised. You may use your **Create** Attribute on any tests made while utilizing the fabricated item. Furthermore, whenever you roll to Create an object, you may sacrifice **Hits** from your Action Roll to establish a **Sustained Blocker Effect** (1 Blocker die per 2 Hits sacrificed) that opposes any attempts by hostile creatures to visually spot, detect, or identify the item.

MirageWeave Coating [Action]

- **Attribute:** Modify
- **Cost:** 1 Reserve, 1 AP
- **Effect:** *A shimmering, light-refracting film crawls across skin, armor, and gear to reshape silhouettes or mimic identities.* You coat a creature or object in your space. You can cosmetically alter the target's physical appearance, colors, uniforms, insignia, or facial features to disguise them. You can also roll **Modify** on tests relying on the coated creature or object to remain unseen or relying on other creatures to believe your disguise is authentic. Additionally, you may roll an Action Roll using **Modify**; for every **2 Hits** sacrificed, you establish a **Sustained Blocker Effect** (1 Blocker die per 2 Hits sacrificed) opposing all attempts to perceive, detect, or target the coated subject from outside its space.

MirageWeave Veil [Action]

- **Attribute:** Control
- **Cost:** 1 Reserve (recharges at the start of the next round), 1 AP
- **Effect:** *An obscuring aerosol cloud of blackout nanites and optical chaff billows outward to shield your cell.* You disperse a mobile veil of refractive nanites that moves with you and covers your current space, shielding everyone within it. Roll an Action Roll using **Control**. For every **2 Hits** sacrificed, you establish a **Blocker Effect** (1 Blocker die per 2 Hits sacrificed) against incoming ranged attacks and visual detection from outside the space. This veil lasts until the beginning of the next Player Turn, but instantly breaks and dissipates if any creature makes an attack from within the veil.

CYBERWEAVE

CyberWeave configures nanites into conductive micro-circuitry, logic gates, and sensor diodes capable of infiltrating and dominating electronic systems.

CyberWeave Drone [Action]

- **Attribute:** Create
- **Cost:** 1 Reserve, 1 AP
- **Effect:** You assemble a palm-sized hexapod crawler drone in your space. Roll a **Create Success Test**. For every **2 Success Points**, allocate a +1 bonus between its **Interfacing** or **Sensors** ratings. The drone moves up to 20 meters per round and can slice terminals or transmit telemetry. It disassembles if damaged or moving beyond 40 meters.

CyberWeave Virus [Action]

- **Attribute:** Modify
- **Cost:** 1 Reserve, 1 AP
- **Effect:** You infect an electronic terminal, locked blast door, or sensor node in your space. Rolling **Modify**, you force the device to execute a standard function, display a false error, or short-circuit its primary bus. You can re-trigger this effect remotely within 40 meters.

CyberWeave Swarm [Action]

- **Attribute:** Control
- **Cost:** 1 Reserve, 1 AP
- **Effect:** You deploy an atmospheric sensor cloud (4-meter radius within 20 meters). Roll a **Control Success Test**: every 2 Success Points grants **+1 Upgrade** to all allied ranged attacks made against targets within the cloud. The swarm can be repositioned as an Action for 0 Reserve.

CLASS MODS

Weaver Class Mods cost **25,000 Credits** each (socketed at Levels 3 and 5, max 2 active):

- **Extra Reserve:** Gain **+1 Reserve** (increasing baseline reservoir capacity from 4 to 5).
- **Reborn Weave:** When rolling a Success Roll on Weaver tests, disassemble an active Creation/Modification enhanced with Hits to score those Hits and **8 Success Points** automatically.
- **Revitalizing Weave:** When recycling a Creation/Modification, also regain a spent Reserve that would have recharged at the end of the turn.
- **Woven Bond:** Gain **+1 Upgrade** on any test made while using equipment or weapons you have Created or Modified.
- **Weave Infusion:** Spend **1 additional Reserve** on a Weave test to add **+3 Success Points** or score an additional **Hit**.

PROGRESSION

At character creation, distribute **7 Points** among Create, Control, and Modify (base 1 / 1 / 1, max 5). You begin with **1 Weave**.

WEAVER CHASSIS PROGRESSION (LEVELS 1-5)

LEVEL	BENEFITS UNLOCKED	CREDIT COST
Level 1	Base Chassis, 7 Attribute Points (base 1/1/1), Starting Weave, 4 Reserve	**100,000 Credits***
Level 2	+1 Attribute Point, +1 Weave (3 Abilities)	**20,000 Credits**
Level 3	+1 Attribute Point, +1 Class Mod Slot (Slot 1), +1 Weave (3 Abilities)	**40,000 Credits**
Level 4	+1 Attribute Point, +1 Weave (3 Abilities)	**75,000 Credits**
Level 5	+1 Attribute Point, +1 Class Mod Slot (Slot 2)	**150,000 Credits**

**The 100,000 Credit cost for Level 1 applies only when purchasing an additional class chassis after character creation; an operative's starting class chassis is free.*

TACTICAL WEAVER ARCHETYPES

- **The Armament Smith:** Invests in *Create* paired with BoltWeave and HardWeave. Forges customized sniper rifles and ballistic barriers on demand, arming the entire cell from a single reservoir.
- **The Kinetic Striker:** Balances *Control* with SliceWeave and FloatWeave. Slices through armored enemy bulkheads with sweeping monomolecular ribbons, hovering weightlessly across the battlefield.
- **The Infiltration Specialist:** Synergizes *Modify* and *Control* with MirageWeave and CyberWeave. Coats allies in chameleon films, overrides security terminals with viral tendrils, and deploys crawler drones for remote reconnaissance.
- **The Cellular Medic:** Dedicated to LifeWeave, synthesizing restorative nutrient elixirs and deploying medical micro-swarms to knit torn tissue and restart vital organs mid-firefight.

POST WAR HEAD- AND HEARTACHES

A CORSAIR STORY • FICTION INTERLUDE

The primary trouble with installing military-grade reflex governors in a human nervous system, Marcus had long concluded, was that the machinery never quite accepted the concept of peacetime.

A normal human brain, when exposed to a rainy evening on Nimbus, understands that a neon noodle stall is just a place where tired mechanics buy bowls of hot broth. The reflex implant wired into Marcus's spine, however, had been built during the worst eighteen months of the Kazahn campaign, when the Orkish Empire was dropping armored shock walkers into the frozen mud every few days. The implant did not understand soup. It understood muzzle flashes, shock waves, and flying iron. When a wet metal sign swung in the mountain wind with a rusty screech, his nerves didn't register an advertisement for dumplings; they registered an incoming mortar shell, sending a jolt of panic through his muscles and telling his hands to break something before it broke him.

Marcus exhaled slowly, his boots planted on the wet steel of the Level Eighty-Four skywalk. He counted to four. *Inhale.* He counted to four. *Exhale.*

"You're drifting, Sergeant," a voice said from his left.

Marcus didn't turn his head. If you looked at Corporal Aris, Aris vanished, and Marcus preferred him where he was. Aris was leaning his elbows on the safety rail, looking out over the two-mile drop of purple and gold clouds churning beneath Cloudspire. Aris was nineteen, smelled of burnt engine oil and cheap tobacco, and still wore his mud-caked combat webbing. Through the ragged hole in the center of Aris's chest rig, Marcus could see the blue neon glare of an insurance billboard across the way.

"I'm not drifting," Marcus whispered under the steady hiss of the rain. "I'm watching the crossing."

"Crossing's clear," Aris muttered, flicking a phantom cigarette butt into the clouds. "You got two snipers up on the crane towers, though. Orks. See them?"

Marcus looked up toward the thick steel cables stretching between the needle towers. No snipers. Just two city maintenance workers in yellow raincoats, tightening bolts against the wind.

"Workers," Marcus murmured. "Just maintenance."

"Sure," Aris said cheerfully. "And that drop-pod coming down through the clouds is just a weather balloon."

THUD.

A deep vibration hammered through the soles of his boots. The walkway shuddered. Overhead, the cloud deck flashed violet.

Marcus didn't think; his body dropped six inches and his hand swept under his coat for a heavy pistol that wasn't there. He had tossed the pistol into an industrial furnace three weeks ago, watching the steel melt because he couldn't trust his hands in the dark anymore.

His heart battered against his ribs like a trapped bird. He pressed his back against the pillar of a cab kiosk, his breath ragged, tasting copper and ozone.

In his mind, the towers of Cloudspire dissolved into the scarred trenches of the frontier. The rain wasn't clean water; it was the greasy stench of burning fuel and wet ashes. The sky tore open with fiery re-entry streaks. Orkish drop-cages—fourteen tons of stamped pig-iron with no parachutes and no mercy—screamed through the clouds on crude solid rockets, hitting the dirt with the sound of a falling cathedral. From the smoking wreckage rose two-legged iron battlemechs—towering bipedal war-machines that stamped forward through the red mud on thick hydraulic pistons, their rotary thumpers already spinning.

They're dropping, his nervous system screamed. *They're dropping right on our heads, Marcus, get down—*

"Move it, grandpa!"

A young human courier on a hoverboard zipped past his elbow, swerving around the puddle at Marcus's feet, chewing melon-flavored gum. The kid didn't even glance back.

Marcus blinked. The mud of Kazahn washed away, replaced by the glare of a three-story holographic display advertising corporate bonds.

The vibration under his feet hadn't been an Orkish drop-cage. It had been the pneumatic coupling of a freight tram, latching its magnetic brake calipers onto the central rail three hundred meters down the concourse.

Marcus pressed his palms into his eyes until constellations of silver phosphor bloomed behind his eyelids. His body was trembling so violently that the change in his pocket jingled like small bells.

Safe, he told himself. *You are on Nimbus. You are thirty-four years old. You are on the mid-decks of Cloudspire. The war ended ten years ago. The treaty was signed. The Orks are on their side of the buffer. You are out of uniform.*

"You're out of uniform, Marcus," a second voice remarked dryly.

Sergeant Vane was sitting cross-legged on the lid of a grease-bin three feet away, field-stripping a phantom rail-carbine. Vane was forty, had a grey buzzcut, and had died in Marcus's arms behind the fuel depot on Ridge Nine when a stray flechette pierced his neck seal.

"You look like a vagrant," Vane said, blowing imaginary carbon dust from the bolt. "The Flotilla didn't spend a fortune wiring your spine to an optical firing computer so you could wander in the rain wearing a dead clerk's coat. Check your corners. We've got a tail."

"Leave me alone, Vane," Marcus rasped, keeping his head down as he began walking again, his work boots splashing through the shallow puddles.

"Can't do that, Sergeant," Vane replied calmly, falling into step two paces behind his right shoulder. The wet scrape of Vane's boots was silent to the world, but deafening to Marcus. "Three men trailing on the skybridge. Gangers. Scrappers from the lower ravines. They saw the silver in your neck."

Marcus didn't look. If you started checking corners every time your dead squad leader called out an ambush, the peacekeepers dragged you into a ward and pumped you full of neuro-blockers.

Besides, Marcus knew what real danger looked like. Real danger walked on two iron legs, ran on dirty diesel, and could stomp an armored carrier flat with a single hydraulic stride. Three men in the shadows were just noise.

He turned off the wide, brightly lit arterial boulevard and ducked into the shadowed maze of the city's service conduits.

Here, sixty meters beneath the pedestrian decks, the city revealed its bones. Heavy coolant lines the thickness of ancient redwoods ran along the ceilings, dripping condensation into rusty gutters. Steam hissed from valves, shrouding the narrow catwalks in warm, damp fog that smelled of sulfur and fried oil.

Marcus liked the dark. In the dark, the implant had fewer lights to mistake for targeting lasers. In the dark, his eyes didn't sting.

He stopped in the recessed alcove of an inactive ventilation turbine, resting his forehead against the vibrating steel.

He reached into the inner breast pocket of his coat and pulled out a small photograph sealed in creased plastic.

Elena was laughing in the picture. She was sitting on the wooden steps of their modest terraced cottage on the slopes of Landfall, her knees drawn up under a blanket, a mug of chicory tea steaming between her hands. Leaning against her side was Toby, five years old then, proudly holding up a crooked toy hopper he had carved from scrap pine with a plastic butter knife. Toby's front teeth were missing, and his grin was wide enough to swallow the valley.

Marcus touched the plastic with a rough, scarred thumb.

He remembered the kitchen. It was the last memory he had of them that wasn't soaked in terror.

It had been an ordinary Tuesday evening, four months after his discharge. Elena was drying the dishes, humming a half-remembered tune from the orbital ferries. Toby was asleep in the back bedroom under a patchwork quilt.

Elena had turned to put a ceramic serving platter into the cupboard. Her hands were wet. The platter slipped.

It didn't even fall six inches.

Before the dish could hit the floorboards, the combat implant had taken over. In less than forty milliseconds—faster than a human heart can finish a single beat—Marcus's body had moved without him.

He didn't remember standing up. He only remembered waking up to find his hand buried in the wall plaster, his forearm pinned across Elena's throat, and the shattered platter crushed to fine white dust inside his bare fist.

Elena hadn't screamed. She had just looked into his eyes—eyes whose pupils were dilated to black pools, shivering with targeting micro-tremors. A single tear had cut a clean line through the flour on her cheek.

And from the bedroom doorway, little Toby had stood clutching his wooden toy, staring at his father with eyes hollowed out by horror.

Marcus had dropped to his knees, gasping as if he had climbed out of a breached airlock.

He hadn't packed much. A change of clothes, his papers, and his discharge chits. He had waited until three in the morning, laid his Flotilla pension voucher on the wooden counter—enough credits to pay the lease and buy Toby new shoes every year until he was a grown man—and walked out the door.

A weapon did not belong in a house with children. You do not keep a live mine on the shelf next to the jam jars.

"You did the right thing," Aris whispered from the corner of the turbine housing. "You keep the rear echelon safe. That's doctrine."

"Shut up, Aris," Marcus choked out.

"He's not wrong about the tail, though," Vane's voice cut in, sharp and sudden. "On the catwalk above the coolant manifold. Twelve paces out. They're closing the trap."

• • •

Sixty meters away, crouched behind the exhaust shroud of an air-intake scrubber, Jax lowered his thermal binoculars.

Beside him, Tessa checked the battery charge on her pneumatic capture carbine with a quiet click.

"Target confirmed," Jax whispered into his throat-mic. "Auxiliary turbine bay. It's Ward. Canvas coat, work boots, no weapon. He's leaning against the housing, shaking hard."

"Is he armed?" Tessa asked.

"Threw his service piece into a furnace three weeks ago," Jax replied. "Pockets are empty. But look at his spine on the thermal channel. Mother of mercy."

Tessa leaned over, peering at the secondary display. She let out a low breath.

Beneath the canvas coat, Marcus Ward's spine burned like a rod of white-hot magnesium. Intricate lines of silver traced outward from his vertebrae, wrapping around his ribs and pulsing with steady thermal leakage.

"The Mark-IV Synaptic Loom," Tessa murmured. "Pure naval skunkworks. Only eleven ever made. Built to let human infantry react as fast as mechanized walkers."

"And that's why the wolves are out," Jax said, glancing upward.

Across the gantry, four figures in piecemeal ballistic vests were slipping through the steam. They weren't soldiers; they were an Iron Fang cyber-salvage crew from the lower ravines—chop-shop cutthroats armed with heavy pneumatic taser-carbines and neural shock tethers, tipped off to an off-grid Flotilla veteran carrying four hundred thousand credits worth of military hardware under his skin.

"What about Stormwatch?" Tessa asked, glancing toward the foggy heights.

"They're above us," Jax muttered.

A hundred meters up, half-hidden in the swirling violet smog that rose from the ravines, the pitch-black hull of a Nimbus Rapid Response VTOL hovered in complete silence, its ducted lift-fans dialed to whisper-quiet station-keeping mode.

Stormdrinker, the ancient void dragon who roosted in the violent electrical squalls of Nimbus's upper atmosphere, was revered by the public as the 'Lightning Sage'—the majestic patron of Cloudspire. But behind closed doors, he was also the de facto head of the Sphere Research Center. Reclusive compared to his brother Goldheart down on Landfall, the dragon possessed an insatiable, terrifying thirst for knowledge that had its talons sunk into every sector of Flotilla space.

And the Nimbus Stormwatch was the sharpest talon of all. Their bleeding-edge armor, stealth aerostats, and proprietary weapons were sponsored directly by the SRC and the local megacorps. Because of that funding, Stormwatch was notorious for playing by their own cutthroat rules—more than happy to stage a quiet, questionable arrest under the guise of 'public safety quarantine' whenever the SRC flagged a rare piece of technology wandering the streets.

If the street gang didn't butcher Marcus for scrap, Stormwatch would bag him and haul him straight to an SRC neuro-lab for non-consensual dissection. That was why the Flotilla had chartered Corsairs: to get their veteran out alive and intact before either the wolves or the badge-wearing vultures closed in.

"Stay high," Jax instructed Tessa quietly. "Don't let Ward see us. If his combat governors trip, he won't know friend from foe. Cover him from the shadows."

• • •

In the shadowed alcove, Marcus didn't hear the boots.

What he heard was the scrape of iron against concrete.

Marcus opened his eyes. The photograph of Elena and Toby slipped from his numb fingers, fluttering downward to land face-up in a shallow puddle of rainwater.

Ten paces ahead, emerging from the steam, were two men in greasy leather and scrap armor, holding heavy electric cattle-prods. A third was circling behind the turbine.

Ambuscade, the implant hummed against the base of his skull. *Three hostiles. Triangular envelopment.*

"Easy, soldier," the lead scrapper grinned, showing gold-capped teeth through the mist. "Just hold still. We're here to take a little weight off your spine."

To the gangers, Marcus was just a broken vagrant.

To Marcus, the world suddenly slowed until every drop of falling condensate hung in mid-air like dark glass.

The hum in his teeth vanished, replaced by the terrifying, crystal-clear silence of active combat. His peripheral vision flared with iridescent green vector lines. The silver filaments woven along his spinal cord burned with freezing fire.

He didn't make a decision. The machine made it for him.

The lead scrapper lunged with the shock prod. Marcus didn't dodge; he exploded forward like a released catapult spring, moving five meters in less than a quarter of a second.

His left palm struck the prod's shaft, snapping the fiberglass core clean in half. In the same fluid motion, his right palm drove upward into the scrapper's jaw.

The man flew backward through the steam, crashing into the coolant pipe before dropping limp into the gutter.

"Take him down!" the second scrapper yelled, swinging a heavy iron pipe.

Marcus ducked smoothly beneath the swing, pivoted on his heel, and drove his steel-toed boot into the side of the man's knee. The joint buckled with a sickening crack, and the ganger collapsed with a shriek of agony.

Behind them, up on the raised iron catwalk twenty paces away, a fourth scrapper had leaned over the railing, leveling a high-powered flechette rifle straight at Marcus's exposed back.

Marcus was looking away, his balance committed, blind to the rifle.

From high in the shadows of the ceiling duct, Tessa's suppressed carbine whispered with a silent pneumatic *pfft*.

A needle-thin tranquilizer dart struck the shooter squarely in the neck. The man stiffened, his fingers slipping from the trigger. His eyes rolled back, and he slumped quietly against the corrugated wall, sliding down into the shadows without firing a single shot.

The rifle clattered against the iron grating.

Marcus heard the metallic clatter and spun, assuming the fourth man had simply bolted. His eyes locked onto the third scrapper, who was cowering against the turbine housing.

Neutralize threat, the implant screamed through his marrow.

Marcus seized a heavy, two-meter scaffold pipe from the deck, ripped it from its rusted bracket, and swung it up over his shoulder like a sledgehammer, ready to bring it crashing down through the man's skull.

Smash the hatch. Seal the trench. Don't let them breach.

The scrapper raised trembling hands, shrieking in pure terror.

Marcus tightened his grip. The iron bar began its downward arc.

And then, cutting through the roaring static in his ears, a tiny sound rustled beneath his boot.

Marcus's eyes flicked downward.

There, in the filthy puddle, lay the photograph. Elena's smile. Toby's wooden hopper.

And in the silence of his skull, a small voice asked:

Daddy, are you coming home for dinner?

The iron pipe stopped.

It stopped three inches from the man's face. The displaced air ruffled the scrapper's hair.

Marcus stood frozen in the steam. His arms were shaking. The veins in his neck stood out like knotted cordage. The silver fire in his spine sputtered, flared, and then began to pulse with a chaotic, agonizing arrhythmia that felt like broken glass grinding against his bones.

"Toby..." he whispered.

He looked at the iron bar in his hands. Then he looked at the terrified kid cowering beneath it.

There were no Orkish battlemechs. There was no trench. There was only a terrified mugger in the rain, and Marcus Ward standing over him with an iron bar like a monster.

"Oh, God," Marcus choked out. "God... what am I doing?"

His fingers went limp. The heavy iron pipe clattered against the diamond-tread deck with a loud, ringing *CLANG*.

The terrified ganger didn't wait. He scrambled backward on all fours, scrambled to his feet, and vanished down the service corridor in blind panic.

Marcus sank to his knees in the puddle. His hands were trembling so violently he could barely scoop the wet photograph from the water. He pressed it to his chest, curled inward, and wept—dry, ragged sobs that shook his entire frame.

Above in the smog, the searchlights of the Stormwatch VTOL suddenly cut through the upper ventilation shafts. Sirens wailed in the distance. The gunshots and commotion had tripped municipal sensor grids.

Marcus scrambled to his feet, disoriented, clutching the picture inside his coat, and fled into the dark maintenance tunnels to get away from the noise.

• • •

Twenty minutes later, Marcus stumbled out of the service labyrinth onto a quiet, covered promenade on Level Seventy-Two.

The neon here was subdued. Rain drummed steadily on corrugated plastic awnings that sheltered a row of humble market stalls. The air smelled of woodsmoke, roasting scallions, and boiling broth.

Marcus's legs were like lead. The adrenaline crash had hit him with the weight of an avalanche; his temperature had plummeted, his teeth were chattering, and the silver conduits in his neck ached with a dull, throbbing fever.

He collapsed onto a worn wooden stool beneath the awning of a small, open-front ramen stall tucked under an iron fire escape. He dropped his elbows onto the counter, buried his face in his hands, and tried to stop shaking.

"Two bowls of the pork broth, old friend," a calm, easy voice said from the stool beside him. "Extra noodles. Heavy on the scallions."

Marcus stiffened, his fingers twitching instinctively.

The man sitting on the adjacent stool didn't look like a soldier, a scrapper, or an officer. He looked like an ordinary, tired cargo worker in a faded brown leather jacket, with salt-and-pepper hair and calm grey eyes. He had his elbows propped comfortably on the counter, watching the old noodle chef drop a basket of noodles into boiling water.

"Rough night to be out without an umbrella," the man said mildly, not looking at Marcus directly. "Cloud deck's heavy tonight. Gets into the joints."

Marcus stared at him through bloodshot eyes. "I don't... I don't know you."

"Name's Jax," the man said smoothly.

The cook slid a massive, steaming ceramic bowl of rich amber broth, thick noodles, and roasted pork in front of Marcus, followed by a second bowl for Jax. Steam rose in a fragrant cloud between them.

"Eat up," Jax nudged the bowl an inch closer. "You're shivering like a wet stray. Broth is good for the shakes. Best medicine in the cluster."

Marcus hesitated. Every instinct told him to run, to find an airlock, to hide. But the warmth coming off the bowl was intoxicating, and his stomach was an empty, aching pit. He picked up a wooden spoon with a trembling hand, dipped it into the soup, and tasted it.

It was incredible. Rich, salty, savory, with a deep undertone of roasted garlic.

"Reminds me of Landfall," Jax said conversationally, slurping a mouthful of noodles. "Down in the river valleys. Cold mornings, red dirt under your fingernails. Best chicory tea in the system, if you ask me."

Marcus froze, his spoon hovering halfway to his mouth. "Landfall?"

"Yeah," Jax said, his tone entirely casual, as if chatting with a stranger on a ferry. "Had a buddy who lived out past Crossroads. Little terraced cottage with wooden steps. Used to tell me about his kid carving toy cargo hoppers out of scrap pine with a plastic butter knife. Said the boy carved it so crooked it looked like a potato with wings."

Marcus felt the breath leave his lungs in a sharp, quiet gasp. He looked at Jax.

Jax turned his head and met his gaze. There was no pity in the man's grey eyes, and no threat. There was only the quiet, steady understanding of someone who had seen the same horrors and survived them.

Marcus looked down into his bowl. Tears welled in his eyes and dripped into the steaming broth. He didn't ask how Jax knew. He didn't care. The warmth of the soup was already spreading through his chest, carrying with it a faint, sweet, medicinal numbness—a top-tier neuro-stabilizer formulated by naval surgeons to gently dampen overclocked synaptic loops.

Marcus ate. He ate like a starving man, spooning down the rich broth, chewing the pork, feeling the violent tremors in his hands begin to ease with every swallow.

When both bowls were empty, the old cook wordlessly cleared them away and set down a pot of hot tea.

Jax reached into his leather coat and pulled out a plain silver tin. He opened it, revealing a row of neatly rolled cigarettes.

"Got a smoke?" Jax asked, offering the tin. "Real Landfall leaf. Sun-cured. None of that synthetic chemical crap they sell on the upper decks."

Marcus reached out. His fingers, still stained with rust, took a cigarette.

Jax flicked an old brass lighter, holding the yellow flame steady. Marcus leaned in, drew the smoke into his lungs, and leaned back against the counter.

The tobacco was sweet, smelling of mountain clover and dried earth. And mixed into the fragrant leaf was a fast-acting respiratory sedative, sliding smoothly into his bloodstream to finish the work the broth had started.

Marcus exhaled a long plume of blue-grey smoke.

Across the counter, sitting on an empty vegetable crate in the alley rain, Corporal Aris was watching him. Aris didn't have a hole in his chest anymore. His uniform was clean. He smiled, gave a little two-finger salute, and dissolved softly into the drifting mist. Beside him, Sergeant Vane tipped his cap, turned, and walked away into the dark.

The ghosts were gone.

The sixty-cycle buzzing in Marcus's teeth ceased entirely. The constant, agonizing tension in his shoulders melted away. For the first time in ten years, the world was completely, beautifully quiet.

Marcus's eyelids grew heavy, like lead weights pulling him down. His head began to nod forward.

Jax moved smoothly, sliding an arm beneath Marcus's shoulders and supporting the veteran as he slumped against the counter. Jax leaned in close, his voice quiet, warm, and steady right beside Marcus's ear.

"You held the line, Sergeant," Jax whispered. "You held it until the war was over. But you're off the clock now."

Marcus breathed out, his forehead resting against Jax's worn leather sleeve. "The... the iron..."

"The iron's done falling, Marcus," Jax said softly. "The Flotilla chartered us to bring you in. No lockups. No salvage hounds. No cages. We've got a naval hospital frigate waiting at the high docks with surgeons who know how to turn that machinery down so you can live a normal life."

A single tear rolled down Marcus's cheek, catching the yellow light of the paper lanterns.

"And if all goes well," Jax murmured, "you're going home, Marcus. Elena and Toby are waiting."

A faint, peaceful smile touched the corner of Marcus's lips.

"Home..." he whispered.

He closed his eyes, and fell into a deep, dreamless sleep.

At the curb of the alley, a sleek, enclosed electric transport skiff glided to a silent stop in the rain. Tessa stepped out, opening the rear door and helping Jax lift the sleeping veteran onto the cushioned interior bench.

Jax turned back to the counter, dropped a generous stack of Flotilla credit chits beside the teapot, and nodded to the old cook. The cook nodded back in silent respect, pocketed the credits, and began wiping the counter.

Overhead, through the thick purple smog of Level Seventy-Two, the searchlights of the Nimbus Stormwatch VTOL swept blindly across the empty rooftops, hunting for a fugitive who was already gone.

And miles above the city, high in the wild, violet lightning of the storm-wells, the colossal form of Stormdrinker drifted through the jet stream. The great dragon circled once through the electrical clouds, his golden eyes gazing down upon the vast, glittering needle towers of Cloudspire, before turning his wings into the deep storm, leaving the quiet streets and the sleeping soldier behind.

COMBAT & THE ARMORY

In the world of Corsair, conflict is inevitable. Whether facing down a squad of corporate enforcers, battling a monstrous alien in the depths of a derelict ship, or engaging in a desperate firefight across depressurized docking gantries, combat is a thrilling and dangerous reality of high-frontier survival. When conflict turns violent and every action matters, the game shifts into Moment to Moment pacing. While you can resolve combat using "theater of the mind," employing a grid-based battle map adds tactical depth and clarity to character and enemy positioning.

MOVEMENT

Navigating the battlefield is crucial for survival. Positioning determines cover, line of sight, and your ability to engage or evade foes. In combat, you can spend **1 Action Point (AP)** to move. When you move, you perform a **Success Test**, typically with **Agility**, then move a number of meters equal to the result, plus your base speed (by default, **4 meters**).

The Success Test is typically made with your Agility attribute, representing your ability to run, climb, and vault across terrain. The GM may call for a different attribute based on the situation (e.g., Strength for climbing a sheer cliff).

MOVEMENT ON A GRID

For ease of play, use a battle grid with squares or hexes representing a **4 meter diameter circle**. On a grid, movement is calculated as follows:

- Your base speed of 4 meters translates to **1 space**.
- Your Success Test adds additional movement: divide the number of meters rolled on your test by four, rounding up, and move an additional number of spaces equal to the result.

A single move action covers a maximum of 16 meters (4 spaces). Because a player can spend multiple Action Points on movement, the potential distances can be significant.

VERTICALITY

Since the world is not a 2D plane, you can move up and down as well as left and right. When the situation introduces verticality, you can model this by adding more layers of flat horizontal grids on top of each other. These layers are separated by **2 meters**, and moving up and down between layers is always considered difficult terrain, unless of course, you fall.

When you fall more than 2 meters, you take damage equal to **three times the number of meters you fell**, and the damage is completely **unmitigated by Protection**. Stories in a building, while not exactly 2 meters high, roughly correspond to tactical layers.

FLYING

Flying is a type of movement that allows you to use your movement to move in the air, as if on solid ground. Ascending costs double; this means to ascend 2 meters, you need to use 4 meters of your movement. Moving downwards or horizontally while flying uses your movement as if you were on solid ground. You ignore Difficult Terrain while flying.

During the turn you lose flight, you can remain in the space you occupy in the air until the end of the turn, and you fall to the ground at the end of the turn, taking falling damage if you fell more than 2 meters.

DIFFICULT TERRAIN

Not all battlefields are open fields. Movement can be hindered by obstacles, hazardous ground, or changes in elevation. This is represented by **Difficult Terrain**. When you move through difficult terrain, every 1 meter of progress costs you 2 meters of your speed. On a grid, moving into a space containing difficult terrain (such as mud, dense rubble, or thick vegetation) costs **8 meters** of movement instead of the usual 4 meters. This also applies if the *boundary* between two otherwise clear spaces is difficult (e.g., vaulting a barricade).

CONTESTING MOVEMENT

Movement is not always unopposed. A character can attempt to block or trip a creature moving through a space they occupy by contesting the moving creature's movement Success Test:

1. **The Contester Narrates:** Describe how you impede movement (tripping, grabbing, blocking).
2. **The GM Chooses an Attribute:** Relevant Attribute (e.g., Strength to grab, Agility to trip).
3. **The Contest Roll:** Roll d10s equal to the chosen Attribute.
4. **Eliminating Dice:** Each success (8+) eliminates one highest die from the movement roll. If no dice 8+ remain, the moving creature is stopped in the contester's space.

TACTICAL EXAMPLE: CONTESTING JAX'S MOVEMENT

The Scenario: Jax is attempting to run past a burly corporate enforcer to reach a control panel. Jax spends 1 Action Point for a move action and makes an **Agility** Success Test to determine the total distance. Jax has Agility 4 and rolls `[9, 7, 5, 2]`. The highest die is a 9, so he can move his base 1 space (4m) plus 2 extra spaces (from the 9, which is 8m, rounded up to 2 spaces), for a total of 3 spaces.

The enforcer stands along Jax's path. As Jax enters the enforcer's space, the GM declares the enforcer will contest the movement using **Strength 5** to grab him.

1. The Contest Roll: The enforcer rolls 5d10: `[10, 8, 6, 4, 1]`—generating two successes (10 and 8).

2. Eliminating Dice: The two successes eliminate the two highest dice from Jax's movement roll (`[9, 7, 5, 2]`). The 9 and 7 are eliminated.

3. Final Outcome: Jax's remaining pool is `[5, 2]`. Since there are no dice showing 8 or higher, the contest succeeds. Jax's movement ends immediately in the enforcer's space, stopped dead in his tracks.

SPACE AND OCCUPANCY

In Corsair, combat is dynamic and often close-quartered. A single space on the battle map is not limited to one character. Understanding how multiple characters occupy and interact within a single space is key to tactical success. A single 4x4 meter space can comfortably house up to **4 standard-sized creatures**. Many actions, especially melee attacks and certain Teamwork maneuvers, require you to be in the same space as your target or ally.

OUTNUMBERING

Ganging up on a foe is a valid and effective tactic. When you and your allies outnumber your opponents within a single space, you gain a significant advantage in melee combat. You receive a number of **Upgrades** on your melee attack tests equal to the difference between the number of allied creatures and hostile creatures in that space. For example, if 3 allies are in a space with 1 enemy, all allies receive **2 Upgrades** (3 – 1 = 2) on their melee attacks against that enemy.

MELEE POSITIONING

You can attack a creature in the same space as you, or an adjacent space. Melee attacks must use any combination of two separate Physical Attributes. For example, Jax might combine **Strength + Agility** to drive a heavy blade through a pirate's defense, or pair **Agility + Finesse** when aiming a swift, precise knife strike at a weak point in armor.

When you attack a creature in an adjacent space, you move into it, provided it holds less than 4 creatures. If it already holds 4, you perform the attack from your current space, but count as if you and all allies in your space were in the target's space for outnumbering purposes.

CREATURE SIZE

The capacity of a space is affected by the size of creatures within it: **Large** creatures take up the space of **2** standard creatures; **Huge** creatures take up the space of **4** standard creatures. Truly massive creatures may occupy multiple spaces at once, counting as a Large or Huge entity in each space for capacity and targeting.

CLOSE QUARTERS COMBAT (CQC)

When you are in the same space as a hostile creature, you are in **Close Quarters Combat (CQC)**. This impacts ranged weaponry:

- **Firing in CQC:** Firing a ranged weapon while in CQC inflicts **2 Downgrades** to your attack test. Wielding long guns or aiming optics while dodging bayonets is intensely difficult.
- **Firing into CQC:** Firing from outside into a space where allies and enemies are engaged in CQC inflicts **1 Downgrade** to your attack test. The chaotic swirl of close-quarters combat makes it hazardous to get a clean shot without endangering friends.

COVER & DEFENSIVE POSITIONING

Taking cover is a fundamental tactic for surviving a firefight. When a character is in a space that contains a source of cover (like a large crate, a sturdy pillar, or a low wall), they gain a flat bonus to their Protection against attacks originating from *outside* of their space. This bonus stacks directly with Protection from armor and shields:

- **Light Cover:** (**+1 Protection**) A small object offering partial concealment, like a thin pipe, light furniture, or a small fuel drum.
- **Medium Cover:** (**+2 Protection**) A solid object hiding a significant portion of your body, like a large engine block or thick metal bulkhead.
- **Heavy Cover:** (**+3 Protection**) A large durable fortification, like a reinforced bunker wall, blast gantry, or armored vehicle chassis.

DESTROYING COVER & COVER FACING

Light, Medium, and Heavy Cover have **12, 24, and 36 health segments** and an innate Protection of **4, 8, and 12** respectively when directly targeted. Attacking cover is a **Success Test** instead of a Complex one. For every 12 damage the cover absorbs, its provided Protection benefit is reduced by 1. Specialized breaching charges, anti-materiel weapons, and demolition explosives specifically ignore cover's innate Protection.

The first time you take an attack benefiting from cover, draw a line from the attacker to your center: whichever side of your space the line crosses becomes your **covering side**. When the line crosses a corner, both adjacent sides become covering sides. On subsequent attacks: **Full Bonus** across the covering side; **Reduced Bonus** (–1 hex, –2 square) across adjacent sides; **No Bonus (Exposed)** across non-adjacent sides.

TACTICAL DOCTRINE: FLANKING SECTORS & COVER EXPOSURE

Positioning relative to cover is directional. When a combatant maneuvers around an enemy's covering side into an adjacent or rear flank sector, the target's cover bonus is reduced or stripped entirely (leaving them exposed). Coordinated fire teams use one operative to suppress a target from the front while a flanker advances to an open angle, bypassing bulkheads and eliminating Protection bonuses before delivering the lethal strike.

THE ARMORY & EQUIPMENT

Not every item a character carries has a significant mechanical impact on the game. Everyday objects like personal commlinks, apartment keys, or sentimental trinkets are assumed to be part of a character's belongings without needing specific rules. However, items that provide a distinct advantage in challenging situations—from weapons and armor to specialized tools—are classified as **Equipment**, governed by the **Load** system.

THE LOAD INVARIANT

Every piece of mechanically significant equipment has a **Load** value representing its weight, physical size, and cumbersomeness. A character's ability to carry equipment into combat is strictly governed by their physical strength:

> **Maximum Load Capacity = 12 + (Strength × 2)**
>
> An absolute physical limit: items exceeding capacity cannot be carried under any circumstances.

This limit is absolute; an operative cannot carry items with a total Load exceeding this capacity under any circumstances. It is often a wise tactical decision to leave some of your Load capacity unused. An open slot might be exactly what you need to carry a vital piece of salvage, emergency oxygen tanks, or a mission-critical objective you discover on the job.

EQUIPMENT CATEGORIES & DAMAGE BONUS

Equipment is divided into Weapons, Armor, Gear, and Exotic Hardware. All weapons share a common statistic: the **Damage Bonus**. The Damage Bonus is a flat integer value added directly to the success points you generate on a successful attack roll, strictly increasing damage dealt.

EQUIPMENT DAMAGE & FIELD REPAIRS

Deployable gear, fortifications, vehicles, and technological hardware possess structure ratings measured in **Health Points (HP)**. If an item is reduced to 0 HP, it is disabled and ceases to function until repaired. An operator carrying a toolkit with the **Tinkering** attribute can perform field maintenance to restore damaged hardware:

- **Repairing Equipment:** Restoring HP to damaged equipment costs **1 AP** (in structured combat) or standard narrative time (in downtime) and requires a **Success Test** using **Tinkering + Knowledge**.
- **HP Restored:** The item immediately recovers **1 HP per Success Point** generated on the test, up to its maximum HP rating.
- **Workshop Fabrication:** Rebuilding completely destroyed or vaporized hardware requires access to an engineering workshop or machine lathe, taking 1 Downtime Action and an Engineering test.

FIREARMS

In the cold vacuum of space, across contested orbital platforms, and inside pressurized ship corridors, firearms are the ultimate arbiters of ranged combat. Ranging from rugged chemical-propellant slugthrowers to electro-thermal chemical (ETC) rifles and high-velocity magnetic rail drivers, firearms give Corsairs the range, stopping power, and suppression capability necessary to overwhelm hostile forces before they close the distance.

WEAPON STATISTICS EXPLAINED

Every firearm is defined by mechanical attributes dictating tactical performance across engagement distances:

- **Accuracy (Short / Medium / Long / Extreme):** Ranged attacks always pair weapon Accuracy at the target's distance with **Finesse** (**Accuracy + Finesse**):
  - **Short Range (S):** 0–5 spaces (~0–20m). Corridors, breaches, point-blank skirmishes.
  - **Medium Range (M):** 6–12 spaces (~20–40m). Cargo bays, hangar decks, station concourses.
  - **Long Range (L):** 13–20 spaces (~40–80m). Maintenance tunnels, gantries, open terrain.
  - **Extreme Range (E):** 20+ spaces (~80m+). Standoff defense, sniper perches. Dash (–) = out of range.
- **Rate of Fire (RoF):** Strict upper limit on total **Crit Effects** and **Chain Effects** on an attack roll:
  - **Heavy-Hitters (RoF 0):** Single-shot rifles, heavy revolvers, slug guns. No burst Crits/Chain.
  - **Precision & Semi-Auto (RoF 1):** Duty pistols, marksman rifles (up to 1 Crit/Chain).
  - **Burst & Automatic (RoF 2):** Assault carbines, combat shotguns (up to 2 Crits/Chain).
  - **Rapid Suppression & Rotary (RoF 3–4):** Squad automatics, heavy machine guns, rotary cannons (up to 3–4 Crits/Chain).
- **Damage Bonus:** Flat integer added directly to total success points of a successful attack.
- **Hands:** 1H sidearm vs 2H shoulder-fired platform. · **Load & Cost:** Mass in Load system; Credits.

PROMINENT MANUFACTURERS

Panthera Arms: Sleek high-tolerance carbines and marksman rifles favored by corporate strike teams. · **Vandal's Workshop:** Stamped-sheet high-RoF submachine guns cycling reliably in dirt and vacuum. · **Caldera Foundry:** Heavy-bore rifles and trench shotguns for boarding defense. · **Ker'Satz Korp:** Precision magnetic rail drivers and magnum revolvers. · **Chidori-Qwei:** Lightweight polymer smart-linked sidearms.

> **TACTICAL DOCTRINE: STORING & SECURING LOAD**
>
> Unused Load capacity isn't wasted—it represents physical agility, breathing room, and readiness. Veterans rarely kit out to their absolute maximum limit, reserving 2 to 3 slots for heavy mission objectives, recovered flight recorders, or seized weapon prototypes before navigating pressurized airlocks back to their vessel.

HANDGUNS CATALOG

Compact sidearms designed for personal defense, emergency boarding backup, and rapid close-quarters deployment. Highly concealable and quick to draw when long guns are fouled in tight airlocks.

WEAPON NAME	ACC (S/M/L/E)	ROF	H	DMG	LOAD	COST	DESCRIPTION
Holdout Pistol	2 / 1 / – / –	1	1H	+0	1/2	300	Ultra-compact concealable polymer pistol designed for covert carry and last-ditch defense.
Service Pistol	3 / 2 / 1 / –	1	1H	+1	1	800	Standard-issue semi-automatic sidearm offering reliable cycling and balanced handling across pressurized environments.
Heavy Revolver	3 / 2 / 1 / –	0	1H	+2	1	1,200	Large-frame cylinder handgun firing high-grain magnum cartridges with punishing recoil and armor-cracking velocity.
Machine Pistol	3 / 2 / – / –	2	1H	+0	1	1,500	Compact automatic handgun capable of dumping high-volume bursts in point-blank skirmishes and corridor breaches.
Hand Cannon	2 / 3 / 2 / 0	0	1H	+2	1	2,200	Massive reinforced handgun chambered in anti-armor kinetic rounds for devastating single shots that shatter bulkheads.

SUBMACHINE GUNS & SHOTGUNS

Close-quarters primary weapons engineered for boarding operations, clearing tight ship bulkheads, and dominating short-range firefights across station corridors where pellet spread and cyclic saturation turn the tide.

WEAPON NAME	ACC (S/M/L/E)	ROF	H	DMG	LOAD	COST	DESCRIPTION
Compact SMG	4 / 3 / 1 / –	2	2H	+1	2	2,000	Lightweight collapsible submachine gun designed for vehicle crews, void-suit operations, and shipboard boarding teams.
Tactical SMG	3 / 4 / 2 / 0	3	2H	+1	2	2,800	Balanced automatic platform featuring integral recoil compensators and high cyclic fire rates for sustained close-quarters fire.
Trench Shotgun	5 / 2 / – / –	0	2H	+4	2	2,400	Heavy pump-action smoothbore scattergun delivering catastrophic kinetic spread at point-blank range, shredding unarmored targets.
Combat Shotgun	4 / 3 / 0 / –	1	2H	+3	3	3,500	Semi-automatic magazine-fed shotgun engineered for rapid room clearing, airlock breaches, and close-quarters suppression.
Riot Scattergun	4 / 2 / – / –	2	2H	+2	3	4,000	Fully automatic drum-fed scattergun delivering overwhelming short-range projectile swarms for area crowd control.

TACTICAL DOCTRINE: CORRIDOR BALLISTICS & POINT-BLANK BREACHES

Within pressurized ship corridors (0–5 spaces), Shotguns and SMGs possess overwhelming Accuracy (4 to 5). An operative wielding a Trench Shotgun at point-blank range combines Accuracy 5 with Finesse and adds a massive +4 flat Damage Bonus, making it capable of breaching reinforced security doors or dispatching unshielded combatants in a single deafening blast.

Furthermore, because submachine guns feature high cyclic rates (RoF 2–3), they excel at laying down suppression before breaching defensive bulkheads. Spending extra Hits on Chain Effects allows boarding operatives to sweep secondary hostiles pinned along the corridor walls without sacrificing primary target penetration.

COMBAT RIFLES CATALOG

Versatile long guns that balance effective range, stopping power, and tactical flexibility across ship corridors, open cargo bays, and planetary battlegrounds.

WEAPON NAME	ACC (S/M/L/E)	ROF	H	DMG	LOAD	COST	DESCRIPTION
Assault Carbine	3 / 3 / 2 / 1	2	2H	+2	3	3,800	Short-barreled rifle optimized for high mobility, fast target acquisition, and medium-range skirmishes.
Assault Rifle	2 / 4 / 3 / 1	2	2H	+2	3	4,800	Standard military battle rifle delivering disciplined burst fire and balanced accuracy across all combat zones.
Battle Rifle	2 / 3 / 4 / 2	0	2H	+4	3	5,500	Heavy-caliber semi-automatic rifle engineered for hard-hitting, armor-cracking kinetic penetration.
DMR	1 / 3 / 5 / 3	1	2H	+4	4	7,000	Precision-machined semi-automatic rifle equipped with high-magnification optics for mid-to-long range fire.
Sniper Rifle	0 / 2 / 5 / 4	0	2H	+5	4	9,500	Long-range bolt-action or precision-lock rifle delivering extreme terminal ballistics at standoff ranges.

HEAVY SUPPORT WEAPONS CATALOG

Crew-served and reinforced heavy platforms requiring substantial physical leverage to operate, delivering unmatched suppressive fire, corridor saturation, and anti-materiel kinetic energy against armored targets and light vehicles. Wielding these systems effectively demands setting up integral bipods or locking magnetic boot clamps to brace against massive cyclic recoil.

WEAPON NAME	ACC (S/M/L/E)	ROF	H	DMG	LOAD	COST	DESCRIPTION
SAW	3 / 4 / 3 / 1	3	2H	+3	4	8,500	Belt-fed light machine gun designed to pin down enemy squads with continuous, sustained automatic fire.
Heavy Machine Gun	3 / 5 / 4 / 2	4	2H	+4	5	12,000	Massive large-caliber machine gun capable of shredding light vehicle plating and reinforced barricades.
Rotary Autocannon	5 / 4 / 2 / 1	4	2H	+4	5	16,000	Multi-barrel motorized cannon delivering devastating saturation fire at extreme cyclic rates.
Anti-Materiel Rifle	0 / 2 / 5 / 5	0	2H	+7	5	15,000	High-caliber magnetic-assisted anti-tank rifle designed to disable light vehicles and penetrate heavy bulkheads.

TACTICAL DOCTRINE: HEAVY FIREPOWER & BIPOD BRACING

Heavy weapons with RoF 3–4 (such as the SAW, HMG, and Rotary Autocannon) excel at area control and perimeter suppression. When firing into spaces with clustered hostiles, their high RoF allows operatives to spend up to 4 Hits on Crit and Chain Effects simultaneously, splitting fire across multiple targets and shredding light barricades in a single sustained burst.

Operating these systems effectively demands physical stability. Bracing a heavy weapon on deployable fortifications or adopting a prone firing position negates recoil drift, allowing gunners to lay down relentless cyclic saturation across hangar decks and open landing pads without sacrificing shot placement.

DUAL WIELDING FIREARMS

A combatant can choose to wield a one-handed firearm in each hand, laying down intense suppressive fire or engaging multiple targets simultaneously:

- **One-Handed Only:** You can only dual wield firearms with the **1H** designation (holding one sidearm in each hand).
- **Combined Firepower (Damage & RoF):** When making a ranged attack while dual wielding two 1H firearms, you combine the offensive output of both weapons, adding together both the flat **Damage Bonus** and the **Rate of Fire (RoF)** of the two firearms.
- **Worse Accuracy:** Discharging two weapons simultaneously compromises sight alignment and muzzle stability. When resolving the attack test, you must use the **worse (lower) Accuracy rating** at the target's current range band between the two wielded firearms.

FIREARM UPGRADE KITS

Stock firearms can be customized into precision mastercrafted weapons through high-tolerance machining, carbon-fiber skeletal framing, match-grade barrels, tuned gas pistons, and custom optics. Because each subsequent modification requires increasingly complex gunsmithing, upgrade kits escalate in cost with every installation:

- **Upgrade Limit:** A single firearm can benefit from a maximum of **3 Upgrade Kits** in total, while one-handed (1H) sidearms are limited to a maximum of **2 Upgrade Kits**.
- **Tiered Cost Structure:**
  - **1st Upgrade: 10,000 Credits**
  - **2nd Upgrade: 25,000 Credits**
  - **3rd Upgrade: 50,000 Credits**
- **Upgrade Choices:** Each time an Upgrade Kit is applied, choose one permanent modification:
  - **Lightweight Chassis:** Precision skeletonization and composite furniture reduce the weapon's **Load by 1** (minimum 1/2 Load).
  - **Lethal Tuning:** Match-grade barrel rifling increases flat **Damage Bonus by +1**.
  - **Recoil Dampening:** Hydraulic buffer tubes increase **Rate of Fire (RoF) by 1**.
  - **Optic Calibration:** Advanced holographic sights increase **Accuracy by +1** at one designated range band (e.g., Medium Range Accuracy +1).

AMMUNITION & MAGAZINE EJECTION

In Corsair, ammunition tracking is streamlined: firearms operate with high-capacity magazines or power cells sufficient for an entire tactical firefight. However, reloading a fresh magazine, swapping a depleted battery pack, or clearing a fouled bolt in combat costs **1 Action Point (AP)**.

Discharging slugthrowers in microgravity introduces unique hazards: floating spent brass casings can be sucked into life-support air recyclers, cooling intake turbines, or radiator vanes. Mil-spec firearms incorporate magnetic brass-catchers or utilize caseless propellants to preserve shipboard atmospheric scrubbers during boarding actions.

OPTICS & SMART-LINK CALIBRATION

Target acquisition across varying engagement distances is heavily augmented by combat optics. Holographic sights, thermal focal arrays, and helmet smart-links allow operators to calculate projectile drop in microgravity and track thermal signatures through obscurants. Weapons upgraded with Optic Calibration provide vital precision bonuses (+1 Accuracy) at designated range bands.

VACUUM THERMAL DISSIPATION

Because a vacuum lacks ambient air to conduct convective heat away from the receiver, automatic fire causes rapid thermal buildup. Weapons fired in decompression rely entirely on radiative heat sinks. Laying down continuous cyclic saturation (RoF 3–4) without pause can cause barrel warping or cook-offs, demanding disciplined fire control during external hull skirmishes.

TACTICAL EXAMPLE: THE HANGAR DECK FIREFIGHT

Jax advances down an industrial catwalk overlooking a contested cargo hangar. Positioned **8 spaces (~26 meters)** away behind low freight containers, an armed syndicate mercenary returns fire. The distance places the mercenary squarely at **Medium Range**.

Jax is armed with an **Assault Rifle** (Accuracy `2 / 4 / 3 / 1`, RoF 2, 2H, Load 3, and a **+2 Damage Bonus**). Jax's character sheet shows **Finesse 5**, **Instinct 3**, and **Strength 4**.

1. Determining the Test Pool: Jax prepares a precision shot, declaring an **Accuracy + Finesse** Complex Test. At Medium Range, the Assault Rifle has an **Accuracy of 4**. Pairing Jax's **Finesse 5** with the rifle's **Accuracy 4**, the higher attribute is Finesse 5 and the lower attribute is Accuracy 4.

2. Action Roll (Higher Attribute = Finesse 5): Jax rolls 5d10 for the Action Roll: `[2, 5, 8, 8, 9]`. The roll yields three Hits (8, 8, 9). Because the Action Roll succeeded (at least one 8+), Jax spends one of his extra Hits (8) to activate an **Upgrade Effect**, stepping up one die in his upcoming Success Roll from a d10 to a **d12**. Jax retains the remaining Hits for resolution.

3. Success Roll (Lower Attribute = Accuracy 4): Jax now takes a pool equal to the weapon's Accuracy at this range (**4 dice**). With the Upgrade Effect applied, Jax rolls 3d10 and 1d12: rolling `[4, 7, 8]` on the d10s and a `10` on the upgraded d12.

4. Activating Effects & RoF Limits: The Success Roll produced two Hits (8 and 10). Jax spends both Hits on **Crit Effects** to maximize damage (+2 Success Points per Crit). Because the Assault Rifle has **RoF 2**, it perfectly accommodates spending 2 Hits on Crits (reaching the rifle's full burst capacity).

5. Calculating Total Damage: Highest remaining non-spent die: **7 Success Points** + Two Crit Effects (+2 each): **+4 Success Points** + Rifle Flat Damage Bonus: **+2** = **Total Damage Dealt: 13 points of damage**. The rifle burst punches through the container seam, striking the mercenary cleanly.

MELEE WEAPONS

In the tight corridors of starships, depressurized maintenance shafts, and claustrophobic orbital stations, discharging a firearm risks puncturing critical hull plating or ricocheting in zero-gravity. In these confined environments, a dependable melee weapon is an indispensable tool for survival. Whether utilizing precision combat knives, weighted riot clubs, or heavy two-handed mauls, close-quarters combat demands physical prowess, tactical positioning, and mastery over your weapon's mechanical profile.

WEAPON STATISTICS EXPLAINED

Every melee weapon is defined by mechanical attributes that dictate its lethal profile and interaction with physical attributes:

- **Damage Type & Favored Attribute Pair:** Melee weapons inflict damage through three distinct physical methods:
  - **Piercing (Agility + Finesse):** Swift, pinpoint thrusts directed at structural seams, visor slits, and armor joints.
  - **Slashing (Agility + Strength):** Wide, sweeping kinetic cuts combining dynamic movement with heavy cutting force.
  - **Striking (Strength + Finesse):** Controlled, bone-shattering impacts delivered with precise leverage and body mechanics.
- **Favored Pair Damage Bonus:** When you make an attack test using the weapon's favored Attribute Pair, you gain a damage bonus equal to the **lower attribute** in that pair. While a character is free to perform a melee attack using any combination of two physical attributes, choosing the weapon's favored pair unlocks this substantial boost.
- **Minimum Strength (Min STR):** Physical combat tools require sufficient muscular leverage to control effectively:
  - **One-Handed Weapons (1H):** If your Strength is lower than the weapon's Min STR, you must wield the weapon with **two hands (2H)** to attack with it.
  - **Two-Handed Weapons (2H):** If your Strength is lower than the weapon's Min STR, the weapon is too cumbersome or heavy to wield, and you **cannot attack** with it under any circumstances.
- **Damage Bonus:** Flat numerical value added directly to total success points on a successful attack roll.
- **Hands:** 1H sidearm weapon vs 2H heavy polearm. · **Load & Cost:** Mass in Load system; Credits.

DUAL WIELDING MELEE

A combatant can hold and fight with a weapon in each hand, creating an aggressive combat style that overwhelms opponents with combined offensive pressure:

- **One-Handed Only:** You can only dual wield weapons with the **1H** designation. You must meet the Minimum Strength requirement of each weapon individually.
- **Combined Damage Bonus:** Add together the flat **Damage Bonus of both weapons** to your total outcome.
- **Attack Resolution:** Designate which weapon leads the strike to determine **Damage Type** and its corresponding favored Attribute Pair. If the attack utilizes that favored pair, add the lower attribute of the test to the combined damage.

MELEE UPGRADE KITS

Mastercrafted through high-grade aerospace machining, monomolecular edge-honing, ergonomic carbon balancing, or vibration emitters. Maximum **3 Kits for 2H** weapons, **2 Kits for 1H** weapons. Tiered costs: **1st: 10,000 CR** · **2nd: 25,000 CR** · **3rd: 50,000 CR**. Choices: *Lightweight Tuning* (–1 Load, min 1/2) or *Lethal Edge / Weighted Core* (+1 Damage Bonus).

SHIELDS

Shields are rigid defensive barriers constructed from ballistic polymers, layered ceramics, or reinforced titanium alloys. Wielded in the off-hand (**1H**), they provide vital cover during tactical breaches and close-quarters engagements:

SHIELD NAME	PROTECTION	MIN STR	HANDS	LOAD	COST	DESCRIPTION
Buckler	+1 Protection	2	1H	1	800	Compact arm-mounted composite disc designed to parry blades and deflect shrapnel.
Riot Shield	+2 Protection	4	1H	2	2,500	Reinforced transparent polycarbonate barrier providing solid torso and limb coverage.
Ballistic Shield	+3 Protection	6	1H	4	6,500	Heavy ceramic-composite assault pavise built to withstand high-caliber kinetic fire.

TACTICAL DOCTRINE: THE DEFENSIVE PHALANX & BOARDING SHIELDS

A combatant wielding a Ballistic Shield (+3 Protection) becomes a moving bulwark in narrow corridors. While holding a shield prevents wielding two-handed weapons, the flat Protection bonus stacks directly with worn armor and environmental cover, enabling breachers to absorb concentrated kinetic point-defense while allies advance safely in their wake.

MELEE WEAPONS CATALOG

The table below outlines standard melee weapon archetypes across all weight classes and damage types. Attacking with the weapon's favored Attribute Pair unlocks its full lethal potential, adding the lower attribute directly to damage.

WEAPON NAME	DAMAGE TYPE	FAVORED PAIR	MIN STR	H	DMG	LOAD	COST	DESCRIPTION
Shiv / Stiletto	Piercing	Agility + Finesse	1	1H	+0	1/2	150	Compact, concealable thrusting blade designed for quick jabs into unarmored seams.
Combat Knife	Slashing	Agility + Strength	1	1H	+0	1/2	200	Standard utility and combat knife with a balanced single-edged blade.
Knuckleduster	Striking	Strength + Finesse	1	1H	+0	1/2	100	Fitted metal fist reinforcement that concentrates bare-knuckle punching force.
Dagger	Piercing	Agility + Finesse	2	1H	+1	1	400	Double-edged tactical dagger engineered for penetrating thrusts and close defense.
Hatchet / Machete	Slashing	Agility + Strength	2	1H	+1	1	500	Forward-weighted chopping blade effective for utility clearing and melee strikes.
Baton / Club	Striking	Strength + Finesse	2	1H	+1	1	300	Weighted polymer or steel rod designed to deliver blunt kinetic trauma.
Shortsword	Piercing	Agility + Finesse	3	1H	+2	2	1,200	Straight, rigid blade optimized for rapid lunges and high-mobility thrusts.
Boarding Axe	Slashing	Agility + Strength	3	1H	+2	2	1,500	Sturdy single-handed axe designed for breaching bulkheads and chopping through limbs.
Mace / Crowbar	Striking	Strength + Finesse	3	1H	+2	2	1,000	Flanged iron bludgeon or heavy steel prybar capable of cracking bone through plating.
Spear	Piercing	Agility + Finesse	4	2H	+3	3	2,200	Two-handed hafted spear delivering deep penetrating thrusts with significant leverage.
Longsword	Slashing	Agility + Strength	4	1H	+3	3	2,800	Versatile, well-tempered blade that generates powerful, fluid cutting arcs.
Warhammer	Striking	Strength + Finesse	4	1H	+3	3	2,400	Heavy, reinforced hammerhead built to crumple armor plating and crush internal frame.
Halberd / Poleaxe	Piercing	Agility + Finesse	5	2H	+4	4	4,500	Long two-handed polearm capped with a reinforced piercing spike and axe head.
Greatsword	Slashing	Agility + Strength	5	2H	+4	4	5,000	Massive two-handed blade that leverages full body rotation for devastating cleaves.
Heavy Maul	Striking	Strength + Finesse	5	2H	+4	4	4,800	Enormous two-handed sledgehammer delivering catastrophic, armor-pulverizing force.

TACTICAL EXAMPLE: THE BOARDING ACTION STRIKE

Jax breaches an airlock into the secondary generator deck, confronting a corporate security guard. Jax wields a **Boarding Axe** (Slashing, Favored Pair: **Agility + Strength**, Min STR 3, 1H, Load 2, +2 Damage Bonus). Jax's sheet shows **Strength 4**, **Agility 4**, and **Finesse 3**.

1. Action Roll (Strength 4): Jax declares a sweeping cleave using his axe's favored pair (Agility + Strength). Both attributes are 4, so Jax rolls 4d10 for the Action Roll: `[3, 6, 8, 9]`—generating two Hits (8 and 9). Jax spends one Hit on an **Upgrade Effect** to step up a die in his Success Roll from a d10 to a **d12**.

2. Success Roll (Agility 4): Jax rolls 3d10 and 1d12: `[5, 7, 8]` on the d10s and an `11` on the upgraded d12. Two Hits generated (8 and 11). Jax spends both Hits on **Crit Effects** (+2 damage each).

3. Damage Resolution: Highest non-spent die: 7 SPs + Two Crits (+4) + Favored Pair Bonus (lower of STR 4 / AGI 4 = +4) + Axe Damage Bonus (+2) = **17 points of damage**, cleaving clean through the guard's arm plate.

ARMOR

In the perilous expanses of the settled systems, a dependable suit of armor is often the only barrier between a Corsair and lethal trauma. Whether weathering rifle fire in a depressurized corridor, deflecting shrapnel from an explosive hull breach, or absorbing punishing melee impacts during a boarding skirmish, protective gear preserves a combatant's operational capability in the deadliest environments.

ARMOR STATISTICS EXPLAINED

Every suit of armor is defined by mechanical attributes that govern its defensive resilience, tactical properties, and logistical burden:

- **Protection:** The flat integer value of physical and kinetic damage reduced from each incoming attack before it affects your health. When you are struck by an attack, subtract your armor's Protection directly from the incoming damage.
  - **Stacking Rules:** Armor Protection stacks directly with defensive bonuses provided by **Shields** (e.g., a Riot Shield providing +2 Protection) and **Cover** (e.g., Medium Cover providing +2 Protection). However, a character can only wear **one suit of armor** at a time; separate armor Protection values do not stack.
- **Load:** The mass and physical bulk of the armor as governed by the inventory Load system. Armor counts against your character's maximum Load limit (`12 + (Strength × 2)`).
- **No Minimum Strength Requirement:** Unlike melee weapons and shields, armor does not enforce a binary Minimum Strength requirement to don or wear. Any operative can wear any suit of armor, provided they have sufficient Load capacity to carry its weight. However, heavier suits feature the **Cumbersome (X)** property, imposing significant physical penalties on characters who lack the conditioning or agility to handle dense ballistic plating.
- **Armor Properties:** Specialized engineering features and structural treatments that provide unique tactical benefits:
  - **Cumbersome (X):** Mass and rigid plates restrict articulation. Suffer **X Downgrades on all tests involving Agility** (including movement Success Tests, acrobatics, athletics, stealth, and agility-based attack rolls or contest rolls).
  - **Hardened:** Strike faces diffuse kinetic penetrators. Bonus Success Points gained per Hit spent on Crits is reduced by 1 (granting **+1 SP per Hit spent**, instead of +2).
  - **Blast-Dampened:** Concussive baffles dissipate shockwaves. Gain **+2 additional Protection against Area Attacks and Explosives**.
  - **Tactical Harness (X):** Reinforced load-bearing webbing provides **X dedicated Load slots for any equipment** (weapons, medkits, sensors) that do not count against standard Load.
  - **Muffled:** Friction-reducing joint gaskets suppress gear rattle. Gain **+1 Upgrade on Stealth tests**.

PROMINENT MANUFACTURERS

Chidori-Qwei Combatwear: Sleek flexible polymer garments and armored flightsuits. · **Panthera Arms:** Precision lightweight composite plate carriers. · **Vandal's Workshop:** Stamped alloy armor and industrial hazard suits. · **Caldera Foundry:** Heavy cast ceramic-titanium battleplate. · **Ker'Satz Korp:** Ballistic assault chassis and mechanized siege rigs.

ARMOR UPGRADE KITS

Standard suits can be customized into mastercrafted systems through armorer machining, gel trauma dampeners, or high-density ceramic strike faces. Max **3 Upgrade Kits** per suit. Tiered costs: **1st: 50,000 CR** · **2nd: 100,000 CR** · **3rd: 180,000 CR**. Choices:

- **Reinforced Plating:** Increase armor's **Protection by +1** (max +3 Protection total across all kits).
- **Lightweight Composites:** Reduce armor's **Load by 1** (to a minimum of 1 Load).
- **Specialized Modification:** Installs one specialized property: *Hardened*, *Blast-Dampened*, *Tactical Harness (1)*, or *Muffled*.

LIGHT ARMOR CATALOG (LOAD 1–3 · PROT 2–4)

Light armors provide essential protection without impeding speed, reflexes, or acrobatics. Favored by pilots, scouts, and agile skirmishers.

LIGHT ARMOR CATALOG

ARMOR NAME	PROT	LOAD	PROPERTIES	COST	DESCRIPTION
Padded Flightsuit	2	1	—	1,200	Pressurized spacer jumpsuit; unencumbering.
Infiltration Suit	2	1	Muffled	3,500	Acoustic-dampening bodysuit favored by scouts.
Armored Jacket	3	2	—	3,000	Rugged utility jacket with ballistic aramid inserts.
Hardened Vest	3	2	Hardened	5,500	Security vest fitted with ceramic strike faces.
Light Combat Armor	4	3	—	10,000	Mil-spec plate carrier balancing defense with mobility.
Spec-Ops Combat Armor	4	3	Hardened	18,000	Elite plate carrier featuring boron-carbide inserts.

MEDIUM ARMOR (LOAD 4–5 · PROT 5–6)

Medium armors deliver heavy kinetic mitigation for frontline combat. Tactical Battleplate represents the peak of unencumbered military protection before full-body carapace penalties apply.

MEDIUM ARMOR CATALOG

ARMOR NAME	PROT	LOAD	PROPERTIES	COST	DESCRIPTION
Tactical Battleplate	5	4	—	30,000	Full-torso plate carrier; max protection without Agility Downgrades.
Flak Combat Rig	5	4	Blast-Dampened	38,000	Shrapnel-lined assault vest designed for surviving grenade blasts.
Vanguard Battleplate	5	4	Hardened, Tac (1)	45,000	Squad-leader vest with reinforced trauma plates and utility webbing.
Heavy Carapace Armor	6	5	Cumbersome (1)	65,000	Full-body interlocking alloy carapace; exceptional stopping power.
Bastion Carapace	6	5	Cumbersome (1), Hard, Tac (1)	85,000	Fortified trench carapace engineered to weather sustained fire.

HEAVY ARMOR (LOAD 6–7 · PROT 7–8)

Heavy armors turn the wearer into an unyielding battlefield anchor. They require significant investment and impose movement penalties, but render the operative nearly impervious to standard small arms.

HEAVY ARMOR CATALOG

ARMOR NAME	PROT	LOAD	PROPERTIES	COST	DESCRIPTION
Breacher Carapace	7	6	Cumbersome (1), Blast, Tac (1)	140,000	Heavy blast apron and limb plating for airlock point-men.
Juggernaut Armor	7	6	Cumbersome (1), Hardened	160,000	Dense fortress armor shrugging off critical hits and heavy slugs.
Titan Rig	8	7	Cumbersome (2), Hard, Blast, Tac (2)	280,000	Massive mechanized siege carapace; pinnacle of personal protection.

Due to the sheer mass and joint resistance of heavy carapace, operators frequently utilize powered servo-joints, hydraulic stabilization braces, and load-distribution harnesses to maintain agility during violent close-quarters room breaches and airlock assaults.

TACTICAL DOCTRINE: STACKING DEFENSES & BREACHING OPERATIONS

Because Armor Protection stacks directly with defensive bonuses provided by **Shields** and **Cover**, a defensive operative can achieve formidable damage negation. An operative in Tactical Battleplate (5 Protection) bracing behind a Riot Shield (+2) in Medium Cover (+2) achieves **9 total Protection**, mitigating an entire volley of rifle fire before taking a single scratch.

During room breaches, combining heavy carapace with an Active Protection System (APS Beacon) creates an impenetrable foothold. The beacon detonates incoming fragmentation grenades mid-flight, while the breacher's heavy plating absorbs suppressive small arms fire without suffering armor breaches.

TACTICAL EXAMPLE: WEATHERING THE BOARDING BARRAGE

During a violent breach of a station cargo bay, Jax is caught in the open when a pirate gunner opens fire with a **Battle Rifle**.

Jax is equipped with **Tactical Battleplate** (Protection 5, Load 4) and carries a **Riot Shield** (+2 Protection, Min STR 4, 1H, Load 2). Because Tactical Battleplate carries no Cumbersome penalty, his Agility rolls remain unhindered.

1. Incoming Attack: The pirate scores a Hit, spending 1 Hit on a Crit Effect (+2 damage) alongside the Battle Rifle's flat +4 Damage Bonus, generating **14 points of physical damage**.

2. Total Protection: Tactical Battleplate Base (5) + Riot Shield (+2) = **7 Combined Protection**.

3. Damage Reduction: 14 Incoming Damage − 7 Protection = **7 net damage**, absorbed cleanly within Track I of Jax's Physical Condition.

GEAR

Gear encompasses the broad spectrum of mission-critical tactical equipment, specialized toolkits, refillable field rigs, and survival hardware utilized by operators in the Corsair universe. While weapons and armor govern basic combat survival, gear provides the technical leverage, mobility, intelligence, and utility needed to complete dangerous boarding operations and wilderness expeditions.

GEAR RULES & RESOLUTION

1. **Dedicated Attributes & Test Pairs:** Gear provides dedicated item attributes (such as *Mobility*, *Medicine*, *Sensors*, *Tinkering*, *Locksmith*, *Disguise*, *Forgery*, *Interfacing*, *Hacking*, *Ordnance*). The item's attribute pairs with a core attribute to form the dice pool.
2. **Action Point Costs:** Activating gear requires **1 Action Point (AP)**, unless explicitly noted otherwise. Passive items (deploying Cover) still cost 1 AP.
3. **Capacity & Automatic Refill:** Expendable gear has an innate **Capacity (Cap X)**. Charges **automatically refill to maximum** whenever visiting an eligible supply hub (starship, clinic, armory, depot) during place-to-place or day-to-day pacing, without spending Credits.
4. **Stand-Alone Explosive Rolls:** Explosives resolve as Area Attack Success Tests rolling pure **Ordnance** pools without pairing with an attribute.
5. **Upgrade Compatibility:** Gear can be enhanced with up to 3 standard Upgrade Kits to reduce Load by 1 or increase primary attribute by +1.

1. MOBILITY GEAR

MOBILITY GEAR CATALOG

ITEM	PROPERTIES	LOAD	COST (CR)	DESCRIPTION
Light Jump-Pack	Jetpack (8m), Mobility 3	3	35,000	Compact personal thruster pack for short tactical bounds.
Tactical Jetpack	Jetpack (12m), Mobility 4	4	72,000	Standard mil-spec jump rig with balanced fuel capacity.
Heavy Jump-Rig	Jetpack (16m), Mobility 5	5	120,000	High-output vector thruster chassis for high-altitude assaults.
Gecko Climbing Kit	Mobility 3, Surface Adhesion	1	15,000	Micro-fiber magnetic gloves and boots for scaling metallic hulls.
Assault Zipline (40m)	Zipline (40m), 24 HP	3	15,000	Pneumatic line launcher deploying high-tensile motorized cables.
Standard Grapple	Grapple (8m), Mob 3, Cap 3	2	5,000	Compact gas-tether launcher for rapid ascent and pull.
Tactical Grapple	Grapple (16m), Mob 4, Cap 4	2	12,000	Reinforced magnetic winch rig with extended pull and winch.
High-Tensile Rope	Utility Cordage (40m)	1	100	Braided synthetic rope rated for extreme loads and rappelling.

MOBILITY SPECIAL PROPERTIES

- **Jetpack (Xm):** Activating costs **1 AP**; Success Test using **Mobility + Agility**. Flight movement = base speed (Xm) plus 1m per SP. Move 3D, hover, ignore difficult terrain. Vector Boost: spend Hit on Crit to gain **+4m movement**. Charging: Spend 1 AP to fly base speed in a straight line and immediately execute a Melee Attack. Ignore falling damage.
- **Surface Adhesion:** 1 AP; Success Test using **Mobility + Strength**. Base climb speed 8m plus 1m per SP.
- **Zipline (40m):** Launching cable costs 1 AP. Any creature traverses cable as part of standard move. Reeling in costs 1 AP.
- **Grapple (Xm) & Target Displacement:** 1 AP, expends 1 Charge. Inanimate targets: automatic success; winch pulls user to anchor. Hostile creatures: Complex Test using **Mobility + Strength**. Hits spent trigger **Push Effect** pulling target 1 space (2m) toward user; user may advance along line; deals damage equal to SPs.

2. FORTIFICATION GEAR

Deployable fortifications provide instant cover, automated defense, and remote weapon platforms across contested ship corridors and perimeter defense zones.

FORTIFICATION GEAR CATALOG

ITEM	PROPERTIES	LOAD	COST (CR)	DESCRIPTION
Deployable Cover (Light)	Light Cover (+1), 12 HP, Prot 4	2	5,000	Rapid-deployment ballistic fabric barrier for quick ambushes.
Deployable Cover (Med)	Med Cover (+2), 24 HP, Prot 8	3	8,000	Telescoping ceramic-composite barricade with ground spikes.
Deployable Cover (Heavy)	Heavy Cover (+3), 36 HP, Prot 12	4	12,000	Heavy alloy blast shield designed to withstand sustained assault.
APS Beacon	Intercept 5, Reaction, 24 HP	3	25,000	Automated Active Protection System firing counter-munitions.
Smartpod Mount	Automount 3, 12 HP	3	36,000	Motorized gyro-stabilized turret chassis for mounted weapons.

FORTIFICATION SPECIAL PROPERTIES

- **Deployable Cover:** 1 AP to deploy or pack up. Grants listed Protection bonus (+1 to +3) to shelterers. Possesses own Cover HP and Innate Protection. Recover for 1 AP.
- **Intercept (X) & Area Defense:** Gains **1 Free Reaction AP per round** to contest incoming Area Attacks and Ordnance explosions, rolling pure Intercept (X). If no dice 8+ remain, munition is destroyed.
- **Automount (X):** 1 AP to deploy and mount weapon. Spend 1 AP to fire remotely: rolls Automount (X) + Finesse (or pure Automount if autonomous). Recover for 1 AP.

3. EXPLOSIVES & LAUNCHERS

Explosives deliver high-yield area destruction, obscuration, and tactical disruption. Rather than tracking individual loose throwables, combatants carry refillable **Grenade Rigs** that allow on-the-fly munition selection at the point of use.

EXPLOSIVES & LAUNCHERS CATALOG

ITEM	PROPERTIES	LOAD	COST (CR)	DESCRIPTION
Tactical Grenade Rig	Cap 3, Refillable, Choice	2	4,000	Armored chest bandolier holding 3 refillable charges.
Assault Grenade Rig	Cap 5, Refillable, Choice	3	10,000	Heavy combat rig holding 5 refillable charges with instant choice.
Heavy Demolitions Rig	Cap 2, Refillable, Choice	3	8,000	Reinforced breaching rig holding 2 heavy demolition charges.
Siege Demolitions Rig	Cap 4, Refillable, Choice	4	16,000	Military demolition harness carrying 4 heavy breaching charges.
Grenade Launcher Rig	Delivery (Medium Range)	2	6,000	Shoulder-fired tubular launcher firing Ordnance to Med Range.
Rocket Launcher Rig	Delivery (Long Range)	4	22,000	Tube-launched unguided rocket system firing to Long Range.
Missile Guidance System	Delivery (Extreme Range)	6	60,000	Heavy laser-guided missile tube firing to Extreme Range.

MUNITION PROFILES & EXPLOSIVES PROPERTIES

- **Frag Munition:** Ordnance 4, Blast 3, 8m Radius. Shrapnel anti-personnel bomb.
- **Flashbang Munition:** Ordnance 5, Area Stun, 4m Radius. Blinds targets (discards highest die on next roll).
- **Smoke Canister:** Area Obscurance, 8m Radius. Fills area with thermal smoke blocking sight without rolling.
- **HE Munition:** Ordnance 5, Blast 5, 4m Radius. High-explosive concussion charge for bulkheads.
- **Remote Demolition:** Ordnance 7, Blast 5, 12m Radius, Remote detonator (Heavy Rig only).
- **Ordnance (X) Area Attack:** Thrown to Short Range (or launcher range). Pure Ordnance Success Test. **Blast (X)** adds +X damage per Hit spent on Crits.

4. MEDICAL & CONSUMABLES

Medical kits and performance stimulant injectors provide emergency field triage, physical recovery, and temporary biochemical boosts. All medical equipment operates on durable, refillable casings.

MEDICAL & CONSUMABLES CATALOG

ITEM	PROPERTIES	LD	COST	DESCRIPTION
Field Medi-Kit	Medicine 3, Cap 3, Lesser (1/2)	1	2,500	Auto-sutures, dermal staplers, and coagulant spray.
Trauma Rig	Medicine 4, Cap 4, Lesser (1/1)	2	7,500	Mil-spec suite with rapid tissue welders and synthetic blood.
Phoenix Reconstruct	Medicine 4, Cap 2, Greater (1/1)	2	15,000	Stabilizes trauma and clears Aggravated damage.
Neuro-Inhaler	Medicine 3, Cap 3, Mental (1/2)	1	2,000	Pressurized mist dispenser countering panic and shock.
Neuro-Rig	Medicine 4, Cap 4, Mental (1/1)	2	6,000	Cranial auto-injector delivering potent cognitive restoratives.
Stim Injector	Capacity 3, Refillable, Choice	1	5,000	Transdermal auto-injector delivering 3 stim doses.
Chem-Rig	Capacity 5, Refillable, Choice	2	12,000	High-capacity harness carrying 5 performance stim doses.

MEDICAL RULES & STIMULANTS

Medicine (X) Triage: 1 AP, 1 Charge; test using **Medicine + Knowledge**. **Lesser:** Restores 1 segment / X SPs. **Greater:** Clears Aggravated damage at 2X SPs.

Combat Stimulants (Volatile 2, Fleeting): 1 AP to inject. Grants +1 to one Core Attribute: *Roid:* +1 STR · *Nitro:* +1 AGI · *Edgedance:* +1 FIN · *SharpX:* +1 INS · *Cognita:* +1 KNO · *Rizz:* +1 PRE. **Volatile 2:** User takes 2 unmitigated damage upon injection, plus additional damage per active stim in system.

5. INFILTRATION & TECH KITS

Specialized toolkits and electronic rigs used to bypass physical security, falsify credentials, and penetrate secure data networks across the Sphere.

INFILTRATION & TECH KITS CATALOG

ITEM	PROPERTIES	LD	COST	DESCRIPTION
Mechanic's Kit	Tinkering 2, Locksmith 2	2	1,000	Standard bypass picks, tension wrenches, diagnostic drivers.
Engineer's Kit	Tinkering 4, Locksmith 4	2	12,000	Precision ultrasonic picks and electronic bypass shunts.
Maker's Kit	Tinkering 6, Locksmith 6	2	25,000	Mil-spec quantum lock decoders and micro-plasma cutters.
Infiltrator Kit	Disguise 2, Forgery 2	2	1,000	Cosmetic prosthetics, seal replicators, pass laminators.
Spy Kit	Disguise 4, Forgery 4	3	12,000	Holographic identity cloners and biometric stamp mimics.
Chameleon Kit	Disguise 6, Forgery 6	3	25,000	Neural-adaptive latex mesh and encrypted identity fakers.
"Spider" Cyberdeck	Interfacing 3, Hacking 2	2	1,000	Baseline portable cyberdeck with standard optical transceiver.
"Mantis" Cyberdeck	Interfacing 5, Hacking 4	3	12,000	Tactical deck with dedicated intrusion coprocessors.
"Scorpion" Cyberdeck	Interfacing 7, Hacking 6	3	25,000	Black-market military cyberdeck built to shred mainframe ICE.

TECHNICAL ACTIONS (1 AP)

- **Tinkering:** Repairs, field modifications, and hardware sabotage (*Tinkering + Knowledge*).
- **Locksmith:** Bypassing electronic locks, mechanical tumblers, and airlock seals (*Locksmith + Finesse*).
- **Disguise:** Crafting physical disguises, facial prosthetics, and behavioral mimicry (*Disguise + Knowledge*).
- **Forgery:** Replicating cargo manifests, fabricating security seals, and counterfeiting identity chits (*Forgery + Finesse*).
- **Interfacing:** Operating standard computer terminals, extracting flight telemetry, and station commands (*Interfacing + Knowledge*).
- **Hacking:** Breaching corporate mainframe ICE, subverting automated defenses, and seizing data nodes (*Hacking + Knowledge*).

6. DETECTION, SURVEILLANCE & SURVIVAL

Sensors, autonomous drones, and environmental gear essential for deep-space excursions and recon operations.

SURVEILLANCE & SURVIVAL CATALOG

ITEM	PROPERTIES	LD	COST	DESCRIPTION
Proximity Sensor	Scouting 4m, Alert	1/2	1,000	Magnetic trip-sensor broadcasting alert.
Proximity Radar	Scouting 20m, 360-Sweep	2	25,000	Radar mapping motion and voids.
Recon Drone	Fly 20m, Sensors 2	2	35,000	Micro-quadcopter with night optics.
Forensic Sensor	Sensors 4, Chemical Scan	3	20,000	Handheld spectrometer for field scans.
Vacuum Suit	Environmental Immunity	1	5,000	Pressurized suit for vacuum and heat.
Field Rations	Sustenance (1 Week)	1	50	Nutrient-dense meal packs for ops.
Wilderness Camp	Squad Shelter (4 Ops)	4	500	Pressurized tent, cycler, blankets.
Tactical Commlink	Interfacing 2, Long-Range	0	1,000	Frequency-hopping comm transceiver.

Sensor & Survival: *Sensors:* Active sweep (Sensors + Knowledge, 1 AP) · *Scouting:* Passive alert · *Drone:* Fly 20m/round (1 AP) · *Environmental:* Immunity to –150°C to +200°C and vacuum (12 hrs).

EXOTIC HARDWARE

Exotic Hardware refers to the narrow, lethal category of equipment far beyond standard procurement: black-budget prototypes, hybrid alien alloys, and Precursor dark-matter transducing relics. They are rare, exorbitantly expensive, and carried only by veterans who have both the coin to afford them and the physical constitution to carry their crushing weight.

THE RULES OF EXOTIC HARDWARE

1. **Load Taxation Over Limits:** Operatives carry what their spine endures against the absolute limit of **12 + (Strength × 2)**.
2. **Action Point Economy:** Activating functions costs **1 AP**. Passive defenses apply continuously.
3. **Pacing Cooldowns:** Moment-to-Moment (~5–10s), Place-to-Place (~1 hr), Day-to-Day (24-hr cycle).
4. **Irreplaceable Maintenance:** 0 HP requires a workshop and **Tinkering + Knowledge** test against Tier DC. Precursor relics cannot be repaired by mortals without rare molecular salvage.
5. **Non-Customizable Architecture:** Precision prototypes operating at atomic tolerances **cannot accept Upgrade Kits**. Statistics and Load values are permanently fixed as written.

THE 4-TIER RARITY & ECONOMIC LADDER

EXOTIC HARDWARE RARITY & ACQUISITION LADDER

TIER	CLASSIFICATION	TYPICAL COST (CREDITS)	MARKET REALITY & ACQUISITION
Tier 1	Mil-Spec Skunkworks	15,000 – 30,000 CR	Limited-run military trials and aerospace machining (Caldera, Port Zenith, Panthera). Corporate fixers or colonial sponsors.
Tier 2	Classified Prototypes	40,000 – 80,000 CR	Bleeding-edge espionage targets, hybrid alien polymers, and cybernetic field rigs. Corporate black-site heists or black markets.
Tier 3	Precursor Relics	100,000 – 250,000 CR	Intact alien artifacts and self-repairing lattices from Vault excavations. Strictly illegal contraband under Covenant Accords.
Tier 4	Singularities & Wonders	**Priceless** (Not for Sale)	Mythic artifacts of campaign-defining significance (dreadnought core, Shard lattice, null-beam projector). Major campaign milestones.

Campaign Integration: Game Masters are encouraged to introduce Exotic Hardware as tangible milestones rather than routine loot drops. A Tier 1 prototype in the hands of an elite rival gives players an immediate preview of high-tier capabilities, while recovering a Tier 3 Precursor relic triggers attention from corporate retrieval squads, Covenant inquisitors, and pirate cartels alike.

STARSHIPS & SPACE COMBAT

In the airless void of the Sphere, your ship is more than transportation—it is your life support, your operational sanctuary, and your most lethal instrument of survival. Space combat in *Corsair* is an unforgiving dance of orbital mechanics, Newtonian momentum, heat rejection, and physiological endurance. The setting obeys strict hard science fiction constraints: there is no artificial gravity, no faster-than-light transit, and no deflector shielding. Every maneuver burns precious reaction mass, every high-G vector turn crushes human ribs against acceleration couches, and every penetrating round strikes pressurized titanium-composite bulkheads directly.

DUAL-SCALE ENGAGEMENT

Naval engagements unfold across two synchronized modes of tactical resolution. When closing distance across interplanetary trajectories or planetary orbits, combat is tracked on the **Macro-Grid**, where commanders manage vector commitments, long-range sensor locks, and relativistic railgun strikes across vast orbital distances. When hostile vessels close within knife-fighting range, the engagement shifts into **Dogfight Mode**, resolving micro-positioning on an abstract tactical scale from 1 to 10 as pilots fight tooth and nail for the optimal firing cone.

THE MACRO-GRID

On the Macro-Grid, tactical space is mapped using a hexagonal grid where each hex represents a **1-kilometer diameter spherical volume** of open void. Ships maneuver across this grid utilizing their Engine's **Acceleration** rating.

To move on the Macro-Grid, the ship's Pilot performs a **Success Test** using the vessel's **Acceleration**. The craft traverses **500 meters for every Success Point** scored, translating to exactly **one hex space for every 2 Success Points**, rounded down. An Acceleration roll yielding 5 Success Points allows a vessel to traverse 2 hex spaces (2,500 meters), while a roll of 8 Success Points propels the craft 4 hex spaces (4,000 meters) along its flight path.

NEWTONIAN MOMENTUM & VECTOR INERTIA

Because vacuum transit is governed by pure inertia, starships cannot halt on a dime or reverse course without expending massive counter-thrust. A ship is **strictly prohibited from moving back into a space it just vacated** during its current movement action.

To reverse vector or re-enter a hex it has recently departed, the vessel must first traverse through at least **two adjacent intervening spaces** on the grid, burning thrusters to bleed lateral momentum and swing its nose around. This requirement models realistic orbital mechanics and ensures that positioning, approach angles, and intercept corridors require deliberate tactical planning.

G-STRAIN & CREW PHYSIOLOGY

While a ship's reinforced titanium keel can survive immense structural strain, the fragile organic crew strapped inside its bridge cannot. Sustained burns and violent evasive maneuvers exert crushing gravitational forces (G-forces) that pull blood away from cerebral tissues and crack ribs against flight harness mounts.

If a pilot spends **more than 6 Success Points** on movement in a single turn, the crew suffers **G-Strain**. For every additional Success Point spent beyond 6, every crew member on board immediately suffers:

- **1 Light Wound** from internal capillary tearing, blunt harness impact, and extreme hydrostatic blood pressure.
- **1 Light Stress** from tunnel vision, sensory deprivation, and physiological shock under sustained G-forces.

Damage sustained from G-Strain represents direct physiological trauma and is **completely unmitigated by personal Armor or ship Protection**. Spacers who push their engines beyond safe operating parameters risk blacking out or rupturing internal organs before ever entering firing range.

INERTIAL TRAJECTORY & FLIP-AND-BURN DECELERATION

Because vacuum offers zero atmospheric drag, shutting down a vessel's main drive does not bring the ship to a halt; it merely causes the craft to drift along its established vector indefinitely. Changing heading requires firing cold-gas Reaction Control System (RCS) thrusters to pivot the vessel's nose, followed by burning the main fusion drive directly against the vector of travel —a grueling maneuver known among spacers as a flip-and-burn.

DOCTRINE // HARD SCI-FI INERTIAL FLIGHT

Starships in the Sphere do not bank or glide like aircraft. Velocity commitments are absolute: every kilonewton of forward momentum imparted by a burn must eventually be counteracted by an equal expenditure of reaction mass and engine thrust to alter vector or achieve orbital capture.

ENTERING THE DOGFIGHT

When two or more hostile vessels enter the **same 1 km hex space** on the Macro-Grid, macro-movement immediately suspends. The encounter transitions into **Dogfight Mode**, tracking close-range spatial orientation, relative closing angles, and weapon engagement cones on the micro-level **Dogfight Scale from 1 to 10**.

The Dogfight Scale is tracked independently for every pair of opposing vessels sharing the hex, always measured from the **players' perspective**:

```
[ 1 – 2 – 3 ] ---> [ 4 – 5 – 6 – 7 ] ---> [ 8 – 9 – 10 ]
```

DISADVANTAGE	NEUTRAL	ADVANTAGE
Enemy on your Tail / Defensive Vector	Passing Vectors / Broadside Slashing	You are on their Tail / Optimal Firing Arc

RELATIVE VECTOR GEOMETRY

Each zone of the Dogfight Scale models specific relative spatial orientations in three-dimensional vacuum:

- **Disadvantage (Positions 1–3):** The hostile ship has matched your vector and sits in your rear baffle. Forward spinal mounts cannot bear, and your main thrusters are vulnerable to raking fire.
- **Neutral (Positions 4–7):** The vessels cross on perpendicular or slashing vectors. Turreted weapons bear easily, but high closing speeds make sustained spinal locks difficult.
- **Advantage (Positions 8–10):** You have out-turned your adversary, tucking into their blind quarter. Your forward weapons point directly at their vulnerable engineering spaces.

CLIMBING THE DOGFIGHT SCALE

On their turn, a character seated in the Pilot Seat can execute a **Combat Maneuver** to alter relative positioning. The pilot performs a **Complex Test** combining the ship's **Maneuverability + Instinct**. For every Success Point scored on this test, the pilot can climb (or drop) **one position on the Dogfight Scale**.

Shifting relative orientation in a dogfight demands savage lateral thruster burns. Just like macro-grid movement, **G-Strain** applies if a pilot uses **more than 6 Success Points** to move on the scale during a single action, inflicting 1 Light Wound and 1 Light Stress per excess point.

THE INTERCEPTION ADVANTAGE

In void combat, predatory momentum grants an immediate operational edge. The craft that initiates the intercept by flying into an occupied macro-grid hex enters the Dogfight Scale at **Position 6** (Attacker Advantage). The defending ship already occupying the hex begins at **Position 5** (Neutral Defense). This slight offset reflects the attacker's prepared firing solutions and closing vector.

BREAKAWAY MANEUVERS

A vessel trapped in a disadvantageous dogfight position cannot simply disengage and burn away into the void; doing so presents its unprotected engine bells to hostile fire. To break away, the pilot must first maneuver the ship back into the neutral envelope:

- **Return to Neutral:** The pilot must successfully climb the Dogfight Scale to **Position 4 or higher** before the ship is permitted to leave the dogfight hex.
- **Acceleration Burn:** The pilot can spend an action to roll a Success Test using **Acceleration**. The resulting Success Points are first spent climbing the Dogfight Scale to Position 4; any **remaining Success Points** are then immediately used to traverse outward onto the Macro-Grid (1 hex per 2 SPs).

CONTESTING TACTICAL MANEUVERS

Void combat is actively contested. Opposing pilots can burn reaction time and thrusters to deny positional advantage using standard contest rules:

- **Contesting Breakaways (1 AP):** When an opposing ship attempts to break away from your dogfight space, a Pilot in the same hex can spend 1 AP to contest the action by rolling a Simple Test with the ship's **Acceleration**. Each Hit (8+) rolled on the contest eliminates one of the highest dice from the fleeing pilot's Acceleration roll. If all 8+ dice are eliminated, the contest succeeds: the fleeing ship scores 0 Success Points and is stopped in its tracks, unable to shift position or leave the hex.
- **Contesting Maneuvers (1 AP):** When an opponent attempts a Combat Maneuver to shift the Dogfight Scale, an opposing Pilot can spend 1 AP to contest by rolling a Simple Test with **Maneuverability**. Each Hit (8+) rolled eliminates one of the highest dice from the active pilot's Action Roll. If all 8+ dice are eliminated, the Action Roll fails and the scale does not shift.

TACTICAL PLAY // ESCAPING THE KILL ZONE

The crew of the *Kestrel* is pinned at **Position 2 (Disadvantage)** with a gunboat on their tail. Pilot Jax declares a Full Throttle breakaway burn, making a Success Test with Acceleration (3 dice) and rolling `[9, 8, 4]`—yielding 9 Success Points (from the 9).

The gunboat pilot spends 1 AP to contest using Acceleration (3 dice), rolling `[8, 5, 2]`—scoring 1 Hit (the 8). The gunboat's Hit eliminates Jax's highest die (`9`), leaving `[8, 4]`. The highest remaining die is an 8, so Jax still secures 8 Success Points! Jax spends 2 SPs to climb from Position 2 to Position 4 (Neutral), and uses 4 of the remaining SPs to traverse 2 hexes onto the Macro-Grid, successfully evading the gunboat.

ANATOMY OF A STARSHIP

Every space vessel operating across the Sphere is built around five core mechanical systems: its structural **Hull**, defensive **Armor**, dual-purpose **Engines**, electronic **Systems**, and offensive **Hardpoints**. Understanding these interconnected systems is essential for tactical survival when hull integrity fails and decompression alarms sound.

1. HULL INTEGRITY & CONDITION TRACKS

A starship's **Hull Rating** represents its physical structural integrity, pressure containment, and bulkheads. Because hard sci-fi craft do not possess energy shields, any weapon projectile or thermal laser beam that penetrates point-defense grids strikes the hull directly.

A starship's Hull Condition Track is divided into smaller tracks, each having a length equal to the ship's **Hull Rating** (always an even number, such as 6, 8, 10, 12, 14, or 16). The total number of individual tracks is determined by the vessel's Size Class, typically ranging from **4 to 6 tracks**:

- **Track Damage Progression:** Hull tracks take damage exactly like a character's Health Track. Hits first mark off **Light Wounds**. When a single track fills completely with Light Wounds, damage does not spill over into the next track; instead, subsequent hits on that track convert Light Wounds into permanent **Aggravated Wounds**.
- **Compartment Buckling:** As individual tracks fill with wounds, the crew experiences secondary hazards: hydraulic lines sever, atmospheric bulkheads slam shut, and artificial environmental loops struggle to scrub carbon dioxide.
- **System Shutdown:** When all tracks on a ship are filled with Light Wounds, the vessel suffers cascading power failure. Engines go dark, sensor buses fail, and the ship **shuts down**, tumbling out of control in vacuum. The life-support reserve battery provides roughly 24 hours of oxygen before cold sets in.
- **Catastrophic Destruction:** When all tracks fill with Aggravated Wounds, the hull experiences explosive decompression, reactor containment breach, and complete structural annihilation.

2. ARMOR (PROTECTION)

A ship's **Armor** rating represents passive ablative ceramic plates, layered titanium-foam composite plating, and whipple shields. Each point of Armor functions as **Protection**, reducing all incoming weapon damage by a flat 1 point per hit before damage is marked onto the Hull Condition Track.

Against light rapid-fire weapons like Point-Defense Cannons (+1 Damage), an Armor rating of 3 renders the vessel almost entirely impervious to direct fire. However, against heavy spinal railguns (+10 to +15 Damage) or siege torpedoes (+20 Damage), armor belts can only blunt a fraction of the devastating kinetic or thermonuclear impact.

KEEL STRUCTURES & WHIPPLE SHIELDS

Modern starship hulls are engineered as layered composite sandwiches of titanium-aluminide framework, foamed metal arrestors, and spaced ceramic Whipple shields. When a hypervelocity kinetic slug impacts the outer Whipple foil, the projectile vaporizes into an expanding cone of plasma and micro-fragments, distributing its kinetic energy harmlessly across the wider secondary bulkhead rather than piercing the central habitat cylinder.

3. DUAL ENGINE ARCHITECTURE

Engines in *Corsair* are split into two distinct mechanical attributes, reflecting the radical engineering differences between straight-line fusion drives and lateral reaction thrusters:

- **Acceleration:** Governs main drive propulsion and forward delta-V. Used exclusively for **Macro-Grid movement** and executing long-range Breakaway burns.
- **Maneuverability:** Governs cold-gas and hypergolic reaction control thrusters (RCS). Used exclusively for **Dogfight movement** to roll, pitch, yaw, and climb the Dogfight Scale.

4. SHIP SYSTEMS & AVIONICS

The **Systems** attribute measures the sophistication of onboard optical sensors, ladar, cooling loops, fire-control computers, automated maintenance hives, and main reactor power grids:

- **Sensor Range:** Starships can establish electronic tracking and target locks out to a maximum distance equal to **twice their Systems attribute in kilometers** (e.g., Systems 4 yields an 8 km sensor envelope).
- **Power Grid Distribution:** Engineers can reroute reactor output to supercharge specific ship subsystems. By rolling a Simple Test with **Systems**, each hit scored grants an **Upgrade** (up to a maximum of 3) to all tests made with the designated subsystem until the end of the round:
  - *Weapons:* Grants Upgrades to **Accuracy** and **Tracking** tests.
  - *Engines:* Grants Upgrades to **Acceleration** and **Maneuverability** tests.
  - *Systems:* Grants Upgrades to internal **Systems** checks and EWAR.
- **Repair Drones:** Autonomous zero-g drone hives deployed by engineers to patch breached compartments and restore damaged hull tracks.

> **ENGINEERING NOTICE // REACTOR SHUNTING**
>
> Shunting reactor power is the key to surviving asymmetric combat. A light ship with Systems 4 can dump energy into thruster manifolds to outrun a heavier gunboat, or funnel every watt into fire-control matrices to land a decisive opening strike before hostile torpedoes cross the gap.

BRIDGE ROLES & COMMAND SEATS

Every starship bridge or flight deck is equipped with dedicated physical workstations. While any spacer can monitor auxiliary telemetry or trigger basic thruster bursts from an auxiliary terminal, sitting strapped into a **dedicated command seat** connects the operator directly into high-speed fire-control buses, pneumatic flight yokes, and reactor shunts.

If a crew member is incapacitated by G-Strain or tactical priorities shift mid-battle, a character may spend **1 Action Point (AP)** to unstrap, pull through zero-G handrails, and swap into an unmanned seat.

BASIC SHIP ACTIONS (ANY STATION)

Any crew member at an operational terminal can perform the following baseline maneuvers:

- **Full Throttle:** A Success Test using the ship's **Acceleration**. Used to maneuver on the Macro-Grid or initiate a dogfight Breakaway burn.
- **Combat Maneuver:** A Complex Test combining **Maneuverability + Instinct**. Used to climb or drop positions along the Dogfight Scale.
- **Weapons Hot:** Trigger and discharge an operational weapon mounted to any available hardpoint, provided its rate of fire has not been expended.

THE THREE CORE BRIDGE SEATS

To unleash a vessel's true combat potential, crew members take their places across three primary command stations:

THE PILOT SEAT

The pilot interfaces directly with primary propulsion and attitude thrusters, reading vector trajectories through the main canopy or synthetic wrap-around displays.

- **Enhanced Controls:** Sitting strapped in the Pilot seat grants **1 Upgrade** to all *Full Throttle* and *Combat Maneuver* tests.
- **Evasive Maneuvers:** When the ship is targeted by incoming weapon fire, the Pilot can spend 1 AP to **contest attacks using Instinct**.
- **Stay on Target:** When an enemy tries to disengage or alter vector, the Pilot can spend 1 AP to **contest Breakaways and Maneuvers** using the ship's Acceleration or Maneuverability.

THE GUNNER SEAT

The gunner commands weapons feeds, optical lead calculators, and point-defense interception grids to track and destroy incoming threats.

- **Enhanced Targeting:** Sitting in the Gunner seat grants **1 Upgrade** to all attack tests using weapon *Accuracy* and *Tracking*.
- **Target Lock:** The Gunner can roll a Simple Test with **Systems** to acquire a Target Lock on a vessel within Sensor Range for each hit sacrificed. Each level of Target Lock provides 1 Upgrade to guided weapons.
- **Point Defense:** The Gunner can spend 1 AP to **contest guided weapon attacks** using a Point-Defense Cannon's (PDC) Accuracy. Firing with multiple active PDCs grants **1 Upgrade per additional PDC**.

THE ENGINEER SEAT

The engineer manages the ship's reactor core, magnetic cooling loops, EWAR jammers, and automated maintenance drones.

- **Enhanced Interface:** Sitting in the Engineer seat grants **1 Upgrade** to all tests made using *Systems*.
- **Repair Drones:** Perform a Complex Test using **Knowledge + Systems** to deploy automated repair drones and patch damaged hull segments or restore offline modules mid-battle.
- **Radar Jammer:** Perform a Complex Test using **Knowledge + Systems** to emit broad-spectrum electronic counter-measures, breaking enemy Target Locks held on your ship.
- **Power Distribution:** Roll a Simple Test with **Systems** to shunt surplus reactor output, granting up to 3 Upgrades to Weapons, Engines, or Systems until the end of the round.

TACTICAL COMMS & SENSOR WARFARE

Combat operations demand strict voice discipline under high acceleration ("Ladar hard on bearing two-seven, salvo away"). Concurrently, electronic warfare (EWAR) stations monitor passive radio frequencies and drive thermals, executing *Passive Surveillance* to track hostile signatures without radiating active ladar.

DAMAGE CONTROL & DEPRESSURIZATION

When penetrating hits buckle outer bulkheads, damage control teams don magnetic boots to seal compartments, dog down emergency hatches, and flood burning bays with halon gas (granting +1 Upgrade to Engineer repair tests). Prior to engagement, veteran crews execute combat depressurization, pumping cabin air back into reserve tanks to eliminate explosive decompression and flash fires when bulkheads are breached.

AUXILIARY STATIONS & SKELETON CREWS

Larger starships carry multiple Gunner and Engineer consoles for simultaneous PDC interception and damage control. Shorthanded vessels operating with a skeleton crew suffer severe limits: without a dedicated Gunner, PDCs cannot execute reaction intercepts; without an Engineer, power cannot be redistributed mid-flight.

SHIP WEAPONS & HARDPOINTS

Starship weapon systems consist of external structural mounting collars called **Hardpoints** and the specialized kinetic, thermal, or guided ordnance fitted into them. Unlike personal firearms, naval weapons operate under extreme environmental constraints: massive recoil forces that affect flight vectors, immense electrical capacitor drains, and the physics of firing unguided projectiles across thousands of kilometers of vacuum.

HARDPOINT CLASSIFICATIONS

Hardpoints are structural hull zones wired directly into power conduits and fire-control buses. They come in three standardized sizes:

- **Small Hardpoints:** Agile, high-traverse gimbals designed for rapid-tracking rotary PDCs, light seeker drones, pulse lasers, and proximity mine dispensers.
- **Medium Hardpoints:** Heavy turret wells and reinforced bays accommodating naval laser arrays, multi-missile pods, heavy PDCs, flak cannons, particle beams, and twin-barrel railgun batteries.
- **Large Hardpoints:** Massive structural keels and spinal mounting frames reserved for ship-length coilguns, heavy siege railguns, and thermonuclear fusion torpedo tubes. Large spinal weapons typically require aligning the ship's entire chassis to aim.

GUIDED VS. UNGUIDED ORDNANCE

Naval weaponry falls into two distinct operational paradigms:

- **Unguided Weapons:** Kinetic slugthrowers, PDCs, railguns, and laser arrays. Fired manually by calculating target lead vectors with a Complex Test using **Finesse + Accuracy**. Unguided weapons can be fired at any target within range without electronic acquisition.
- **Guided Weapons:** Missiles, torpedoes, and hunter drones equipped with onboard rocket thrusters and seeker packages. Guided ordnance **strictly requires an active Target Lock** before launch. Guided attacks are resolved with a Complex Test using **Tracking + Tracking**. Each level of Target Lock held on the target provides **1 Upgrade** to the roll.

ORBITAL BALLISTICS & LIGHT-SPEED LATENCY

Across thousands of kilometers, targeting a maneuvering ship is constrained by sensory delay. Because ladar echoes travel at the speed of light, sensor returns from a vessel 3,000 km away depict where the target was ten milliseconds ago. For unguided kinetic rounds traveling at twenty kilometers per second, projectile transit time spans several seconds, allowing a watchful pilot to bleed vector momentum and slip outside the incoming trajectory cone.

POINT-DEFENSE INTERCEPTION SCREENS

Defending against guided missile swarms requires establishing overlapping interception cones. A single rotary PDC creates a localized flak curtain; when two or more PDCs link their radar trackers through the ship's fire-control bus, they create an interlocking kill zone, granting +1 Upgrade per additional operational turret.

MISSILE GUIDANCE ARCHITECTURE & COUNTER-MEASURES

Guided ordnance in the Sphere relies on autonomous seeker brains combining infrared imaging, passive ladar receivers, and inertial guidance. When approaching an active point-defense grid, modern missiles execute pre-programmed erratic vector pulses, rolling and dodging along their flight path to spoil optical lead solutions calculated by hostile PDCs.

TARGET LOCK & EWAR ELECTRONIC BATTLES

Establishing a Target Lock represents flooding an enemy hull with ladar pulses, passive optical tracking, and thermal lock-on. Gunners acquire locks using a Systems Simple Test within Sensor Range. However, targets equipped with electronic counter-measure suites can deploy broad-spectrum noise and false radar echoes to shatter locks before ordnance can be launched.

RECOIL DYNAMICS & MUNITIONS SAFETY

Naval kinetic weapons produce violent Newton reaction forces upon discharge. Automated avionics fire synchronized cold-gas counter-bursts to maintain gunnery alignment and prevent recoil tumble. Furthermore, high-explosive torpedo magazines are encased in armored containment coffins with directional blowout hatches, venting secondary cook-offs into outer vacuum rather than collapsing interior decks.

SPECIAL WEAPON PROPERTIES

- **Long-Range Ballistics (Railguns & Coilguns):** Projectiles exit electromagnetic barrels at hypersonic velocities (tens of kilometers per second). Accuracy dropoff on the Macro-Grid is measured in **10 km (10 hex) increments** rather than standard 1 km increments!
- **Point-Defense (Rating):** Rapid-traverse rotary cannons equipped with autonomous radar tracking. When intercepting incoming missiles, the gunner contests the attack using **Accuracy + Point-Defense Rating**. Multiple PDCs grant 1 Upgrade per additional cannon.

AMMUNITION LOGISTICS & RESUPPLY

Refilling ordnance magazines requires authorized docking at any civilized port, orbital station, or naval tender. Standard resupply costs: **2,000 Credits** for Small weapons, **4,000 Credits** for Medium weapons, and **8,000 Credits** for Large weapons.

MASTER STARSHIP WEAPONS CATALOG

The table below provides operational specifications for all twenty-two standard naval weapon systems deployed across the Sphere. Unguided weapons reference their Accuracy array across Dogfight positions (Dis/Neu/Adv) and Macro-Grid distances (1/2/3/4/5+ km; railguns and coilguns use 10 km increments). Guided ordnance requires active Target Lock and references Tracking ratings.

WEAPON NAME	SIZE	TYPE	ACC (DOGFIGHT)	ACC (MACRO)*	TRK	DMG	ROF	AMMO	COST (CR)
GVI "Buzzer" Seeker Drone	Small	Guided	—	—	1	+2	1 / turn	6	200,000
PA "Sentinel" Rotary PDC	Small	Unguided	2 / 3 / 3	1 / 0 / — / — / —	—	+1	Unlimited	Unlim	250,000
GVI "Stinger" Light Missile	Small	Guided	—	—	2	+3	1 / turn	4	300,000
PA "Caltrop" Mine Dispenser	Small	Unguided	3 / — / —	— / — / — / — / —	—	+6	1 / turn	4	350,000
CQV "Wasp" Pulse Laser	Small	Unguided	— / 2 / 3	1 / — / — / — / —	—	+1	Unlimited	Unlim	450,000
PA "Guardian" Heavy PDC	Medium	Unguided	1 / 2 / 2	2 / 1 / — / — / —	—	+2	Unlimited	Unlim	600,000
KSK "Harpoon" Kinetic Missile	Small	Guided	—	—	4	+1	1 / turn	6	650,000
CF "Sledgehammer" Flak Cannon	Medium	Unguided	— / 1 / 2	1 / — / — / — / —	—	+3	2 / turn	12	750,000
CQV "Solarflare" Laser Array	Medium	Unguided	— / 1 / 2	2 / 1 / 0 / — / —	—	+2	Unlimited	Unlim	850,000
GVI "Javelin" Missile Pod	Medium	Guided	—	—	2	+4	1 / turn	4	950,000
KSK "Lance" Kinetic Torpedo	Medium	Guided	—	—	3	+3	1 / turn	8	1,100,000
CF "Anvil" Railgun Battery	Medium	Unguided	— / 1 / 2	2 / 1 / — / — / —	—	+5	2 / turn	20	1,200,000
GVI "Breacher" Thermal Lance	Medium	Unguided	— / 1 / 3	1 / — / — / — / —	—	+8	1 / turn	Unlim	1,350,000
GVI "Hydra" Multi-Missile Rack	Medium	Guided	—	—	1	+2	4 / turn	2 salvos	1,500,000
CF "Bulwark" PDC Battery	Large	Unguided	0 / 1 / 1	3 / 2 / 1 / — / —	—	+3	Unlimited	Unlim	1,800,000
CQV "Eclipse" Particle Beam	Medium	Unguided	— / 0 / 2	3 / 2 / 1 / 0 / —	—	+4	1 / turn	Unlim	2,200,000
KSK "Voidlance" Torpedo Tube	Large	Guided	—	—	1	+12	1 / round	2	3,200,000
GVI "Cataclysm" Siege Torpedo	Large	Guided	—	—	0	+20	1 / round	1	3,800,000
KSK "Specter" Stealth Missile	Medium	Guided	—	—	5	+4	1 / turn	2	4,200,000
CF "Mjolnir" Spinal Coilgun	Large	Unguided	— / — / 2	3 / 2 / 1 / 0 / —	—	+10	1 / turn	6	4,500,000
CQV "Prometheus" Heavy Laser	Large	Unguided	— / 0 / 1	3 / 2 / 1 / 0 / —	—	+6	Unlimited	Unlim	5,000,000
CF "Gigant" Heavy Railgun	Large	Unguided	— / — / 1	4 / 3 / 2 / 1 / 0	—	+15	1 / turn	4	6,500,000

* Railguns and Spinal Coilguns measure Macro-Grid accuracy in 10 km (10-hex) increments due to Long-Range Ballistics. Special Properties: Sentinel (PD 5), Guardian (PD 4), Sledgehammer (PD 3), Bulwark (PD 5), Anvil/Mjolnir/Gigant (Railgun).

NAVAL COMBAT DOCTRINES

The Kinetic Envelope: Rotary PDCs and flak batteries form a ship's primary defensive umbrella. While individual tungsten flechettes deal modest hull damage, their high rate of fire allows gunners to fill closing engagement cones with dense screens of metal, shredding incoming missiles before impact.

Spinal Keel Alignment: Large spinal railguns and coilguns represent terrifying kinetic force (+10 to +15 Damage Bonus). However, because they are mounted directly into the ship's longitudinal spine, the pilot must align the entire vessel's chassis along the target vector, restricting their fire to Advantage in dogfights.

NAVAL ORDNANCE PROFILES (1-11)

1. GVI "BUZZER" SEEKER DRONE

A low-cost, expendable seeker equipped with cold-gas attitude thrusters and a shaped high-explosive warhead. Slow and easily outmaneuvered by seasoned pilots, but cheap enough for persistent swarming harassment.

Mount: Cold-gas attitude thrusters with micro-rocket sustainer and contact piezo-electric trigger fuze.
Size: Small • **Type:** Guided • **Tracking:** 1 • **Damage:** +2 • **RoF:** 1/turn • **Ammo:** 6 • **Cost:** 200,000 CR.

Doctrine: Deployed in multi-drone flights to saturate hostile point-defense grids, forcing opposing gunners to exhaust reaction APs before heavier torpedoes arrive.

2. PA "SENTINEL" ROTARY PDC

The gold standard for close-in defense across the Sphere. Composed of a six-barreled rotary autocannon on a high-speed hydraulic gimbal, firing tungsten flechettes to paint an impenetrable wall of lead.

Mount: Six-barrel motorized Gatling gimbal with liquid-nitrogen jacket and high-rate linkless ammunition feed.
Size: Small • **Type:** Unguided • **Dogfight Acc:** 2/3/3 • **Macro Acc:** 1/0/—/—/— • **Special:** Point-Defense (5) • **Damage:** +1 • **RoF:** Unlimited • **Ammo:** Unlimited • **Cost:** 250,000 CR.

Doctrine: Essential survivability installation. Dedicated gunners hold reactions to shred inbound torpedoes within 500 meters of the hull.

3. GVI "STINGER" LIGHT MISSILE

A compact, high-velocity missile designed for light interceptors. It trades raw explosive mass for a sophisticated seeker matrix that makes it remarkably difficult to shake in close dogfights.

Mount: Solid-fuel booster core with gimbaled thrust-vector nozzle and dual optical/RF terminal sensor array.
Size: Small • **Type:** Guided • **Tracking:** 2 • **Damage:** +3 • **RoF:** 1/turn • **Ammo:** 4 • **Cost:** 300,000 CR.

Doctrine: Standard offensive strike armament for corsair corvettes; delivers dependable punch against unarmored utility craft.

4. PA "CALTROP" PROXIMITY MINE DISPENSER

A rear-mounted pneumatic dispenser releasing shaped-charge proximity mines. Useless in an offensive chase, but devastating when a pursuer sits on your tail at Disadvantage.

Mount: Rear-venting pneumatic rotary rack launching magnetized shaped-charge canisters with command-destruct codes.
Size: Small • **Type:** Unguided • **Dogfight Acc:** 3/—/— • **Macro Acc:** — • **Damage:** +6 • **RoF:** 1/turn • **Ammo:** 4 • **Cost:** 350,000 CR.

Doctrine: The ultimate defensive equalizer for slow freighters; turns an enemy's tail pursuit into catastrophic hull trauma.

5. CQV "WASP" PULSE LASER

A specialized dogfighting laser firing rapid ultraviolet pulses. Lacks cutting power against heavy armor, but high mirror slew speeds grant pinpoint accuracy against agile targets.

Mount: Rapid-pulsing diode-pumped solid-state laser cavity mounted on high-traverse piezoelectric mirror mounts.
Size: Small • **Type:** Unguided • **Dogfight Acc:** —/2/3 • **Macro Acc:** 1/—/—/—/— • **Damage:** +1 • **RoF:** Unlimited • **Ammo:** Unlimited (Reactor) • **Cost:** 450,000 CR.

Doctrine: Infinite ammunition draws directly from reactor loops, making it an excellent suppression weapon during extended zero-resupply operations.

6. PA "GUARDIAN" HEAVY PDC

A medium-caliber evolution of the Sentinel. Uses 30mm tungsten-jacketed rounds and heavy liquid-nitrogen cooling loops, extending defensive interception envelopes out to 2 km.

Mount: Motorized twin-barrel 30mm autocannon with integrated millimetric radar tracker and recoil-damping hydraulic dampers.
Size: Medium • **Type:** Unguided • **Dogfight Acc:** 1/2/2 • **Macro Acc:** 2/1/—/—/— • **Special:** Point-Defense (4) • **Damage:** +2 • **RoF:** Unlimited • **Ammo:** Unlimited • **Cost:** 600,000 CR.

Doctrine: Combines reliable point defense with genuine offensive bite against medium hulls at macro approach distances.

7. KSK "HARPOON" KINETIC MISSILE

Fires an ultra-dense depleted uranium penetrator dart at extreme closing speeds. While it lacks explosive yield, its pinpoint tracking makes it a favorite for sniping engines.

Mount: High-density depleted uranium dart driven by two-stage solid rocket booster with inertial gyro autopilot.
Size: Small • **Type:** Guided • **Tracking:** 4 • **Damage:** +1 • **RoF:** 1/turn • **Ammo:** 6 • **Cost:** 650,000 CR.

Doctrine: Extraordinary base Tracking 4 ensures reliable hits even through heavy hostile EWAR jamming environments.

8. CF "SLEDGEHAMMER" FLAK CANNON

Fires heavy, proximity-fused explosive canisters that burst into razor-sharp titanium shrapnel clouds. Engineered to shred incoming missile clusters and strip sensor domes.

Mount: Heavy rifled naval cannon firing pre-fragmented titanium canister rounds with variable electronic time fuzes.
Size: Medium • **Type:** Unguided • **Dogfight Acc:** —/1/2 • **Macro Acc:** 1/—/—/—/— • **Special:** Point-Defense (3) • **Damage:** +3 • **RoF:** 2/turn • **Ammo:** 12 • **Cost:** 750,000 CR.

Doctrine: Excellent area denial; creates dense kinetic screens that degrade light interceptors attempting knife-fighting flybys.

9. CQV "SOLARFLARE" LASER ARRAY

A continuous multi-megawatt chemical laser focusing thermal energy through synthetic sapphire optics. Delivers damage at the speed of light, melting structural ribs and vaporizing armor.

Mount: Multi-megawatt continuous-wave chemical oxygen-iodine laser channel with liquid-helium radiator loops.
Size: Medium • **Type:** Unguided • **Dogfight Acc:** —/1/2 • **Macro Acc:** 2/1/0/—/— • **Damage:** +2 • **RoF:** Unlimited • **Ammo:** Unlimited (Reactor) • **Cost:** 850,000 CR.

Doctrine: Near-zero flight time makes it impossible for targets to evade at close range, stripping ablative plates with ruthless precision.

10. GVI "JAVELIN" GUIDED MISSILE POD

A modular quad-launcher packed with high-thrust tactical missiles. Upon Target Lock acquisition, the salvo launches in a coordinated fan, adjusting vector mid-flight to overwhelm point defense.

Mount: Hexagonal four-tube modular launch pod with pneumatic soft-ejection and programmable ripple-fire logic.
Size: Medium • **Type:** Guided • **Tracking:** 2 • **Damage:** +4 • **RoF:** 1/turn • **Ammo:** 4 salvos • **Cost:** 950,000 CR.

Doctrine: Heavy tactical warheads crack frigate-grade bulkheads once hostile point-defense turrets are distracted or suppressed.

11. KSK "LANCE" KINETIC TORPEDO

A fin-stabilized kinetic torpedo driven by a solid-fuel booster core. Relies on immense closing momentum to smash deep into an adversary's internal machinery and shatter drive mounts.

Mount: Heavy hardened tungsten-carbide core encased in thermal ablative shroud with solid-fuel pursuit motor.
Size: Medium • **Type:** Guided • **Tracking:** 3 • **Damage:** +3 • **RoF:** 1/turn • **Ammo:** 8 • **Cost:** 1,100,000 CR.

Doctrine: Hardened seeker casing resists electronic countermeasures; devastating for crippling fleeing targets during high-G pursuit.

NAVAL ORDNANCE PROFILES (12-22)

12. CF "ANVIL" RAILGUN BATTERY

Twin electromagnetic accelerators firing tungsten slugs at hyper-velocity. Bridges the gap between light PDCs and spinal mounts with reliable medium-range striking power without extreme alignment limits.

Mount: Parallel copper-alloy magnetic rail guides launching hypervelocity tungsten sabots at 25 kilometers per second.
Size: Medium • **Type:** Unguided • **Dogfight Acc:** —/1/2 • **Macro Acc (10km):** 2/1/—/—/— • **Special:** Railgun • **Damage:** +5 • **RoF:** 2/turn • **Ammo:** 20 • **Cost:** 1,200,000 CR.

Doctrine: Long-Range Ballistics allow effective fire out to 20 km; excellent for softening approaching combatants before dogfight transition.

13. GVI "BREACHER" THERMAL LANCE

An industrial salvage cutting laser retrofitted for close-quarters void brawls. Poor range, but its focused thermal output provides unmatched cutting power against heavy armor plating at point-blank range.

Mount: Overclocked industrial cutting beam focusing plasma-arc thermal energy through heavy sapphire magnetic collimators.
Size: Medium • **Type:** Unguided • **Dogfight Acc:** —/1/3 • **Macro Acc:** 1/—/—/—/— • **Damage:** +8 • **RoF:** 1/turn • **Ammo:** Unlimited • **Cost:** 1,350,000 CR.

Doctrine: Devastating finisher at Advantage (Positions 8–10); slices cleanly through armored bulkheads and disabled hulks alike.

14. GVI "HYDRA" MULTI-MISSILE RACK

Sacrifices individual missile payload for sheer saturation volume. Fires four micro-missiles simultaneously, forcing target point-defense computers to spread intercept fire dangerously thin.

Mount: Pneumatic rapid-fire launcher dispensing ripple-fire cluster micro-missiles with coordinated swarm algorithms.
Size: Medium • **Type:** Guided • **Tracking:** 1 • **Damage:** +2 • **RoF:** 4/turn • **Ammo:** 2 salvos (8 missiles) • **Cost:** 1,500,000 CR.

Doctrine: Firing 4 missiles per turn overwhelms single-turret PDC grids through pure statistical target saturation.

15. CF "BULWARK" POINT-DEFENSE BATTERY

A large-scale multi-barrel defensive installation for frigates and monitors. Backed by dedicated fire-control mainframes, it projects an impenetrable interception umbrella out to 3 km.

Mount: Quad-barrel 40mm rotary battery tied directly to ship mainframe fire-control buses and dedicated cooling shunts.
Size: Large • **Type:** Unguided • **Dogfight Acc:** 0/1/1 • **Macro Acc:** 3/2/1/—/— • **Special:** Point-Defense (5) • **Damage:** +3 • **RoF:** Unlimited • **Ammo:** Unlimited • **Cost:** 1,800,000 CR.

Doctrine: Fleet-level screen; shields adjacent friendly vessels from torpedo strikes across multi-kilometer macro engagements.

16. CQV "ECLIPSE" PARTICLE BEAM

Accelerates ionized subatomic matter to relativistic velocities. Unlike lasers, the particle beam maintains focus at extreme ranges and delivers kinetic impact alongside thermal trauma.

Mount: Electrostatic subatomic particle accelerator utilizing superconducting magnets to collimate relativistic ion streams.
Size: Medium • **Type:** Unguided • **Dogfight Acc:** —/0/2 • **Macro Acc:** 3/2/1/0/— • **Damage:** +4 • **RoF:** 1/turn • **Ammo:** Unlimited (Reactor) • **Cost:** 2,200,000 CR.

Doctrine: Superb sniper weapon; strikes out to 4 km on the Macro-Grid with heavy accuracy and relentless armor erosion.

17. KSK "VOIDLANCE" FUSION TORPEDO TUBE

An instrument of absolute devastation. Launches an armored torpedo packing a multi-megaton thermonuclear payload. Slow and expensive, but a direct impact vaporizes heavy armor plating.

Mount: Pressurized naval torpedo tube launching multi-megaton thermonuclear warheads with armored terminal penetration caps.
Size: Large • **Type:** Guided • **Tracking:** 1 • **Damage:** +12 • **RoF:** 1/round • **Ammo:** 2 • **Cost:** 3,200,000 CR.

Doctrine: Capital ship executioner; a single penetrating strike tears through multiple hull condition tracks simultaneously.

18. GVI "CATACLYSM" SIEGE TORPEDO

The heaviest guided ordnance in the Sphere. Less a torpedo and more a demolition charge with rocket thrusters. Sluggish guidance, but its immense yield is sufficient to crack orbital stations.

Mount: Heavy demolition missile carrying high-yield shaped fusion payload with autonomous terminal dogfight thrusters.
Size: Large • **Type:** Guided • **Tracking:** 0 • **Damage:** +20 • **RoF:** 1/round • **Ammo:** 1 • **Cost:** 3,800,000 CR.

Doctrine: Station siege and fortress cracking; requires prior EWAR suppression to ensure the sluggish torpedo reaches its target.

19. KSK "SPECTER" STEALTH MISSILE

A marvel of black-budget engineering. Built with radar-scattering composites and cold-gas attitude jets. Nearly invisible to standard sensor suites, making it the premier assassination weapon.

Mount: Radar-absorbent ferrite composite airframe equipped with ultra-low-signature cold-gas vector thrusters.
Size: Medium • **Type:** Guided • **Tracking:** 5 • **Damage:** +4 • **RoF:** 1/turn • **Ammo:** 2 • **Cost:** 4,200,000 CR.

Doctrine: Tracking 5 slices through defensive jammers; lethal against high-value targets before defensive alarms trigger.

20. CF "MJOLNIR" SPINAL COILGUN

A massive mass accelerator built directly into a frigate's longitudinal keel. Accelerates a 100 kg depleted uranium slug to a fraction of light speed. Aiming requires pointing the entire ship.

Mount: Multi-stage electromagnetic induction coil assembly running the entire longitudinal structural keel of the vessel.
Size: Large • **Type:** Unguided • **Dogfight Acc:** —/—/2 • **Macro Acc (10km):** 3/2/1/0/— • **Special:** Railgun • **Damage:** +10 • **RoF:** 1/turn • **Ammo:** 6 • **Cost:** 4,500,000 CR.

Doctrine: Devastating spinal sniper; fires across 10–40 km corridors to shatter heavy keels before enemies can close.

21. CQV "PROMETHEUS" HEAVY LASER ARRAY

A turreted ultraviolet laser array with triple-core ruby resonators. Sips massive reactor power to ablate reinforced bulkheads at ranges where kinetic rounds drift off target.

Mount: High-output continuous-wave chemical laser driven by triple-core ruby resonators and high-capacity radiator vanes.
Size: Large • **Type:** Unguided • **Dogfight Acc:** —/0/1 • **Macro Acc:** 3/2/1/0/— • **Damage:** +6 • **RoF:** Unlimited • **Ammo:** Unlimited (Reactor) • **Cost:** 5,000,000 CR.

Doctrine: Sustained light-speed thermal lance; turreted mount allows continuous fire across neutral and advantage vectors alike.

22. CF "GIGANT" HEAVY RAILGUN

The pinnacle of conventional mass acceleration. Fires multi-ton slugs capable of snapping a cruiser's spine in a single volley. Immense recoil can knock smaller hulls off course.

Mount: Super-heavy naval railgun barrel with reinforced cryogenic field coils, firing multi-ton hypervelocity kinetic penetrators.
Size: Large • **Type:** Unguided • **Dogfight Acc:** —/—/1 • **Macro Acc (10km):** 4/3/2/1/0 • **Special:** Railgun • **Damage:** +15 • **RoF:** 1/turn • **Ammo:** 4 • **Cost:** 6,500,000 CR.

Doctrine: Interplanetary artillery; extreme range out to 50 km (50 hexes) forces entire battlefleets into evasive dispersed formations.

INTERNAL MODULES & SUBSYSTEMS

Internal modules represent specialized structural bays, avionics suites, and crew life-support installations housed within a starship's pressurized hull. A vessel's capacity for internal upgrades is strictly governed by its **Module Slots** based on Size Class: **Small craft (4 slots)**, **Medium vessels (8 slots)**, and **Large capital ships (12 slots)**.

MODULE NAME	RULES & TACTICAL EFFECT	SLOTS	COST (CR)
Injector Seats	Take half damage from G-Strain (round down) during high-G burns.	1	0 (Standard)
Extra Ammo Storage	Double the ammunition capacity of all weapons installed on the ship.	1	350,000
Reinforced Bulkheads	Permanently increases the vessel's Hull Rating by +2.	1	650,000
Auto-Loaders	Increases Rate of Fire (RoF) by +1 for unguided kinetic and guided missiles.	1	850,000
Basic MedBay	Single auto-doc berth; all Recovery tests on the ship receive 1 Upgrade.	1	450,000
Advanced MedBay	Automated trauma bay; all Recovery tests on the ship receive 2 Upgrades.	2	1,200,000
Intensive Trauma Suite	Clinical biosculpting bay; all Recovery tests on ship receive 3 Upgrades.	3	2,500,000
Signal Scrambler	Broad-spectrum EWAR array; grants +2 Upgrades to all Sensor Jam actions.	1	1,500,000
Fire-Control Computer	Predictive orbital tracking core; grants +2 Upgrades to Target Lock actions.	1	1,800,000
Advanced Repair Drones	Smart zero-g nanite swarm; grants +2 Upgrades to in-combat Repair actions.	1	2,000,000
Enhanced Sensor Suite	Cryogenic array; increases base Target Lock and Sensor Range by +2 km.	1	2,500,000
Hangar Bay	Pressurized launch deck; internally houses 2 Drone-fighters or 1 Shuttle.	3	4,000,000
Extra Hardpoint	Adds one hardpoint of a size already present on ship. (Max once per ship).	2	5,000,000

DETAILED MODULE DESCRIPTIONS

1. Injector Seats (1 Slot • 0 CR): Standard equipment for interceptors. Uses hydrostatic liquid-immersion cradles and automated cardio-vasoconstrictor drug injectors to prevent cerebral blood pooling during crushing maneuvers. Whenever crew members suffer G-Strain, damage is halved (rounded down).

2. Extra Ammo Storage (1 Slot • 350,000 CR): High-density armored ammunition drums and conveyor elevators tucked into cargo voids. Doubles the Ammunition capacity of all kinetic slugthrowers, railguns, and missile pods installed on the ship. Has no effect on reactor-powered lasers or particle beams.

3. Reinforced Bulkheads (1 Slot • 650,000 CR): Titanium-foam composite cross-braces and ceramic arrestor plates welded along internal keels. Permanently increases the ship's **Hull Rating by +2**, expanding every individual track segment across the vessel's Hull Condition Track.

4. Auto-Loaders (1 Slot • 850,000 CR): High-speed hydraulic rams and smart-sorting magazines that rapidly cycle heavy rounds and missile racks. Increases Rate of Fire (RoF) by +1 for all unguided kinetic weapons and guided missiles/torpedoes. Does not apply to continuous lasers or weapons with Unlimited RoF.

5. MedBay Installations (1–3 Slots): Ranging from compact auto-doc berths (*Basic*: 1 slot, 1 Upgrade) to multi-bed trauma centers (*Advanced*: 2 slots, 2 Upgrades) and full biosculpting clinical suites (*Intensive Trauma Suite*: 3 slots, 3 Upgrades). Grants Upgrades to all Recovery tests performed on board.

6. Electronic Warfare & Sensor Packages: The *Signal Scrambler* (+2 Upgrades to Sensor Jam) floods incoming ladar buses with false noise, while the *Fire-Control Computer* (+2 Upgrades to Target Lock) runs predictive orbital lead algorithms. The *Enhanced Sensor Suite* boosts raw Sensor Range by +2 km.

7. Drone Swarms & Structural Bays: *Advanced Repair Drones* (+2 Upgrades to Repair) deploy nanite spider-swarms into vacuum to weld breached bulkheads mid-combat. The *Hangar Bay* (3 slots) houses two combat drone-fighters or a personnel shuttle, while the *Extra Hardpoint* (2 slots) adds an additional external mounting collar.

FLEET REGISTRY & STARSHIP COMPARISON

Across the orbital habitats, asteroid belt mining claims, and lawless fringes of the Sphere, starships represent the apex of industrial engineering. From cobbled-together scavenger tugs to military-grade interdictors and crushing dreadnoughts, ten distinct hull classifications dominate operational service.

SHIP MODEL	SIZE	HULL	ARM	ACC	MAN	SYS	SENSORS	HARDPOINTS	BRIDGE SEATS	MODS	COST (CR)
GVI "Rusty Hook"	Small	10	2	2	4	2	4 km	3 / 0 / 0	P, G, E (x2)	2 / 4	1,200,000
RF "Kestrel"	Small	10	1	3	4	3	6 km	2 / 1 / 0	P, G, E (x2)	2 / 4	2,000,000
CQV "Shinobi"	Small	6	0	6	7	4	8 km	1 / 1 / 0	P, G, E (x2)	2 / 4	2,800,000
RF "Talon"	Small	8	1	4	6	3	6 km	2 / 1 / 0	P, G (x2), E	2 / 4	3,500,000
GVI "Ironbound"	Medium	10	3	3	3	4	8 km	4 / 2 / 0	P, G, E (x2)	4 / 8	8,500,000
RF "Falcon" (Vulture)	Medium	12	4	4	2	3	6 km	3 / 3 / 0	P, G (x2), E	3 / 8	12,000,000
KSK "Dagger"	Medium	10	2	5	5	5	10 km	2 / 2 / 0	P, G, E (x2)	2 / 8	15,500,000
GVI "Bastion"	Large	14	5	3	2	4	8 km	8 / 2 / 0	P, G (x2), E (x2)	5 / 12	45,000,000
CF "Cinder"	Large	12	4	5	2	5	10 km	2 / 3 / 1	P, G (x2), E	5 / 12	65,000,000
KSK "Leviathan"	Large	16	6	2	1	6	12 km	6 / 4 / 0	P, G (x3), E (x2)	8 / 12	120,000,000

SHIPYARDS OF THE SPHERE

Grabowski Void Industries (GVI): Headquartered throughout the lawless asteroid clusters of the Fringe, GVI builds unrefined, heavy-framed vessels assembled from pressurized cargo containers, salvaged ore haulers, and reinforced structural I-beams. Their designs (the *Rusty Hook*, *Ironbound*, and *Bastion*) are notoriously loud, uninsulated, and prone to hydraulic weeping, but their thick industrial armor belts and generous internal mounting volumes make them beloved by pragmatists who demand survivability over elegance.

Redfeather Aerospace (RF): The primary commercial shipwright for colonial planetary defense forces, exploration guilds, and licensed corsairs. Redfeather produces balanced, dependable craft (the *Kestrel*, *Talon*, and *Falcon*) characterized by modular hardpoint rails, standardized avionic buses, and readily available spare parts in every civilized orbital berth.

Chidori-Qwei Voidworks (CQV): Specializing in bleeding-edge sensor arrays, faceted stealth hulls, and ultra-high-efficiency microwave thrusters. The *Shinobi* represents their design philosophy: zero armor, paper-thin structural bulkheads, but extreme maneuverability and electronic invisibility that lets operatives strike and vanish.

Caldera Foundry (CF): The industrial forge-masters of deep space. Caldera specializes in massive electromagnetic coil structures and reinforced naval keels. The *Cinder* frigate is built entirely around an unyielding longitudinal spine, designed to deliver relativistic slugs across interplanetary corridors.

Ker'Satz Korp (KSK): State-contracted military shipwrights producing the apex of naval violence. KSK designs (the *Dagger* interdictor and the terrifying *Leviathan* dreadnought) boast hardened ceramic composite armor, quadruple-redundant avionics, and multi-station fire-control bridges capable of dominating entire orbital sectors.

NAVAL CLASSIFICATION & HULL TIERS

Vessels in the Sphere are categorized into three broad structural tiers: **Small craft** (corvettes, light scouts, and fast interceptors under 80 meters), **Medium craft** (patrol boats, armed freighters, and long-range interdictors from 80 to 200 meters), and **Large capital vessels** (defensive monitors, strike frigates, and dreadnoughts exceeding 200 meters with multi-deck spinal keels).

DOCKING FEES & REACTION MASS LOGISTICS

Maintaining a starship in active flight status requires steady capital. Civilized orbital hubs charge standardized berthing fees: **500 CR/day** for Small craft, **1,500 CR/day** for Medium craft, and **5,000 CR/day** for Large vessels. Refueling reaction mass (purified water-slurry and deuterium fusion pellets) costs roughly 1,000 CR per macro burn corridor, ensuring crews must constantly seek profitable corsair contracts to stay space-worthy.

SMALL STARSHIP REGISTRY

1. GVI "RUSTY HOOK" JURY-RIGGED CORSAIR

A common sight in the Fringe, the Rusty Hook is less a ship and more a collection of pressurized cargo containers, salvaged ore-crushers, and exposed wiring conduits. Ugly, noisy, and cramped, it is remarkably tough and mounts surprising forward firepower.

Hull Rating: 10 • **Condition Track:** 4 tracks of 10 segments (`[10] → [10] → [10] → [10]`)
Armor (Protection): 2 • **Acceleration:** 2 • **Maneuverability:** 4 • **Systems:** 2 (4 km Sensor)
Hardpoints: 3 Small • **Bridge Seats:** 4 (1x Pilot, 1x Gunner, 2x Engineer) • **Cost:** 1,200,000 CR
Chassis Specifications: LOA 48m • Beam 22m • Dry Displacement 620 metric tons • Welded container frame with high-tensile trunnions.
Standard Weapons: 1x PA "Sentinel" Rotary PDC (S), 1x PA "Caltrop" Mine Dispenser (S), 1x KSK "Harpoon" Kinetic Missile (S)
Installed Modules: Extra Ammo Storage (1 slot), Injector Seats (1 slot) [Total: 2/4 Slots]
Tactical Doctrine:

- The Rusty Hook is a close-quarters brawler that lures enemies in, using Armor 2 to absorb incoming fire.
- Punishes pursuing craft with the PA "Caltrop" Mine Dispenser while landing high-velocity Harpoon penetrators.
- Dual Engineer stations allow simultaneous power shunting to thrusters and active damage control in combat.
- Reinforced structural tow-winches allow rapid grappling and recovery of disabled derelict hulls in deep vacuum.

2. RF "KESTREL" MULTI-ROLE CORVETTE

The quintessential "Corsair's first ship." Produced in vast quantities by Redfeather Aerospace, the Kestrel is a reliable, balanced patrol craft designed for multi-mission modularity. The perfect platform for an ambitious crew to make their mark.

Hull Rating: 10 • **Condition Track:** 4 tracks of 10 segments (`[10] → [10] → [10] → [10]`)
Armor (Protection): 1 • **Acceleration:** 3 • **Maneuverability:** 4 • **Systems:** 3 (6 km Sensor)
Hardpoints: 2 Small, 1 Medium • **Bridge Seats:** 4 (1x Pilot, 1x Gunner, 2x Engineer) • **Cost:** 2,000,000 CR
Chassis Specifications: LOA 62m • Beam 28m • Dry Displacement 850 metric tons • Modular extruded titanium alloy monocoque.
Standard Weapons: 1x PA "Sentinel" Rotary PDC (S), 1x GVI "Stinger" Light Missile (S), 1x CQV "Solarflare" Laser Array (M)
Installed Modules: Injector Seats (1 slot), Fire-Control Computer (1 slot) [Total: 2/4 Slots]
Tactical Doctrine:

- Versatile all-rounder with Systems 3 and 6 km Sensor Range, operating effectively across all tactical envelopes.
- Carries a triad weapon mix: unguided PDC defense, guided Stinger burst, and sustained Solarflare thermal damage.
- Balanced 4-seat bridge ensures Pilot, Gunner, and Engineers each have the tools needed to contribute to the fight.
- Slaves sensor telemetry through the Fire-Control Computer to share precision Target Locks across allied escorts.

3. CQV "SHINOBI" STEALTH RECON

A masterpiece of signature reduction built with faceted carbon composites and chilled skin panels. Highly fragile with zero armor, but extreme acceleration and cryogenic electronics make it the premier scout and assassin vessel.

Hull Rating: 6 • **Condition Track:** 4 tracks of 6 segments (`[6] → [6] → [6] → [6]`)
Armor (Protection): 0 • **Acceleration:** 6 • **Maneuverability:** 7 • **Systems:** 4 (8 km Sensor)
Hardpoints: 1 Small, 1 Medium • **Bridge Seats:** 4 (1x Pilot, 1x Gunner, 2x Engineer) • **Cost:** 2,800,000 CR
Chassis Specifications: LOA 54m • Beam 20m • Dry Displacement 480 metric tons • Faceted carbon-nanotube radar-absorbent shell.
Standard Weapons: 1x CQV "Wasp" Pulse Laser (S), 1x KSK "Specter" Stealth Missile (M)
Installed Modules: Signal Scrambler (1 slot), Fire-Control Computer (1 slot) [Total: 2/4 Slots]
Tactical Doctrine:

- Relies on stealth and first-strike capability; Systems 4 and 8 km sensors acquire locks before detection.
- Uses extreme Maneuverability 7 to maintain Advantage (8–10) while staying out of the enemy's forward firing cone.
- Signal Scrambler enables the Engineer to break hostile locks while the Gunner fires stealth Specter missiles.
- Cools outer hull plating with internal liquid-helium heat sinks to vanish completely from enemy passive IR sensors.

4. RF "TALON" LIGHT INTERCEPTOR

A razor-thin interceptor built around carbon nanotubes with massive lateral thrusters, engineered for high-G sector patrol, fast dogfighting, and aggressive pursuit. Vulnerable to sustained fire, but uncatchable in agile turns.

Hull Rating: 8 • **Condition Track:** 4 tracks of 8 segments (`[8] → [8] → [8] → [8]`)
Armor (Protection): 1 • **Acceleration:** 4 • **Maneuverability:** 6 • **Systems:** 3 (6 km Sensor)
Hardpoints: 2 Small, 1 Medium • **Bridge Seats:** 4 (1x Pilot, 2x Gunner, 1x Engineer) • **Cost:** 3,500,000 CR
Chassis Specifications: LOA 58m • Beam 24m • Dry Displacement 710 metric tons • Reinforced tubular aerospace alloy spaceframe.
Standard Weapons: 2x PA "Sentinel" Rotary PDC (S), 1x GVI "Javelin" Missile Pod (M)
Installed Modules: Injector Seats (1 slot), Auto-Loaders (1 slot) [Total: 2/4 Slots]
Tactical Doctrine:

- Excels at closing distance rapidly to establish Advantage (Positions 8–10) using high Maneuverability 6.
- Once on the target's tail, Gunner fires Javelin guided missiles while Auto-Loaders cycle rapid follow-up salvos.
- Dual Gunner seats ensure complete coverage of both offensive missile targeting and defensive PDC interception.
- High lateral RCS clusters allow radical 180-degree flip-and-burn vector turns without bleeding closing velocity.

DOCTRINE // SMALL CRAFT OPERATIONAL LOGISTICS

Small starships represent the tactical backbone of corsair privateering across the Sphere. Their low displacement allows agile thrust-to-weight ratios and minimal reaction water consumption during interplanetary transit. However, limited internal magazine volume requires disciplined fire control: pilots who exhaust their ordnance in early skirmishes must flee to friendly orbital stations or face capital gunboats with empty launcher racks.

MEDIUM STARSHIP REGISTRY

5. GVI "IRONBOUND" HEAVY PATROL VESSEL

A blocky, industrial workhorse reinforced with thick layers of steel plating and structural bracing. Slow and unglamorous, but its rugged modular interior houses a full four-seat bridge, an advanced medbay, and generous repair drones.

Hull Rating: 10 • **Condition Track:** 4 tracks of 10 segments (`[10] → [10] → [10] → [10]`)
Armor (Protection): 3 • **Acceleration:** 3 • **Maneuverability:** 3 • **Systems:** 4 (8 km Sensor)
Hardpoints: 4 Small, 2 Medium • **Bridge Seats:** 4 (1x Pilot, 1x Gunner, 2x Engineer) • **Cost:** 8,500,000 CR
Chassis Specifications: LOA 112m • Beam 44m • Dry Displacement 3,400 metric tons • Cast-steel multi-frame keel with heavy bulkhead web.
Standard Weapons: 2x PA "Sentinel" Rotary PDC (S), 2x Empty Small Mounts, 1x CQV "Solarflare" Laser Array (M), 1x CF "Sledgehammer" Flak Cannon (M)
Installed Modules: Advanced MedBay (2 slots), Advanced Repair Drones (1 slot), Reinforced Bulkheads (1 slot) [Total: 4/8 Slots]
Tactical Doctrine:

- Operates on a war of attrition; Armor 3 reduces damage while 10-wound tracks absorb heavy punishment.
- Engineer shunts power to Weapons or Systems, granting Upgrades to the Gunner's laser and flak strikes.
- Gunner weakens targets with continuous thermal beams before tearing through exposed hulls with flak bursts.
- Second Engineer directs Advanced Repair Drones with Knowledge + Systems to restore integrity mid-combat.
- Internal hydro-recyclers and expansive machine shops permit months of independent patrol off civilized supply lanes.

6. RF "FALCON" (VULTURE) SYSTEM PATROL BOAT

The dependable backbone of colonial system defense forces, nicknamed "Vulture" for picking over disabled pirate hulls. Features a heavy armor belt, a balanced engine suite, and dangerous multi-barrel railgun batteries.

Hull Rating: 12 • **Condition Track:** 4 tracks of 12 segments (`[12] → [12] → [12] → [12]`)
Armor (Protection): 4 • **Acceleration:** 4 • **Maneuverability:** 2 • **Systems:** 3 (6 km Sensor)
Hardpoints: 3 Small, 3 Medium • **Bridge Seats:** 4 (1x Pilot, 2x Gunner, 1x Engineer) • **Cost:** 12,000,000 CR
Chassis Specifications: LOA 135m • Beam 52m • Dry Displacement 4,600 metric tons • Double-hulled layered composite armored belt.
Standard Weapons: 2x PA "Sentinel" Rotary PDC (S), 1x PA "Guardian" Heavy PDC (M), 1x CF "Anvil" Railgun Battery (M), 1x GVI "Javelin" Missile Pod (M)
Installed Modules: Advanced MedBay (2 slots), Extra Ammo Storage (1 slot) [Total: 3/8 Slots]
Tactical Doctrine:

- Uses Armor 4 and dual PDC screens to withstand incoming missile salvos while closing engagement gaps.
- The CF "Anvil" Railgun Battery delivers consistent kinetic trauma across medium Macro-Grid ranges (10–20 km).
- Focuses on area denial and intercepting hostile boarding craft before they reach docking collars.
- Dual Gunner stations allow simultaneous long-range railgun fire and defensive point-defense interception.
- Interlocking fire arcs create a forward kill corridor that prevents smaller corvettes from closing without taking heavy rail fire.

7. KSK "DAGGER" LONG-RANGE INTERDICTOR

A high-speed pursuit vessel built around oversized fusion engines and an advanced cryogenic sensor suite. Designed to chase down fleeing corsairs, break vector momentum, and pin targets until fleet dreadnoughts arrive.

Hull Rating: 10 • **Condition Track:** 4 tracks of 10 segments (`[10] → [10] → [10] → [10]`)
Armor (Protection): 2 • **Acceleration:** 5 • **Maneuverability:** 5 • **Systems:** 5 (10 km Sensor)
Hardpoints: 2 Small, 2 Medium • **Bridge Seats:** 4 (1x Pilot, 1x Gunner, 2x Engineer) • **Cost:** 15,500,000 CR
Chassis Specifications: LOA 120m • Beam 36m • Dry Displacement 3,800 metric tons • High-density ceramic-matrix reinforced pursuit chassis.
Standard Weapons: 2x PA "Sentinel" Rotary PDC (S), 1x KSK "Lance" Kinetic Torpedo (M), 1x CQV "Eclipse" Particle Beam (M)
Installed Modules: Fire-Control Computer (1 slot), Enhanced Sensor Suite (1 slot) [Total: 2/8 Slots]
Tactical Doctrine:

- Unrivaled at the Breakaway contest, using Acceleration 5 to stay glued to an escaping target's tail.
- The CQV "Eclipse" Particle Beam maintains tight beam focus out to 4 km, softening armor before torpedo impact.
- The KSK "Lance" Kinetic Torpedo uses heavy kinetic closing velocity to punch directly into hostile engine compartments.
- Supercooled cryogenic sensor arrays burn through passive electromagnetic stealth at ranges exceeding 10 kilometers.

DOCTRINE // MEDIUM HULL ENDURANCE & HYDRO-LOOPS

Medium hulls (80–150m) represent independent expeditionary platforms capable of long-range interplanetary transit. Unlike cramped corvettes, their internal displacement accommodates private bunk spaces, closed-loop hydroponic water recycling, and multi-week vacuum endurance. This operational self-sufficiency makes them the premier choice for corsair crews venturing far beyond the inner moons into uncharted asteroid corridors.

CAPITAL STARSHIP REGISTRY

8. GVI "BASTION" DEFENSIVE MONITOR

A massive, slab-sided station guardian that trades main propulsion for battery banks and eight small hardpoints, creating an overlapping wall of flak and proximity mines. Effectively a mobile orbital fortress capable of shredding entire fighter wings.

Hull Rating: 14 • **Condition Track:** 4 tracks of 14 segments (`[14] → [14] → [14] → [14]`)
Armor (Protection): 5 • **Acceleration:** 3 • **Maneuverability:** 2 • **Systems:** 4 (8 km Sensor)
Hardpoints: 8 Small, 2 Medium • **Bridge Seats:** 5 (1x Pilot, 2x Gunner, 2x Engineer) • **Cost:** 45,000,000 CR
Chassis Specifications: LOA 210m • Beam 95m • Dry Displacement 18,500 metric tons • Cast-iron and composite armor slab citadel.
Standard Weapons: 4x PA "Sentinel" Rotary PDC (S), 4x PA "Caltrop" Mine Dispenser (S), 2x CF "Sledgehammer" Flak Cannon (M)
Installed Modules: 2x Reinforced Bulkheads (2 slots), Advanced Repair Drones (1 slot), Extra Ammo Storage (1 slot), Injector Seats (1 slot) [Total: 5/12 Slots]
Tactical Doctrine:

- A nightmare for close-range attackers; eight small hardpoints deploy dense minefields and PDC walls.
- Entering the Bastion's macro hex is suicidal for light craft; mines force pursuers to break or explode.
- Dual Gunners track multiple closing vectors simultaneously while dual Engineers run continuous drone repairs.
- Functions as an immovable anchor for convoy defense, using overlapping flak envelopes to deny entire orbital hexes.

9. CF "CINDER" STRIKE FRIGATE

A long-range capital killer built entirely around a massive spinal rail system. Devastating forward acceleration lets it dictate macro-grid engagements, though poor lateral agility makes dogfights perilous if enemy craft close the gap.

Hull Rating: 12 • **Condition Track:** 4 tracks of 12 segments (`[12] → [12] → [12] → [12]`)
Armor (Protection): 4 • **Acceleration:** 5 • **Maneuverability:** 2 • **Systems:** 5 (10 km Sensor)
Hardpoints: 2 Small, 3 Medium, 1 Large Spinal • **Bridge Seats:** 4 (1x Pilot, 2x Gunner, 1x Engineer) • **Cost:** 65,000,000 CR
Chassis Specifications: LOA 245m • Beam 48m • Dry Displacement 16,200 metric tons • Longitudinal forged-tungsten spinal keel.
Standard Weapons: 2x PA "Sentinel" Rotary PDC (S), 1x CF "Mjolnir" Spinal Coilgun (L), 1x CQV "Solarflare" Laser (M), 1x GVI "Javelin" Missile (M), 1x KSK "Voidlance" Torpedo (M retrofit)
Installed Modules: Fire-Control Computer (1 slot), Enhanced Sensor Suite (1 slot), Extra Ammo Storage (1 slot), 2x Reinforced Bulkheads (2 slots) [Total: 5/12 Slots]
Tactical Doctrine:

- The CF "Mjolnir" Spinal Coilgun possesses extreme range out to 40 km; pilot aligns chassis along target vectors.
- If hostile craft enter close dogfights, the Pilot uses Acceleration 5 to Full Throttle breakaway into open space.
- Gunners utilize the Voidlance Torpedo Tube and Javelin Missile Pod to suppress targets before they enter knife-range.
- Executes hit-and-run relativistic strikes, firing spinal rounds along planetary flyby trajectories before bleeding momentum.

10. KSK "LEVIATHAN" HEAVY DREADNOUGHT

The supreme apex of naval architecture. A mobile fortress of multi-layered ceramic armor and six bridge stations that commands entire fleet battlegroups and projects an impenetrable zone of fire across an entire sector.

Hull Rating: 16 • **Condition Track:** 4 tracks of 16 segments (`[16] → [16] → [16] → [16]`)
Armor (Protection): 6 • **Acceleration:** 2 • **Maneuverability:** 1 • **Systems:** 6 (12 km Sensor)
Hardpoints: 6 Small, 4 Medium • **Bridge Seats:** 6 (1x Pilot, 3x Gunner, 2x Engineer) • **Cost:** 120,000,000 CR
Chassis Specifications: LOA 320m • Beam 110m • Dry Displacement 34,000 metric tons • Multi-layered composite ceramic armored citadel.
Standard Weapons: 4x PA "Sentinel" Rotary PDC (S), 2x KSK "Harpoon" Kinetic Missile (S), 2x CF "Anvil" Railgun Battery (M), 2x GVI "Hydra" Multi-Missile Rack (M)
Installed Modules: Extra Hardpoint (2 slots), Advanced Repair Drones (1 slot), Advanced MedBay (2 slots), Reinforced Bulkheads (1 slot), Fire-Control Computer (1 slot), Injector Seats (1 slot) [Total: 8/12 Slots]
Tactical Doctrine:

- Designed to absorb everything an enemy fleet can unleash; Armor 6 and four PDCs intercept almost all missile fire.
- Three dedicated Gunners maintain multiple Target Locks simultaneously, synchronizing railguns and missile swarms.
- Dual Engineers coordinate advanced nanite repair swarms, keeping weapons online and repairing bulkheads mid-fight.
- Maintains absolute sector supremacy; coordinated secondary missile batteries prevent swarm tactics from overwhelming the dreadnought.

NAVAL DOCTRINE // CAPITAL KEELS & ORBITAL FLEET DOMINANCE

Capital dreadnoughts and monitors cannot make planetary landfall without structural collapse under their own gravity. They are permanently space-borne naval leviathans requiring orbital drydocks and tenders for resupply, mounting spine-length keels capable of orbital bombardment.

COMBAT WALKTHROUGH: THE SKIRMISH AT VESTA VOID

To illustrate how orbital vector mechanics, bridge command actions, point-defense screens, and G-Strain interact under *Corsair's* core rules, observe the following encounter during **Round 1** between the player crew's **RF "Kestrel"** (corvette) and an aggressive pirate **GVI "Rusty Hook"** in the debris belt of Vesta. Both crews begin with **3 AP each**, and control alternates between sides whenever an active side spends **2 or more AP**.

PLAYER TURN 1 (2 AP SPENT — APPROACH & INTERCEPTION)

1. The Engineer Shunts Power (1 AP): Sitting in the Engineer seat, Sarah makes a Simple Test with **Systems (3)** + 1 Upgrade (Seat) = 1d12 + 2d10. Rolling `[9]` on the d12 and `[8, 4]` on the d10s, she scores **2 Hits**. She allocates both hits as Upgrades to *Engines* (Acceleration and Maneuverability) until the end of the round. *(Sarah: 2 AP left)*

2. Pilot Full Throttle (1 AP): Jax sits in the Pilot seat and executes Full Throttle. Success Test with **Acceleration (3)** + 1 Upgrade (Seat) + 2 Upgrades (Shunt) = 3d12. Rolling `[11, 8, 7]`, highest die is 11. Jax spends 4 Success Points to traverse 2 hex spaces (2 km) straight into the pirate's hex (0 G-Strain). Moving into the hex grants Jax the **Interception Advantage**: the *Kestrel* begins at **Position 6 (Attacker Edge)**, the pirate at **Position 5 (Defender Neutral)**. *(Jax: 2 AP left)*

GM TURN 1 (2 AP SPENT — GUIDED MISSILE SALVO & POINT DEFENSE)

1. Pirate Gunner Acquires Lock (1 AP): At Position 5, the pirate gunner rolls a Simple Test with **Systems (2)**, rolling `[8, 3]`. The 8 is a Hit! The pirate sacrifices the Hit to establish **1 level of Target Lock** on the *Kestrel*. *(Pirate Gunner: 2 AP left)*

2. Harpoon Launch & PDC Reaction (1 AP): The pirate fires a **KSK "Harpoon" Kinetic Missile** (Tracking 4, Damage +1). Guided Complex Test with Tracking (4 dice) + 1 Upgrade (Target Lock) = 1d12 + 3d10. Action Roll: `[10, 8, 5, 2]`—two Hits (10 and 8).

• *Point Defense Reaction (1 AP):* Miller reacts from the Gunner seat with the **PA "Sentinel" Rotary PDC** (Point-Defense 5, +1 Seat Upgrade = 1d12 + 4d10). Simple Test: `[9, 8, 7, 6, 2]`—two Hits (9 and 8). Each Hit eliminates a highest die from the missile roll (10 and 8). With zero 8+ dice remaining, the missile is shredded 200m out! *(Miller: 2 AP left)*

PLAYER TURN 2 (2 AP SPENT — TAIL POSITION & LASER STRIKE)

1. Combat Maneuver (1 AP): Jax executes a Combat Maneuver. Complex Test: **Maneuverability (4) + Instinct (3)** + 3 Upgrades (Seat + Shunt) = 3d12 + 1d10. Action Roll: `[11, 9, 8, 6]` (three Hits).

• *Pirate Contest (1 AP):* Pirate pilot spends 1 AP to contest with Maneuverability (4d10), rolling `[8, 5, 3, 2]` (one Hit). The 8 eliminates Jax's highest die (11), leaving `[9, 8, 6]`. Two Hits remain; Action succeeds! Jax takes Instinct (3) dice: `[9, 8, 6]`. Highest is 9. Jax spends 3 SPs to advance from Position 6 to **Position 9 (Advantage: On their Tail!)**. *(Jax: 1 AP left)*

2. Solarflare Laser Strike (1 AP): Miller fires the **CQV "Solarflare" Laser Array** (Damage +2). Complex Test: Finesse (3) + Advantage Accuracy (2) + 1 Upgrade (Seat) = 1d12 + 2d10. Action Roll: `[10, 8, 5]` (two Hits; Action succeeds). Success Roll (2 dice): `[10, 8]`—highest is 10 SPs! Total Damage: 10 SP + 2 Bonus = 12 damage. Pirate **Armor 2** absorbs 2; **10 penetrating damage** completely fills the pirate's **First Hull Track (10/10 Light Wounds)**! *(Miller: 1 AP left)*

GM TURN 2 (2 AP SPENT — FAILED BREAKAWAY & SURRENDER)

1. Pirate Desperate Breakaway (1 AP): Pinned at Position 2 from their view, the pirate pilot executes a Breakaway Burn. Success Test with **Acceleration (2)**: rolls `[9, 5]` (highest die 9 SPs).

• *Stay on Target Contest (1 AP):* Jax spends his final 1 AP to contest with Acceleration (3) + 1 Upgrade (Seat) = 1d12 + 2d10. Jax rolls `[10, 8, 4]`—two Hits (10 and 8)! Jax's two Hits eliminate both the 9 and 5 from the pirate's roll! With zero 8+ dice remaining, the contest succeeds: Breakaway yields **0 SPs**! The pirate remains pinned at Position 2. *(Jax: 0 AP left)*

2. Pirate Surrender (1 AP): Trapped before the charged laser array with hull plating ruptured, the pirate captain spends their final AP to vent thrusters and broadcast emergency surrender: *"Cease fire, Kestrel! We're dead in the water! We surrender!"*

ENCOUNTER DEBRIEF // CORE RULE INVARIANTS

- **The 2 AP Turn Switch:** Control alternated dynamically between the player crew and the GM as Action Points were expended (Player Turn 1: 2 AP → GM Turn 1: 2 AP → Player Turn 2: 2 AP → GM Turn 2: 2 AP), resolving the entire tactical skirmish within a single Round.
- **Standard Contesting Rule:** When Miller contested the missile with Point Defense and Jax contested the Breakaway with Stay on Target, each contest Hit (8+) eliminated one of the highest dice from the incoming roll. Eliminating all 8+ dice caused the attack to miss and the Breakaway Success Test to yield 0 Success Points.
- **Bridge Station Synergies:** Dedicated bridge seats granted decisive tactical advantages—the Pilot seat's free Upgrades and Stay on Target reaction, the Gunner seat's Point Defense reaction, and the Engineer seat's Power Distribution test allowed a coordinated 3-person crew to neutralize incoming ordnance and secure victory.

DOWNTIME & DAY-TO-DAY OPERATIONS

Not every hour of a Corsair's career is defined by pressurized breach-charges, howling decompression sirens, or high-stakes firefights through zero-gravity bulkheads. Corsairs are flesh-and-blood operatives who must decompress, treat physical trauma, overhaul battered starships, shop for high-grade ordnance, and scrounge up freelance income to pay dockyard berthing fees. Between operational contracts, play shifts into **Day-to-Day pacing**. This macro-pacing scope gives players the creative freedom to pursue personal projects, train new competencies, and manage their ship's logistics, while providing Game Masters with a structured engine to track operational runway, simulate a living station economy, and pace campaign arcs.

1. THE 24-HOUR DOWNTIME ROUND & SHIFT STRUCTURE

Day-to-Day pacing operates on a unified, macro-scale round structure. A single round represents **one full 24-hour day** in the game world. At the start of each Day-to-Day round, every player character receives **3 Day-to-Day Action Points (AP)**. Each Action Point represents an **8-hour operational shift**:

Shift	Timeframe	Operational Focus	Example Downtime Actions
Shift 1: Morning	08:00 – 16:00	Primary Operations	Medbay recovery, hull repairs, market run
Shift 2: Afternoon	16:00 – 24:00	Secondary Endeavors	Freelance gigs, tactical training, study
Shift 3: Night	00:00 – 08:00	Rest, Drills, or Gigs	Evening freelance, simulators, relaxation

FREE ALLOCATION & SUSTENANCE

Characters may allocate their 3 Day-to-Day AP across any combination of downtime activities (such as training, taking freelance gigs, or shopping). Consuming 1 Supply at the End of the Round covers standard meals, personal hygiene, and healthy sleep patterns distributed naturally across the 24-hour cycle. Operatives do not need to spend an AP on sleep unless they are actively seeking medical recovery from **Wounds** or **Stress** through a **Long Rest**.

THE THREE PACING SCOPES

In *Corsair*, the GM dynamically adjusts pacing between three interconnected time scopes. **Moment-to-Moment** governs tactical combat, room breaches, and high-G dogfights where seconds matter and combatants spend 3 Moment-to-Moment AP. **Place-to-Place** shifts to hours, governing orbital transit, infiltration approaches, and tactical surveillance. **Day-to-Day** zooms out to 24-hour cycles, providing the structural canvas for repairs, medical convalescence, and long-range interplanetary burns.

2. SUPPLIES & OPERATING RUNWAY

A crew's remaining operational runway is measured in **Supplies**. Rather than burdening the table with separate bookkeeping for protein packs, hydroponic greens, reactor coolant cartridges, and life-support filter scrubbing chemicals, all vessel consumption is unified into a single daily burn rate.

THE END-OF-ROUND HEARTBEAT

At the **End of the Round** (every 24 hours of in-game time), deduct **1 Supply** from the starship's cargo hold. Paying this 1 Supply sustains environmental life support and refills every crew member's pool back to **3 Day-to-Day AP** for the upcoming day.

THE CONSEQUENCES OF ZERO SUPPLY

If the starship enters a new day with **0 Supplies remaining**, the vessel's auxiliary reserves shut down, imposing severe immediate penalties starting that morning:

- **Auxiliary Systems Offline:** All passive internal module benefits (medical bays, fabrication workshops, advanced sensors) power down.
- **Repairs Blocked:** Starship hull damage cannot be repaired by crew or automation.
- **Crew Deprivation:** Life-support scrubbers falter and food rations run dry. Every crew member immediately suffers **1 Light Wound** and **1 Light Stress** at the start of each unsupplied day.
- **Advancement Frozen:** Physical exhaustion and hunger prevent effective practice; characters **cannot spend Day-to-Day AP to gain XP** or train attributes.

> **DOCTRINE // MACRO-PACING & CAMPAIGN MOMENTUM**
>
> Day-to-Day pacing prevents downtime from devolving into vague hand-waving. By assigning concrete costs to shifts and supplies, every day berthed at a station creates meaningful tension: do the operatives spend their hours resting to clear debilitating wounds, drilling in combat simulators to gain precious XP, or working dockside odd jobs to afford drydock repair fees before their operating runway runs dry?

PURCHASING SUPPLIES & CARGO CAPACITY

Supplies can be procured at any civilized port, orbital station, or mining colony. Bulk provisioning offers substantial discounts to cells planning extended interplanetary burns across the Fume system:

Provisioning Option	Supply Amount	Total Credit Cost	Effective Cost / Supply
Emergency Rations	1 Supply	$2,000 Credits	$2,000 Credits
Standard Crate	5 Supply	$8,000 Credits	$1,600 Credits *(Save $2,000)*
Sponsor Cargo Pallet	10 Supply	$12,000 Credits	$1,200 Credits *(Save $8,000)*
Industrial Haul	20 Supply	$20,000 Credits	$1,000 Credits *(Half Price!)*

CARGO CAPACITIES BY SHIP SIZE

A vessel's internal cargo volume limits the maximum number of Supplies it can haul:

- **Small Ships (Interceptors, Couriers):** Maximum **10 Supply** (10 days operational runway).
- **Medium Ships (Corvettes, Cutters):** Maximum **20 Supply** (20 days operational runway).
- **Large Ships (Frigates, Heavy Transports):** Maximum **30 Supply** (30 days operational runway).

3. RECOVERY, LONG REST & HEALTHCARE

Combat injuries and psychological strain are inevitable hazards of the trade. While field dressings and stim-injectors provide rapid triage during tactical engagements, deep healing requires quiet rest and clinical support.

THE LONG REST ACTION

A character who spends **1 Day-to-Day AP** resting quietly in their quarters or undergoing treatment in a medical facility executes a **Long Rest**. To resolve a Long Rest, the player makes a **Success Test** using **Endurance + Willpower**. Because attribute pairs always use the lower rating as the base dice pool, an operative with Endurance 4 and Willpower 2 rolls 2 base dice.

Every Success Point (SP) generated on the roll is freely allocated to restore Condition tracks:

- **Light Wounds & Light Stress:** Restoring 1 Light segment costs **1 Success Point**.
- **Aggravated Wounds & Stress:** Clearing 1 Aggravated segment costs **2 Success Points**.
- **Clearing Impaired & Crippled:** The moment a filled Condition track is cleared of all damage segments, any **Impaired** (1 Downgrade) or **Crippled** (2 Downgrades) condition tied to that track is instantly removed.

Facility Tier	Upgrades	Standard Availability	Healthcare Coverage Notes
Crew Bunk / Field	+0	Ship quarters, surface tents	Baseline self-care; roll base Endurance + Willpower.
Port Clinic	+1	Station med-bays, berthing	Covered by standard contract berthing & port fees.
Trauma Center	+2	Specialized municipal hospitals	Covered by sanctioned mission pay & medical riders.
Biosculpting Ward	+3	Elite corporate hospital suites	Covered by high-tier Corsair sponsor underwriting.

Shipboard MedBays: A starship equipped with an internal **MedBay Module** provides permanent, autonomous medical care wherever the vessel travels, granting **+1, +2, or +3 Upgrades** to all Long Rest tests performed aboard (see Starship Internal Modules).

MEDICAL DOCTRINE // IMPAIRMENT & RECOVERY

Entering combat while suffering from Impairment imposes a brutal 1 Downgrade penalty on all tests governed by that attribute. When an operative sustains critical bone fractures or psychic trauma, prioritizing an afternoon shift in a Port Clinic is essential to strip the impairment before the next contract deployment.

4. TRAINING & CHARACTER PROGRESSION

When operatives have downtime to spare, they can hone their physiological reflexes, technical expertise, or academic mastery. Downtime training allows characters to bridge the gap between combat deployments, steadily earning Experience Points through disciplined study and physical conditioning.

- **Training AP Cost & Reward:** Spending **1 Day-to-Day AP** on focused physical conditioning, target shooting, flight simulations, or cyber-warfare theory awards **1 Experience Point (1 XP)**.
- **Strict Daily Limit:** To reflect biological and cognitive limits, an operative can earn a **maximum of 1 XP from Training per 24-hour round** (spending at most 1 AP on training per day). The remaining 2 AP must be allocated to other activities (such as medical rest, ship maintenance, freelance odd jobs, shopping, or personal projects).
- **Closing the Gap:** Downtime training serves primarily to close the small remaining XP gap (typically 1 to 2 XP) needed to learn a new Skill rank, purchase an appealing Trait, or increase an Attribute after completing an operational mission.
- **Spending XP:** Accumulated XP can be spent at any time during downtime to increase Skills, acquire new Traits, or improve Attributes according to the standard progression ladder:

Progression Element	XP Investment	Advancement Mechanics & Restrictions
Skill Improvement	**2 XP** per rank	Increases any Skill by +1 rank (up to maximum rank 5).
Acquire New Trait	**2 to 8 XP**	Purchases a new Class Mod or general Trait based on rarity tier.
Attribute Increase	**3 × Target Level**	Cost equals 3 times the new rank (e.g., Rank 2 to 3 costs 9 XP).
Training Ceiling	**1 XP / 24 Hours**	Hard biological daily limit; maximum 1 AP allocated to training per day.

5. STARSHIP MAINTENANCE & THE SHIP FUND

Starships endure tremendous strain from orbital maneuvers, atmospheric reentry friction, and point-defense fire. Maintaining a space-worthy hull requires daily labor from the crew and access to industrial drydocks.

- **The Ship Fund ($250,000 Credits Baseline):** Every Corsair cell begins play with a dedicated **$250,000 Credits Ship Fund** maintained in an escrow account, earmarked specifically for drydock repairs, hull reconstruction, docking fees, and shared vessel upgrades.
- **Field Self-Repair:** Spending **1 Day-to-Day AP**, consuming **1 Supply**, and using a **Mechanic's Kit** allows an engineer to roll a **Knowledge + Tinkering** (or **Finesse + Tinkering**) Simple Test. Each Hit restores **1 Light Hull segment**. Self-repairs **cannot clear Aggravated Hull damage**.
- **Professional Drydock Overhauls:** Berthed at an orbital shipyard, a crew can contract a full overhaul taking **1 Day-to-Day round** (24 hours) per Hull track, restoring **1 full Hull track** completely (clearing Light and Aggravated Wounds) at a cost of **$25,000 Credits per track** paid from the Ship Fund.
- **Equipment Upgrades Note:** Installing, calibrating, or swapping mastercrafted weapon and armor upgrade kits takes place naturally during downtime and costs **0 AP** aboard ship.

Maintenance Tier	Time / AP Cost	Resource Cost	Structural Restoration Rate
Field Patch Repair	1 AP (8 hours)	1 Supply + Tool Kit	Restores 1 Light Hull segment per Hit on Tinkering test.
Drydock Overhaul	24 Hours / Track	$25,000 / Track	Completely restores 1 full Hull track (clears Aggravated).
Module Recalibration	1 AP (8 hours)	Standard diagnostics	Restores online status for disabled internal modules.
Station Berthing Slip	Continuous	Contract Escrow	Covered by sanctioned missions; $500/day for unauthorized.

ENGINEERING DOCTRINE // FIELD VS DRYDOCK OVERHAULS

Self-repair in open vacuum is vital for patching superficial micro-meteorite breaches and keeping thruster manifolds firing. However, when structural keels buckle under heavy kinetic missile impact, the vessel requires heavy shipyard gantries to unseal hull plates and replace load-bearing titanium frames.

6. SHOPPING & COMMERCIAL BAZAARS

Every civilized spaceport, orbital aerostat, and domed mining settlement hosts bustling commercial concourses where Corsairs spend contract earnings. Spending **1 Day-to-Day AP** on a shopping excursion allows an operative to browse local vendor stalls, military surplus depots, and tech bazaars, purchasing any weapons, armor, ammunition, tool kits, and gear cataloged in the rulebook within that port's commercial market tier:

Market Tier	Port Environment	Hardware & Equipment Availability
Tier 1: Frontier Hab	Mining outposts, scrap havens	Basic slugthrowers, hazard suits, survival rations, tools.
Tier 2: Orbital Hub	Station concourses, trade ports	Military surplus, precision optics, armor upgrades, cybernetics.
Tier 3: Spire Citadel	Corporate capitals, megacities	Mastercrafted exotics, prototype chassis, neural suites.

7. INTERPLANETARY TRAVEL & FUEL BURN

Travel across the Fume system is governed by Newtonian physics and constant fusion burn. Vessels execute continuous acceleration burns toward the voyage midpoint, perform a zero-g turnover maneuver, and decelerate into orbital capture. Fuel consumption scales directly with astronomical distances:

Transit Scope	Time Required	Fuel Cost	Operational Scope
Between Sibling Moons	~1 hour (Place-to-Place)	**1 Supply**	Local binary moon transfer
Between Binary Moons	~8 hours (1 Day AP)	**2 Supplies**	Sub-orbital 1-g brachistochrone
Between Gas Giants	72 hours (3 Day Rounds)	**4 Supplies**	Interplanetary deep-void transit

8. CONTRACTS & MISSION OVERVIEW

Contracts provide the capital and institutional reputation needed to upgrade weapons and maintain operational independence. The **Corsair Oversight Committee** categorizes contracts into three distinct tiers:

Contract Tier	Sanctioned Pay (Per Operative)	Rep Gain	XP Award	Unsanctioned Pay
Tier 1 (Local / Precinct)	$5,000 – $7,500 Credits	**+1 Rep**	**+4 XP**	$15,000 – $25,000
Tier 2 (System / Corporate)	$15,000 – $20,000 Credits	**+3 Rep**	**+8 XP**	$35,000 – $60,000
Tier 3 (High-Threat / Black-Site)	$35,000 – $50,000+ Credits	**+7 Rep**	**+12 XP**	$75,000+ Credits

9. FREELANCE WORK & EARNING INCOME

Between major contracts, Corsairs frequently pick up local freelance work to pocket extra credits, learn station rumors, or close the small financial gap ($1,000 to $2,000 Credits) remaining to purchase a weapon upgrade kit. Accepting an odd job takes **1 Day-to-Day AP** (one 8-hour shift). The player rolls a **Simple Test** using the specified Attribute Pair.

- **1 or More Hits:** Earns **$500 Credits base pay**, plus **+$250 Credits for each additional Hit** beyond the first.
- **0 Hits:** Earns **$0 Credits**. The shift is spent without mechanical injury.

Hits on Test	Credit Payout	Narrative Outcome
0 Hits	$0 Credits	Shift wasted; client stiffs on payment.
1 Hit	$500 Credits	Solid work; completed without incident.
2 Hits	$750 Credits	Great efficiency; client adds a generous tip.
3 Hits	$1,000 Credits	Masterful performance; glowing dock recommendation.
4+ Hits	+$250 / Extra Hit	Legendary hustle; station talks about the job for days.

ECONOMIC DOCTRINE // THE DOCKSIDE HUSTLE

Freelance odd jobs are the glue of spacer society. Whether clearing frozen conduits, guarding fragile greenhouse pollinator swarms, or playing synth at a dockside tavern, these small gigs give characters local roots and vital walking-around cash.

THE MASTER D100 ODD JOBS TABLE (GIGS 01 - 50)

d100	Gig Title	Description & Situation	Required Test
01	Lost Featherwing	Track an administrator's alien songbird in ducts.	Instinct + Know
02	Spacer Stand-Up	Deliver an 8-min comedy routine at a dive bar.	Pres + Pres
03	PI Tail Shadow	Trail a merchant's partner through a bazaar.	Agility + Instinct
04	Cook-Off Judge	Adjudicate a heated street-noodle culinary duel.	Endur + Instinct
05	Synthwave Guard	Keep rowdy spacers in line at a synth concert.	Strength + Pres
06	Zero-G Catering	Carry floating drink trays at an eccentric party.	Finesse + Agility
07	Pawn Appraisal	Help a dealer identify weird salvage relics.	Know + Know
08	Dockside Boxing	Teach teens footwork and defensive guard.	Strength + Inst
09	Love Courier	Hand-deliver a wax-sealed letter across town.	Agility + Pres
10	Cargo Bay Sort	Untangle freight crates before customs check.	Know + Finesse
11	Micro-Pigs Run	Chase down a dozen mini pet pigs in a park.	Agility + Agility
12	Apartment Move	Haul heavy pressurized sofas up broken stairs.	Strength + Endur
13	Line Cook Shift	Flip protein patties through diner lunch rush.	Finesse + Endur
14	Line-Stand Proxy	Stand 6 hours in line at municipal records.	Endur + Willpower
15	Lunch Stakeout	Catch the breakroom thief stealing sandwiches.	Instinct + Agility
16	Life Drawing	Hold grueling classical poses for an art class.	Endur + Pres
17	Mascot Performer	Don a giant foam suit to hand out opening flyers.	Pres + Endur
18	Zero-G Dodgeball	Officiate a dock crew dodgeball grudge match.	Instinct + Pres
19	Drone Gatekeeper	Set radio gates and retrieve crashed drones.	Agility + Know
20	Graffiti Wash	Scrub disrespectful slogans off a bronze statue.	Strength + Endur
21	Exotic Walker	Walk three 6-legged hunting dogs in promenade.	Strength + Inst
22	Bar Singalong	Lead drunken miners in colony folk ballads.	Pres + Finesse
23	Market Hawker	Sell refurbished kitchen gadgets at a booth.	Pres + Know
24	Flat-Pack Build	Assemble modular desks from confusing manuals.	Know + Finesse
25	Hydro Weeder	Prune invasive mutated mosses from aeroponics.	Finesse + Inst
d100	**Gig Title**	**Description & Situation**	**Required Test**
26	Rickshaw Driver	Pedal passengers and luggage between bays.	Endur + Strength
27	Wedding Guard	Keep an estranged uncle from ruining reception.	Pres + Strength
28	Trash Unclogging	Crawl down waste chute with a pry-bar for a bin.	Strength + Endur
29	Lost Ring Search	Comb a tourist dome with a metal detector.	Instinct + Inst
30	Cat Cafe Minder	Feed and brush 20 zero-g cats during hours.	Finesse + Inst
31	Voiceover Jingle	Record commercial slogans for used starships.	Pres + Pres
32	Mooring Coiler	Haul and inspect heavy magnetic mooring cables.	Strength + Endur
33	Pest Trapper	Set acoustic traps for hydroponic cable vermin.	Instinct + Know
34	Neon Sign Tech	Climb scaffolding to replace plasma sign tubes.	Agility + Finesse
35	Arcade Bounty	Beat an unbeatable pinball score for a child.	Finesse + Inst
36	Prom Chaperone	Escort an anxious teen to an academy ball.	Pres + Know
37	Crane Rigging	Rig magnetic cables to hoist a disabled skiff.	Strength + Finesse
38	Sourdough Guard	Watch a century-old sourdough mother culture.	Instinct + Endur
39	Luggage Unjam	Untangle oversized vacuum bags in intake chute.	Strength + Finesse
40	Used Rover Flagger	Direct chaotic vehicle traffic at a rover auction.	Agility + Pres
41	Solar Scraper	Scrape volcanic ash off domestic solar panels.	Endur + Endur
42	Karaoke Host	Encourage shy singers and manage mic disputes.	Pres + Instinct
43	Rover Trials	Put a tuned all-terrain rover through crater trials.	Endur + Agility
44	Lost Comm-Pad	Fish a lost data slate out of a narrow drain grate.	Finesse + Inst

d100
45 Ru
46 Do
47 Sp
48 Fi
49 Ic
50 Ta

DOCK
Freela
trap
disgru
freela

THE MASTER D100 ODD JOBS TABLE (GIGS 51 – 100)

d100	Gig Title	Description & Situation	Required Test
51	Tower Guy-Wires	Tension heavy braided guy-wires on a radio mast.	Agility + Strength
52	Magic Shilling	Pose as amazed audience for a street magician.	Pres + Agility
53	Vending Restock	Lug crates of synthetic soda cans to terminals.	Strength + Endur
54	Museum Patrol	Guard prehistoric fossil replicas from pranksters.	Inst + Willpower
55	Stunt Fall Dummy	Take padded slapstick falls for an indie film.	Agility + Endur
56	Lost Tourist Guide	Guide confused pilgrims through a chaotic market.	Know + Pres
57	Window Gondola	Squeegee observation dome windows on ropes.	Agility + Finesse
58	Coffee Roaster	Monitor roasting temperatures for micro-roastery.	Instinct + Finesse
59	Balloon Animals	Twist latex balloons into beasts for swarms of kids.	Finesse + Pres
60	Gyro Calibration	Fine-tune optical balance sensors on flywheels.	Know + Finesse
61	Food Truck Tire	Jack up and swap bald tires on a greasy rover.	Strength + Know
62	Locker Attendant	Sort laundry and keep peace at gym bathhouse.	Endur + Pres
63	Data-Tape Recovery	Digitize fragile magnetic reel tapes from archives.	Know + Instinct
64	Lost Ferret Hunt	Coax an escaped biting mustelid from furniture.	Finesse + Agility
65	Fountain Dredging	Wade through decorative mall fountain for coins.	Endur + Instinct
66	Board Game Demo	Teach complex rules to families at game open day.	Know + Pres
67	Cable Stripper	Strip plastic sheathing off heavy copper wires.	Strength + Finesse
68	Counter-Sniper	Scan rooftops to guarantee patron security lines.	Instinct + Endur
69	Trampoline Spot	Catch tumbling acrobatics students in zero-g gym.	Agility + Instinct
70	Bakery Sprint	Sprint armfuls of hot pastries across town on foot.	Agility + Endur
71	Chess Hustling	Play speed-chess in park to draw betting crowd.	Know + Instinct
72	Keg Roller Shift	Roll pressurized ale kegs down a cellar ramp.	Strength + Agility
73	Lost Keys in Grill	Fish magnetic car keys out of sewer with string.	Finesse + Finesse
74	Puppet Stagehand	Operate hidden puppet strings behind curtain.	Finesse + Agility
75	Floral Arranger	Trim stems and compose centerpieces for banquet.	Finesse + Pres
d100	Gig Title	Description & Situation	Required Test
76	Crosswalk Guard	Hold stop sign to escort kids across rover street.	Pres + Instinct
77	Squeaky Bed Fix	Tighten bolts and grease joints for capsule hotel.	Know + Strength
78	Rooftop Goat	Coax domestic mountain goat off corrugated shed.	Instinct + Agility
79	Ice Cream Scoop	Scoop rock-hard frozen cream during heatwave.	Strength + Endur
80	Movie Extra Shock	Look shocked in crowded starport for 20 takes.	Pres + Endur
81	Mannequin Dress	Dress and pose stiff fiberglass display figures.	Finesse + Pres
82	Bellhop Luggage	Balance tall suitcase tower through revolving doors.	Agility + Finesse
83	Greenhouse Bees	Refill sugar syrup troughs for pollinator swarms.	Instinct + Finesse
84	Telescope Buffing	Buff condensation off observatory glass mirror.	Finesse + Know
85	Dog Wash Shift	Wrestle soapy alien hounds into wash tubs.	Strength + Endur
86	Trophy Polishing	Buff tarnish off heavy brass bowling trophies.	Endur + Finesse
87	Skiff Inspection	Verify fuel restrictors on speed-skiffs before race.	Know + Instinct
88	Nav-Beacon Tuning	Adjust frequency dials on an erratic nav beacon.	Know + Instinct
89	Sled Puller	Pull a broken-down family snow-sled up slope.	Strength + Endur
90	Degauss Shields	Sweep degaussing coils over radiation shields.	Know + Finesse
91	Critic Bodyguard	Shield food critic from chefs throwing vegetables.	Agility + Pres
92	Circus Rigging	Inspect wire tethers for zero-g silks performance.	Agility + Finesse
93	Mascot Wrestling	Wrestle opponent dressed as alien in stunt match.	Strength + Agility
94	Drain Snaking	Run mechanical snake down salon's blocked sinks.	Strength + Finesse

d100
95 He
96 Ro
97 Lo
98 Li
99 Bo
100 Ro

COM

Corsa
stall's
corpo
the w

10. PRACTICAL DOWNTIME: SHORE LEAVE AT PORT ZENITH

Following a grueling pirate interdiction in the upper atmosphere of Landfall, Jax, Silas, and Tessa dock their battered cutter at **Port Zenith** for a **24-hour layover**. The GM opens the scene in **Day-to-Day pacing (Round 1)**, granting each operative **3 Day-to-Day Action Points (AP)** to allocate across the 24-hour cycle.

Shift	Operative	AP Cost	Operational Downtime Action & Resolution
	Jax	1 AP	Medbay Long Rest (Endurance 3 + Willpower 2 in Port Clinic, +1 Upgrade)
S1: Morning	Silas	1 AP	Starship Self-Repair (1 AP + 1 Supply, Mechanic's Kit, Knowledge 4 + Tinkering 2)
	Tessa	1 AP	Bazaar Shopping Spree (Standard Crate of Supplies: 5 Supply, $8,000 Credits)
	Jax	1 AP	Physical Conditioning (Centrifuge gym workout; earns 1 XP towards Athletics)
S2: Afternoon	Silas	1 AP	Freelance Gig #01: Lost Featherwing (Instinct 4 + Knowledge 4 Simple Test)
	Tessa	1 AP	Freelance Gig #05: Synthwave Bouncer (Strength 3 + Presence 4 Simple Test)
	Jax	1 AP	Freelance Gig #02: Spacer Bar Stand-Up (Presence 4 + Presence 4 Simple Test)
S3: Night	Silas	1 AP	Technical Study (Orbital navigation data-slate analysis; earns 1 XP)
	Tessa	1 AP	Flight Simulator Drills (Emergency thruster failure rehearsal; earns 1 XP)

SHIFT 1: MORNING OPERATIONS (3 AP SPENT)

Docking umbilical clamps hiss shut at 08:00 as pressurized station air floods the airlock. The crew assesses operational priorities before disembarking into Port Zenith's bustling industrial rings:

- **Medbay Long Rest (Jax, 1 AP):** Jax took heavy shrapnel during atmospheric dogfighting, leaving Track I of his Physical Condition filled with 4 Light Wounds and 1 Aggravated Wound (inflicting **Impaired Strength**). Jax checks into Port Zenith's dockside trauma clinic. Sanctioned contract riders cover the clinic fee, granting **+1 Upgrade**. Jax pairs **Endurance 3** and **Willpower 2** (2 base dice stepped up to 1d12 + 1d10). Jax rolls a `10` on the d12—scoring **10 Success Points**!
  - He spends **2 SP** to clear the 1 Aggravated Wound.
  - He spends **4 SP** to heal all 4 Light Wounds.
  - With Track I cleared of all damage, Jax instantly removes the **Impaired** condition from Strength, restoring his full combat capability! *(Jax: 2 AP remaining)*
- **Starship Self-Repair (Silas, 1 AP):** Silas straps on a vacuum harness to patch punctured titanium armor plates. Expending **1 Supply** and using his **Mechanic's Kit**, Silas rolls a **Knowledge (4) + Tinkering (2)** Simple Test (4d10): `[3, 6, 8, 9]`. Scoring two Hits (`8` and `9`), Silas welds structural patches and restores **2 Light Hull segments**, saving thousands in drydock fees. *(Silas: 2 AP remaining)*
- **Bazaar Requisitions (Tessa, 1 AP):** Tessa navigates the station's concourse to purchase a **Standard Crate of Supplies** (5 Supply for $8,000 Credits), hauling crates of protein paste, filters, and coolant back to the cargo bay. *(Tessa: 2 AP remaining)*

Operative / Vessel	Pre-Shift Status	Morning Resolution	Post-Shift State
Jax (Marine)	4 Light, 1 Aggravated Wound	Clinic Long Rest (10 SP)	**Fully Healed** (0 Wounds)
Silas (Engineer)	-2 Light Hull Segments	Tinkering Test (2 Hits)	**Hull Repaired** (-1 Supply)
Tessa (Pilot)	0 Supplies in Cargo Hold	Bazaar Purchase ($8,000)	**+5 Supplies** in Hold

OPERATIONAL TRIAGE // MEDICAL & REPAIR PRIORITY

Notice how the crew prioritized survival in Shift 1. If Jax had delayed medical care, his Impaired Strength would have degraded any physical freelance gig. Concurrently, patching hull segments and purchasing supplies restored the ship's runway before any personal projects were attempted.

SHIFT 2: AFTERNOON ENDEAVORS (3 AP SPENT)

At 16:00, the crew disperses across Port Zenith's commercial decks to pursue personal conditioning, study, and freelance cash:

- **Physical Conditioning (Jax, 1 AP):** Jax hits the station's centrifuge gymnasium, running high-G interval sprints to build explosive power. Spending 1 Day-to-Day AP awards Jax **1 Experience Point (1 XP)**, reaching his daily training ceiling of 1 XP/day. *(Jax: 1 AP remaining)*
- **Freelance Gig #01: Lost Featherwing (Silas, 1 AP):** Silas accepts an odd job from a wealthy merchant to capture an escaped iridescent songbird. Climbing into the station's overhead utility crawlways with acoustic monitors, Silas rolls an **Instinct (4) + Knowledge (4)** Simple Test (4d10): `[5, 8, 8, 10]`—three Hits! Silas lures the bird with synthetic whistle chirps, collecting a **$1,000 Credits** payout ($500 base + 2×$250 bonus). *(Silas: 1 AP remaining)*
- **Freelance Gig #05: Synthwave Bouncer (Tessa, 1 AP):** Tessa takes a security shift at "Sub-Zero," a neon-lit nightclub. Rolling **Strength (3) + Presence (4)** (4d10): `[2, 7, 8, 9]`—two Hits! Tessa disarms a belligerent belter miner and secures the exit, earning **$750 Credits** ($500 base + $250 bonus). *(Tessa: 1 AP remaining)*

SHIFT 3: NIGHT SHIFT (3 AP SPENT)

As Port Zenith dims its promenade lighting to simulate nightfall, the crew concludes their remaining operational shifts:

- **Freelance Gig #02: Spacer Stand-Up (Jax, 1 AP):** Jax grabs the open mic at "The Rusted Anchor," rolling **Presence (4) + Presence (4)** (4d10): `[4, 7, 8, 9]`—two Hits! His dry, deadpan military stories about Flotilla ration mix-ups earn roaring spacer laughs and **$750 Credits**. *(Jax: 0 AP remaining)*
- **Technical Study (Silas, 1 AP):** Silas reviews encrypted jump-beacon telemetry, earning **1 Experience Point (1 XP)** towards higher Astrogation skills. *(Silas: 0 AP remaining)*
- **Flight Simulator Drills (Tessa, 1 AP):** Strapped into a motion-rig trainer, Tessa runs emergency RCS maneuvers, earning **1 Experience Point (1 XP)**. *(Tessa: 0 AP remaining)*

END OF THE ROUND: THE 24-HOUR HEARTBEAT

Exactly 24 hours elapse aboard Port Zenith as all 9 Day-to-Day Action Points are resolved. The GM executes the universal end-of-round heartbeat:

1. **Consuming Supplies:** The vessel deducts **1 Supply** from the hold. Having bought 5 Supplies and spent 1 on repair, the hold finishes at **4 Supplies remaining** (4 days operating runway).
2. **Refilling Action Points:** With life support fully sustained, all three operatives refill their pools back to **3 Day-to-Day AP** for the upcoming day.
3. **Advancing the World Clock:** The station calendar advances by one day. New mission contracts arrive via Corsair commlink.

Operative	Credits Earned	Credits Spent	XP Progression	Final Status
Jax	+$750 (Stand-Up)	$0 (Covered)	+1 XP (Athletics)	Fully Healed, Unimpaired
Silas	+$1,000 (Featherwing)	-$1 Supply (Repairs)	+1 XP (Astrogation)	Hull Restored (+2 Light)
Tessa	+$750 (Bouncer)	-$8,000 (5 Supplies)	+1 XP (Piloting)	4 Supplies in Cargo Hold

Transitioning Back to Tactical Pacing: Once the 24-hour heartbeat resolves, the GM transitions the table from macro Day-to-Day pacing back to Place-to-Place (for interplanetary burns and approach vectors) or Moment-to-Moment tactical action the moment the crew accepts their next high-threat contract dispatch.

OPERATIONAL DEBRIEF // DOWNTIME INVARIANTS

1. The 3 AP Economy: Dividing 24 hours into three 8-hour shifts gives players tactical flexibility between medical rest, ship maintenance, training, and gigs.

2. Condition Recovery: Clearing a damaged track instantly strips the debilitating Impaired or Crippled condition from that attribute.

3. Advancement Pacing: The strict 1 XP/day training limit prevents artificial grinding, anchoring progression to real operational contracts.

NEXT: PART IV • WORLDS OF THE SPHERE

With the operational systems of Part III complete—spanning personal hardware, voidcraft, and station downtime—the rulebook bridges into the vast celestial theater of the setting through the fiction interlude *Space Tourism*, followed by the definitive planetary gazetteer and faction dossiers of the Sphere.

SPACE TOURISM

A CORSAIR STORY • FICTION INTERLUDE

The red dust of Suncatcher did not merely settle; it had ambitions.

It was a fine, iron-heavy powder with the consistency of pulverized emery paper and the persistence of a junior tax collector. It bypassed atmospheric airlock gaskets, insinuated itself into the lubricated ball bearings of heavy mining crawlers, and had long since established permanent colonies inside the socks of every human being who had ever set foot on the moon. If you lived in Dustwall long enough, you learned that your teeth never quite touched without a faint, dry crunch, and that attempting to maintain a clean white shirt was legally classified as an act of municipal insanity.

Which was why Tessa, standing on the observation walkway of the city's Great Wall with an adjustable hydraulic spanner tucked into her tool belt, was staring at her client with the slow, horrified fascination of an engineer watching someone pour fine sugar into a reactor intake.

"It is magnificent," Valis said.

Valis was an Ancestral from Irul'lia, which meant he was tall, possessed the pale, alabaster grace of an uncarved marble statue, and moved with the serene, effortless balance of a species that had spent several hundred thousand years never once having to sprint to catch a bus. He was dressed in shimmering, high-collared silks woven from radiotrophic taiga ferns—a garment that on Irul would have commanded the respectful silence of a cathedral. Over this, however, Valis had draped an aggressively loud, short-sleeved cotton vest printed with violent neon-yellow citrus fruits and electric-blue silhouettes of dancing Newcomer musicians. He had bought it three days ago at a street stall on Avon 2, and he wore it with the unshakeable dignity of an emperor wearing a coronation mantle. Hanging around his slender neck was a digital holocam slate—a sleek, brushed-alloy device with a high-resolution optical sensor and a glowing glass interface.

"It's a slag heap, Valis," Tessa said wearily, wiping a smudge of grease from her protective goggles. Tessa was a third-generation crawler mechanic from Dustwall, which meant she viewed scenery primarily in terms of its abrasive index and tensile strength. Since taking a Corsair charter and flying corvettes for the Flotilla, she had seen planetary rings, binary eclipses, and the cold, terrifying majesty of deep-void dreadnoughts. None of them, in her professional opinion, justified wearing a lemon-patterned vest in an industrial mining settlement. "It's four million tons of low-grade basalt tailings dumped out by the primary smelter. Even with the Great Wall out here holding back the worst of the desert sandstorms, enough grit drifts over the parapet to turn your fancy silk trousers into thirty-grit sandpaper."

Valis tapped the slate's glass face, the capture saving into memory with a soft pulse of light while a miniature preview floated above the screen. "A monument to honest exertion," Valis corrected pleasantly, admiring the sharp capture on his display. "In the Upper Spires of Irul'lia, our refuse is dissolved at the molecular level by harmonic resonance scrubbers. It is exceedingly tidy, of course, but it completely lacks drama. One never gets the impression that anyone had to sweat to achieve it. Here, the struggle between mortal will and stubborn geology is written upon the very horizon. Look at that glorious mechanical behemoth!"

He pointed a slender, immaculate finger across the open mining basin beyond the wall. Half a mile away, shuddering through the heat shimmer of midday, rose *The Gilded Bore*. It was a bucket-wheel excavator the size of a municipal hospital, its six-story steel wheel chewing rhythmically into the red sandstone cliff with a relentless, bone-shaking rhythmic crunch that vibrated straight through the soles of Tessa's magnetic work boots. Great plumes of reddish-black silica billowed from its exhaust stacks, catching the harsh glare of the sun before settling back down toward the desert plains.

"That," Tessa muttered, "is fourteen thousand tons of un-greased scrap metal that breaks an axle every Tuesday shift. If my father hadn't retired to Crossroads to grow plums, he'd be down in that gear-box right now with a cutting torch, swearing in four different colonial dialects."

"Fascinating," Valis breathed, his golden eyes wide with sincere delight. "Your father must be an artist of extraordinary temperament. Shall we descend into the concourse? My itinerary indicates that we are scheduled to inspect the municipal market before the celestial occlusion."

Tessa sighed, tapped the environmental gauge on her forearm console, and unlatched the heavy transit hatch leading down from the battlements. "Mind the steps. And for the love of the stars, Valis, if anyone offers to sell you an 'authentic Precursor cooling rod' out of a wheelbarrow, keep your hands in your pockets. It's just a spray-painted radiator core from an old tractor."

The lower commercial concourse of Dustwall was less of an open street and more of a heavily fortified industrial thoroughfare sheltered behind the city's colossal outer barrier. Though Suncatcher possessed a breathable atmosphere like every terraformed moon across the Sphere, its dry, low-humidity air carried an iron bite, and its surface took the brunt of extreme thermal swings. When the sun hung high, the iron plains outside baked into shimmering heat traps, driving the populace into the shaded lower concourses and deep-chilled foundry tunnels. Overhead, massive yellow pipes hissed with pressurized ammonia coolant, sweating condensation into rusted drip-pans that local urchins guarded like gold mines.

The air smelled intensely of scorched machine oil, sulfurous slag, boiled cabbage, and the bitter, roasted chicory beverage that the local Craggen miners drank by the gallon. Painted in peeling white stencils above every pressure door was the Consortium's solemn civic creed: *Respect the Vent, Guard the Seal, Mind the Gauge.*

Valis strolled through the clamor like an immortal prince inspecting a particularly lively country fair. To the miners, dockhands, and heavy equipment haulers crowding the concourse, he was a spectacle of alarming proportions. Craggen stone-carvers—small, dense folk barely four feet tall, like lean, gnomish dark iron dwarves with skin of chisel-marked basalt and eyes like glowing cut garnets—paused with their mugs of chicory halfway to their stony lips, squinting up in disbelief at Valis's radiant silk robe and loud tourist vest. Slender Naga pipe-fitters coiled along overhead steam conduits flicked their forked tongues, their neck crests flushing a bewildered indigo.

"Greetings!" Valis announced cheerfully to a table of four heavily muscled human drillers whose hazard suits were caked in red grit. "May your thermal conduits remain unimpeded and your extraction quotas bring spiritual harmony to your lineage!"

The drillers stared at him in dead silence. One of them slowly looked down at his own grease-blackened wrench, then back up at Valis's immaculate face, and finally over at Tessa.

"Relative of yours, Tess?" the driller asked in a voice like two gravel trucks colliding.

"Diplomatic contract, Brant," Tessa said flatly, keeping one hand resting casually on the butt of her sidearm. "He's an Ancestral scholar. He looks, he takes pictures, he doesn't touch anything, and the Flotilla pays my docking fees for three months. Go back to your soup."

Brant grunted, shook his head, and went back to sawing through a piece of synthetic salt-beef that looked capable of deflecting a railgun slug.

"They possess remarkable physical density," Valis observed quietly as they moved past a row of sputtering kerosene cook-stoves. "And a very direct economy. I noticed Brant did not offer to exchange digital credits. He had a brass token stamped with an anvil."

"Caldera Foundry scrip," Tessa said, steering him deftly around an open drainage sump where greasy wastewater gurgled beneath iron grating. "You work a twelve-hour shift at the smelting furnaces, the company credits your slate. But out here in the rim-blocks, the comm-relays cut out whenever a solar flare clips the magnetosphere. So the company mints brass chits. You buy your water with foundry brass, you rent your bunk with foundry brass, and when you die, the foundry charges your next-of-kin three chits to recycle your hazard suit. It's not spiritual harmony, Valis. It's a closed-loop accounting trap."

Valis paused, tapping a quick note onto his slate. "A fascinating mechanism of societal continuity. On Irul'lia, we have no chits. When one requires a garment, or a meal of radiotrophic moss-loaf, one simply presents oneself at the Distribution Spires. The Triumvirate maintains the quotas, the automated dynamos produce the goods, and everyone receives precisely what was allotted to their generational cohort three thousand years ago."

Tessa stopped dead on the metal decking and turned to look at him. "You mean nobody argues about the bill?"

"Never," Valis said, genuinely puzzled by the suggestion. "Why would one argue with a dynamo? The dynamo is a holy instrument left to us by the Precursors. To suggest it has under-delivered would be an impious critique of paradise."

Tessa rubbed the bridge of her nose, right where her goggles had left a deep red groove in her skin. "I swear, Valis, half the fun of buying a bowl of noodles in Dustwall is spending ten minutes telling the cook his broth tastes like bilge water until he knocks two copper bits off the price."

"A ritual contest of determination," Valis noted solemnly, nodding as if he had just uncovered a profound cosmic truth. "I shall record that in my dissertation."

At the eastern edge of the concourse, where the steel overhangs opened out into a wide, dusty recreation lot sheltered by the inner curve of the Great Wall, a tremendous uproar echoed across the yard. It was not the sound of an industrial accident, nor the panicked shouting that accompanied a breached pressure line. It was the distinct, full-throated, profoundly joyous roar of forty off-shift workers watching a sporting contest. Valis's eyes lit up. Before Tessa could grab his festival vest, he had already glided through the perimeter gate and into the yard.

The lot was a flat, unpaved stretch of red sandlot, bounded by an old chain-link fence and a row of parked maintenance crawlers. Across the dirt, someone had laid out a textbook baseball diamond: four canvas bags anchored with steel pegs, sixty feet apart, with lines of white gypsum chalk marking out the baselines.

In the batter's box stood a wiry, three-meter Naga mechanic wearing a backwards cap, his long muscular tail coiled for balance as he rested a smoothed ash-wood bat across his scaly shoulder. Sixty feet away on the pitcher's mound, Marik, a lean, compact Craggen drill-operator in a grease-stained undershirt—scarcely coming up to an ordinary man's chest, but built like a solid block of dark cast iron—was palming a scuffed, red-stitched baseball with his chisel-carved stone fingers. Behind the plate, an elderly human umpire in dusty denim squatted behind a wire catcher's mask, his knuckles resting on his knees.

"Come on, Ssaros!" a woman on the team bench shouted, rattling the chain-link fence. "Put the wood on it! Two outs, bottom of the seventh, bring the runners home!"

The Craggen pitcher nodded, shook off a sign, and dropped into a low, coiled windup. His dense basalt arm whipped forward like a leaf-spring, hurling the ball with a sharp, spinning hiss. Fastball, belt-high, right over the heart of the plate. The Naga batter didn't hesitate. His tail uncoiled like a steel spring, driving his torso through a clean, picture-perfect swing.

The solid, unmistakable crack of hardwood meeting leather rang out across the entire yard. The ball launched into the thin desert air in a soaring, majestic arc, climbing higher and higher into the sunlight, sailing clean over the outfielders' reaching gloves, over the chain-link fence, and clearing the corrugated roof of a storage shed two hundred feet away.

"IT'S GONE!" the crowd shrieked in unison. "HOME RUN!" the umpire bellowed, pumping his fist into the air with theatrical gusto.

The entire bench cleared. Off-shift miners, mechanics, and weld-inspectors swarmed out into the dust, cheering, laughing, and banging metal lunchboxes against the fence posts. The two runners on base trotted home, followed by Ssaros, who rounded third base with a wide, triumphant grin, casually tossing his bat aside before slapping hands with half the spectators.

Valis stood at the edge of the fence, his digital slate chiming softly as he captured a burst of high-speed photos. His face was flushed with pure, incandescent wonder. "Old Earth baseball," Valis whispered reverently. "The sacred liturgy of the diamond."

Tessa leaned against a fence post, crossing her arms with an amused grin. "You know about this?"

"Of course!" Valis said, his eyes shining as he scrolled through the photos of the laughing players. "On Avon 2, during the Festival of the Solstice, the Newcomer communities clear temporary diamonds on the moss plains. I spent two whole cycles studying the archives. It is an astonishing sociological phenomenon, Tessa. Your ancestors crossed the lightless void in great cryogenic arks, carrying the sum total of human wisdom—quantum mechanics, cellular synthesis, stellar navigation—and nestled right alongside those monumental truths, they brought the rules for hitting a stitched leather ball with a piece of wood."

"My grandfather used to play third base for the Caldera Foundry team," Tessa said, a faint, nostalgic smirk tugging at the corner of her mouth. "He broke his collarbone sliding into home plate during the 502 AA championship against the Water Harvesters. He kept the bent cleat on his mantelpiece until the day he died. Said it was the proudest day of his life."

"Why?" Valis asked, genuinely enthralled. "What did he win? A concession of territory? A reduction in labor tariffs?"

"A battered tin cup that leaked from the bottom," Tessa replied. "And the right to call the Water Harvester foreman a blind idiot in the commissary for twelve months without getting punched."

Valis watched as the three-meter Naga batter coiled triumphantly down in the dust, grinning from ear to ear as a pack of compact Craggen teammates swarmed around him to pound his scaly ribs and dump a cup of cold water over his head.

"It is sublime," Valis murmured. "In our archives, we have records of another human pastime—the game of *Chess*. Two kings, two queens, four bishops, four knights, four castles, and sixteen pawns, all locked upon a sixty-four-square grid of black and white stone. Two elderly scholars will sit across a table for four hours in absolute, agonizing silence, contemplating whether a carved wooden horse should jump in the shape of an 'L'. And when the horse finally jumps, the other scholar groans as if he has suffered a mortal wound to his soul."

"Silas plays chess," Tessa said. "Our crew's tech specialist. Spends half his downtime on the ship staring at a little magnetic board, rubbing his chin. Drives Jax crazy. Jax just wants to hit things with his boarding axe."

"Do you not see the genius of it?" Valis turned to her, his long fingers gesturing toward the celebrating ballplayers. "Your people have engineered a civilization where survival is precarious, unpredictable, and often deeply unfair. The rock breaks when it should hold; the air scrubber fails when you need to breathe; the Flotilla passes laws you did not vote for. And so, to keep from screaming into the dark, you invent tiny, artificial universes where the rules are absolute, entirely arbitrary, and completely meaningless. You draw a line in the red dust, you declare that hitting a ball over a shed is a moment of pure triumph, and for two hours, you can celebrate with all your heart about something that has no consequence whatsoever. It is a vaccine against despair."

Tessa looked at the laughing miners, watching the losing team hand over a handful of brass foundry chits with good-natured grumbling. "I never thought about it like that," she admitted slowly. "I just thought miners liked having an excuse to hit things and drink beer after a ten-hour shift."

"That too," Valis smiled gently. "Pragmatism and poetry are frequently roommates in mortal history."

They left the ballgame behind and climbed a broad iron staircase to the upper parapet of the Dust Wall. Here, high above the rooftops, the industrial rumble of Dustwall faded into a steady, distant thrum. The view opened out into the vast, terrible grandeur of the Suncatcher badlands: wind-carved sandstone plateaus and crimson dunes stretching toward a jagged horizon, shimmering beneath a blistering sun that hung in the deep-blue sky like an unshielded fusion torch.

They sat down on an iron bench welded directly to the parapet stanchions. Tessa pulled a battered thermos from her pack, unscrewed the cap, and poured two cups of steaming, dark-brown chicory. She handed one to Valis. He took it with two hands, inhaling the bitter, roasted steam. He took a tiny, polite sip, paused, and blinked.

"It tastes," Valis said carefully, "as though someone burned a pine cone, ground it into dust, and boiled it in battery acid."

"That's the high-grade stuff," Tessa grinned. "The cheap stuff strips the enamel off your molars. Drink up. It keeps the dust from sticking to your throat."

Valis took another sip, his face settling into an expression of stoic academic endurance. "Tell me, Tessa. As a Corsair who travels between the spheres... how do your people endure the leaders of these worlds? From Irul'lia, Newcomer civilization appears less like a government and more like a collection of very stubborn arguments drifting in parallel orbits."

Tessa chuckled into her cup. "That's because it *is* an argument, Valis. That's the whole point."

She leaned back against the iron railing, looking out toward the horizon where the sun was beginning to touch the distant purple rim of Nimbus.

"Take Crossroads," Tessa began. "Down on Landfall. You've got the High Council. Speaker Jesse Haddon sits at a cedar table he built himself thirty years ago, surrounded by five lineage delegates who would rather eat broken glass than agree on a property tax. When they want to dig a drainage ditch behind the orchard, they don't just dig it. They hold three public readings. They commission an environmental impact report to make sure the local river beetles won't get offended. They spend four hours debating whether the rocket shuttles taking off from the south field are blowing too much soot onto the town councilwoman's clean bedsheets."

Valis smiled faintly. "And does anyone listen?"

"Oh, everyone listens," Tessa said. "Especially Goldheart. The old dragon sits on the council terrace with his chin on the marble railing, eating roasted apples and chiming in whenever he feels like it. If the councilors start yelling at each other, Goldheart lets out a little rumble that rattles the tea cups and reminds them that haste is the enemy of good manners. It takes six months to pave a street, but nobody gets shot, nobody starves, and the bedsheets stay reasonably white."

"A deliberative democracy tempered by draconic avuncularity," Valis noted. "Charming. And Nimbus?"

Tessa's expression shifted. "Cloudspire is a different beast entirely. It's a pure, hyper-capitalist technocracy wrapped in neon and rain, all perched across high-altitude plateaus. The Arcology Directorate runs the show—corporate consortiums, precision avionics cartels, and high-frequency data exchanges where money moves at the speed of light."

"Altitude is status, corporate shares are law, and half the city's engineers spend eighteen hours a day trying to patent a faster circuit."

"And does anyone govern their ambitions?" Valis asked.

"Stormdrinker," Tessa said, nodding toward the sky. "The Scholar Dragon. He perches high above the Cloudspire towers, watching everything with eyes like lightning storms. The corporations might own the patents and the trading floors, but Stormdrinker holds the ultimate veto. If the boardrooms get too reckless or start digging into forbidden research that threatens the sky, the dragon steps in with the weight of an empire. It's a cutthroat capitalist jungle, but it stays standing because a five-hundred-year-old cosmic scholar has a very heavy thumb on the scale."

"A technocratic oligarchy monitored by an ancient draconic sovereign," Valis whispered, his golden eyes narrowing in quiet fascination. "A precarious equilibrium of ledger books and apex power."

"And then you have Pelagia," Tessa continued, waving her cup toward the sky where the water-world drifted in co-orbital harmony. "Ruled by Land Barons who had the capital to create their artificial islands as their own little kingdoms. Whatever natural land there is though is kind of like Nimbus just without any dragons, and with more water."

"And the Orks?" Valis asked.

"The Orks don't have councils," Tessa snorted. "They have an emperor. And slavery. And violence. Lots of it. I don't know how he does it but Vrakketh manages to steer all of that frenzy in the direction he points his finger at and they listen to him. Must be one hell of an ork," she said, then paused—"Not that I don't hate his guts like everybody on this side of the DMZ."

"And the void between them?" Valis asked, gesturing toward the stars. "The Flotilla that brought me here?"

"The Flotilla has the Admiralty Board," Tessa said. "Twelve line admirals sitting in high-orbit command dreadnoughts, looking at radar boards and casualty charts."

"And here?" Valis looked down at the iron rooftops and smoking flues of the concourse below. "Who governs this moon?"

Tessa looked out over the parapet, her eyes softening as she watched the distant dust plumes on the plain. "Nobody."

Valis blinked in surprise. "Nobody?"

"Suncatcher isn't a state, Valis. It's just a scatter of mining settlements and drilling camps trying to get by in the red dust. The Badlands out there are a lawless, sun-baked meat grinder where rogue crawlers fight over water wells and scrap. But in Dustwall... there are no politics. No corporate boardrooms, no lineage delegates, no taxes. The whole reason we're organized is that folks asked the best man they knew for the job to be Aldorman—old Aldorman Grady. He's a retired bore-mechanic, rough around the edges, with hands like iron anvils and a voice like a rockslide. But he's fair, honest, and good and proper. When folks have a dispute over a smelting quota or a water valve, they take it to Grady's porch, he listens, he spits in the dust, and he gives an answer. And people listen because he earned it."

"And the law?" Valis asked, genuinely enthralled. "Who enforces the Aldorman's judgments?"

"The Dustwall Rovers," Tessa said, nodding toward the lower gate where two riders in long canvas dusters were checking the latch on a tracked buggy, heavy steel bolas and carbines slung from their saddles. "They're not funded by any planetary budget. Most of them are rough-and-tumble locals, vagabonds, and grease-monkeys with a sharper moral compass than most. The community volunteers food, foundry scrip, and spare parts to keep them supplied because everybody knows they're just and trustworthy."

"If a crawler breaks down in a silica storm, or a bandit pack creeps in from the dunes, the Rovers ride out and handle it. Out in the Badlands, it's every soul for themselves. But here behind the wall... folks figured out that looking after each other was the only way not to drown in the grit."

Valis smiled warmly, resting his chin on his hands. "A commonwealth of mutual trust. How remarkably fragile... and how profoundly noble."

Tessa took a long drink of her chicory, wiping her mouth with the back of her glove. She looked over at the elegant, silk-clad Ancestral beside her. "Alright, bright-vest," she said. "I've laid out the whole messy circus. Now tell me about your lot. You've got six worlds of pristine spires in X'ara. You've got automated dynamos that never break down, cities where nobody yells, and fleets of silent ships with hard-light lances that could skewer a Flotilla cruiser before the captain finished reading his morning orders. Who runs the show on Irul?"

Valis set his cup down on the iron rail. He looked up at the sky, his expression shifting into something quiet, reverent, and ancient. "The Elder," Valis said softly.

"The Archon?" Tessa asked. "We hear rumors in the Flotilla corridors. An immortal ruler living deep inside the capital."

"He is not merely a ruler, Tessa," Valis said, his voice dropping to a melodious murmur. "He is our living father. Our revered god. When our civilization awoke from the long darkness millions of years ago, it was the Elder who gathered our ancestors. He taught us that the Sphere was not an accidental formation of cosmic gravity, but a sacred sanctuary constructed by the Precursors—the First Builders—and bequeathed to us, their chosen inheritors, so that we might dwell in everlasting peace."

Tessa raised an eyebrow. "And where does this Elder live? In a palace of solid diamond?"

Valis smiled—a small, enigmatic curve of his lips. "He lives everywhere. And nowhere. The Elder possesses the divine gift of wandering. He does not sit upon a golden throne surrounded by guards. He walks among us. He may take the form of an elderly gardener pruning the radiotrophic taiga on the northern slopes. He may be a weary traveler seeking shelter at a waystation in the glass plains of Irul'oa. He may be the quiet scholar reading an ancient scroll in the corner of the Great Scriptorium."

Tessa stared at him. "You're telling me your god wanders the streets in disguise? Like an Old Earth myth?"

"Precisely like your myths of Zeus or Odin," Valis nodded. "It is the foundational ethic of our entire culture. In Ancestral society, you never raise your voice to a stranger. You never turn away a traveler who asks for bread. You never strike a servant or mock an artisan. Because that humble individual, sweeping the dust from the marble portico, could be the Elder himself, testing the purity of your virtue."

Tessa let out a low whistle. "Damn. That's a hell of a way to keep people polite."

"It does ensure profound civility," Valis agreed. "And while the Elder is away—dwelling unrecognized amongst the populace, tending gardens or wandering the mountain trails—our world is administered by the **Triumvirate of the Firstborn**."

"And what do they do?"

"Nothing," Valis said simply.

Tessa blinked. "Nothing?"

"Their sacred charge," Valis explained, "is the preservation of the Sacred Vigil. Their duty is not to legislate, nor to reform, nor to conquer. Their duty is to ensure that tomorrow is mathematically, architecturally, and spiritually identical to yesterday. They ensure the dynamos continue to hum. They ensure the spires remain upright. They ensure that no new laws are written, no old traditions are broken, and that our people do not fall into the fatal sin of mortal ambition."

He looked out over the sprawling iron roofs and smelting towers of Dustwall, watching a heavy tracked crawler rumble through the streets below, its warning sirens wailing as it hauled a sixty-ton ingot of glowing iron toward the railhead. "It is a paradise, Tessa," Valis said softly. "It is peaceful. It is eternal. It is flawless. And it is completely, utterly suffocating."

Tessa turned her head, surprised by the sudden edge in his voice. "Suffocating?"

"Do you know why I wear this ridiculous vest?" Valis asked, touching the bright lemon pattern with a self-deprecating smile. "Do you know why I boarded a Flotilla transport and crossed ninety million kilometers of void just to inhale iron dust on a mining rock? I visited **Avon 2**," Valis murmured. "Across the binary gap from Avon 1, where the Pure Blade hawks sharpen their hard-light spears and preach hatred of Newcomer vulgarity. I stood in the Newcomer festival plaza during the solstice. I saw your people dancing. Humans, nagas, craggens, sylvans, elves, and drakelings, all linked arm-in-arm, drinking cheap fermented cider, laughing until their sides ached, shouting over the rules of a ballgame, and singing songs about ancient Earth mountains they have never seen."

He picked up his digital slate, running his thumb over the sleek glass casing. "On Irul'lia, nothing ever begins, and nothing ever ends. We have achieved perfection, and in doing so, we have frozen our history in amber. But here... on Landfall, on Nimbus, on Pelagia, even here behind the Dust Wall on Suncatcher... your people are imperfect. You argue. You bleed. You build cities that fall down, and then you rebuild them with better bricks. You invent games where grown men celebrate over a stitched leather ball. You have so little time, and so much dust, and yet you live with such frantic, desperate, magnificent joy. That is why I am a tourist, Tessa. On Irul'lia, I am an immortal statue waiting for eternity to notice me. Here, I am merely a traveler with dirty shoes. And it is the most extraordinary thing I have ever experienced."

A deep, mournful horn echoed across the high wall parapet. Across the afternoon sky, the colossal purple curve of **Nimbus** was sliding cleanly across the face of the sun. The blazing heat-shimmer over the desert basin wavered, collapsed, and vanished into a bruised twilight of deep amber and violet. The Pause had arrived.

Along the perimeter of Dustwall, the automated gas streetlamps lit with a staggered series of muffled pops, flickering in the icy breeze rushing across the cooling stone. Tessa pulled her heavy canvas jacket tighter around her chest, feeling the sharp drop in temperature against her cheeks. She smiled, picked up her thermos, and stood up. "Well, Valis, that's the eclipse. The rock will freeze to minus ten, and if we don't get inside, our chicory will turn into an icicle."

Valis stood beside her, pointing his optical sensor at Tessa—standing in her scuffed work suit, wrench in her belt, the vast purple shadow of Nimbus towering over her shoulder—and tapped the screen. The display flashed softly. "A splendid composition," Valis said happily. "Shall we proceed to the commissary? I understand they serve a dish called a 'pastrami sandwich' that is eaten entirely by hand, with no regard for finger cleanliness whatsoever."

Tessa was about to reply when two shadows detached themselves from a nearby recessed service alcove.

Her immediate instinct was mild, professional irritation. Flotilla inspectors had a tedious habit of showing up at planetary gates to check cargo manifests and demand maintenance logs right when a shift was ending. But as the two men stepped into the dim, amber glow of the gas lamp, a quiet note of wariness edged into her mind. They wore the charcoal-grey overcoats of fleet officers, their high collars fastened with polished silver clasps. But regular line officers did not look like this. Line officers who spent nine months a year in the void had frayed cuffs, coffee stains on their flight manuals, and that perpetually rumpled, exhausted look that came from sleeping in pressurized bunks next to a thrumming reactor core.

These two men had coats without a single fold or wrinkle. Their black boots were polished to a mirror shine that had clearly never touched Suncatcher's red dirt until about ten minutes ago. And on their lapels, the silver double-chevrons of the Transit Wing were completely, unnervingly blank. No division rockers. No squadron numerals. No ship crests. Every line officer Tessa had ever served with during her One-Year Tour would rather have their ears boxed by a boatswain than walk around without their ship's colors.

The lead officer stopped a polite two paces away, clasping his gloved hands loosely behind his back. He had clean, angular features, short iron-grey hair, and the calm, practiced smile of an accountant reviewing an overdue bill. "Operative Thorne," the man said. His voice was smooth, cultured, and devoid of any recognizable accent. "A pleasant evening on the rim. We trust your excursion has been informative?"

Hearing her name spoken by a stranger on a deserted gantry made her skin prickle. Her right thumb casually hooked into her work belt beside the heavy steel handle of her hydraulic spanner. "Pleasant enough," Tessa said, keeping her tone flat, careful, and unhurried. "Though usually when Transit inspectors come down to the surface, it's because a fuel lighter took out a communication relay. You're a long way from orbit, Commander."

"Special assignment," the officer replied, reaching smoothly into his coat to produce a slim, brushed-alloy data slate. "The Admiralty Board has been monitoring your charter with great interest. Given the delicate geopolitical posture across the Avon frontier, Central Command has determined that an Ancestral scholar touring an unsecured civilian mining colony presents an unacceptable risk."

He offered the slate. Across the glass display, official Flotilla cryptographic seals pulsed in steady green hashes—an emergency custody requisition stamped by Fleet Intelligence. "We have an enclosed diplomatic transport waiting on the outer freight spur," the second officer added quietly, stepping slightly to the flank to narrow Tessa's path to the airlock. "Climate-controlled, full medical suite, direct burn to Redmane Station. We'll relieve you of Scholar Valis from here, Operative. Your cell will receive full contracted disbursement, plus a twenty-percent administrative hazard bonus credited to your registry tonight."

It was all so agonizingly reasonable. Yet something was off. "The outer freight spur?" Tessa asked, her brow furrowing. "That's an unmonitored pad for bulk ore barges. The fleet landing hub is over by the main concourse."

The lead officer's smile didn't waver. "Discretion is paramount, Operative. Public berths attract unwanted observation."

She looked closer at the display in his hands. "And this authorization hash. Admiral Kaelen's office. Kaelen's division was folded into Logistics right after the Frontier War."

"A legacy administrative routing," the officer answered without hesitation. "Standard protocol for high-classification handovers. Please instruct your ward to collect his belongings."

Every response was instant, seamless, and completely flat. Not a flicker of irritation. Just frictionless, rehearsed perfection. And that was when the cold settled into her bones: *Shadow Wing.* The phantom branch that officially had no ships, no personnel, and no budget, but whose agents always showed up when a defector or an alien artifact needed to vanish. If these men took Valis, he was never reaching Redmane Station. They would dissect his understanding of Precursor physics in an unmarked asteroid lab.

Tessa looked at Valis, smiling by the rail at a flock of dust-crows in the twilight. *Damn it.* Walking him into a slaughterhouse to pay her hangar fees would rot her soul.

"I don't think so, Commander," Tessa said, keeping her tone casual despite the cold sweat prickling her collar. "Why don't we ask Valis who he wants to keep escorting him? An Ancestral scholar traveling on a registered visa... dragging him to an unmonitored spur sounds diplomatically messy."

Valis beamed, clasping his hands: "Most astute! Operative Thorne has proven an exceptionally attentive guide. Furthermore, we have an urgent culinary appointment at the concourse commissary for a pastrami sandwich. I respectfully decline your shuttle, gentlemen."

"Operative Thorne," the lead officer murmured softly, all pretense stripped away. "Do not allow sentimental delusions to shorten your lifespan." The second officer's hand slid beneath his coat toward a concealed sidearm.

The heavy airlock door swung open with a screech. Stepping out was Aldorman Grady himself in his oil-stained canvas duster, flanked by two Dustwall Rovers with cocked carbines and weighted bolas, followed by Marik the Craggen balancing a forty-pound pipe wrench, Ssaros the Naga with his ash bat, and half a dozen drillers smelling of chicory and tobacco.

"Something wrong out here, Tess?" Grady asked, his gravel voice cutting through the wind.

"This is a closed Flotilla matter, civilian," the lead operative snapped.

Grady spat chicory over the rail. "Don't know much about 'security matters,' son. Out in the void, you admiralty folks can play whatever games you like. But you're standing on Dustwall stone. If Scholar Valis wants to go inside and have a sandwich with Tess, he has a sandwich. If that hand under your coat comes out with iron in it, my Rovers are gonna wrap three pounds of lead bola around your knees and drop you forty feet into the slag sump. Now tuck your slate away."

Valis stepped between them, holding up his slate: "Officers! Before you depart, you simply must permit me to capture a photographic likeness! The brooding severity of your charcoal tailoring against this raw industrialism—hold that splendid expression of constitutional vigilance!" Valis tapped the display. The flash flared bright.

Slowly, the lead officer pocketed his slate. "Enjoy your dinner, Operative Thorne. Do keep your ward close. Accidents on the frontier are difficult to anticipate." The two phantoms turned and melted silently into the dark.

Tessa grabbed the railing to steady her shaking knees. Grady squeezed her shoulder: "Good spine, Tess. Your grandfather would've done the same. Come on inside."

"Come on, tourist," Tessa said, steering Valis through the hatch. "Let's get that pastrami sandwich before someone starts an interplanetary war over your scrapbook."

"Splendid!" Valis exclaimed, striding into the warm concourse in his radiant lemon vest. "And remember, Tessa—extra mustard. A proper cultural immersion requires one to risk genuine physical consequence."

ACT IV • THE WORLDS OF THE SPHERE

The journey continues across the celestial heavens. Turn the page to enter **Chapter 07: Worlds of the Sphere**—exploring the macro-engineering of the clockwork system, the planetary gazetteers of the Fume and X'ara clusters, the five-century timeline, and the sovereign faction dossiers of the civilized void.

WORLDS OF THE SPHERE

THE SETTING AT A GLANCE

Corsair is a tabletop roleplaying game of high-stakes frontier adventure, mystery, and intrigue, blending the mythic wonder of **Space Fantasy** with the grounded weight of **Hard Science Fiction**. Set within the **Sphere**—a breathtaking, macro-engineered solar system featuring more than a hundred habitable worlds locked in tight binary orbits around colossal gas giants—the setting pairs ancient cosmic dragons, forgotten alien vaults, and diverse lineages with the tangible reality of sub-light orbital mechanics and kinetic weaponry.

You and your crew play a **Corsair Cell**: licensed, independent operatives flying a nimble starship with a cross-jurisdictional charter. When planetary law ends at the clouds and the naval peacekeepers are light-minutes away, your sponsors call on you. Whether investigating corporate sabotage in an orbital arcology, braving hazardous Precursor ruins in search of lost technology, unmasking political conspiracies, or negotiating tense standoffs across a fraying frontier, your crew stands as the thin line holding a young civilization together.

Five hundred years ago, automated seed arks brought the survivors of four dying worlds into the Sphere. Rather than a naturally accreted stellar system, the Sphere is a marvel of celestial engineering: concentric rings of massive gas giants locked in gravitational harmony around a quiet Orange Dwarf star.

Within the magnetic shelters of these gas giants, terrestrial worlds orbit in close-knit binary pairs. Separated by mere tens of thousands of kilometers, neighboring moons hang like colossal jewels in each other's skies. Yet for all its mythic grandeur, everyday survival in the Sphere is governed by strict, tangible physical laws:

- **No Faster-Than-Light Travel:** Interplanetary transit relies entirely on continuous-thrust fusion engines burning along calculated Brachistochrone trajectories. Hopping between twin binary moons takes mere hours, while journeys across the deep void between neighboring gas giants take only a few days.
- **No Artificial Gravity:** Stations and ships obey Newtonian physics. Gravity exists only when an engine is under thrust or when an orbital station's habitat rings are spinning. Everywhere else, life is defined by magnetic boots, safety tethers, and the silent float of microgravity.
- **Kinetic and Thermal Realities:** In place of energy shields or disintegrator beams, ships and ground operatives rely on layered composite armor, point-defense lasers, and ballistic firearms. Every burning engine and fired weapon generates waste heat that must be carefully radiated into the vacuum through glowing thermal arrays.
- **The Living Dragons:** The titans of the void are not mere myths, but colossal, ancient biological entities that navigate the vacuum using internal bio-fusion dynamos. From gentle Goldheart watching over Landfall to the thunderous Stormdrinker circling the electrical storm-wells of Nimbus, dragons are sovereign beings whose presence and alliances shape the fate of entire worlds.

TEN LINEAGES, TWO PHILOSOPHIES

Newcomer civilization is composed of ten distinct lineages, reimagining classic fantasy archetypes through an evolutionary and biological lens. All trace their ancestry back to the four original seed arks: the adaptable **Humans**, the crest-bearing and cold-blooded **Naga**, the dense-skinned and crystalline-eyed **Craggen**, and the tall, chlorophyllic **Sylvan**.

Over five centuries of shared survival on Landfall and across the moons, six natural hybrid lineages took root: the draconic **Drakelings**, graceful **Elves**, ingenious **Gnomes**, stout and enduring **Dwarves**, nimble **Kobolds**, and towering **Trolls**. Yet, as the species intermingled, a profound philosophical rift divided Newcomer society:

- **Integrationism:** The dominant cultural current, championed in metropolitan melting pots like Crossroads and Cloudspire. Integrationists believe that cultural blending, shared destiny, and inter-lineage solidarity represent the true future of the Sphere.
- **Preservationism:** A traditionalist movement born from filial reverence for lost homeworlds. Preservationists maintain insular, single-lineage settlements on the outward frontiers, dedicated to keeping ancestral bloodlines, cultural rituals, and ancient languages pure to honor their forgotten ancestors.

THE LAW OF THE VOID

Order across the populated moons is governed by the **Skyline Accords**, a historic treaty ratified in 335 AA that divided civilization into two distinct realms of legal authority:

1. **The Sovereign Moons:** Planetary governments hold total jurisdiction within their atmospheric gravity wells, enforcing their own local laws, taxation, and colonial charters.
2. **The Flotilla:** A massive, neutral peacekeeping fleet that holds supreme jurisdiction over open space, orbital transfer corridors, Lagrange stations, and void shipping lanes.

While this separation prevented civil war, it created a dangerous legal seam. Smugglers, corporate raiders, rogue mercenaries, and political conspirators routinely commit crimes in planetary skies and burn into orbit, daring local authorities to chase them past their legal boundaries.

THE SKYLINE SEAM: WHY DUAL JURISDICTION EXISTS

The division was not born of idealism, but exhaustion. Following the Drift Wars in the Fume rings, colonial leaders refused to surrender orbital sovereignty to the Flotilla, while the Admiralty refused to police squabbling planetary cities. The resulting boundary—the "Karman Verge"—became both a peace line and a haven for organized crime.

THE NEW WAVE: YOUR ROLE AS CORSAIRS

To bridge this jurisdictional void, the Flotilla and colonial administrations established the **Corsairs**—autonomous specialist crews granted cross-jurisdictional mandates to operate seamlessly from planetary mud to the cold vacuum of deep orbit.

The year is **518 AA**. Exactly one decade ago, the apocalyptic Frontier War against the Orkish Empire and the catastrophic fall of the ancient alien super-dreadnought *Evergaol* shattered the Flotilla's veteran battle fleet. With naval hulls in short supply and the frontier fraying under piracy, corporate land-grabs, and border skirmishes, the High Council has issued emergency charters to recruit a **New Wave of Corsairs**.

THE CORSAIR CELL

As players, you form a **Corsair Cell**—a tight-knit crew of 3 to 5 specialists operating aboard an agile, multi-role starship. Every cell is unique: backed by multiple Sponsors (such as a naval officer, a governor, a corporation, or an independent union) to preserve operational neutrality. Supervised by an Oversight Committee of retired veteran Corsairs and civilian delegates, your cell enjoys total freedom of approach across the void.

THE CORSAIRS OF THE SPHERE

The Corsair system was established to manage jurisdictional friction between the **Flotilla** and the **Sovereign Moons**. It provides a mechanism for cross-jurisdictional operations in cases where local laws and orbital regulations overlap. Corsairs are operatives granted a cross-jurisdictional mandate to operate in both planetary and orbital environments.

BACKGROUND AND ORIGINS

The Corsairs originated as a specialized division within the Patrol Wing following a landmark legal decision that established their jurisdiction to operate seamlessly across both orbital space and planetary surfaces. Initially, their mandate was focused on cross-jurisdictional investigations and bounty hunting. However, as the system proved its utility, both the Flotilla and the planetary colonies began offloading other critical duties. Today, Corsair cells are regularly tasked with localized law enforcement, reconnaissance, search and rescue, and recovery operations—missions ideally suited for a small, versatile crew.

THE SPONSORS

Behind every Corsair, there is a major power in the Sphere that sponsored their entry into the organization. The system could not exist without the sponsors who grant the means for it to operate, both in terms of granting them legal jurisdiction and in terms of funding their existence.

Being a sponsor grants you the right to bring matters to the attention of the Corsair Cells. When you need a perceived injustice or a threat investigated or handled, you can directly petition the organization to act. In exchange, sponsors are required to fund the entry of at least one member into the Corsairs, the majority of which is for the ship they will be operating from. Sponsors handpick the individuals who become Corsair agents and provide their initial funding.

Furthermore, sponsors gain a voice in the organization's governance. Representatives from each sponsor sit on the **Sponsor Board**, allowing them to vote on broader decisions that concern the organization's overall policies, budget, and leadership.

The biggest sponsors of the Corsairs are the Flotilla and the Colonies, but there are also a number of smaller organizations that have been granted sponsorship, such as corporations, NGOs, and even private individuals. To retain their voting seat on the Board, sponsors must maintain their funded assets in good standing and subject their petitions to the scrutiny of the central registry.

THE OVERSIGHT COMMITTEE

To prevent sponsors from wielding the Corsairs as personal weapons or using them to advance partisan agendas, the organization is supervised by the **Oversight Committee**. This body is composed of former Corsair agents with exemplary service records, alongside civilian officials approved by the Sponsor Board. The Committee's role is twofold:

- **Contract Review:** They evaluate all contracts submitted by sponsors to ensure they serve the public interest and the common good, filtering out requests that are purely self-serving or malicious.
- **Internal Investigations:** They investigate allegations of misconduct or inappropriate behavior by active Corsair agents, holding the authority to hand down disciplinary actions or strip agents of their mandate if found guilty.
- **Audit of Arms & Munitions:** They maintain continuous remote monitoring of high-yield ordnance, boarding charges, and restricted telemetry arrays deployed to licensed hulls.

THE CHARTER TOKEN & VERIFICATION PROTOCOL

Every licensed Corsair vessel carries a cryptographic **Charter Token** hardwired into its primary comms transponder. When challenged by local planetary militia or Flotilla patrol cruisers, broadcasting the token initiates an automated handshake with the nearest relay beacon, confirming the crew's legal clearance to transit airspace, carry combat armor, and execute warrants without interference.

THE CORSAIR CELL: THE FUNDAMENTAL UNIT

The Corsair system is decentralized and operates through the **Corsair Cell**. Each cell is a small, autonomous group of **3 to 5 specialists** based on a single, high-performance vessel.

This small-scale structure is a strategic choice: a single vessel can operate in crowded spaceports like Pelagia, dock at Nimbus refineries, or land at fringe outposts on Kazahn without the political implications of a military deployment. This versatility allows cells to handle investigations and tactical operations that would otherwise be complicated by interplanetary bureaucracy.

To ensure neutrality, every cell is a mandatory collaboration between different **Sponsors**. Candidates are typically placed into cells with mixed sponsorships. This structure provides a self-policing environment; because members represent different interests, the cell is discouraged from serving any single power's exclusive agenda, enforcing their impartiality.

CELL OPERATIONAL ROLES

While every cell tailors its operational dynamic to its members' talents, most balanced crews organize into five key operational functions:

- **Commander / Negotiator:** Manages legal warrants, charter compliance, sponsor negotiations, and diplomatic de-escalation under pressure.
- **Helm / Astrogator:** Plots Brachistochrone burns, calculates orbital slingshots, manages propellant reserves, and maneuvers in tight dockings.
- **Tactical / Point Defense:** Operates fire-control computers, manages kinetic coilguns, and coordinates intercept geometry against hostile bogeys.
- **Breaching Specialist:** Wields MANTLE rigs in zero-g boarding actions, CQB clearing, structural cutting, and physical site security.
- **Systems Engineer / Tech:** Calibrates drive plumes, maintains life support scrubbers, radiates reactor heat, and overrides security locks.

RECRUITMENT AND SELECTION

Becoming a Corsair agent is a prestigious but difficult path. There are two primary avenues for entering the organization:

THE INSTITUTIONAL PATH

Candidates can enlist directly with a major sponsor—such as the Flotilla or a colonial law enforcement agency—and work their way through the ranks. Outstanding performance, dedication, and recommendations from superiors within these organizations can eventually lead to a nomination for sponsorship as a Corsair agent.

THE FREELANCE PATH

Alternatively, individuals can build a reputation through bounty hunting, security consulting, or other freelance work across the Sphere. When a sponsor cannot find a suitable nominee within their own ranks, they often turn to established freelancers. To facilitate this, retired Corsairs run several smaller organizations and networks dedicated to mentoring promising freelancers; recommendations from these veterans carry significant weight with the Sponsor Board.

OPERATIONAL VARIATIONS

While the standard mandate establishes chartered cells sponsored by major powers and equipped with dedicated starships, two distinct operational variations operate across the Sphere:

FREELANCER CREWS (ASPIRANTS)

Not all who seek to become Corsairs have secured a charter or a ship. Freelancer crews operate on the ground level, taking contract security, planetary tracking, and low-level salvage to prove their capabilities to watching sponsor scouts. Without a personal vessel, they rely on commercial transport, cargo shuttles, and station transit across the Sovereign Moons, striving to build the reputation needed to earn a sponsor's backing.

ROGUE CORSAIRS (OUTLAWS)

At the opposite end of the spectrum are Rogue Corsairs—operatives who were stripped of their mandate by the Oversight Committee, broke strict neutrality protocols, or walked away from corrupt superiors. Operating unregistered, jury-rigged, or re-flagged starships, rogue cells take on high-risk, legally questionable contracts in the grey and black markets. Though officially hunted as outlaws, many maintain precarious backchannel contacts, mutual blackmail arrangements, or clandestine pipelines with their former sponsors.

MANTLE CHASSIS & THE FREELANCER NETWORK

MANTLE rigs (*Modular Adaptive Neural Transmission Linked Equipment*) are classified as Tier-1 Restricted Military Hardware, legally manufactured and controlled by the Flotilla for specialist strike corps. While commissioned Corsairs receive officially sanctioned frames underwritten by their sponsors, Freelancers acquire their required starting MANTLE either through competitive **Sponsor Candidate Pipelines** (training programs pending formal charter confirmation) or via **The Freelancer Network**—an underground fraternity of retired Corsair veterans, mentors, and dockside armorers who distribute repaired, surplused, or salvaged frames to promising aspirants.

THE BLACK MARKET ECONOMY & TRANSPONDER SPOOFING

Rogue crews survive by disabling their vessel's primary transponders, adopting forged ID beacons burned into civilian comm-chips by syndicate slicers. However, operating without a clean charter carries severe risks: unflagged vessels have zero legal protections in open space and may be targeted on sight by Flotilla patrol cutters or colonial defense craft without warning.

THE CANDIDATE PIPELINE & EVALUATION

Before any charter token is minted, prospective candidates undergo exhaustive evaluation. Flotilla intelligence and corporate sponsors run applicants through high-fidelity flight simulators, stress-tolerance tanks, and live-fire tactical drills. The attrition rate exceeds eighty percent; those who wash out either return to commercial transport ranks or drift toward the freelance underground, carrying half-completed training and bruised pride.

SANCTIONED VS. OUTLAWED ORDNANCE

Under the Skyline Accords, chartered Corsair cells are authorized to carry military-grade railguns, point-defense lasers, and shaped-charge boarding torpedoes. However, strict naval conventions prohibit high-yield nuclear warheads, unguided kinetic swarms in commercial orbits, and biological agents. Possessing such outlawed ordnance triggers instant charter revocation and an unconditional Flotilla strike warrant.

THE CONTRACT REGISTRY & ESCROW

All sanctioned Corsair contracts post their performance bonds into escrow accounts managed by the Flotilla Bank of Fume. Upon verifiable completion of operational objectives, funds are released directly to the cell's ship ledger, ensuring that crews operating across hostile borders never have to chase delinquent sponsors for promised payouts.

OPERATIONAL MODES MATRIX

MODE	LEGAL STATUS	VESSEL ACCESS	MANTLE SOURCE
Freelancer (Aspirant)	Civilian Contractor	Commercial Transit	Surplus / Pipeline
Corsair (Chartered)	Cross-Jurisdictional	Dedicated Starship	Sponsor-Sanctioned
Rogue (Outlaw)	Hunted / Unlicensed	Unregistered Hull	Black Market / Retained

THE CHARTER'S WEIGHT

"A charter does not make you a hero; it makes you an accountant with a railgun. Every shell you fire, every airlock you breach, and every treaty you cite is logged in the Committee's ledgers. Walk straight, mind your vector, and never lie to your crew."

LOCATIONS: THE WORLDS & CORRIDORS

If you ask an astrophysicist at the Sphere Research Center to describe where you live, they will lean back, clean their spectacles with a microfiber cloth, and sketch a cosmic masterpiece: an amber dwarf star ringed by twenty-six colossal gas giants locked in a mathematical hymn called the 4:2:1 Laplace resonance.

If you ask an orbital shuttle pilot hauling fifty tons of fertilizer from Crossroads to Pelagia, however, they will tell you that the Sphere is a cosmic nuisance invented by someone who had clearly never smelled raw fish in microgravity. To the pilot, the Sphere is the thirty-minute panic window when your sister planet blotted out the sun and your solar arrays dropped seventy percent efficiency while you were trying to line up with a docking collar. It is the permanent, dull headache caused by switching between the 0.98g of Landfall's continental dirt and the zero-g spin-lock of an L1 cargo hub.

Civilization in the Sphere does not cling to a single cradle. It is scattered across more than a hundred habitable worlds suspended in the magnetic hollows of twenty-six titans. To navigate this clockwork expanse, one must understand the ground beneath their magnetic boots, the sister world hanging overhead, and the orbital corridors that link them.

I. THE ANATOMY OF THE CLOCKWORK SYSTEM

The Sphere is not a solar system in the traditional, chaotic sense; it is a meticulously calibrated machine running on geological timescales. The entire architecture rests on three foundational structural invariants:

1. THE AMBER ANCHOR & RESONANT RINGS

At the heart of the system sits an Orange Dwarf star (K-type). Cooler, steadier, and far less prone to violent coronal mass ejections than ancient Earth's yellow sun, its amber-tinted light bathes the entire system in warm, long-wavelength illumination with significantly reduced ultraviolet radiation, mitigating genetic damage to surface biospheres while delivering stable solar energy across millenia.

Around this gentle forge orbit twenty-six gas giants arranged into three concentric rings (six in the Inner Ring, eight in the Middle, twelve in the Outer). Because they are locked into an immutable **4:2:1 Laplace orbital resonance**, their gravitational pulls continuously cancel out systemic drift: for every single orbit completed by an Outer giant, the Middle completes two, and the Inner completes four. This mathematical synchronization functions as a gravitational dampener, preventing chaotic orbital drifts and ensuring that the densest collection of terrestrial biospheres in the galaxy never wobbles out of alignment.

2. THE 800,000-KILOMETER SANCTUARY

Naturally formed gas giants are cosmic meat grinders, surrounding themselves with lethal radiation belts generated by violent metallic hydrogen cores. The builders of the Sphere bypassed this by altering the giants' cores to dampen high-energy dynamos and installing faint inner ring systems that continuously sweep trapped particles from the void.

The primary habitable track sits precisely **800,000 kilometers** from each gas giant's center—far enough out to escape the inner radiation belts, yet comfortably shielded inside the giant's vast magnetospheric bubble, which effortlessly deflects the stellar wind.

3. TROJAN CO-ORBITAL CONFIGURATIONS

Within this 800,000-kilometer track, orbital capacity is maximized via the utilization of L4 and L5 Lagrange points. Because the central gas giant easily exceeds the 24.96 mass ratio required to maintain stable "tadpole" orbits, a single orbital track hosts three distinct positions: a Primary Binary Pair, a leading Trojan Pair 60 degrees ahead, and a trailing Trojan Pair 60 degrees behind.

> **THE LAPLACE HARMONIC: GRAVITATIONAL DAMPENING**
>
> In chaotic stellar accretion, packing twenty-six giants into close orbits would inevitably fling worlds into deep space within a million years. The 4:2:1 resonance ensures that conjunctions occur only at opposite orbital nodes, turning potential gravitational disruptions into self-correcting nudges that preserve perpetual orbital harmony.

II. BINARY BARYCENTRIC MECHANICS

The standard habitable configuration within the Sphere is the **Binary Pair**—two Earth-mass planets orbiting a shared center of gravity (the barycenter). To achieve a strict 30-hour orbital period while preventing destructive tidal forces (remaining outside the Roche limit), these sister worlds are separated by exactly **61,000 kilometers**.

This close proximity dictates the fundamental geophysics of both worlds:

- **Tidal Locking:** The planets are tidally locked to one another, perpetually presenting the exact same hemisphere to their twin across the void.
- **The Permanent Tidal Bulge:** Gravitational attraction across the 61,000-kilometer gap pulls the hydrosphere and lithosphere toward the barycenter. The *Inner Face* facing the sister world is characterized by elevated sea levels, flooded river deltas, and dense archipelagos. The *Outer Face*, directed toward the void, features significantly lower sea levels, exposing vast continental basins, receding shorelines, and arid plateaus.
- **Internal Dynamo Generation:** Gravitational friction generated by this tight binary orbit ensures the planetary cores remain active and molten. This geological activity allows twin planets to generate their own overlapping magnetic fields, creating a localized magnetospheric bubble that repels any ambient radiation from the gas giant.

THE ROCHE MARGIN & TIDAL HEATING

For two Earth-mass terrestrial worlds, the fluid Roche limit sits at roughly 21,500 kilometers. The 61,000-kilometer separation provides an engineered safety buffer of nearly three-to-one, preventing catastrophic lithospheric shredding while generating just enough tidal flex to keep sub-surface tectonic heat pipes active. This continuous tidal kneading drives geothermal sea-vents, mineral-rich ocean thermal columns, and perpetual geothermal tap points that supply limitless clean baseload power to colonial settlements.

III. SURFACE CONDITIONS & ORBITAL ECLIPSES

Life on the surface is governed by the 30-hour rotational cycle and the complex lighting conditions created by multiple celestial bodies.

THE SYSTEMIC 1-HOUR ECLIPSE ("THE PAUSE")

Because the binary pairs orbit on the same ecliptic plane as the central star, a total solar eclipse is a mathematical certainty during every cycle. Once every 30 hours, the sister planet eclipses the Orange Dwarf for approximately one hour.

This results in a rapid, predictable drop in surface temperature and a temporary shift in global wind patterns as the atmosphere cools. Biospheres and civil infrastructures are tightly synchronized to this rhythmic thermal cycling, utilizing **"The Pause"** as a universal period for systemic recalibration, shift turnover, and biological rest.

ILLUMINATION & THE SKYBOX

The visual environment of the Sphere is dynamic and spectacular. The central Orange Dwarf provides a warm, amber-shifted baseline illumination. At the poles, the interaction between the binary worlds' magnetic bubble and the gas giant's magnetosphere produces permanent, brilliant crimson and gold auroras.

From the Inner Face, the sister planet dominates the heavens. At a distance of only 61,000 kilometers, it appears immensely larger than ancient Earth's moon, transitioning through a complete cycle of phases every 30 hours and providing substantial reflected "planetshine" during the solar night. Beyond the sister world, the host gas giant looms as a massive, ever-present backdrop at an 800,000-kilometer distance, tracking across the sky over its longer orbital period.

THE INNER VS. OUTER HEMISPHERES

The tidal bulge fundamentally divides civilization: the **Inner Face** enjoys brilliant night-sky planetshine, flooded river shipping lanes, and dense metropolitan capitals (Crossroads, Cloudspire). The **Outer Face** looks into the dark void, housing deep-core mines, corporate launch facilities, and insular Preservationist enclaves.

THE 30-HOUR WORK SHIFT & CIVIL RECALIBRATION

Across all Sovereign Moons, society operates on 10-hour work blocks separated by the 1-hour Eclipse. During the Eclipse, public transit halts, orbital power grids switch to local capacitors, and markets close. Spacers call it the "Shadow Breath"—the quiet hour when the void stands still.

IV. THE SPACER'S HORIZON: TRANSIT & ORBITAL GEOGRAPHY

Because the system was engineered rather than formed by cosmic accident, interplanetary logistics do not require centuries of cryogenic sleep or fictional faster-than-light engines. Instead, society operates on cold, predictable Newtonian physics and continuous-thrust Brachistochrone burns.

HOPPING THE BINARY GAP (61,000 KM)

Jumping between sister worlds is a commuter run. A modest courier vessel burning at 1g reaches the midpoint in just over an hour, flips its main drive plume 180 degrees, and decelerates into the sister world's gravity well. Total transit time is roughly **3 hours**, with a communication delay of less than a quarter of a second. The two worlds effectively share a single media ecosystem, financial exchange, and criminal docket.

TRAVERSING THE TROJAN EXPANSE (800,000 KM)

Traveling across the 800,000-kilometer straight line between the Primary Pair and the L4 or L5 Lagrange points at a standard 1g burn takes approximately **3.5 hours**, with a light-speed communication lag of only **2.6 seconds**. The Primary and Trojan worlds form a tightly integrated economic triangle where freight, agricultural produce, and naval patrols move with the ease of an oceanic shipping line.

CROSSING THE DEEP VOID (90,000,000 KM)

Journeys between neighboring gas giant clusters—such as the run from the Newcomer cradle of **Fume** to the Ancestral bastion of **X'ara**—cross deep interplanetary space. Under continuous 1g acceleration and deceleration, this run takes approximately **2.2 days**, with a communication lag peaking around five minutes. While requiring robust reaction-mass reserves, radiation shelters, and careful course calculations, the void between clusters is a highway, not a lifetime barrier.

THE HIGH GROUND: L1 ANCHORAGES & BASTION YARDS

Between every binary pair sits the **L1 Lagrange point**, a gravitational null zone suspended precisely 30,500 kilometers between the sister moons. Standard geostationary orbits are impossible, as they would intersect with the sister planet's pull. Consequently, heavy orbital infrastructure is anchored at L1: sprawling transfer hubs like **Waypoint Station**, high-bandwidth comm relays, and orbital bastion docks like the **Port Zenith Bastion Yards** above Landfall, where capital hulls are overhauled and the first combat MANTLE frames were forged. Communication and surveillance satellites are confined to tight **Low Moon Orbits (LMO)** beneath the localized radiation belts.

ATMOSPHERIC RE-ENTRY DYNAMICS

Re-entering a sister moon's atmosphere from high orbit demands precise angle management. Ships employ lifting-body hull geometry and ablative ceramic heat shields to bleed off velocity during atmospheric capture. A steep vector risks incinerating the ship in atmospheric friction, while a shallow burn skips off the mesosphere into deep interplanetary space.

WHY THE CORRIDORS BELONG TO CORSAIRS

Under the Skyline Accords of 335 AA, planetary police authority terminates sixty kilometers up, while Flotilla capital dreadnoughts cannot fire into planetary atmospheres without triggering civil war. Between the clouds and high orbit lies the **jurisdictional seam**—where smugglers, corporate raiders, and fugitive cartels thrive. Corsairs alone possess the cross-jurisdictional warrants and agile multi-environment ships to hunt across this boundary.

MICROGRAVITY HEALTH & RADIATION SHELTERS

Life beyond the magnetic shelter of planetary atmospheres requires strict biological safeguards. Spacers endure continuous microgravity during drift phases, mitigating muscular atrophy and osteopenia through high-resistance pneumatic exercise rigs, daily compression wraps, and magnetic boots. To combat cosmic radiation during deep interplanetary runs, crew quarters and bridges are encased within hydrogenous polyethylene composite shielding, while storm shelters are ringed by the vessel's potable water and reaction mass tanks.

> **PROPELLANT ECONOMICS: WATER & HE-3 LOGISTICS**
>
> Brachistochrone flight demands vast quantities of reaction mass (purified water) and fusion fuel (Helium-3 skimmed from gas giants). Stations at L1 act as municipal filling depots; a crew that miscalculates its delta-V budget can find itself stranded in high orbit, facing predatory corporate towing rates.

INTERPLANETARY TRANSIT & COMMUNICATION REFERENCE (1G CONTINUOUS THRUST)

VECTOR ROUTE	DISTANCE	1G TRANSIT TIME	FLIP POINT	MAX VELOCITY	COMM LATENCY	LOGISTICAL ROLE
Binary Sister Hop (e.g. Landfall ↔ Nimbus)	61,000 km	~3.0 Hours	30,500 km (L1)	~20 km/s	< 0.25 sec	Commuter shuttles, daily food barges, shared media & markets
Trojan Inter-Lagrange (Primary ↔ L4 / L5)	800,000 km	~3.5 Hours	400,000 km	~63 km/s	~2.6 sec	Bulk raw ore, industrial water hauls, regular passenger lines
Opposite Trojan Run (L4 Trojans ↔ L5 Trojans)	1,385,000 km	~4.7 Hours	692,500 km	~82 km/s	~4.6 sec	Direct industrial transfer, avoiding primary traffic corridors
Inter-Cluster Void Run (Fume ↔ X'ara Bastion)	90,000,000 km	~2.2 Days	45,000,000 km	~930 km/s	~5.0 min	Diplomatic convoys, high-tier trade, Corsair escort missions
Outer Frontier Drift (Fume ↔ Wanabo DMZ)	140,000,000 km	~2.8 Days	70,000,000 km	~1,170 km/s	~7.8 min	Frontier patrols, military logistics, blockade runner vectors
Cross-System Transit (Inner Ring ↔ Outer Ring)	450,000,000 km	~5.0 Days	225,000,000 km	~2,100 km/s	~25.0 min	Deep-range exploration, capital fleet deployments, heavy freighters

THE BRACHISTOCHRONE FLIGHT PROFILE

In hard-physics spaceflight, there is no coasting on long leisurely orbits if time matters. Starships perform **Brachistochrone burns**: accelerating continuously toward the target under 1g thrust (simulating comfortable Earth-gravity for the crew), performing a 180-degree **Turnover Maneuver** precisely at the mathematical midpoint, and decelerating under equal 1g reverse thrust into the destination's orbital envelope.

This continuous-thrust profile requires high-efficiency Draco fusion drives and disciplined reaction-mass accounting. If an engine fails before flip, or if fuel runs dry mid-burn, the vessel becomes a ballistic missile screaming into the outer void at hundreds of kilometers per second.

THERMAL RADIATION REALITIES

Vacuum does not conduct heat; it insulates. Every burning fusion reactor, fired kinetic railgun, and energized MANTLE chassis generates waste heat that must be pumped through internal ammonia loops into massive, glowing **thermal radiator arrays** extending from the hull.

In combat, retracting radiators protects them from enemy shrapnel but locks thermal heat into the ship's internal heat sinks. If a duel drags on too long, the crew risks boiling in their own pressure suits.

NAVIGATION IN MICROGRAVITY: THE PILOT'S AXIOM

"Speed is an illusion; vector is reality. When you cut your burn at the midpoint, you are not slowing down—you are falling backward into the other world's arms at sixty kilometers per second. Keep your RCS thrusters clear of frost and trust the computer's burn timer."

COMMUNICATIONS & PACKET NETWORKS

While binary sister worlds enjoy instantaneous voice and data channels (<0.25s), cross-cluster communications operate via **store-and-forward packet buoys**. Relay drones accelerate along fast trajectories, transmitting encrypted batch ledgers and news feeds to avoid the multi-minute speed-of-light lag.

ORBITAL SLINGSHOTS: THE OBERTH MANEUVER

In tactical intercepts or emergency getaways, skilled helmsmen plunge deep into a gas giant's gravity well, firing main drives at closest approach (periapsis). The Oberth effect multiplies effective kinetic delta-V, allowing an agile corsair hull to outrun heavier military pursuit. Navigators refer to this high-g trajectory as "skimming the furnace," where radiator shields are locked flat and structural stress gauges shriek in redline telemetry.

THE FUME CLUSTER

The Fume cluster is a hyper-dense, engineered orbital node within the Sphere. Centered on the colossal gas giant "Fume," this cluster hosts three distinct binary pairs—a total of six terrestrial worlds—within a single radiation-shielded orbital track at 800,000 kilometers. Each pair is locked in a 30-hour cycle, resulting in a system defined by extreme tidal stress, consistent eclipses, and profound atmospheric diversity.

I. THE CENTRAL ANCHOR: FUME

Fume is a massive, ringed gas giant characterized by an artificially altered metallic hydrogen core that suppresses violent magnetic dynamos, minimizing lethal high-energy radiation output. Its atmosphere is a turbulent expanse of deep amber and violet clouds, illuminated by the internal heat of its primordial formation and the reflected light of its sibling gas giants.

Fume's vast magnetosphere is the vital life-support mechanism for the six worlds in its local track, acting as a massive cosmic umbrella against stellar wind while producing spectacular, permanent aurorae that wash across the polar skies of its orbiting moons in ribbons of emerald and gold.

ATMOSPHERIC SKIMMING & HE-3 HARVESTERS

The upper cloud decks of Fume are rich in Helium-3 and deuterium. Automated orbital skimmers and daring corporate scoop-ships dive into the mesosphere along steep aerocapture arcs, compressing raw fusion fuels into cryogenic tanks before slingshotting back to high orbit.

II. THE BINARY PAIRS

1. THE PRIMARY PAIR (BARYCENTER): LANDFALL & NIMBUS

Situated at the base of the orbital track, these two worlds provide the system's baseline terrestrial conditions and represent the political and economic heart of Newcomer civilization.

Landfall: Landfall is the most Earth-like world of the cluster. It features a balanced distribution of continents and oceans, with moderate plate tectonics driven by the tidal pull of its twin. The geography consists of temperate forests, mountain ranges, and large, stable basins. Its climate is the most temperate in the Fume cluster, with the hourly eclipse serving as a mild seasonal shift. The planet's geopolitical landscape is anchored by **Crossroads**, the rustic capital founded five centuries ago, and the scarred, radiation-swept **Evergaol Crash Site** exclusion zone.

Nimbus: Landfall's twin is a vertical world of high-altitude plateaus separated by dizzying, vertical chasms. Because of the planet's unique atmospheric density, heavy inert gases collect in these low-lying ravines, creating "atmospheric lakes" that possess a liquid-like viscosity and swallow sunlight. The high-altitude plateaus are relatively thin-aired and arid, while the ravines are sheltered, pressurized micro-environments choked with heavy, luminous fog.

Perched across the high plateaus is **Cloudspire**, a massive, hyper-dense metropolis of soaring arcologies washed in neon and plasma advertisements. Its five vertical tiers house the elite financial houses and biotech laboratories of the Sphere. Beneath this affluent, brightly lit surface layer lies a volatile criminal underworld: the dense, fog-ridden ravines below the city lines are completely unpoliced, serving as decentralized hideouts for heavily armed syndicates, rogue slicers, and illegal bio-synthesis labs known collectively as the Ravine Cartels.

AEROSTATS & SKY-RANCHES

Between the thin highlands and the dense gas ravines sits Nimbus's habitable middle troposphere. Here, wealthy agricultural consortiums float massive solar aerostats—colossal buoyant domes kilometers wide where genetically engineered grain and citrus crops bask in uninterrupted amber sunlight, tended by airborne migrant crews.

These floating plantations are connected by pressurized cargo cable-cars and vertical lift shuttles. During heavy cyclonic seasons, dockworkers tether the aerostats to reinforced granite pylons sunk into the cliff walls to prevent the domes from drifting into the toxic smog-wells below.

THE ATMOSPHERIC LAKES OF NIMBUS

The gas pooling in Nimbus's ravines is so dense that specially hydro-foiled skimmers can float on its surface without airfoils. Crossing these chemical mists requires rebreathers and pressurized suits; breathing raw ravine gas causes rapid asphyxiation and lung calcification.

2. THE LEADING PAIR (L4 TROJANS): PELAGIA & SUNCATCHER

These worlds occupy the leading Lagrangian point, forming the most climatically polarized binary in the cluster.

Pelagia: Pelagia is a world composed almost entirely of water. Shallow, interconnected island chains span the equator, but the poles are marked by massive, abyssal deep-sea trenches. The planet possesses enormous thermal inertia, remaining largely indifferent to the hourly solar eclipse. Its atmosphere is thick, humid, and rich in oxygen, supporting expansive semi-aquatic flora and colossal floating kelp beds.

Societally, Pelagia is defined by a rigid class divide. The planet's elite reside on massive, floating megastructures—luxurious, self-sustaining pontoon cities that glide gracefully across the open ocean, operating with an insulated, aristocratic elegance. The common working populace is restricted to the natural equatorial island chains, which are heavily urbanized, densely packed, and largely dedicated to harvesting chemical kelp and processing marine pharmaceuticals for the upper tiers under the watchful, hidden gaze of the deep-sea Leviathan.

Suncatcher: Pelagia's twin is a brutal contrast: a planet of low albedo, dominated by vast, heat-absorbing desert basins and savannah-like equatorial plateaus. Its surface features very low thermal inertia, experiencing rapid thermal spikes during solar exposure and steep cooling during the eclipse. Its landscape is defined by vast, wind-scoured plains, glassed dunes, and permanent dust storms.

While surface agriculture is nearly impossible, the arid crust is rich in highly concentrated heavy mineral and crystalline deposits, driving a massive, volatile mining industry. The primary civil hub is **Dustwall**, a heavily fortified industrial frontier settlement built directly around a massive crater mine. Beyond the hub lies the **Badlands**, a lawless expanse of wind-carved canyons where corporate law enforcement cannot penetrate, leaving the territory to cutthroat outlaws, prospectors, and bounty hunters.

3. THE TRAILING PAIR (L5 TROJANS): KARST & RIME

This pair showcases the extreme effects of gravitational tidal friction on planetary crusts.

Karst: Karst's surface is a landscape of collapse. Centuries of tidal flexing have shattered the crust into a network of massive cenotes and sinkholes. The surface is essentially a barren, razor-sharp plateau. However, the true geography of Karst lies beneath; the planet's interior is hollowed into massive, cavernous networks filled with geothermally heated inland seas and bioluminescent fungal forests.

This subterranean ecosystem is home to the **Lithari**, a primitive intelligent species of tribal hunters. Following their discovery, the Flotilla enacted the **Non-Interference Protocol**, declaring Karst a quarantined zone. All Newcomer presence is strictly prohibited, and the Flotilla maintains a permanent orbital blockade to ensure the Lithari remain undisturbed until they achieve spaceflight capability.

Rime: Rime is defined by its extreme albedo. The Outer Face is locked under a permanent, kilometers-thick ice sheet that reflects incoming stellar radiation. The planet's geography is a gradient of temperature: the outer hemisphere is a frozen wasteland, while the Inner Face features a single, geothermally maintained circular ocean. This coastal ring is the only habitable region, pinned between encroaching glacial walls and the tidal-warmed sea.

> **THE LEVIATHAN'S SHADOW IN THE ABYSS**
>
> In Pelagia's deepest trenches lies the slumbering Leviathan, an ancient dragon entity whose psychic hum whispers into the minds of the floating city Barons. Those who dredge the abyssal shelves report missing submersibles and unmapped magnetic pulses rising from the deep floor.

FUME CLUSTER MOONS GAZETTEER OVERVIEW

WORLD	PAIR LOCATION	DOMINANT BIOME	PRIMARY CIVIL HUB	STRATEGIC ROLE & KEY FEATURES
Landfall	Primary Barycenter	Temperate / Continental	Crossroads (Capital)	Exodus Landing Memorial, Evergaol Exclusion Zone, SRC Labs
Nimbus	Primary Barycenter	Plateaus / Gas Ravines	Cloudspire	Atmospheric Lakes, 5-Tier Arcologies, Ravine Cartel havens
Pelagia	L4 Leading Trojan	Global Warm Ocean	Pontoon Megastructures	Land Barons, Marine Extraction, Leviathan abyssal presence
Suncatcher	L4 Leading Trojan	Arid Desert / Canyons	Dustwall Crater	Heavy Mineral Extraction, Corporate Scrip, Badlands Outlaws
Karst	L5 Trailing Trojan	Subterranean Cenotes	None (Quarantined)	Lithari tribal species, Non-Interference naval blockade
Rime	L5 Trailing Trojan	Glacial / Geothermal	Coastal Geothermal Ring	Circular Tidal Ocean, Deep-Ice Research, Outer Glaciers

LANDFALL: CRADLE OF NEWCOMERS

Landfall was the very first moon in the Sphere that the Newcomers touched down upon circa 500 years ago. The original four races—Humans, Naga, Craggen, and Sylvan—woke from cryo-sleep aboard their crash-landed seed arks in Crossroads Valley. The monuments of those founding days remain central to planetary life, chiefly Crossroads itself, the very first settlement built by Newcomer hands and today the cultural and demographic capital of the known Sphere.

PLANETARY GEOGRAPHY & CONTINENTS

Landfall is the most Earth-like of the colonized moons in climate and biome, though with slightly more clustered continental landmasses than ancient Earth. Crossroads sits at the confluence of two wide freshwater rivers on the near-side of the moon, facing directly toward its sister world Nimbus and situated within sight of the historic Exodus Arks.

The surrounding landscape is defined by fertile continental plains, rolling fields, and ancient purple-leafed forests. Traveling east beyond the continental shelf and across the **Sun Canal**—a narrow strait dividing the northeastern and southeastern continents—savannahs give way to dense equatorial rainforests. Following the river valleys north toward the pole leads into the colossal granite spines of the Crown Mountains, where early Craggen prospectors established the first deep-crust geothermal shafts.

The western continent lies on the far side of the moon, facing the cold void. Slightly smaller and offset to the south, it is anchored by **Settler's Bay**, established in 60 AA as the primary marine port of the western hemisphere. Broad swaths of both continents are legally protected wildlife reserves, preserving the virgin ecosystems that greeted the first generation of pioneers.

THE GEOTHERMAL SPINES OF THE CROWN MOUNTAINS

High above the continental plains, the Crown Mountains house the deepest mining shafts in the Newcomer territories. Craggen tunneling clans operate massive geothermal boreholes reaching twenty kilometers into the mantle, tapping super-critical magma vents to smelt heavy construction alloys and composite hull plating. In the high passes, mountain outposts maintain sensor listening posts tracking orbital conjunctions.

QUIRKS OF NATIVE FLORA & FAUNA

Landfall's native biosphere evolved under the gentle amber spectrum of an Orange Dwarf. To absorb long-wavelength radiation efficiently, native plants developed leaves and stems rich in purple, crimson, and deep indigo pigments; true green foliage is a botanical rarity confined largely to flowering petals.

Native fauna is equally distinctive: even apex predators display a remarkable neutrality toward Newcomers, avoiding populated settlements unless their nesting grounds or migratory corridors are directly threatened. Biologists credit this calm demeanor to the subtle pheromonal harmonizing fields seeded by the ancient Precursors before the seed arks touched down.

LANDFALL PLANETARY DOSSIER

Mass / Gravity	1.00 Earth Mass / 0.98g Surface Gravity
Day / Orbital Cycle	30.0 Hours (1-Hour Solar Eclipse during Pause)
Primary Capitals	Crossroads (Near Face), Settler's Bay (Far Face)
Key Landmarks	Landing Site Memorial, Evergaol Exclusion Zone, SRC
Major Exports	Grain, non-GMO produce, structural ceramics, research

THE SUN CANAL SHIPPING LANE & SETTLER'S BAY

The Sun Canal is Landfall's maritime artery. Hundreds of automated electric cargo catamarans ply its waters daily, hauling grain, raw ceramics, and timber between the agricultural heartland of Crossroads and the coastal industrial complexes of Settler's Bay. Settler's Bay operates as a scrappy frontier seaport, home to deep-ocean fisheries, independent maritime salvage outfits, and regional shipwright yards that construct rugged amphibious exploration crawlers. Its waterfront taverns are legendary among off-duty spacers seeking unpasteurized ales and untracked berths.

CROSSROADS: THE CAPITAL CITY

Crossroads is deliberately low-slung, eschewing the gleaming vertical megastructures of Cloudspire in favor of an open, sprawling footprint. Aside from monumental structures like the **Crossroads Council Hall**, the **Sphere Research Center (SRC)**, and the orbital spaceport, the city is a harmonious blend of high-tech modular prefabs, carved local granite, and reclaimed ark timbers. Paved streets are lined with flowerbeds, communal verandas, and festive banners strung between rooftops. Underground tram networks handle heavy passenger transit, preserving the quiet, garden-like tranquility of the surface.

Five centuries of shared survival have forged Crossroads into a cultural melting pot. This unity is reinforced by **Unitarianism**—a prevailing cultural and philosophical movement that views the four founding lineages as kin shaped by ancient design. Crossroads hosts more cultural festivals than any other city in the Sphere, celebrating the traditions of all ten lineages with open-air feasts, music, and artistic galas.

MEGACORPORATIONS ON LANDFALL

Nearly all major corporate conglomerates maintain headquarters or flagship offices in Crossroads, rooted in their historical origins. **Vandal's Workshop** and **Redfeather Aerospace** maintain expansive campuses here. To prevent corporate enclaves from monopolizing civic life, the Crossroads Directorate strictly confines heavy industry to zoned outer perimeters, actively penalizing companies that attempt to construct isolated corporate arcologies.

THE ANTI-ARCOLOGY ACTS OF CROSSROADS

To preserve public solidarity and democratic cohesion, the Crossroads Charter strictly prohibits private corporations from establishing fully enclosed employee arcologies. Every worker is guaranteed private civilian housing within municipal wards, preventing the corporate serfdom seen in the frontier mining hubs.

THE LANDING SITE MEMORIAL

Located just outside Crossroads, the **Landing Site** is preserved as a revered historical sanctuary. The four original Exodus Arks stand where they touched down in -4 BA. Generations of citizens visit the cavernous cargo bays and preserved autotutor crèches on civic pilgrimages, reflecting on the mysteries of their forgotten homeworlds and the journey across the stars.

THE EVERGAOL EXCLUSION ZONE

In stark contrast to Crossroads lies the **Evergaol Exclusion Zone**—the scarred impact trench where the disabled alien super-dreadnought crashed during the climax of the Frontier War in 508 AA. An automated Monolith war engine dispatched from the Praetor's arsenal, the dreadnought was brought down only when Flotilla warships, Orkish heavy rams, and the dragons Goldheart and Stormdrinker united to drag it into the crust.

A decade later in 518 AA, the site remains a lethal, cordoned exclusion zone. Automated defense pods, leaking radiation sinks, and rogue scavenger cartels known as the **Jailers** infest the wreckage, stripping dark matter conduits and Precursor alloys. Corsairs are routinely contracted by colonial magistrates to intercept rogue salvage teams and clear lethal automata wandering beyond the perimeter.

THE SCAVENGERS OF THE SCAR

"The Evergaol is not dead; it is sleeping with one eye open. You hear the hulls groan when the wind catches the breach, and every few nights the automated repair drones weld another scavenger inside a bulkhead. Go in with sealed armor and a full coilgun magazine, or don't go in at all."

THE SPHERE RESEARCH CENTER (SRC)

The SRC is the premier academic institution of Newcomer civilization. Its massive subterranean sensor arrays continuously monitor the 4:2:1 Laplace resonance and track cosmic anomalies across the outer rings, providing crucial navigational charts for Flotilla navigators and Corsair pilots.

CROSSROADS SPACEPORT & CUSTOMS GATE

While orbital beanstalks were debated, Landfall's dual-jurisdiction laws favor aerospace shuttles. The Crossroads Spaceport handles over two thousand sub-orbital and interplanetary launches every ten-hour cycle, linking the surface directly with Waypoint Station at L1. Customs inspection gates run biometric checks on every inbound spacer to prevent contraband bio-shunts from entering civilian markets.

THE X'ARA CLUSTER

The X'ara cluster is an engineered orbital node located across a 2.2-day transit corridor from Fume. In macro-engineering, radiation shielding, and orbital geometry, X'ara closely mirrors Fume: three binary pairs—six Earth-mass worlds in total—orbiting at 800,000 kilometers within a synchronized 30-hour cycle.

Unlike Fume's radical biospheric extremes, X'ara's six worlds are remarkably uniform, featuring temperate continental distributions that closely match Landfall. Variations arise from localized soil chemistry, ancient Precursor installations, and the solemn architecture of the **Ancestrals**. In the Ancestral tongue, the suffixes *-ria/-lia* and *-oa* designate the first and second worlds of each binary pair.

I. THE CENTRAL ANCHOR: X'ARA

X'ara is a massive, ringed gas giant identical in structural physics to Fume. Its subdued metallic hydrogen core minimizes baseline radiation while generating a dense magnetospheric sheath that protects its six moons from cosmic rays. Its cloud bands swirl in deep amethyst and amber, casting ethereal twilight across the sister worlds.

II. THE BINARY PAIRS

1. THE PRIMARY PAIR: IRUL'LIA & IRUL'OA (IRUL 1 & 2)

Situated at the base of the orbital track, these twin Earth-mass worlds serve as the sovereign, heavily fortified home territory of the Ancestral civilization.

Irul'lia (Irul 1): The first world of the primary pair mirrors Landfall's baseline geography, though high atmospheric concentrations of xenon and iodine give its massive northern taiga forests a dark purple hue. The planet is the administrative core of Ancestral society. Its Inner Face is dominated by soaring lithium-sheathed spires that tap directly into deep tectonic heat dynamos. While closed to outside commerce, the Flotilla maintains a single heavily fortified diplomatic consulate on the surface—the only port where Newcomers may legally clear transit protocols and interface with Ancestral archons.

Irul'oa (Irul 2): The second world is an industrial and martial redoubt. High surface silicate concentrations cause its equatorial savannahs to grow stiff, glassy, golden-orange grasses. Its Outer Face is a barren, scorched desert exposing ancient automated cloning vaults and subterranean manufacturing bays dating back millions of years—sacred assets fiercely guarded by the Ancestral military elite.

THE SHROUDED GENESIS VAULTS

Deep beneath the glassy savannahs of Irul'oa lie automated genesis vaults. Maintained by mechanical servitors since before the First Arrival, these subterranean cryo-catacombs store the frozen genetic codices of billions of extinct biospheres, guarded under eternal vigil by elite Ancestral phalanxes. The genetic lines of the Ancestrals themselves have remained unchanged for over fifty millennia, replicated with zero drift.

DIPLOMATIC ENCLAVES & TRANSIT VISAS

The Flotilla Consulate on Irul'lia is a sovereign walled enclave. Foreign spacers, merchants, and Corsairs must register their biometric tokens and post diplomatic bonds before taking a single step outside the port gantry. Unregistered visitors face immediate detention by Ancestral wardens, who escort trespassers to orbital holding rings without appeal.

> **THE SACRED VIGIL: ANCESTRAL DOGMA**
>
> Ruled by the immortal Archon and guided by the theological dogma of the Sacred Vigil, the Ancestrals maintain strict biological uniformity and reject genetic intermingling. They view Newcomer dynamism with a mix of bemused condescension and deep existential unease.

> **THE LITHIUM SPIRES OF IRUL'LIA**
>
> Soaring five kilometers above Irul'lia's purple taiga, the Spires are solid monobloc structures of Precursor lithium-alloy. Acting as massive solid-state heat exchangers, they channel planetary magma currents into microwave power beams that illuminate the orbital shipyards above. Navigators describe seeing these brilliant vertical beacons from across the binary gap, piercing the planetary shadow during the 30-hour eclipse like pillars of incandescent violet fire.

2. THE LEADING PAIR (L4 TROJANS): AVON'RIA & AVON'OA (AVON 1 & 2)

Occupying the leading Lagrangian point, this binary pair acts as an orbital graveyard for Precursor debris, evolving into a famous cultural convergence zone.

Avon'ria (Avon 1): This world features temperate forests and broad oceans, pocketed by hyper-velocity impact craters from orbital debris. Its flora is radiotrophic, jet-black, and silicon-based. Populated almost exclusively by Ancestrals, Avon 1 hosts solemn, ritualistic festivals where participants commemorate ancient lineages in close proximity to the relics of their "Gods."

Avon'oa (Avon 2): Stained intense metallic green by rich copper deposits, Avon 2 features winding rivers of liquid mercury cutting through moss-covered plains. Heavily populated by Newcomer Preservationist communities, the world hosts vibrant, chaotic art festivals that have become a rare, beloved bridge of mutual cultural admiration between Newcomers and Ancestrals.

3. THE TRAILING PAIR (L5 TROJANS): ORAN'RIA & ORAN'OA (ORAN 1 & 2)

Designated as sacred ground, this binary pair operates as an inviolable wildlife and Precursor sanctuary where permanent commercial settlement is strictly outlawed.

Oran'ria (Oran 1): A temperate ocean world where 30-hour rotational tides generate 500-meter tidal waves, churning nutrient-rich iron into crimson coastal kelp. Pilgrims travel here to witness impossible Precursor monuments: mirror-polished mountain peaks that reflect amber starlight, stone fields that sing resonant chords in the wind, and a titanic petrified tree enclosing a massive waterfall.

Oran'oa (Oran 2): A mystical wetland world of cobalt and sulfur bogs inhabited by colossal Great Beasts of undocumented evolutionary lineage. According to Ancestral lore, a living ancient Precursor slumbers in the shifting core of this world, watched over by these primeval guardians.

THE WANABO BUFFER & THE OUTER FRONTIERS

West of the civilized corridors lies **Wanabo**, a battered, asteroid-strewn system serving as the demilitarized buffer zone between the Flotilla and the **Orkish Empire**. Ravaged during the Frontier War (485–508 AA), Wanabo is a dangerous frontier of contested mining claims, scarred orbital outposts, and tense military pickets. Around the lawless boomtowns of **Kazahn** and the wild volcanic peaks of **Karak**, the fragile **Truce of Iron and Ash** is tested daily by rogue raiders, desperate scavengers, and independent prospectors hunting for Precursor cache vaults.

THE WANABO PICKETS: FLASHPOINT OF THE FRONTIER

Flotilla patrol corvettes and Orkish ram-frigates maintain tense standoffs along the Demarcation Line. A single unauthorized mining claim or drifting corsair wreck can ignite a localized naval skirmish in minutes.

X'ARA CLUSTER & WANABO BUFFER OVERVIEW

WORLD / REGION	LOCATION / ALIGNMENT	DOMINANT BIOME	PRIMARY HUB	STRATEGIC SIGNIFICANCE & HIGHLIGHTS
Irul'lia (Irul 1)	Primary Barycenter	Purple Taiga Forest	The Spires	Ancestral Administrative Seat, Flotilla Consulate Enclave
Irul'oa (Irul 2)	Primary Barycenter	Glass Savannah / Desert	Genesis Redoubts	Automated Cloning Vaults, Heavy Military Industry
Avon'ria (Avon 1)	L4 Leading Trojan	Silicon Forest / Craters	Relic Bastions	Ancestral Sacred Vigil Festivals, Debris Graveyards
Avon'oa (Avon 2)	L4 Leading Trojan	Copper Plains / Mercury	Preservationist Enclaves	Newcomer Cultural Festivals, Inter-Species Trade Hub
Oran'ria & Oran'oa	L5 Trailing Trojan	Tidal Oceans / Cobalt Bogs	None (Sacred)	Singing Stone Monuments, Great Beasts, Precursor Sanctuary
Wanabo Buffer	Demilitarized Zone	Asteroids / Volcanic Moons	Kazahn & Karak	Contested Asteroid Mines, Orkish Frontier Pickets

TIMELINE OF NEWCOMER CIVILIZATION

This chronicle documents the recorded history of Newcomer civilization across the Sphere, from the arrival of the four ancestral seed arks on Landfall to the present day in 518 AA.

ERA I: THE ERA OF GENESIS & THE PRIMARY PAIR (0 AA – 60 AA)

? BA — THE GREAT EXODUS

According to curated ship archives and sacred oral tradition, the four ancestral lineages—Humanity, Naga, Craggen, and Sylvan—fled catastrophic stellar collapse in their home systems aboard four colossal automated seed arks. Guided across the lightless interstellar void by automated navigational systems, these massive colony vessels safeguarded the genetic repositories, cultural libraries, philosophies, and scientific knowledge of their dying homeworlds, seeking a habitable system where civilization could begin anew.

-4 BA — SILENT TOUCHDOWN IN CROSSROADS VALLEY

Under sub-light automated navigation, the four arks entered the atmosphere of the temperate moon **Landfall** and touched down silently within a single verdant, sheltered valley. While the hulls rested on alien soil, the ships' automated nurseries remained sealed; the onboard autotutors were programmed to keep their adolescent charges sequestered within simulated biodomes until they reached full biological and social maturity at age twenty.

-3 TO -1 BA — THE CLANDESTINE BREAKOUTS

Confinement proved impossible against restless, inquisitive youth. Bored by looping historical lectures, synthetic nutrition paste, and sterile nursery corridors, teenage troublemakers (aged 14–16) began prying open ventilation shafts, overriding maintenance bulkheads, and slipping out into the misty valley under the cover of night.

In the untamed alien ferns of the valley floor, runaway humans, nagas, craggens, and sylvans collided. Although their databanks had never disclosed the existence of the other three hulls resting mere kilometers away, they discovered to their shock that their autotutors had taught them all the same engineered Common Tongue.

Waiting for them in the valley was **Goldheart**, a gentle, solitary young dragon who nested among the crags. Rather than alarming the ships' security sensors or herding the runaways back into confinement, Goldheart became their secret guardian, protector, and older brother. He shielded the teenagers from Landfall's native predators, taught them to avoid natural hazards, and concealed their illicit excursions from the arks' external scanners. Around clandestine campfires beneath the dragon's folded wings, the teenagers traded smuggled rations, shared homeworld myths, and forged a fierce cross-species camaraderie that transcended the sterile boundaries of their individual ships.

0 AA — GRADUATION DAY

The automated gestation and education cycles reached scheduled completion. Ship sirens wailed, floodlights activated, and the primary nursery airlocks swung wide to formally release **Cohort Zero**—an initial generation of young adults (aged 18–20) meant to step onto an alien moon for the first time.

The ship autotutors anticipated bewildered, solemn survivors clutching ancestral archives. Instead, the breakout veterans burst back into their respective arks, laughing and dragging their wide-eyed, obedient peers out into the sunlight. Rather than four frightened alien factions encountering each other in defensive isolation, the cohorts stepped into a valley where shared jokes, deep friendships, rivalries, and first loves had already been quietly flourishing for three years. Goldheart greeted the assembled multitudes, playfully reinforcing the beloved cultural belief that he had pulled their drifting ships from the void and watched over them.

1 AA — FOUNDATION OF CROSSROADS

Cohort Zero began building their first permanent settlement in the valley where the four arks landed. Naming it **Crossroads**, they constructed low-slung, rustic dwellings from local stone, timber, and salvaged ark hulls. Influenced by Goldheart's gentle warnings to avoid high-altitude electromagnetic emissions that might draw unknown dangers from the void, the settlement established an intentionally horizontal footprint that eschewed massive vertical spires. The four lineages formed a provisional council, electing one representative from each ark.

6 AA — BIRTH OF INTEGRATIONISM

The birth of the first cross-lineage child sparked a profound cultural transformation. Natural romances, having taken root during the secret midnight gatherings of the breakout years, blossomed openly across Crossroads. This gave rise to **Integrationism**—a socio-political movement advocating total cultural synthesis, mutual adaptation, and shared destiny as the moral core of the Newcomer civilization.

14 AA — THE FIRST VAULT & THE COVENANT

Expeditions venturing into Landfall's crags discovered the First Precursor Vault—a humming subterranean complex of crystalline lattices. The anomaly attracted **Stormdrinker**, a massive dragon roosting in the violent electrical storms of Landfall's binary twin, **Nimbus**. Driven by an insatiable curiosity for ancient technology and energy phenomena, Stormdrinker descended upon the site.

Goldheart stepped in to mediate, forging an unprecedented alliance between mortals and dragons: the Newcomers provided the nimble hands and fine tools to navigate human-sized maintenance conduits, while Stormdrinker and Goldheart provided the sensory depth and brute energy to crack heavy exterior bulkheads.

Inside the Vault, the expedition leaders encountered active automated defenses and energetic systems of incomprehensible power. Recognizing that reckless tampering with Precursor ruins or broadcasting energetic distress signals into open space could trigger devastating planetary catastrophes, the expedition leaders, council elders, Goldheart, and Stormdrinker swore an eternal oath. They formed **The Covenant**: a classified circle dedicated to containing dangerous technologies, sanitizing active Vault sites, and shielding the young civilization from cosmic hazards.

15 AA — THE PRESERVATIONIST COUNTER-MOVEMENT

As Integrationism swept the urban heart of Crossroads, an ideological counter-current emerged. Led primarily by the "dutiful students" of Cohort Zero—those who had remained inside the arks until Graduation Day, absorbing the unadulterated poetry, tragedy, and philosophies of Earth, the Naga swarms, the Craggen deep-hives, and the Sylvan groves—these traditionalists viewed the freewheeling hybrid culture as an irreverent betrayal of their sacred ancestral heritage. Adopting the philosophy of **Preservationism**, they began migrating toward Landfall's outward-facing hemisphere to establish insular, single-lineage settlements dedicated to keeping their bloodlines and traditions pure.

35 AA — THE NIMBUS RENDEZVOUS

Guided by data shared through The Covenant, researchers at the Sphere Research Center (SRC) constructed Landfall's first deep-space manned rocket. Commanded by a daring multi-species crew, the vessel braved the turbulent electrical storm-wells of Nimbus to rendezvous with Stormdrinker at his high-altitude roost. In exchange for historical texts, mathematical proofs, and cultural data, Stormdrinker allowed SRC physicists to study his unique bio-fusion biology and gravitic flight mechanics.

38 AA — THE DRACO FUSION BREAKTHROUGH

Synthesizing telemetry from Stormdrinker's biological dynamo with Precursor magnetic shielding principles, the SRC developed the **Draco Fusion Drive**. Operating on continuous-thrust fusion physics, the drive made rapid sub-light interplanetary transit safe, reliable, and commercially viable.

39 AA — MAIDEN FLIGHT OF THE *BIRDY*

The transport vessel *Birdy*, equipped with the prototype Draco Drive, successfully crossed the 61,000-kilometer binary gap between Landfall and Nimbus in under two hours, formally opening the space age for Newcomer civilization.

45 AA — THE RISE OF CLOUDSPIRE

A permanent research outpost on the high-altitude arid plateaus of Nimbus rapidly expanded into a metropolis of gleaming towers, neon arrays, and lightning catchers: **Cloudspire**. Stormdrinker became the public patron of the city, revered by citizens as the "Lightning Sage," circling the upper atmosphere above the clouds while maintaining quiet council with Covenant leaders in restricted subterranean bays.

ERA II: THE TROJAN EXPANSION & THE GREAT BEASTS (60 AA - 200 AA)

62 AA — WAYPOINT STATION AT L1

Civil engineering reached a monumental milestone with the deployment of **Waypoint Station** at the gravitational L1 null-point, precisely 30,500 kilometers between Landfall and Nimbus. Waypoint served as the primary customs terminal, logistics clearinghouse, and data relay coordinating transit across the primary pair.

80-110 AA — THE BINARY CENTURY

Crossroads and Cloudspire matured into dense, industrial city-states. The facing hemispheres of both moons became the brilliant, hyper-connected heart of Integrationist civilization. Meanwhile, corporate charters and Preservationist settlements dominated the outward hemispheres, funding private prospecting into the wider Fume system.

120 AA — THE RUSH TO THE L4 TROJANS

With the primary pair heavily colonized, ambitious mining conglomerates and independent pioneers looked outward to Fume's co-orbital L4 Lagrange point, 800,000 kilometers ahead. Colony fleets launched toward the oceanic water-world of **Pelagia** and the hyper-arid, mineral-rich desert moon of **Suncatcher**.

125 AA — THE BALLISTIC LOGISTICS CORRIDORS

Because neither Trojan world was self-sustaining alone, an audacious engineering marvel was established: massive planetary railguns were constructed on the equatorial island chains of Pelagia to launch sealed water-ice canisters across the 61,000-kilometer gap directly into Suncatcher's catchment basins. In return, Suncatcher fired heavy ores and refined structural metals back to Pelagia.

130-150 AA — RISE OF THE TROJAN MEGACITIES

Port Azure on Pelagia evolved from a humble aquatic landing pad into a sprawling network of floating pontoon arcologies, dominated by shipping dynasties, kelp-harvesting unions, and maritime fishing syndicates. Across the co-orbital void, **Dustwall** on Suncatcher grew inside a massive impact crater into the iron-bound capital of heavy industry, smelting, and ore refinement, surrounded by the untamed, canyon-cut expanse known as the **Badlands**.

As the two cities expanded, trade intensified: forty-ton canisters of liquid water fired from Pelagia slammed into Suncatcher's catchment basins daily, while Suncatcher's massive magnetic cannons launched refined titanium ingots back toward Pelagia's oceanic landing grids.

165 AA — AWAKENING OF THE SANDWYRM

Heavy deep-core tectonic fracking in Suncatcher's Badlands awakened a gargantuan subterranean predator: the **Sandwyrm**. A colossal serpentine beast of terrifying proportions, the creature began swallowing mining crawlers, drilling platforms, and frontier rail lines whole, turning the Badlands into a lethal wasteland.

170 AA — THE SHADOW OF THE ABYSS

Deep-sea acoustic hydrophones deployed along Pelagia's oceanic trenches detected an ultra-massive biological entity slumbering in the abyss: the **Leviathan**. Whispers spread through maritime crews and corporate corridors of an ancient, intelligent titan resting in the fathomless deep, exerting an eerie psychological presence over the oceanic world.

175 AA — THE CLASH OF THE TITANS & THE INTER-BINARY FAMINE

Desperate to eliminate the Sandwyrm, Suncatcher authorities re-aimed Pelagia's planetary water railguns to execute orbital bombardments against the beast's nest. Enraged and grievously wounded, the Sandwyrm sprouted massive membranous wings, broke atmosphere, and flew across the void toward Pelagia to annihilate the railgun complexes.

As the airborne titan tore through Pelagia's coastal defense arrays, the **Leviathan** violently breached the ocean surface. Coiling around the Sandwyrm, the abyssal dragon dragged the thrashing monster down into the black depths of the trench, drowning it.

The collateral damage leveled Pelagia's launch arrays. The severed water logistics corridor plunged both worlds into catastrophic drought and industrial collapse: the **Inter-Binary Famine**.

180 AA — THE FIRST FLOTILLA CHARTER

With famine ravaging the Trojans and piracy surging along the disrupted shipping routes, the Landfall Council and the newly formed Trade Alliance chartered a joint emergency peacekeeper force: the **Flotilla**. Governed by a provisional Admiralty Board, the fleet mobilized all available freighters to escort emergency food and water convoys across the system.

> **BALLISTIC LOGISTICS & THE FAMINE YEARS**
>
> In the early decades of the Trojan expansion, planetary railguns were the vital link holding civilization together. Launching forty-ton ice containers across 61,000 kilometers of hard vacuum into Suncatcher's catchment basins kept millions of miners alive. When the Sandwyrm's wrath shattered Pelagia's launch rings in 175 AA, the six-month cutoff proved how inextricably linked the sister worlds were—a vulnerability that forced the creation of the Flotilla's first convoy escorts.

ERA III: THE CORPORATE FEUDS & THE SCAVENGER WARS (200 AA - 340 AA)

205 AA — RESOLUTION OF THE FAMINE & THE DEEP-SEA FARMS

Pelagia reconstructed its launch platforms while deploying bio-engineered kelp and aquaculture farms, permanently ending the famine. However, the political divide between the central governments of the primary pair and the corporate oligarchies of the Trojans became permanently entrenched.

220-255 AA — THE DRIFT WARS

Fierce competition over helium-3 fuel and heavy isotopes around Fume's radiation-swept inner moons sparked the **Drift Wars**. Planetary governments refused to fund the joint Flotilla, choosing instead to arm private corporate security navies. Proxy skirmishes, commerce raiding, and state-sponsored piracy turned the space lanes into a treacherous free-fire zone.

270 AA — ARRIVAL OF THE SCAVS

Attracted by the electromagnetic clutter, radio noise, and wreckage of the Drift Wars, the **Scavs**—a brutal, nomadic alien raider species driven by an insatiable hunger for high technology and ancient relics—entered the Fume system. Operating in fast, scrap-welded strike crafts, dozens of Scav raider clans launched coordinated incursions against frontier mining outposts and orbital fuel platforms.

285 AA — THE SACK OF CLOUDSPIRE

In the most brazen raid of the century, a massive Scav armada breached Nimbus's atmosphere. Their objective: looting the SRC's deep Precursor relic vaults and harvesting high-output power arrays. Stormdrinker unleashed his fury across the sky, incinerating dozens of boarding craft with plasma lightning, while Cloudspire's ground batteries fought room-by-room in the arcologies. The defenders successfully repelled the invaders, but the upper districts suffered catastrophic structural damage and several vital research vaults were ransacked.

290-310 AA — THE FRACTURED SYSTEM & REDMANE'S REMNANTS

Terrified planetary governments withdrew their remaining warships into low-orbit defense grids, leaving open space completely unguarded. Piracy and Scav raids skyrocketed. Refusing to abandon the shipping lanes, veteran Flotilla commander **Velen Redmane** gathered a loyal coalition of spacers, corporate defectors, and volunteer crews to operate as an independent, non-aligned defense fleet: **Redmane's Coalition**.

320 AA — THE BATTLE OF FUME RINGS

A massive Scav armada gathered within Fume's inner ring system to launch a coordinated planetary assault against Landfall. Redmane's Coalition intercepted the raiders in a brutal, multi-day fleet engagement among the icy ring debris. Utilizing tight Brachistochrone maneuvers and point-blank railgun volleys, Redmane decisively obliterated the Scav fleet, securing the void lanes and saving the colonies from collapse.

335 AA — THE SKYLINE ACCORDS & CREATION OF THE CORSAIRS

Hailed as saviors, Redmane's coalition forced the planetary governments to the negotiating table. The landmark **Skyline Accords** were signed:

- **The Flotilla** was permanently established as the sovereign, neutral naval and peacekeeper authority over all open space, orbital lanes, and transit hubs.
- **Planetary Governments** retained absolute legal sovereignty within their atmospheric gravity wells.
- **The Corsairs**: Recognizing that criminals, smugglers, and rogue corporate agents exploit the jurisdictional seam between planetary skies and open orbit, the Flotilla authorized independent, multi-party sponsored privateer cells granted cross-jurisdictional mandates: the **Corsairs**.

THE SEAM BETWEEN SKY AND VOID

"Planetary sheriffs cannot fly above the clouds without choking on vacuum. Flotilla captains cannot dive into your canyons without crushing half a city under their fusion backwash. The space between the roof of your world and the edge of our orbit belongs to the lawless—unless we send someone built to walk in both."

— Commander Velen Redmane, *Address at the Skyline Accords (335 AA)*

ERA IV: THE L5 BOUNDARY & THE ANCESTRAL ENCOUNTER (340 AA - 450 AA)

350-368 AA — THE L5 TROJANS & NON-INTERFERENCE

Colonization fleets turning to Fume's trailing pair discovered the tribal, tool-using **Lithari** in subterranean caverns on Karst. Ratifying the **Non-Interference Protocol**, the Flotilla quarantined Karst behind an orbital picket station to protect the species until they achieve independent spaceflight. Expansion was redirected to glacial **Rime**, where subterranean cities were carved around its geothermally heated circular ocean.

410-425 AA — PROBES & FIRST CONTACT AT X'ARA

Long-range autonomous survey drones burning at 1g crossed the 90-million-kilometer void to gas giant **X'ara**, discovering a second six-world binary track inhabited by a hyper-advanced, uniform civilization: the **Ancestrals**. Living under the strict theological dogma of the *Vigil of Reverent Stillness*, the Ancestrals viewed expansion as hubris. In 425 AA, the cruiser *Endeavour* carried Newcomer diplomats to meet their spiritual ruler, the **Archon**.

432 AA — THE ANCESTRAL TREATY

To prevent conflict, the Archon and Flotilla signed the **Ancestral Treaty**:

- **The Avon Partition**: Avon 1 remained Ancestral sovereign soil, while Avon 2 opened to Newcomer settlement, blooming into an art and trade hub.
- **The Avon 1 Schism**: Looking at Avon 2's night-skies, Ancestrals fractured into the *Gilded Movement* (pro-reform) and *Pure Blade* (traditionalists).
- **The Oran Quarantine**: The sacred singing-stone worlds of Oran 1 & 2 were permanently closed to industrial colonization.
- **The Flotilla Consulate**: A single fortified consulate on Irul 1 was established as the sole legal port of entry into core Ancestral space.

ERA V: THE FRONTIER WAR, THE EVERGAOL, & THE PRESENT (450 AA - 518 AA)

455-465 AA — EXPANSION INTO WANABO & THE ORKISH EMPIRE

Prospectors pushing outward reached the middle-ring giant **Wanabo**, founding the lawless boomtown of Kazahn. In 465 AA, explorers encountered the armored battle-cruisers of the **Orkish Empire**—a brutal, conquest-driven warrior civilization governed by martial Warlords.

485-505 AA — THE GREAT FRONTIER WAR

Tensions over Wanabo's rich helium-3 fields boiled over into a grinding, 20-year interstellar war. The Flotilla's disciplined kinetic railgun doctrine clashed with massive Orkish ram-prows across trench-scarred moons, grinding both navies to near-exhaustion.

508 AA — THE EVERGAOL INCURSION & THE GREAT LAST STAND

As exhausted fleets clashed in the outer reaches of Fume, an ancient cataclysm awakened: the **Evergaol**, a colossal automated super-dreadnought, warped into the battlespace and began systematically obliterating warships on both sides.

Facing annihilation, Flotilla battlecruisers and Orkish dreadnoughts forged a desperate alliance. In the skies above Landfall, railgun volleys, Ork boarding torpedoes, **Goldheart**, and **Stormdrinker** united. The two dragons grappled the dreadnought's drive arrays, tearing open heat manifolds and allowing heavy artillery to break its orbital anchors. The burning *Evergaol* crashed violently into Landfall, gouging a continent-scale scar. Boarding commandos sacrificed their lives within the smoldering wreckage to disable the central automated command matrix.

509 AA — THE TRUCE OF IRON AND ASH

Horrified by the dreadnought's destructive power and crippled by wartime casualties, the Flotilla Admiralty and Orkish Warlords signed **The Great Truce**, establishing a heavily demilitarized border across Wanabo.

518 AA — THE PRESENT DAY: THE NEW WAVE

Ten years after the Fall of the Evergaol, the Flotilla is stretched razor-thin, the crash site is contested by rogue cartels, and border tensions simmer. The Admiralty and colonial sponsors have recruited a **New Wave of Corsairs**—independent crews flying refitted hulls to stand as the thin line holding civilization together.

MASTER CHRONICLE OF THE SPHERE (-4 BA TO 518 AA)

YEAR	ERA	HISTORICAL EVENT	KEY FACTIONS & FIGURES	SYSTEMIC CONSEQUENCE
-4 BA	Genesis	Four Seed Arks Touch Down	Humans, Naga, Craggen, Sylvan	Arrival in Crossroads Valley on Landfall
-3 to -1 BA	Genesis	Clandestine Breakouts	Cohort Zero Youth, Goldheart	Secret inter-species friendship & slang forged
0 AA	Genesis	Graduation Day	Cohort Zero, Autotutors	Bulkheads open; peaceful emergence in valley
1 AA	Genesis	Foundation of Crossroads	Provisional Four-Ark Council	Rustic horizontal stone-and-timber capital built
6 AA	Genesis	Birth of Integrationism	First hybrid child, Cohort Zero	Cultural blending embraced as founding ideal
14 AA	Genesis	First Vault & The Covenant	Goldheart, Stormdrinker, Elders	Dragon alliance sworn; cosmic secrecy sealed
15 AA	Genesis	Preservationist Counter-Movement	Traditionalist Ark elders	Insular settlements founded on Far Hemisphere
35–39 AA	Genesis	Draco Drive & Flight of *Birdy*	SRC physicists, Stormdrinker	61,000 km binary gap bridged in under 2 hours
45 AA	Genesis	Rise of Cloudspire	Nimbus colonists, Stormdrinker	Vertical neon metropolis on Nimbus plateaus
62 AA	Trojans	Waypoint Station Deployed	Joint colonial engineers	L1 gravitational customs hub operational
120–125 AA	Trojans	L4 Trojan Rush & Railguns	Pelagia, Suncatcher miners	Planetary water-ice railgun corridor built
165–175 AA	Trojans	Sandwyrm vs. Leviathan	Sandwyrm, Leviathan, Barons	Launch arrays crushed; Inter-Binary Famine
180 AA	Trojans	First Flotilla Chartered	Landfall Council, Trade Alliance	Emergency relief peacekeeper navy formed
220–255 AA	Feuds	The Drift Wars	Corporate navies, He-3 prospectors	He-3 proxy wars shatter early system peace
270–285 AA	Feuds	Scavenger Incursions & Sack	Scav Armadas, Stormdrinker	Nomadic raiders sack Cloudspire's vaults
320 AA	Feuds	Battle of Fume Rings	Commander Velen Redmane	Decisive railgun victory over Scav fleet
335 AA	Feuds	Skyline Accords Signed	Flotilla Admiralty, Colonies	Dual jurisdiction & Corsairs established
365–368 AA	Expansion	Discovery of the Lithari	Flotilla explorers, Lithari tribes	Non-Interference Protocol blocks Karst; Rime settled
410–432 AA	Expansion	First Contact with Ancestrals	Flotilla *Endeavour*, The Archon	Ancestral Treaty; Avon partitioned; Oran protected
465 AA	Frontier	First Contact with Orkish Empire	Frontier scouts, Orkish Warlords	Militaristic empire met beyond Wanabo
485–505 AA	Frontier	The Great Frontier War	Flotilla Navy vs. Orkish Armadas	20-year war over Wanabo He-3 fields
508 AA	Frontier	The Evergaol Incursion	Flotilla, Orks, Dragons vs. Monolith	Precursor dreadnought dragged down on Landfall
509 AA	Frontier	Truce of Iron and Ash	Admiralty Board, Orkish Warlords	Demilitarized border established in Wanabo
518 AA	Present	The New Wave of Corsairs	High Council, Sponsors, New Wave	Independent cells chartered to police fraying void

FIVE CENTURIES IN THE VOID

"We did not cross the stars to build a new empire; we crossed them to escape extinction. Five hundred years later, our children look up at the sister moons and see not alien dirt, but home. Keep your engines tuned and remember who stood beside you in the mud of Crossroads."

FACTIONS: POWERS OF THE SPHERE

To the celestial cartographers and ivory-tower physicists of the Sphere Research Center, the Sphere is a marvel of cosmic clockwork: twenty-six ringed gas giants suspended in a flawless 4:2:1 Laplace resonance around an amber dwarf star. It is clean, elegant, and mathematically sublime.

To the eight billion souls actually living in it, the Sphere is mostly an alarm clock that goes off every thirty hours, a persistent argument over communal water filters, and the stubborn realization that no matter how far your ancestors traveled across the lightless void, someone in middle management will still find a way to charge you for parking.

To the orbital admirals of the Flotilla and corporate executives aboard pressurized stations, planetary bodies are often treated as mere gravitational wells—convenient heat sinks with high atmospheric drag and an irritating habit of requiring reaction mass to leave. But to the billions who dwell at the bottom of those wells, the planet is everything. It is the only place where an accidental drop of your morning coffee results in a broken mug on the floor rather than a scalded eye in microgravity. It is the soil beneath your work boots, the air you do not pay for by the cubic meter, and the municipal hall whose doors you can march through when a sewer pipe bursts.

ANATOMY OF A CROSS-JURISDICTIONAL CRISIS

On an ordinary afternoon in Crossroads, an unregistered scrap-hopper screams through the upper atmosphere, clips a municipal tram line, and crashes into the stained-glass roof of the Council Hall. A terrified Jailer courier scrambles out, clutching a humming Precursor coil stolen from the Evergaol exclusion zone. Behind him, a Flotilla gunboat hovers at flight ceiling, legally forbidden from firing into municipal skies, while corporate lobbyists and municipal guards draw weapons in the gallery.

In less than four minutes of shattered glass and procedural indignation, the Crossroads Council Hall becomes an exact microcosm of the forces that govern the Sphere:

- **The Colonial Administrations (The Soil):** Exercising territorial sovereignty within their atmospheric gravity well under the Skyline Accords, balancing agriculture, taxes, and municipal laws below cloud ceiling.
- **The Megacorporations (The Forge):** Lobbying for transit tariffs and selling the structural titanium, Draco drive components, and life-support patents that keep civilization breathing.
- **The Underworld (The Shadow):** Hawking unstable alien technology from the Evergaol to illicit cartels to bypass corporate monopolies.
- **The Flotilla (The High Drift):** The orbital naval authority whose quarantine codes chased the suspect across the binary gap.
- **The Alien & Cosmic:** The humming Precursor coil, and **Goldheart**, the gentle living dragon lounging on the council terrace.
- **The Corsairs (The Seam-Stitchers):** Who alone possess the legal mandates, powered MANTLE chassis, and cross-jurisdictional charters to leap between orbital vacuum and planetary cobblestones.

THE FIVE SOVEREIGN ARENAS

Power in the Sphere is divided into five distinct arenas, each defined by unique physical boundaries and legal jurisdictions:

- **I. The Hearth & Magistrate (The Colonies):** Planetary governments holding territorial sovereignty below cloud ceiling under the Skyline Accords.
- **II. The Shift & Company Scrip (The Megacorps):** Industrial juggernauts owning life-support patents, scrubbers, and private company towns.
- **III. The Shadow Hours (The Underworld):** Outlaw cartels, hoverboard gangs, and Jailers thriving in unpoliced ravines and crash zones.
- **IV. Above the Clouds (The Flotilla):** The supreme naval authority commanding open space, orbital lanes, and customs hubs.
- **V. The Silent Horizon (Alien Powers):** Foreign civilizations watching from beyond: Ancestrals, Orks, Scavs, and the primitive Lithari.

THE SEAM-STITCHERS

Between the clouds and the high void lies the jurisdictional seam. That seam is where the Corsairs live. Armed with multi-faction sponsorships, powered MANTLEs, and nimble corvettes, Corsairs are the only operatives authorized to chase a fugitive from an orbital docking collar down into the rain-slicked alleys of Crossroads.

THE SOVEREIGN COLONIES

JURISDICTION: Atmospheric Gravity Wells (Skyline Accords, 335 AA)
AUTHORITY: Absolute Municipal & Civil Sovereignty Below Cloud Tops
PRIMARY SEATS: Crossroads, Cloudspire, Port Azure, Dustwall, The Thaw Coast

Under the historic Skyline Accords of 335 AA, planetary governments hold absolute sovereignty within their atmospheric gravity wells. Down in the mud, their word is law: collecting taxes, paving roads, and maintaining sewer mains. But planetary law ends cleanly at the clouds; the moment an engine plume breaks the upper mesosphere, the local magistrate is just another citizen watching the radar screen.

1. THE CROSSROADS HIGH COUNCIL (LANDFALL)

LIVED EXPERIENCE & CIVIC PHILOSOPHY

Life in Crossroads is an unhurried, deeply civic affair governed by thirty-hour cycles, the reassuring chime of municipal tram bells, and the enduring cultural conviction that any disaster in the cosmos can be resolved if five sensible people sit down around a sturdy cedar table with a pot of hot tea and a well-sharpened pencil. Founded in 1 AA by Cohort Zero around the original landing sites of the four exodus arks, Crossroads is the oldest continuously inhabited settlement in the Sphere and the undisputed heart of **Integrationism**.

Its architecture is deliberately horizontal: rustic two-story townhouses and communal cottages constructed from local granite, river timber, and lovingly burnished hull plating salvaged from the arks. Insulated with modern aerogel composites and draped in purple-leafed native ivy, blooming window boxes, and colorful lineage banners, the town eschews vertical spires. This low profile is partly a historic courtesy to the skies—honoring the ancient counsel of **Goldheart**, the gentle void dragon who has lounged on the council terrace for five centuries—and partly a reflection of the town's stubborn refusal to live in a filing cabinet.

Because of Goldheart's calming presence, the citizens possess an almost unflappable temperament. When an unregistered cargo hopper falls screaming through the clouds with a blown maneuvering thruster, the townsfolk do not panic; they step onto their front porches, check their pocket watches, adjust their watering cans, and begin calculating property damage to their prize hydrangeas.

LEADERSHIP & INTERNAL POWER STRUCTURE

Crossroads is administered by the **High Council**, presided over by the Speaker (currently Jesse Haddon, an unshakeable human carpenter-turned-statesman whose patience with bureaucratic filibustering is legendary across three moons). The Council comprises four permanent Lineage Seats—representing Humans, Nagas, Craggens, and Sylvans—alongside rotating delegates elected from municipal labor guilds: Stone-Carvers, River Dredgers, Orchardists, Rail Workers, and Scribes.

Council procedure is notoriously deliberative: every civic ordinance must undergo three public readings, an environmental impact study, and a floor debate. Goldheart holds no official ballot, but the Chair unfailingly recognizes "the dragon's remark" from the terrace. The dragon's warm, resonant commentary—often concerning the crisp scent of line-dried sheets, the sweetness of roasted autumn pears, or the comedic futility of mortal hurry—regularly shames bickering councilors into unanimous, sheepish compromises.

TERRITORY, ASSETS & RELATIONSHIP WITH CORSAIRS

Signature civic assets include the **Sphere Research Center (SRC)**, where physicists study celestial mechanics; the **Landing Site Memorial Arks**, preserving the four exodus hulls as national archives; the **Crossroads Council Hall** with its historic stained-glass dome; and the whisper-quiet **Subterranean Tramway** keeping surface streets uncluttered.

The Council views Corsairs as an essential municipal constabulary with sub-light wings, regularly issuing official **Writs of Recovery** for fugitives fleeing into the upper atmosphere and hazardous Precursor salvage smuggled from the Evergaol. The Council pays promptly in Flotilla Credits, though municipal surveyors rigorously itemize and deduct any collateral property damage from the cell's reward.

2. THE CLOUDSPIRE ARCOLOGY DIRECTORATE (NIMBUS)

LIVED EXPERIENCE & CIVIC PHILOSOPHY

Where Crossroads is horizontal, rustic, and communal, Cloudspire is sheer, blindingly bright, and ruthlessly vertical. Perched across the high-altitude plateaus of Nimbus above a sea of perpetual fog, the metropolis is a dizzying thicket of titanium-lattice spires, chrome needle towers, and carbon-fiber suspension bridges piercing the upper haze. Here, altitude is status, wealth, and literal breath.

In executive aeries three thousand meters above the terrain, corporate directors, high-frequency traders, and senior Directorate officials sip vintage Landfall wines in scrubbed, mountain-fresh air. Two hundred decks down, the mid-levels are a clamorous, rain-washed labyrinth of neon billboards, crowded sky-walks, steaming noodle kiosks, and pressurized transit tubes where middle managers work grueling eighteen-hour shifts. Below Spire 10, street vendors hawk roasted fungal skewers under the glare of flickering holoscreens, while maintenance crews in insulated magnetic boots crawl along exterior struts to repair lightning-rod cables.

At the very bottom, in perpetual twilight where dense, inert gases settle into suffocating "atmospheric lakes," the forgotten sub-deck population lives in damp industrial slums, breathing metered synthetic oxygen and paying off perpetual air debts to utility cartels. The prevailing philosophy is *Stratified Meritocracy*: the sky is free, provided you can afford the rent to stand near it.

LEADERSHIP, ASSETS & CORSAIR CONTRACTS

Administered by the **Arcology Directorate** of seven High Directors, law enforcement across mid-decks is handled by Directorate Wardens and elite **Nightwatch Enforcers** deploying from black VTOLs with kinetic carbines and shock batons. The lower ravines are classified as "Non-Serviced Sub-Deck Concessions." High above the highest needle rests **Stormdrinker**, the ancient Scholar Dragon. While corporations own ledgers, Stormdrinker holds the ultimate veto: if boardroom greed threatens atmospheric balance or meddles with forbidden Precursor energetics, the dragon's lightning descends with cataclysmic finality.

Key assets include the **Cloudspire Sky-Dock Terminal** for sub-orbital shuttles, **Central Scrubber Array (Spire 1)** filtering millions of cubic meters of fog hourly, the **High Pylon Suspension Grid** linking eighty arcologies, and **Ravine Drainage Manifolds**. The Directorate issues lucrative **Black-Lanyard Warrants** for quiet extractions, rogue researcher retrieval, and syndicate takedowns, paying in bearer bonds, avionics components, and priority docking chits.

3. PELAGIA PONTOON COALITIONS (PELAGIA)

LIVED EXPERIENCE & MARITIME CULTURE

On Pelagia, dry land is a children's fairy tale, and civilization is measured strictly in displacement tonnage, draft depth, and buoyancy. With no continental landmasses breaking the surface of its globe-spanning emerald ocean, the entire population lives afloat. Society is sharply cleaved into two distinct maritime castes: wealthy elites inhabit colossal **Pontoon Estates** drifting along tropical currents, while the working populace lives in dense shantytown flotillas lashed to natural coral reefs. The cultural philosophy is *The Law of the Keel*: fail to pay your ballast fee, and the Baron cuts your mooring hawser.

Between floating cities, automated skimmers harvest vast mats of genetically tailored chemical kelp synthesizing carbohydrates, proteins, and industrial polymers. Governed by the **Pontoon Assembly** of hereditary "Land Barons," law is enforced by the **Tidewarden Guild** via high-speed hydrofoils, armed littoral catamarans, and submersible patrol craft, punishing mutiny and contamination with "Keel-Casting" upon unprovisioned drift rafts. In the deepest trenches slumbers the **Leviathan**, an ancient titan exerting a hypnotic pull over maritime crews.

Key assets include the **Sovereign Barge Aurelia** (three-kilometer mobile capital), **Submersible Fortress Nautilus-4**, historic **Equatorial Railgun Piers**, and **Great Trench Wellheads** anchored along ancient bio-luminescent coral reefs. Oceanic storms frequently toss forty-meter rogue waves against outer pontoons, requiring constant ballast trim. The Assembly issues **Letters of Maritime Marque** to Corsairs to hunt submersible raiders and escort fuel barges across the boundless ocean.

4. DUSTWALL MINING CONSORTIUM (SUNCATCHER)

On Suncatcher, nature does not negotiate. The 30-hour day is an ordeal of extremes: fifteen hours of white-hot solar exposure baking the red sandstone plains, followed by fifteen hours of sub-zero flash-freezing during *The Pause*. Life is subterranean and fiercely utilitarian, centered within the fortress-bunkers of **Dustwall** inside a colossal impact crater under the motto: *Respect the Vent, Guard the Seal, Mind the Gauge.* Outside, red silica storms strip automotive paint to bare metal in minutes.

When dust storms roll in from the Badlands, visibility drops to zero, and sirens howl across the crater rim. Life retreats into the bedrock, where Craggen stonemasons carve labyrinthine family halls, trading stories over mugs of bitter chicory while waiting out the sun. Administered by the **Mining Directorate** (Caldera Foundry, Independent Prospectors Union, and Craggen Synod), community justice is embodied by **Aldorman Grady**, a retired bore-mechanic whose fair porch rulings are revered by all miners. The Sheriff commands the **Dustwall Rovers** in armored crawlers, enforcing strict "Mine Law" against claim-jumping, water theft, and oxygen hoarding.

Key assets include **The Gilded Bore** (city-block excavator), **Basalt Geothermal Cooling Banks**, **Crater Blast Vaults**, and **Suncatcher Railheads**. The Consortium issues **Badland Interdiction Contracts** to hunt desert outlaws and recover hijacked ore crawlers, paying in unrefined mineral ingots and forged heat sinks.

5. THE RIME COASTAL MUNICIPALITIES (RIME)

Pinned between the crushing glacial ice sheet of the frozen Outer Face and the storm-tossed waters of the circular geothermal ocean known as "The Thaw," the people of Rime have elevated stoic endurance into an art form under the code: *Keep the Pipes Hot and the Ice Broken.* Seven compact coastal burgs are built directly into volcanic basalt cliffs, anchored with tension cables and heated by geothermal steam pipes routed from deep undersea vents beneath shimmering violet auroras. In cliffside taverns overlooking steaming waters, frost-farmers and deep-sea divers gather around glowing volcanic hearths, telling tales of pre-human relics trapped in the ice shelf.

United under the **Thaw Council** of seven Burgomasters, chief assets include the nuclear super-ice-breaker *Iron Walrus*, **Basalt Vent Thermal Towers**, **Cliffside Beacon Networks**, and **Sub-Glacial Drydocks**. The Council issues **Emergency Crisis Writs** to Corsairs who demonstrate humility and competence, offering an isolated, safe haven where crews can refit hulls in quiet volcanic dry-docks without filing twenty forms with the Flotilla.

THE SOVEREIGN COLONIES & MUNICIPAL JURISDICTIONS MATRIX

COLONIAL BODY	WORLD / BIOME	GOVERNANCE MODEL	LAW ENFORCEMENT	DRACONIC PATRON / TITAN	CORSAIR WARRANT TYPE
Crossroads High Council	Landfall (Temperate)	Representative Guild Council	Municipal Constabulary	Goldheart (The Protector)	Writs of Recovery
Arcology Directorate	Nimbus (Vertical Spire)	Shareholder Oligarchy	Nightwatch Enforcers	Stormdrinker (The Sage)	Black-Lanyard Warrants
Pontoon Assembly	Pelagia (Oceanic)	Aristocratic Land Barons	Tidewarden Guild	Leviathan (The Abyssal)	Letters of Maritime Marque
Mining Consortium	Suncatcher (Arid Crater)	Industrial Directorate & Aldorman	Dustwall Rovers	Sandwyrm (Slain 175 AA)	Badland Interdictions
The Thaw Council	Rime (Glacial Coast)	Autonomous Burgomasters	Municipal Ice-Wardens	None (Geothermal Vents)	Emergency Crisis Writs

THE MEGACORPORATIONS

JURISDICTION: Industrial Enclaves, Corporate Leaseholds, Refinery Orbits
AUTHORITY: Proprietary Patent Codes, Employment Scrip, Private Charters
PRIMARY HOUSES: Trade Alliance, Caldera, Panthera, Vandal's, KSK, CQV, RF, SRC

In a universe where every breath of pressurized air must be metered by an intake valve and every kilogram of structural titanium must be blasted out of an airless crater by heavy excavators, corporations are not merely commercial businesses. They are sovereign, feudal superpowers with balance sheets instead of heraldry and private security battalions instead of royal guards.

Planetary governments may hold the soil under the Skyline Accords, and the Flotilla may rule the void, but the corporations own the plumbing that connects them. They own the atmospheric scrubbers that prevent city spires from suffocating; they hold the patents on the Draco fusion drive coils that keep freighters burning between worlds; and in many mining basins, they print the only currency the commissary will accept.

1. THE TRADE ALLIANCE

COMMERCIAL PROFILE & CORPORATE ETHOS

The **Trade Alliance** is the oldest and most politically entrenched commercial coalition in Newcomer civilization. Founded in 180 AA during the catastrophic Inter-Binary Famine—when the destruction of the Pelagia-Suncatcher water railguns threatened to starve the young colonies—the Alliance was formed by a desperate syndicate of independent freighter captains, warehouse syndicates, and bulk grain brokers who pooled their ships to run emergency relief convoys across the void.

That humanitarian origin story has long since calcified into an all-encompassing, bureaucratic freight cartel. Their philosophy is unyielding: *Civilization is a supply chain, and anyone who disrupts the schedule is an enemy of progress.* They view planetary borders as irritating friction, naval blockades as supply-chain inefficiencies, and custom duties as an unprovoked assault on the natural right of cargo to move from point A to point B without someone opening the crate.

LEADERSHIP, ASSETS & RELATIONSHIP WITH CORSAIRS

The Alliance is governed by the **Board of Syndics** aboard the massive distribution hub *Cross-Drift Station* at Fume L1. While maintaining the armed **Maritime Logistics Escort Division**, their greatest weapon is the **Central Clearing Ledger**: if a planetary council pushes the Alliance too far, the Board declares the port an "Uninsured Vector," tripling shipping insurance premiums until the local economy grinds to a halt.

The Alliance is the largest commercial underwriter of Corsair cells, issuing **Commercial Protection Warrants** to hunt down pirates, recover impounded grain shipments, and secure orbital depots, paying promptly in universal credits.

2. CALDERA FOUNDRY (CF)

COMMERCIAL PROFILE & CORPORATE ETHOS

If the Sphere has a spine, **Caldera Foundry** forged it from hot iron, rolled titanium, and stubborn human sweat. Based in the volcanic craters of Suncatcher and maintaining heavy foundries in Landfall's industrial perimeter, Caldera manufactures the colossal bucket-wheel excavators that chew through planetary crusts, structural girders for arcologies, heavy armor plate for Flotilla cruisers, and devastating kinetic artillery.

Their culture is unapologetically industrial and insular. Caldera communities in Dustwall are closed-loop company ecosystems paying miners in brass **Caldera Scrip**. Employees rally around the legendary **Caldera Foundry baseball team**, whose dust-swept matches against prospector clubs are frontier legends. Steered by the **Board of Iron Masters** under Managing Director **Torin Calder**, security is enforced by the cyber-augmented **Foundry Iron Guard** with pneumatic trench weapons.

Signature assets include the **"Anvil" Railgun Battery**, the monstrous **"Mjolnir" Spinal Coilgun**, the heavy **"Sledgehammer" Flak Cannon**, and the rugged **CF "Cinder" Strike Frigate**. Caldera hires Corsairs to hunt Badland claim-jumpers and recover hijacked ore crawlers, paying in refined alloy ingots and proprietary starship heat sinks.

3. PANTHERA AEROSPACE & ARMS (PA)

COMMERCIAL PROFILE & CORPORATE ETHOS

Where Caldera Foundry represents raw industrial mass, **Panthera Aerospace & Arms** represents cold, lethal precision. Stamped with the distinctive silhouette of a snarling predatory cat, Panthera hardware is the undisputed gold standard for high-spec military operations, corporate private security, and wealthy Corsair cells.

Based out of high-altitude aerospace complexes on Nimbus and maintaining gleaming orbital skunkworks, Panthera operates on an ethos of uncompromising engineering tolerance. They believe that a weapon or an aerospace hull should not merely be functional; it should be a marvel of ergonomic balance, acoustic dampening, and lethal efficiency. Panthera's corporate atmosphere is sleek, sterile, and aggressively competitive. Executive suites are decorated in minimalist frosted glass and dark titanium; research teams are subjected to relentless peer performance reviews; and field agents dress in tailored, low-profile tactical suits that look equally appropriate in an executive boardroom or a zero-gravity boarding corridor.

LEADERSHIP, PARAMILITARY & ASSETS

Panthera is governed by the **Executive Directorate of Defense**, presided over by Chief Executive **Corinne Vance**, a brilliant, ruthless former aerospace engineer whose family has held senior seats since the Scavenger Wars. Vance runs the company with military discipline, enforcing strict operational compartmentation across all research divisions.

The company's private enforcement arm—**Panthera Tactical Solutions (PTS)**—is one of the most capable corporate paramilitary forces in the Sphere. Equipped with proprietary stealth interceptors, smart-linked composite armor, and high-velocity marksman rifles, PTS teams protect corporate VIPs, guard high-security research vaults, and conduct deniable "competitive asset acquisitions" against rival firms.

Signature naval armaments include close-in point defenses: the ubiquitous **"Sentinel" Rotary PDC**, the heavy **"Guardian" PDC**, and the **"Caltrop" Proximity Mine Dispenser**, alongside precision rifles and the orbital **PA Apex Skunkworks**. Panthera frequently issues **Field Evaluation Contracts**, offering prototype rifles and experimental PDC fire-control software in exchange for real-world combat telemetry.

4. VANDAL'S WORKSHOP (VW)

COMMERCIAL PROFILE & CORPORATE ETHOS

If you ask an engineer from Panthera Arms how a firearm functions, they will give you a ninety-minute lecture on gas piston tolerances, ceramic barrel coatings, and micro-harmonic recoil vectors. If you ask an armorer from **Vandal's Workshop**, they will hand you a five-kilo stamped-sheet assault carbine, rack the bolt with a sound like a closing vault door, and tell you: *"Drop it in a mud swamp, bake it in a silica storm, drag it through hard vacuum, and pull the trigger. It goes bang. If it doesn't, hit it with a rock. Now pay me."*

Born in the rough-and-tumble industrial outskirts of Landfall during the early expansion era, Vandal's Workshop was founded by a cantankerous Craggen-Human mechanic collective who believed that frontier equipment had become too fragile, too expensive, and far too obsessed with polite aesthetics. Vandal's Workshop prides itself on utter utilitarian ruggedness. Their weapons are built with thick stamped steel, oversized charging handles, and generous internal clearances that refuse to jam even when packed with abrasive red dust. In the brutal frontiers of Suncatcher, the soggy trenches of Kazahn, or the freezing ice shelves of Rime, spacers trust Vandal because Vandal gear simply refuses to die.

GUILD GOVERNANCE, HARDWARE & CORSAIR SUPPORT

Vandal's Workshop has no corporate board or glossy marketing department. The company is operated as an anarchic, highly efficient **Artisans' Guild**, presided over by the rotating Lead Foreman—currently **Marta "Hammer-Hand" Kovic**, a scarred Naga welder with forty years in industrial fabrication. Guild resolutions are decided over grease-stained workbenches in Foundry Row: if an apprentice designs a new part, the elders throw it off the roof, hit it with a sledgehammer, and soak it in hydraulic acid; if it survives, it enters production.

Signature hardware includes stamped-sheet kinetic carbines, heavy submachine guns, zero-g pump shotguns, industrial hazard battleplate, universal field modification kits, and the sprawling **Scrap-Works Garage** on Landfall. Vandal is beloved by young Corsair crews for cheap, durable gear and lifetime repair warranties honored at any authorized greasy workbench across the Sphere.

5. KER'SATZ KORP (KSK)

COMMERCIAL PROFILE & CORPORATE ETHOS

Ker'Satz Korp is the heavy life-support and long-range ordnance juggernaut of the Sphere. If you are breathing pressurized air on an orbital station, drinking recycled moisture in a mining outpost, or locking an airlock seal before atmospheric reentry, the tiny brass pressure regulator keeping you alive has the stylized hexagonal "K" of Ker'Satz stamped into its casing.

Founded by Naga geothermal engineers and Human aerospace industrialists, KSK views civilization through the lens of thermodynamic survival: space is an active enemy that wants to suck your moisture, freeze your blood, and crush your chest; survival requires uncompromising structural integrity. Hardware is massive and over-engineered, designed for catastrophic structural punishment across interplanetary distances. Headquartered at *Station Hexagon* orbiting Fume under High Director **Sseth Ker'Satz**, security is maintained by the heavy-carapace **Hexagon Vanguard**.

Signature assets include the **"Harpoon" Kinetic Missile**, the **"Lance" Torpedo**, the **"Voidlance" Fusion Torpedo**, radar-absorbent **"Specter" Stealth Missile**, the **KSK "Dagger" Interdictor**, and gargantuan **KSK "Leviathan" Dreadnought**, alongside life-support regulators and ballistic breach chassis. KSK issues **Critical Asset Defense Contracts**, rewarding Corsairs with mil-spec torpedo munitions and high-pressure environmental gear, demanding strict telemetry logs and zero warranty bypasses.

6. CHIDORI-QWEI VOIDWORKS & COMBATWEAR (CQV)

COMMERCIAL PROFILE & CORPORATE ETHOS

Perched in the gleaming spires of Cloudspire on Nimbus, **Chidori-Qwei** is where high fashion, bleeding-edge directed-energy physics, and tactical survivability collide. CQV caters to the high-society elite, executive protection details, and top-tier Corsair marshals who believe there is no reason to look like a grease-stained mechanic during a lethal firefight.

Their **Combatwear** line features tailored trench coats, flightsuits, and evening jackets woven from ballistic smart-fibers that remain flexible in conversation but instantly stiffen into rigid kinetic-dispersing armor when struck by high-velocity rounds. Their **Voidworks** division specializes in directed-energy naval armaments: the **"Wasp" Pulse Laser**, **"Solarflare" Laser Array**, **"Eclipse" Particle Beam**, and massive **"Prometheus" Heavy Laser**, alongside the radar-absorbent **CQV "Shinobi" Stealth Recon** corvette and smart-linked machine pistols.

Presided over by **Lady Evelyn Qwei** and guarded by the elite **Silk Guard**, CQV offers **Brand Ambassador Sponsorships** and discreet espionage contracts to stylish Corsair cells—recovering stolen fashion sketches, extracting compromised corporate fixers, or neutralizing rival blackmail rings.

7. REDFEATHER AEROSPACE (RF)

COMMERCIAL PROFILE & CORPORATE ETHOS

If you ask any working-class spacer in the Sphere to draw a starship, they will sketch the clean, angular lines of a **Redfeather Aerospace** hull. Based on Landfall, Redfeather is the shipyard of the common people, building the honest, reliable, multi-role workhorses that carry the life of the system.

Redfeather's design philosophy is mass production, modularity, and accessibility. Hulls feature standardized bulkhead dimensions, accessible conduit chases, and universal engine mounts accepting virtually any fusion drive. If a component breaks, spacers do not need advanced degrees; they buy a replacement gasket at any dusty port, bolt it into place with an adjustable wrench, and burn before the coffee cools. For generations of spacers, a second-hand Redfeather hull is freedom itself.

Governed by the **Board of Master Shipwrights** under Chairman **Arthur "Wings" Henderson**, Redfeather maintains a close, ethical relationship with its unionized workforce and the High Council. Signature hulls include the **RF "Kestrel" Multi-Role Corvette** (the quintessential Corsair starter ship), **RF "Talon" Light Interceptor**, **RF "Falcon" System Patrol Boat**, and the massive **Western Slipways**. Redfeather actively subsidizes down-payments for promising young crews and issues escort and test-flight recovery warrants.

8. THE SPHERE RESEARCH CENTER (SRC)

COMMERCIAL PROFILE & SCIENTIFIC LEGACY

While technically an academic and scientific consortium rather than a profit-maximizing commercial corporation, the **Sphere Research Center (SRC)** wields industrial and geopolitical influence that eclipses most megacorporations. Headquartered in the sprawling ivory towers of Crossroads on Landfall and maintaining high-altitude lightning observatories in Cloudspire on Nimbus, the SRC is the paramount intellectual institution of Newcomer civilization.

In 38 AA, working in direct consultation with **Stormdrinker**, SRC physicists unraveled the bio-fusion principles that led to the invention of the **Draco Fusion Drive**—the single breakthrough that made sub-light interplanetary spaceflight possible. Today, governed by the **Council of Curators** under **Arch-Curator Varisia Lin**, the SRC catalogs Precursor Vault ruins while enforcing strict containment protocols alongside Stormdrinker and Goldheart to prevent dormant defense networks from waking. Security is enforced by the elite **Archive Wardens**. The SRC issues **Academic Recovery Petitions** to Corsairs to explore newly discovered ruins and recover stolen data drives.

THE EIGHT MEGACORPORATIONS & INDUSTRIAL CARTELS MATRIX

CORPORATION	PRIMARY SEAT	INDUSTRIAL SPECIALIZATION	FLAGSHIP HARDWARE / ASSETS	SECURITY ARM	CORSAIR WARRANT PROFILE
Trade Alliance	Fume L1 (Cross-Drift)	System-Wide Freight, Logistics, Banking	Cross-Drift Central, Clearing Ledger	Maritime Logistics Escort	Commercial Protection Warrants
Caldera Foundry	Dustwall (Suncatcher)	Heavy Mining, Smelting, Kinetic Ordnance	Anvil Railgun, Mjolnir Spinal Coilgun	Foundry Iron Guard	Badland Claim Defense & Recovery
Panthera Arms	Cloudspire (Nimbus)	High-Spec Aerospace, PDCs, Precision Guns	Sentinel Rotary PDC, Guardian PDC	Panthera Tactical Solutions	Field Evaluation & Prototype Trials
Vandal's Workshop	Foundry Row (Landfall)	Rugged Utilitarian Arms, Hazard Armor	Stamped Carbines, Scrap Carapace	Workshop Foremen Collective	Scrap Recovery & Barricade Breaching
Ker'Satz Korp	Station Hexagon (Fume)	Life-Support Systems, Capital Torpedoes	Harpoon Missile, Voidlance Torpedo	Hexagon Vanguard	Critical Asset Defense Contracts
Chidori-Qwei	Cloudspire Upper Spire	Combatwear Smart-Fibers, Pulse Lasers	Prometheus Laser, Shinobi Stealth Recon	The Silk Guard	Brand Ambassador Sponsorships
Redfeather Aero	Western Slips (Landfall)	Modular Starship Construction & Drydocks	RF "Kestrel" Corvette, Talon Interceptor	Yard Constabulary	Freelancer Subsidies & Escorts
Sphere Research Ctr	Crossroads Institute	Precursor Science, Fusion Telemetry, Vaults	Draco Patent Trust, Storm Observatories	The Archive Wardens	Academic Recovery Petitions

THE ECONOMIC ENGINE OF THE SPHERE

While governments debate in Crossroads and admirals review readiness in Redmane Station, the daily survival of the Sphere depends upon the fragile equilibrium of these eight corporate houses. A strike at Caldera's smelting foundries delays Redfeather's slipways; an unannounced tariff by the Trade Alliance strands grain on Landfall; and an aggressive hostile takeover by Panthera can trigger covert proxy wars in Cloudspire's ravines. Navigating these corporate rivalries is the ultimate test of a Corsair cell's tactical acumen.

THE UNDERWORLD & SYNDICATES

JURISDICTION: Unpoliced Ravines, Crash Exclusion Zones, Badlands, The Deep Shadow
AUTHORITY: Raw Physical Force, Syndicate Ledgers, The Black-Market Exchange
PRIMARY FACTIONS: The Jailers of Evergaol, The Cloudsurfers, The Iron Fang, The Desert Wraiths, The Children of the Leviathan

Wherever formal law draws a boundary, human—and non-human—ingenuity immediately invents a way to crawl beneath it. In the Sphere, the "Underworld" is not a single, tidy criminal syndicate with a dark-suited godfather sitting behind a mahogany desk. It is a sprawling, pragmatic, and remarkably stubborn ecosystem of people who looked at the high price of legal air, legal food, and legal docking permits, decided the mathematics were unacceptable, and resolved to make their own arrangements.

Crime in the Sphere is rarely ideological. It is driven by the brutal thermodynamics of the frontier: if the corporate monopoly on Nimbus charges twenty credits for an atmospheric filter that costs two credits to stamp from scrap sheet, someone in the foggy lower ravines will inevitably figure out how to steal the stamping die. And if the Flotilla outlaws the trafficking of unsanitized Precursor tech under naval quarantine and colonial safety edicts, someone on Landfall will happily risk catastrophic cellular radiation to haul an alien focusing coil out of a smoldering impact crater, because that single humming cylinder of superconducting circuitry can buy a family fresh groceries and a decommissioned hopper for ten years.

The underworld exists in the cracks between the great powers: in the three kilometers of toxic, unpoliced fog beneath Cloudspire's gleaming skywalks; in the trackless, red-dust canyons of Suncatcher's Badlands where corporate crawlers fear to tread; in the creaking shantytown reef-barges of Pelagia; and in the radioactive exclusion zones of Landfall where automated alien kill-nodes still hunt the unwary.

1. THE JAILERS OF EVERGAOL

CRIMINAL PROFILE & OUTLAW ETHOS

If you ask an honest citizen in Crossroads about the **Evergaol Crash Site**, they will cross their fingers, murmur a quiet prayer of thanks to Goldheart, and change the subject. The crash site is a continent-scale scar on Landfall's crust where the ancient automated dreadnought was brought down in 508 AA. It is a restricted exclusion zone of jagged black metal, active alien defense drones, and bizarre energy leaks. The **Jailers** are the only people in the Sphere insane enough to call it home.

Composed of eccentric salvagers, renegade scientists, and mutated survivors who refused to abandon the crash perimeter, the Jailers dwell inside the hollowed-out titanium ribbing and cavernous cooling decks of the fallen dreadnought. Their cultural philosophy blends scavenger pragmatism with pseudo-religious reverence for alien technology, viewing the wreck not as an apocalyptic war grave, but as an infinite, miraculous junkyard sent by the gods to provide for anyone brave enough to pry open a bulkhead. They paint crude warning runes with engine grease, wear patchwork hazard suits adorned with pulsing Precursor fiber-optics, and speak a rapid, clipped dialect filled with garbled machine-code terms.

LEADERSHIP & THE "BLOODMAGES"

The Jailers have no central council; they operate as autonomous salvage clans that convene around shared barter-hearths deep inside the wreck. Authority within the clans belongs unconditionally to the **Jailer Bloodmages**. Despite their terrifying, occult-sounding title, Bloodmages possess no mystical magic: they are veteran cyberneticists and scavengers who perform reckless, illegal home-brew surgery upon their own bodies, grafting active Precursor neural shunts and salvaged thermal conduits directly into their nervous systems and circulatory tracks.

By siphoning electrical energy from their own biological metabolic heat and directing it through subcutaneous alien filaments, a Bloodmage projects short-range kinetic displacement barriers (the "Crimson Shield") or vents concentrated, high-velocity thermal arcs from their hands (the "Piercing Blood"). This biological interface takes a horrific physical toll: bulging dark veins, ash-pale skin, and violent auditory hallucinations caused by the humming coils. To outsiders, they look like terrifying warlocks; to their clans, they are living gods who can walk past the dreadnought's automated point-defense nodes without being vaporized.

TERRITORY, ASSETS & CORSAIR CONTRACTS

The Jailers control the primary interior pathways of the Evergaol Exclusion Zone, fiercely guarding their private tunnels against corporate reclamation units and Flotilla research teams. Signature assets include illicit Precursor relics (superconducting coils, alien sensor arrays), the subterranean **Smuggler Trenches** bored beneath the crater's sensor perimeter, and heavy tracked **Jailer Scrap-Rigs** equipped with cutting torches.

While the Jailers view Corsairs with intense wariness as armed lapdogs of the Council, they are above all merchants. When a salvage clan unearths a device that is too dangerous or unstable to keep—such as an active alien beacon heating up bedrock—they quietly contact an independent Corsair cell to buy it off them before corporate death squads arrive.

2. THE CLOUDSURFERS

CRIMINAL PROFILE & OUTLAW ETHOS

Two hundred levels beneath the gleaming, rain-washed penthouses of Cloudspire on Nimbus, where corporate directors sip imported wine, the city's glittering architecture gives way to the "Non-Serviced Sub-Deck Concessions"—a polite bureaucratic term for the dark, damp, and neglected industrial ravines where the air is thick with chemical fog and neon signs flicker with electrical faults. This is the sovereign sky of the **Cloudsurfers**.

The Cloudsurfers are the iconic youth counter-culture, smuggler guild, and aerial gang of Nimbus. Mounted on custom-fabricated magnetic-repulsor hoverboards powered by modified drone turbine batteries, these daredevils soar through the vertical abyss of the city at breakneck speeds. They glide between titanium foundation pylons, ride thermal updrafts of massive ventilation stacks, and dart through narrow gaps between mid-deck skybridges, daring Directorate police craft to chase them into the treacherous gloom. Cloudsurfers dress in colorful, oversized windbreakers patched with thermal lining, wear high-altitude rebreathers sprayed with graffiti, and communicate through complex aerial hand-signals and encrypted radio clicks, despising corporate monopolies on air and real estate.

LEADERSHIP, LOGISTICS & CORSAIR ALLIANCE

The Cloudsurfers are divided into dozens of neighborhood crews (the *Vapor Hawks*, *Pylon Rats*, *Neon Drifters*) claiming specific ventilation shafts and catwalks. Turf disputes are settled not with lethal firefights, but through high-stakes "High-Deck Runs"—perilous hoverboard races through obstacle-laden transit tunnels where the loser forfeits their board and route. Leadership belongs to the fastest "Wing-Lead" who has pulled off the most brazen stunts.

The older crews operate as the most efficient, decentralized courier service in the cluster, delivering un-metered pharmaceuticals, stolen data chips, and black-market electronics. Custom repulsor boards feature miniature solid-fuel rocket boosters for vertical agility, roosting in makeshift **Pylon Hangars** welded to the blind sides of suspension towers.

To most Corsairs, Cloudsurfers are an absolute nightmare to catch in tight vertical alleys. However, clever cells quickly learn they make invaluable allies: spending eighteen hours a day soaring through the city's underbelly, they see every covert shuttle landing and corporate hideout. A Corsair who buys a round of hot noodles at a mid-deck kiosk can purchase the finest reconnaissance network on Nimbus for a handful of credit chits.

3. THE IRON FANG SYNDICATE

CRIMINAL PROFILE & CORPORATE-SCALE CRIME

Where the Jailers are strange hermits and the Cloudsurfers are rebellious daredevils, the **Iron Fang** represents organized, professional, and corporate-scale crime. Spanning the entire Fume cluster and maintaining branch operations in the frontier boomtowns of Wanabo, the Iron Fang is the undisputed heavyweight of interplanetary contraband.

The Iron Fang operates not like street thugs, but like a shadow megacorporation. They maintain audited accounts, enforce strict non-disclosure contracts, employ top-tier maritime lawyers, and conduct their business in private luxury suites aboard orbital transit stations. Their philosophy is pure, cold capitalism stripped of legal pretense: *The law is simply a tariff imposed by governments that lack the efficiency to compete on an open market.* They fill every profitable vacuum created by Flotilla regulations: running black-market shipyards that scrape transponders off stolen corvettes, trafficking unregistered military coilgun munitions, and smuggling refined helium-3 past naval customs pickets.

LEADERSHIP, PARAMILITARY & CORSAIR RELATIONS

The syndicate is steered by the **Fang Directorate**, a secret council of seven criminal bosses based in the commercial underbelly of Port Zenith and Cloudspire. The presiding figure is **Syndic Anton Drake**, a charming, bespoke-tailored Naga gentleman who speaks five languages fluently and has never physically held a firearm in his life.

Enforcement is carried out by the **Iron Guard**—professional mercenary squads composed of dishonorably discharged Flotilla marines and corporate security defectors equipped with military rifles, heavy body armor, and breaching tools. Operating through Port Zenith front companies and stripped-down "Ghost Corvettes" with sensor-absorbing paint, their relationship with Corsairs is one of intense professionalism. The Fang frequently leaks the flight vectors of psychotic rival pirates to trusted Corsair cells, letting the lawmen eliminate disruptions for free via anonymous data chits.

4. THE DESERT WRAITHS

CRIMINAL PROFILE & OUTLAW ETHOS

Out beyond the protective walls of Dustwall on Suncatcher lies the **Badlands**—a vast, searing hellscape of red silica dust, sheer sandstone canyons, and blistering solar winds where the temperature swings eighty degrees in thirty hours. To corporate mining directors, the Badlands are a desolate wasteland to be exploited with heavy tracked crawlers; to the **Desert Wraiths**, the Badlands are holy ground.

The Wraiths are an insular, nomadic federation of survivalist tribes composed of Craggen outcasts, Naga desert-dwellers, and third-generation prospector families who abandoned corporate company towns to live free in the canyons. They view corporate mining cartels—particularly Caldera Foundry—as rapacious parasites who poison water aquifers, shatter sacred geological strata, and treat living beings like disposable tools. Layered in dust-caked sand-cloaks over environmental hazard suits, they wear panoramic rebreathers with polarized filters and travel on high-speed solar sand-skimmers with balloon tires.

GUERRILLA TACTICS & CORSAIR HOSPITALITY

Organized into family clans led by **Elder Sand-Speakers** who navigate by celestial constellations and acoustic canyon echoes, the Wraiths are terrifying ambush predators. Rather than engaging heavy mining crawlers in open firefights, their signature tool is the **Veil of Sand**: aerosol canisters releasing dense clouds of polarized abrasive silica that completely blind radar, infrared, and optical cameras. Emerging from the dust cloud on foot, Wraiths scale the crawler's hull, disable external radiator loops with thermal charges, and force the crew to surrender by threatening environmental seals.

Signature assets include hijacked mining crawlers converted into hidden mobile villages, secret geothermal aquifers, and shoulder-fired magnetic harpoons. While hostile to corporate mercenaries, Wraiths honor ancient desert hospitality: Corsairs who rescue stranded sand-scouts or defend settlements earn "Dune-Kin" standing, gaining safe passage, secret water access, and canyon guides that no corporate satellite can map.

5. THE CHILDREN OF THE LEVIATHAN

CRIMINAL PROFILE & ABYSSAL ZEALOTRY

In the creaking, salt-rimed shantytown flotillas that cling to Pelagia's equatorial reefs, life is fragile, damp, and exhausting. Spacers spend twelve hours a day scraping algae from nylon nets, skin permanently raw from salt spray, while Land Barons on opulent pontoon estates raise the price of fresh water every time a typhoon damages their tennis courts. Under these conditions, it is easy to look down into the deep emerald ocean and look for a higher power.

The **Children of the Leviathan** are a clandestine, fanatical maritime cult that operates across the lower decks of Pelagia. They worship the **Leviathan**—the colossal biological titan slumbering in the Mariana Abyssal Trench four kilometers beneath the surface. To cultists, the Leviathan is not an alien biological hazard; it is the living soul of the world, a slumbering god that drowned the Sandwyrm during the ancient Inter-Binary Famine and preserved the oceans for mortal life.

Their religious dogma teaches that the surface world is a corrupt, temporary illusion, and that one day the Leviathan will rise from the abyss to cleanse the ocean of the Land Barons' floating palaces. While ordinary citizens dismiss them as mad reef-scum, the cult possesses a terrifying, blind devotion that makes them unpredictable and dangerous.

LEADERSHIP, MARITIME SABOTAGE & ALIEN RELICS

Guided by the **Trench Disciples**, charismatic preachers claiming to hear the "Song of the Deep" (sub-audible acoustic reverberations from the trench), the cult operates in absolute secrecy within hollowed-out coral caverns and flooded ballast tanks. Cultists possess an absolute, terrifying indifference to death: a zealot will happily strap acoustic charges to their chest and dive into a luxury yacht's propeller intake, smiling as the hull buckles, convinced their soul will be embraced by the titan in the deep dark.

Signature assets include heavy acoustic limpet mines, stripped submersible sea-scooters, and hallucinogens brewed from deep-sea vent fungi to finance weapons. While the Tidewarden Guild issues **Anti-Cult Suppression Writs** to clear saboteur nests and protect offshore drilling platforms, cultists are often the first to notice energetic anomalies when deep-core drilling breaches ancient undersea Precursor vaults, making them an unsettling source of intelligence for daring Corsair cells.

THE UNDERWORLD & FRINGE CONTRABAND NETWORKS MATRIX

SYNDICATE / FACTION	OPERATIONAL DOMAIN	LEADERSHIP CORE	ILLICIT COMMODITIES & SPECIALTIES	PARAMILITARY THREAT LEVEL	CORSAIR ANGLE
The Jailers of Evergaol	Landfall (Crash Exclusion Zone)	Jailer Bloodmages & Clan Chiefs	Active Precursor coils, alien neural shunts, salvage rigs	High (Precursor shields, thermal arcs, kill-nodes)	Artifact recovery, containment writs, black-market sales
The Cloudsurfers	Nimbus (Sub-Deck Ravines)	Crew Wing-Leads (Vapor Hawks, etc.)	High-speed courier transit, un-metered medicine, data chips	Moderate (Agile repulsor flight, hit-and-run, vertical ambushes)	Urban reconnaissance, covert drop-offs, tracking targets
Iron Fang Syndicate	System-Wide (Fume / Wanabo)	Fang Directorate (Anton Drake)	Ghost corvettes, unregistered coilgun ordnance, He-3 smuggling	Severe (Ex-Flotilla marines, heavy armor, breaching tools)	High-value bounties, anonymous tip-offs, grey-market broker
The Desert Wraiths	Suncatcher (The Badlands)	Elder Sand-Speakers	Hijacked tracked crawlers, subterranean water, heavy harpoons	High (Veil of Sand sensor blinding, canyon ambushes)	Dune-Kin hospitality, desert safe passage, anti-claim bounties
Children of Leviathan	Pelagia (Equatorial Reef Slums)	Trench Disciples	Acoustic limpet mines, sea-scooters, abyssal hallucinogens	Dangerous (Fanatical suicide charges, maritime sabotage)	Platform defense writs, uncovering deep-sea Precursor ruins

THE GOLDEN RULE OF THE UNDERWORLD

In the shadows between planetary law and naval patrols, trust is the only hard currency that doesn't depreciate. A Corsair cell that keeps its word to an underworld informant gains ears in every dockside tavern from Crossroads to Port Azure. A cell that burns an informant or steals from a syndicate ledger will find their life-support valves failing thirty thousand kilometers from the nearest rescue cutter.

FIELD DOSSIER: THE SHADOW HOURS ON LEVEL 120

Midnight in the lower ravines of Cloudspire. Two hundred levels beneath the rain-washed penthouses where corporate directors sip imported wine, the air is thick, humid, and heavy with viscous inert gases. Dax, a freelance avionics technician with a mountain of medical debt, ducks beneath the hissing steam pipes of an abandoned transit tunnel to meet an Iron Fang intermediary for an un-serialized Draco pre-igniter. Overhead, the rhythmic thrum-buzz of hoverboards echoes as Cloudsurfers tag a ventilation stack with glowing paint, daring Directorate police craft to descend into the unpoliced gloom.

NAVIGATING THE BLACK MARKETS OF 518 AA

For newly commissioned Corsair crews, the underworld is rarely a simple shooting gallery of marked targets. While Flotilla bulletins list lavish bounties on Iron Fang lieutenants and Cloudsurfer smugglers, seasoned marshals understand that complete eradication of the black market is a physical impossibility in a system with millions of cubic kilometers of unpatrolled void.

The most successful Corsair cells learn to walk the razor's edge: enforcing naval safety edicts and neutralizing violent marauders while maintaining functional backchannels with grey-market fixers, fence brokers, and scrap salvagers. In the harsh reality of the frontier, a well-timed whisper from a Cloudsurfer runner or a discreet fuel transfer from an Iron Fang depot is often the thin margin between completing a critical mission and suffocating in hard vacuum.

Furthermore, while Flotilla universal credits and Crossroads trade chits circulate through authorized banking terminals, the underworld trades in tangible bearer commodities: pressurized oxygen bottles, un-cracked Precursor cells, refined lithium bars, and encrypted bearer chits verified by Port Zenith ledgers. A Corsair cell operating deep beyond the reach of naval relay buoys knows that carrying tangible barter commodities is often the only way to purchase emergency propellant from a hostile frontier habitat.

Ultimately, the underworld reflects the unfinished business of the migration. Until the colonies can guarantee cheap air and fair wages to every newcomer who wakes from cryo-sleep, the shadow cartels and ravine smugglers will continue to thrive in the dark corners between the spires.

THE FLOTILLA & LAW OF THE VOID

JURISDICTION: The High Void, Transit Lanes, & Lagrange Hubs ("The Law of the Void")
AUTHORITY: Supreme Naval Command & Interplanetary Peacekeeping (Skyline Accords)
PRIMARY SEATS: Redmane Station (HQ), Port Zenith Bastion Yards, Waypoint Station (L1)

To the civilian walking the paved streets of Crossroads or gazing out the panoramic windows of Cloudspire, space is an awe-inspiring, silent canvas of amber starlight and swirling gas giant rings. To those wearing the slate-grey uniform of the Flotilla, space is mostly the smell of ozone and machine oil, the taste of lukewarm instant chicory brewed from recycled greywater, and the unyielding magnetic *clack-clack* of standard-issue steel-toed boots locking onto steel deck plates thirty thousand times a day.

The Flotilla is the sovereign peacekeeper of the void, custodian of the navigational beacon network, and ultimate arbiter of the "Law of the Void." Consecrated by the **Skyline Accords of 335 AA**, the fleet holds absolute legal authority over open space, orbital lanes, and Lagrange customs hubs. Yet, under constitutional treaty, Flotilla warships are strictly barred from firing into planetary atmospheres or deploying boots onto planetary soil without unanimous consent from the High Council. Down in the mud, planetary governors hold the reins; up in the dark, the Flotilla rules alone.

1. LIVED EXPERIENCE & THE ONE-YEAR TOUR

The Flotilla belongs directly to the civilian population through the **One-Year Tour**. Every single eighteen-year-old in the system—pampered heirs from Pelagia, red-dust prospectors from Suncatcher, or apprentice carpenters from Crossroads—is drafted for twelve months of mandatory service. Scraping carbon burns off thruster manifolds in zero-g strips away planetary parochialism in weeks: recruits quickly learn that lineage and class mean nothing compared to keeping your tether clipped and remembering which valve vents the secondary airlock. In the crowded bunk modules of Waypoint Station, lifelong bonds are forged between kids from rival moons who otherwise would never have met.

The prevailing naval philosophy is *The Discipline of the Hull*: space is not cruel, because cruelty requires malice, and the universe is far too busy adhering to orbital mechanics to care about mortal feelings. Survival requires constant vigilance, routine maintenance, absolute honesty regarding fuel reserves, and respect for paperwork filed in triplicate. A leaky gasket does not care about your family name; it simply vents your air into the void until you tighten the bolts.

2. GOVERNANCE & THE MATRIX ORGANIZATION

Daily military command is held by the **Admiralty Board** at Redmane Station, answering directly to the civilian **High Council** of colonial delegates who hold the purse strings. Every sailor belongs to both an operational **Wing** and a technical **Corps** (*Marine, Pilot, Engineering, Medical, Officer, Sailor, Admin*).

The Strategic Wings:

- **Administrative Wing:** (Adm. Hesperia Sol) Manages the Sovereign Wealth Fund, infrastructure licensing, and fair-market procurement.
- **Transit Wing:** (Adm. Gorthan Vane) Maintains shipping lanes, navigational beacons, and transmits remote Drive-Interlocks.
- **Patrol Wing:** (Adm. Kaelen Vance) The public face: customs boardings, search-and-rescue, and frontier anti-piracy sweeps.
- **Scout Wing:** (Adm. Siveer) Deep-space passive sensor monitoring, signal decoding, and tracking ghost ships along the Veil.
- **Bastion Wing:** (Adm. Brak-Tor) Static orbital defenses, Lagrange fuel depots, heavy drydock engineering, and salvage.
- **Sword Wing:** (Adm. Elara Thorne) Armored battlecruisers and torpedo flotillas for existential fleet engagements.
- *The Shadow Wing:* An unacknowledged seventh wing funded through microscopic procurement rounding errors to sanitize existential crises.

The Seven Occupational Corps: Sailors are dual-assigned to a functional trade: **Marine Corps** (zero-g boarding & breach security), **Pilot Corps** (high-g interceptor & capital helmsmen), **Engineering Corps** (Draco drive calibration & reactor coils), **Medical Corps** (decompression trauma & radiation pathology), **Officer Corps** (navigational coordination & command), **Sailor Corps** (magazine loading & life-support watches), and **Admin Corps** (forensic audits & fleet supply chains).

3. FLEET DOCTRINE & KEY BASES

Dictated by the hard physics of sub-light space travel, with no faster-than-light travel and no artificial gravity, space combat is an unforgiving duel of thermodynamics, vector management, and kinetic geometry. Warships fight while conducting brutal multi-g Brachistochrone burns, launching kinetic railgun slugs across thousands of kilometers while rotary PDCs shred incoming torpedoes before impact.

Key strongholds include **Redmane Station** (the colossal rotating spindle habitat serving as administrative HQ in high Fume orbit), **Port Zenith Bastion Yards** (Landfall's orbital drydocks where Fleet-Engineer Kira Abe developed the first prototype **MANTLE** combat chassis during the Scavenger Wars), and **Waypoint Station (L1)**, processing millions of tons of inter-moon transit. Flagships like the battlecruiser *FBS Verdant Dawn* anchor system defense.

4. THE PRESENT CRISIS (518 AA)

In 518 AA, exactly ten years after the Frontier War against the Orkish Empire and the catastrophic fall of the ancient alien dreadnought *Evergaol*, the Flotilla is stretched razor-thin. Dozens of capital ships were vaporized or crashed onto Landfall; veteran crews were decimated. Today, scarred hulls face deferred maintenance across three systems (Fume, X'ara, Wanabo) while colonial politicians bicker over defense budgets.

5. RELATIONSHIP WITH THE CORSAIRS

Born out of the Patrol Wing after the 335 AA Skyline Accords, the **Corsair** institution was created to bridge the legal seam between planetary atmosphere and open vacuum. With capital fleets depleted in 518 AA, the Flotilla relies on the **New Wave of Corsairs** more than ever as flexible troubleshooters. Independent crews receive **Naval Warrants**, universal credit bounties, and ordnance subsidies at Bastion depots. In return, the navy demands strict adherence to rules of engagement: rogue cells face ruthless interdiction under the Law of the Void.

LEX AETHERIA: THE LAW OF THE VOID

Under Article IV of the Skyline Accords, any vessel navigating beyond 100 kilometers altitude enters Flotilla maritime jurisdiction. Transponders must broadcast continuous trajectory telemetry. Tampering with distress beacons, venting cargo without vector authorization, or failing to heave-to upon receiving a naval interlock signal constitutes piracy, carrying immediate forfeit of hull and warrant rights.

THE SIX STRATEGIC WINGS OF THE FLOTILLA MATRIX

WING	COMMANDING ADMIRAL	OPERATIONAL DOMAIN	PRIMARY NAVAL MANDATE	CORSAIR WARRANT PROFILE
Administrative	Adm. Hesperia Sol	Financial & Legal HQ	Sovereign Wealth Fund, Procurement, Tariffs	Corporate tax audits, bond recovery, white-collar warrants
Transit	Adm. Gorthan Vane	System Shipping Lanes	Flight Vectors, Beacon Mesh, Drive-Interlocks	Hijacked freighter interdiction, beacon repair, debris clearing
Patrol	Adm. Kaelen Vance	Customs & Deep Space	Customs Boardings, Search & Rescue, Anti-Piracy	Frontier pirate hunting, distress response, escort sweeps
Scout	Adm. Siveer	The Veil & Periphery	Passive Sensor Arrays, Recon, Ghost-Ship Tracking	Long-range recon, anomaly salvage, Precursor containment
Bastion	Adm. Brak-Tor	Orbital Yards & Stations	Static Fortifications, Depots, Heavy Salvage	Depot defense, depressurized station boarding, hull recovery
Sword	Adm. Elara Thorne	Capital Battlefleets	High-Intensity Kinetic Strikes, Railgun Barrages	Pre-strike reconnaissance, vanguard sabotage, strike escorts

ALIEN POWERS & FOREIGN EMPIRES

JURISDICTION: Neighboring Star Systems, Demilitarized Zones, & Quarantined Moons
AUTHORITY: The Sacred Vigil, Imperial Decrees, The Great Tithe, & Naval Treaties
PRIMARY POWERS: Ancestrals of X'ara, Orkish Empire, Scavenger Clans, Lithari of Karst

To the average citizen living on Landfall or Nimbus, the universe ends at the edge of the Fume cluster. They know twenty-six gas giants turn in the celestial clockwork of the Sphere, but the sixty-million-kilometer void between planetary tracks is so vast that foreign civilizations feel like distant myths—until an Orkish battlecruiser's transponder lights up on an outer sensor buoy, or an Ancestral diplomatic barge slides into a docking ring like an ivory ghost.

The Newcomers are not alone in the Sphere. They were merely the last to arrive. Foreign powers do not operate by Newcomer rules: they dismiss municipal ordinances, treat corporate patent law with contempt, and regard the Flotilla's Skyline Accords as a quaint local custom.

1. THE ANCESTRALS OF X'ARA

The oldest surviving civilization in the mapped Sphere resides across the engineered binary worlds of the neighboring **X'ara cluster**. Ascetic and humanoid with opalescent skin and dark eyes adapted to amber starlight, they live under the rigid theological dogma of the **Sacred Vigil**, teaching that the universe was perfected by the ancient "Makers" and that mortal expansion, reckless curiosity, and technological tinkering are grotesque sins of hubris. Their capital spires on **Irul'lia** produce no industrial waste, tapping directly into geothermal dynamos.

Ruled by the immortal **Archon**, contact in 425 AA sparked the **Great Avon Schism** across the binary moons Avon 1 and Avon 2: youthful reformers of the *Gilded Movement* discard traditional robes for colorful vests to visit Fume as enthusiastic "Space Tourists," while militant temple inquisitors of the *Pure Blade* view mortals as a viral contagion and lobby for a holy crusade to cleanse the noise.

2. THE ORKISH EMPIRE

Emerging from the outer void beyond the buffer moons of **Wanabo**, the **Orkish Empire** is a disciplined, martial autocracy of muscular humanoids with dual circulatory systems and immense physical resilience. Ruled with an iron fist by **Emperor Vrakketh**, Orkish society is organized around absolute hierarchy, institutional slavery, and normalized martial violence. Clan Warlords oversee regional fleets, settling command disputes through ritual melee before their assembled troops.

Orkish doctrine rejects delicate skirmishing: their heavy-displacement warships feature solid-tungsten **Forward Ram-Prows** and armored boarding torpedoes designed to smash through hulls, while planetary armies deploy bipedal diesel-fusion combat walkers with pneumatic siege hammers. Following the joint battle against the ancient dreadnought *Evergaol* in 508 AA, Vrakketh signed **the Great Truce**, though border tensions in 518 AA remain at a fever pitch across the Wanabo DMZ.

3. THE SCAVS (SCAVENGER RAIDER CLANS)

Drifting through the deep void in scrap-welded hulls, the **Scavs** are a nomadic, cloned raider species biologically adapted to hard vacuum: two meters tall, sinewy, with multi-faceted optical clusters and **four fully functional arms** capable of enduring minutes of explosive decompression. Governed by the fanatical dogma of **The Great Tithe**, they believe life is a spiritual debt owed to a mythical master called *The Collector*. Led by cybernetic Warmasters and obsessive Tithe-Counters, Scav boarding parties crawl through zero-g maintenance chases to strip copper wiring, fusion coils, and Precursor relics from living ships.

4. THE LITHARI OF KARST

Discovered in 365 AA on the sinkhole moon **Karst**, the **Lithari** are an indigenous stone-age species of slate-skinned tribal hunters dwelling around subterranean freshwater seas illuminated by bioluminescent fungi. With sensitive acoustic antennae detecting seismic vibrations through stone, they fashion obsidian spears and weave waterproof garments from fungal fibers.

Championed by Goldheart, the Flotilla ratified the **Non-Interference Protocol of 368 AA**, declaring Karst a Total Quarantine Zone enforced by the **Karst L1 Picket Station**. Corsairs are contracted under *Quarantine Interdiction Writs* to extract poachers and bioprospectors without exposing the primitives to starships or modern firearms.

MASTER STRATEGIC STANCES OF FOREIGN POWERS MATRIX

FOREIGN POWER	TERRITORIAL DOMAIN	SOVEREIGN AUTHORITY	STRATEGIC DOCTRINE & ASSETS	FLOTILLA STANCE	CORSAIR WARRANT PROFILE
Ancestrals of X'ara	X'ara Cluster (Irul, Avon, Oran)	The Archon & The Sacred Vigil	Lithospheric spires, crystalline void-cutters, EMP arrays	Ancestral Treaty of 432 AA; Irul 1 Consulate	Discreet petitions, relic recovery, intercepting Pure Blade
The Orkish Empire	Outer Rim & Wanabo Buffer	Emperor Vrakketh (Imperial Throne)	Tungsten ram-prows, boarding torpedoes, combat mechs	The Great Truce (509 AA); Wanabo DMZ	Honor-Bound Auxiliaries, proxy skirmishes, border security
Scavenger Clans	The Deep Drift (Inter-System Void)	The Collector & Tithe-Counters	Hulk-nests, scrap boarding boats, 4-armed assault	Total War; Interdiction Bounties	Interdiction bounties, salvage defense, scrap trade pacts
Lithari of Karst	Karst Subterranean Cenotes	Tribal Shaman Clans	Obsidian tools, fungal weaving, seismic acoustics	Non-Interference Protocol (368 AA); L1 Picket	Quarantine enforcement, anti-poaching, silent extractions

EPILOGUE: THE THREE LAYERS OF REALITY

To survive in the Sphere, a Corsair must master the tension between three distinct layers of reality that coexist across every moon, station, and derelict hull.

Layer 1: The Everyday Struggle (518 AA). This is the tangible world of the Flotilla, the colonial magistrates, the corporate ledgers, and the ravine gangs. It is measured in credit chits, reaction-mass liters, pressure gaskets, and court warrants. To the average spacer, this is the only world that matters: paying off the ship's mortgage, securing fresh provisions, and returning home alive from the dark.

Layer 2: The Five-Hundred-Year History. This is the cultural memory of the Great Arrival, the Inter-Binary Famine, the Skyline Accords, the emergence of the Draco fusion drive, and the bloody scar of the Frontier War. It is the realization that Newcomer civilization is young, fragile, and standing upon the shoulders of dragons who sacrificed their own celestial kin to preserve mortal life in an alien system.

Layer 3: The Cosmic Singularity & The Monoliths. Deep beneath the crusts and hidden within quarantined exclusion zones lies the ultimate truth: the Sphere was not built for mortals. It is an astronomical computational apparatus designed by ancient Precursors to survive an inevitable cosmic collapse. When ancient dreadnoughts wake and non-baryonic relics hum in the dark, mortal laws dissolve into irrelevance.

The Role of the New Wave. In the fragile peace of 518 AA, the Sphere teeters upon a knife-edge. The Flotilla cannot police the moons; colonial councils cannot secure the high drift; corporations pursue profit over stability; and foreign empires test the borders. Into this vacuum steps the Corsair: independent, sworn to the Charter, and armed with MANTLE chassis and sub-light corvettes to stitch the seams of civilization together before the dark claims them all.

The Shepherd's Legacy. Five centuries ago, the Dragon Children made landfall alongside the mortal arks. Goldheart chose the soil of Landfall, Stormdrinker the clouds of Nimbus, Windreaver the ice shelves of Rime. They guide mortal civilization not as conquering tyrants or distant gods, but as patient elders who understand the ancient astronomical machinery ticking beneath the crust. Their guidance was a solemn commitment—the Shepherd's Gambit: nurturing mortals into self-sufficiency so that one day they might unlock the true purpose of the Sphere.

As Speaker Jesse Haddon once observed during a turbulent council session in Crossroads: *"The Flotilla watches the void, the corporate barons watch their ledgers, and the dragons watch the stars. It falls to the Corsairs to watch the doors, because if the doors give way, none of the rest of it matters at all."*

APPROACHING THE FORBIDDEN ARCHIVES

The dossiers contained in this chapter represent the authorized public knowledge of the Sphere. Beyond this threshold lie records never meant for civilian broadcast: classified Flotilla interrogation logs, the true nature of the dragon children, the catastrophic telemetry of the Singularity, and the Shepherd's Gambit. Turn the page with caution: in the dark of space, the truth has its own gravitational pull.